

CIVIL SERVICES EXAMINATION

UPSC • SOCIOLOGY (OPTIONAL) — PAPER 1 (Part-1)



Sociology — Paper 1 (Part-1)

Fundamentals of Sociology



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The Sociological Perspective, Modernity & Social Changes in Europe

1.1 Developing the Sociological Perspective

1.1.1 *Impression Management*

The instructor introduced the idea that every social role is a performance . He said that for the duration of the course, both teacher and students would be “acting” their roles—he as teacher, they as students—and that each side is cautious in how it behaves before the other in order to maintain this arrangement .

KEY CONCEPT

- This behaviour of consciously managing how one appears to others in a given role is called **impression management** . Scholar cited: **Erving Goffman** .
- The instructor illustrated it with his own multiple roles: he is a teacher to his students, but a student to his own PhD supervisor, and a son to his mother—no single role captures him “in absolute sense” .

QUICK REVISION

- **Impression management (Goffman):** consciously managing how one appears in a social role; no one occupies a single role “in absolute sense” .

1.1.2 *Seeing the “System”, Not the Individual*

The instructor ran a picture-based exercise to train students to look for the underlying system, force, or structure behind what is visible, rather than describing only the visible individuals or objects . This is presented as the foundational move of sociological thinking .

EXAMPLE

- **Picture 1 — The Solar System:** Students named the planets they saw, but the instructor pointed out that what is really being seen is a system—the sun giving light to other planets—not any individual planet .
- **Picture 2 — A Man Throwing/Holding a Ball:** Students gave varied answers (a man, a ball, projectile motion), but the deeper common thread the instructor drew out was gravitational force / centripetal force—something that keeps bodies in motion but is not itself empirically

visible; it can only be felt, not seen, touched or heard .

- **Picture 3 — A Benzene Ring (Six Carbons, Six Hydrogens):** As a student of chemistry one does not describe six carbons and six hydrogens individually but names the structure as a whole—benzene—which is something different from the sum of the individual atoms .

CRITICAL POINT

- In each case the instructor did not talk about individual planets, individual men, or individual atoms—only about the system, force, or structure . He said this same shift (from individual to structure) is what sociological perspective requires throughout the picture exercise that follows .

QUICK REVISION

- **Sociological perspective:** Seeing the system/force/structure (not the individual)—illustrated with the solar system, gravity, and benzene .

1.1.3 *Conspicuous Consumption*

Shown a picture of a Starbucks coffee cup, students named the brand, the cup, the price . The instructor's sociological reading:

KEY CONCEPT

Conspicuous consumption—buying an expensive good not for its use-value but to display one's status .

- Economics predicts that demand falls as price rises (the law of demand), yet Starbucks coffee, though costly, is in high demand—people prefer it over cheaper options such as Indian Coffee House .
- The instructor's explanation: the buyer is not purchasing coffee but recognition—the moment of swiping a card, or taking a selfie with the cup, displays one's class status to others .

This is presented as a challenge to the economic idea of man as *homo economicus* (a purely utilitarian, rational being)—in conspicuous consumption, the utility being sought lies beyond the commodity itself, in the status it signals .

QUICK REVISION

- **Conspicuous consumption:** Buying to display status, not for use-value; challenges the idea of man as purely rational *homo economicus* (Starbucks example) .

1.1.4 *Poverty and Structural Inequality*

Shown a picture of a mother and child in poor conditions, students' answers ranged from “poverty” and “happy despite hardship” to “malnutrition” and “single motherhood” .

KEY CONCEPT

- As a sociologist, the instructor said, one does not see “a woman” and “a child” but inequality, division of society into economic classes, unequal opportunity, unemployment, single motherhood, and malnutrition—conditions read as structural rather than individual .

QUICK REVISION

- Poverty read structurally:** Inequality, unequal opportunity, unemployment, single motherhood, malnutrition—not individual failing .

1.1.5 Child Labour and Cheap Labour

A picture of children engaged in labour drew answers such as “child labour,” “exploitation,” “alienation” and “absence of human rights” .

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor added a second, structural reading: from the position of an industrialist, the same picture shows the cheapest labour available—the same phenomenon looks different depending on the social location (industrialist vs sociologist) from which it is read .

QUICK REVISION

- Child labour:** Exploitation/alienation to a sociologist, but reads as “cheapest labour available” from an industrialist’s social location—same fact, different vantage point .

1.1.6 Division of Labour and Sexual Division of Labour

Shown a picture of a man working on a laptop and a woman washing dishes, students named “work from home,” “patriarchal society,” and “sexism” . The instructor built up the underlying concept step by step .

KEY CONCEPT

Division of labour, illustrated through McDonald’s: a burger is ready in about two minutes because five separate people specialise in five separate tasks (making the tikki, dressing the bun, frying the fries, refilling the coke, etc.)—specialised roles integrated together make production efficient .

Scholar and text: Adam Smith, *Wealth of Nations*—an inquiry into why Britain became prosperous . Smith’s answer: division of labour . Industrial revolution brought technological advancement and mass production, but mass production itself was possible only because of division of labour .

KEY CONCEPT

Sexual division of labour—when tasks are assigned not on the basis of skill but on the basis of gender . A woman is as capable of being trained to work on a laptop as a man; the reason she is instead confined to housework is not lack of ability but social assignment of roles by sex .

QUICK REVISION

- **Division of labour (Adam Smith, *Wealth of Nations*):** Specialised tasks for efficiency .
- **Sexual division of labour:** Tasks assigned by gender, not skill .

1.1.7 Media and the Reproduction of Patriarchy

A screenshot instructing “how to be a good housewife” (cleaning, cooking, cutting vegetables) was used to make a point about media as a system, not as a single website .

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor’s reading: media as a whole (not one website) promotes the same gender-stereotypical roles assigned to different sexes; media is described as being “in alliance with patriarchy,” each reproducing and reinforcing the other and keeping women confined to prescribed roles .
- Just as gravitational force and patriarchy are both not directly visible but can be “felt” in their effects, patriarchy is described as an ideology that cannot itself be seen, only its consequences can .

QUICK REVISION

- Media (as a system, not one website) is in alliance with patriarchy, reproducing gender-stereotypical roles; patriarchy, like gravity, is felt through its effects though not itself directly visible .

1.1.8 Alienation, Role Diversity, and Emotional Labour

A picture of women doing repetitive garment/mask-stitching work drew initial answers of “skilling” and “women empowerment” . The instructor complicated this reading .

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor questioned whether monotonous, repetitive factory work over 10 hours a day with no ability to look around, chat, or vary the task can be called empowerment, contrasting it with the role diversity available to, say, an IAS officer .
- **Concept invoked: Alienation (Karl Marx).** With the industrial revolution, man loses control over his productive skills; every day is a repetition of the same task with no colour or charm left in work .
- Marx’s idea of **species being** was cited: human beings have wide-ranging potential (e.g., a mother who is nurturing may have many other talents), but the way society and the economic system are organised confines individuals—such as this mother, or the assembly-line worker—to a single narrow role, and that potential is lost .

Emotional Labour Discussing service-sector roles such as hotel staff and airline cabin crew, the instructor introduced a further concept .

KEY CONCEPT

Emotional labour—smiling and being warm to customers even when one does not feel like it, e.g., cabin crew smiling for hours regardless of their actual mood. Smiling without genuine wish to is described as a form of alienation from one's own self.

- The instructor offered two readings of the service sector in the same breath: it has expanded opportunities for many groups (via internet-based and remote work), while at the same time emotional labour has made the condition of human existence, in his words, “more miserable”. He noted both readings can be right at once—sociology is about seeing things from different angles, not declaring one right and one wrong.

QUICK REVISION

- **Alienation (Marx):** Specialised, monotonous work strips role diversity and loses man's “species being” potential.
- **Emotional labour:** Forced smiling in service work alienates one from one's own self.

1.1.9 Gender, Occupation and the Military

A picture of army/military personnel drew responses of “nationalism,” “unity,” “masculinity” and “military strength”.

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor's reading: **occupational segregation by sex**—the image “army officer” conjures a man in the popular imagination, not a woman, even though bravery and courage are not male-exclusive traits.
- **Exam-relevance note:** The instructor referenced the then-ongoing issue of permanent commission for women in the armed forces as an example of contested access to positions associated with bravery/valour.
- He also pointed to healthcare and frontline pandemic workers—Asha workers, Anganwadi workers, auxiliary nurse midwives (ANMs), lady doctors—as the “real warriors” of the (then) crisis, most of whom are women, arguing this challenges the assumption that only men can fight for the nation.

QUICK REVISION

- Occupational imagery is gendered by default (“army officer” evokes a man); front-line/healthcare women workers reframed as “real warriors”.

1.1.10 Voluntary Segregation and Gated Communities

A picture of a residential gate/quarters drew answers naming class segregation.

KEY CONCEPT

The instructor pointed to how residences of IAS/IPS officers, chief ministers, the President's estate, and five-star hotels are all physically excluded from the mainstream city—a spatial way in which status and class segregation are expressed .

Term introduced: Gated community—voluntary exclusion by some groups from mixing with “ordinary” people, a further form of inequality since not everyone can afford to belong to one .

QUICK REVISION

- **Gated community:** Voluntary spatial self-exclusion by elites (IAS/IPS bungalows, President's estate)—a further form of inequality, since not everyone can afford it .

1.1.11 *Schooling, Discipline and the Hidden Curriculum*

A picture of a classroom drew answers such as “discipline,” “socialization,” and “value system” .

KEY CONCEPT

Hidden curriculum—the unstated lessons a school teaches beyond its official subjects (maths, physics, English): authority, obedience, conformity, and fear of punishment . A child is taught not to be “too creative” and not to question beyond the classroom .

- The instructor drew a direct parallel between the classroom and the factory: school prepares different students for the future roles of manager, supervisor, or worker, and in that sense school is described as “the friend of capitalism”—not only in an economic sense but through the discipline it instils .
- Before school, a child's only authority is the parents; school introduces, for the first time, a controlling authority other than the parents—the teacher .

QUICK REVISION

- **Hidden curriculum:** School teaches authority, obedience and conformity alongside its official subjects; school is described as preparing students for factory-like manager/supervisor/worker roles .

1.1.12 *Surveillance and Conformity*

A picture of a CCTV camera drew the answer “surveillance” .

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor's elaboration: the function of surveillance cameras is to create fear among those who might otherwise commit crime (theft, snatching, etc.), which minimises criminal tendencies and reproduces conformity and discipline—this is presented as one way society avoids deviance .
- He also distinguished **equality of opportunity** from **equality of outcome**, noting that opportunity can be made equal, but outcomes will always differ .

QUICK REVISION

- Surveillance produces fear of detection, minimises deviance, and reproduces conformity; equality of opportunity is distinguished from (unattainable) equality of outcome .

1.1.13 Social Stratification: Caste, Elites, and the Idea of Revolution

A picture symbolising social hierarchy drew answers of “social structure” and “social hierarchy” . The instructor used it to introduce the idea of an estate/state system (stratification) and to bridge into the historical material that follows .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The Indian caste system was cited as an illustration of stratification: Brahmins at the top, Kshatriyas second, Vaishyas third, and Shudras fourth, with a fifth stratum existing beyond these four—opportunity in this system is tied to one’s position in the hierarchy .

This was directly compared to pre-revolutionary French society, which the instructor described as similarly stratified, and to the challenge that stratified order eventually faced: the Tennis Court Oath, described here as a declaration that man has an individual existence of his own that religious or hierarchical authority “in the name of God” could no longer override .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- This picture-based comparison of Indian caste stratification with the French estate system is flagged by the instructor as a bridge into the historical unit on Modernity and Social Changes in Europe that follows .

QUICK REVISION

- Indian caste stratification (Brahmin → Kshatriya → Vaishya → Shudra) compared to pre-revolutionary French estates; Tennis Court Oath cited as the historical challenge to such hierarchical order—the bridge into Topic 2 .

1.1.14 Family, Heteronormativity and Deviance

A picture of a conventional family unit drew the answer “happy family” . The instructor introduced a further concept .

KEY CONCEPT

Heteronormativity—the assumption, embedded in such images, that only heterosexual pairing (man-woman) constitutes a family, so that families formed by same-sex couples are not socially recognised as families, even though assisted/artificial reproductive technologies (ART) now make biological compulsion for children unnecessary .

A subsequent picture depicting a same-sex couple/family drew answers of “homosexuality,” “LGBT,” and “rebellion” .

KEY CONCEPT

Deviance—breaking away from the standard, socially expected notion (here, of family) . The instructor noted the term carries a negative connotation in common usage (“breaking away”), and that this image can be read as both a challenge to heteronormative standards and, in a value-neutral sociological sense, as deviance from the dominant social pattern .

QUICK REVISION

- **Heteronormativity:** Family imagery assumes only heterosexual pairing counts as family, despite ART removing any biological need for this .
- **Deviance:** Breaking from a socially expected pattern—read here as both “challenge” and, value-neutrally, deviation from the dominant norm .

1.2 Sociology, the Discipline: Modernity, Social Changes in Europe & Emergence of Sociology

The syllabus phrase for this unit is: “*Sociology – The Discipline, Part A: Modernity and Social Changes in Europe and Emergence of Sociology.*” The instructor read this literally: the emergence of sociology is tied to social changes in Europe, and the throughline across all of them is modernity .

1.2.1 The Middle Ages: The God-Centric World

Before the Renaissance, in medieval Europe, the priestly class (the Church) dictated every aspect of a person’s life—what to eat, whether one could travel, and even the shape of the universe .

KEY CONCEPT

- God was at the centre of the universe; the world view was entirely religious .
- Individual ability or creativity was not acknowledged—painters could only paint godly/heavenly figures, not ordinary men, women or children .
- The Church held the view that the earth is at the centre of the universe (**geocentrism**) and that the human body is a “divine product” that must not be dissected or studied—this blocked the development of anatomy/medical science .
- Anyone who challenged the Church was declared a **heretic**—someone challenging its authority—and could be charged with **blasphemy** (insulting God or anything religious) .
- The aspiration of mankind in this period was to go to heaven, not any worldly achievement; “life on earth is inconsequential” was the Church’s teaching, and one’s afterlife depended on obedience to the clergy .

QUICK REVISION

- **Middle Ages:** God-centric world view; Church controlled belief and knowledge; heresy/blasphemy suppressed challenge; individual creativity and anatomy/medicine were restricted .

1.2.2 The Renaissance: Rebirth of Man

Renaissance (roughly 1400–1600) literally means rebirth/reawakening—rebirth of what man is capable of doing as an individual .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Trigger:** Europeans came into contact with the Arab world through the Crusades (wars between Muslims and Christians) and trade, and through this contact rediscovered preserved Greek and Roman literature (Aristotle, Plato, the concepts of logic and reason) . Realising how advanced the Greeks and Romans had been, Europeans felt they had been kept underdeveloped by the priestly class .
- The Renaissance is characterised as the restoration of Greek and Roman literature and marks the departure from a God-centric to a man-centric world—mankind, not God, became the centre of the universe .
- **Philosophy of the Renaissance: Humanism**—centering on the human/mankind rather than God . Humanism encompasses (includes) both individualism and secularism .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Individualism:** Man's capacity to think and reason for himself, not simply accept what the priestly class dictates; the idea that individual human contribution and creativity can be celebrated (an idea previously reserved for God/the divine) .
- **Secularism (Renaissance-era sense):** Not against religion, but thinking beyond religion . Reason and faith co-existed rather than opposing each other in this period; the concept of God was not questioned outright—only supplemented by exploring human potential .

Individual Contributions of the Renaissance**EXAMPLE**

- **Nicolaus Copernicus (theory in 1490):** Proposed **heliocentrism** (from “helio,” root word for sun)—the sun, not the earth, is at the centre—directly countering the Church's geocentrism .
- **Johannes Kepler:** First to describe the laws of planetary motion, showing that planets move in an elliptical (not circular) orbit—contrary to the church-sanctioned (“Vatican law”) circular representation .
- **Galileo Galilei:** Verified Copernicus's claim through his own observation (built his own telescope) and openly opposed the Church; Copernicus, Kepler and Galileo were together declared heretics, charged with blasphemy, by the Church .
- **Leonardo da Vinci:** Called “the Renaissance man”; studied human anatomy in defiance of

Church restrictions; famous for the *Mona Lisa*. His most famous painting was contrasted with pre-Renaissance religious art: earlier paintings of *Madonna and Child* gave little attention to facial expression (glory was reserved for the divine), while Renaissance art (e.g., *Mona Lisa*) used perspective to depict individual human emotion and expression—a marker of the shift from god-centric to man-centric art.

- **William Shakespeare:** Renowned for man-centred literary work (e.g., *Hamlet*) about everyday human drama rather than purely religious/Biblical teaching, which had been the content of books in the Middle Ages.
- **Philippo Brunelleschi (named tentatively by the instructor):** Credited with the modern design of the printing press, significant because it allowed knowledge previously restricted to elite languages (Latin in Europe, Sanskrit in India, as opposed to the masses' Pali) to reach ordinary people.
- **Christopher Columbus** and the concept of **cartography** (map-making) and the “age of exploration” were cited as products of the same era—curiosity as a new trait of “man”.

CRITICAL POINT

- Renaissance marked the departure from a God-centric world to a man-centric world. Its philosophy, humanism, revolves around regard and acknowledgement of the existence of the individual, and encompasses both individualism and secularism.

QUICK REVISION

- **Renaissance (1400–1600):** Humanism (individualism + secularism); departure from God-centric to man-centric world; Copernicus (heliocentrism), Kepler (elliptical orbits), Galileo, da Vinci, Shakespeare, the printing press.

1.2.3 The Scientific Revolution (*Scientific Renaissance*)

KEY CONCEPT

- The scientific revolution is described as another name for “scientific renaissance”—not a separate period from the Renaissance but the strand of it in which man used reason, his own observation, and experimentation to understand the working of the (natural) universe.
- It is exemplified by the same figures already discussed—Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo—whose work was based on observation/experimentation rather than church teaching.

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- This period paved the way for the age of reason—the **Enlightenment era**, dated roughly 1600–1800 (with the Renaissance placed at roughly 1400–1600, and the scientific renaissance in between).

QUICK REVISION

- **Scientific Revolution = “scientific renaissance”:** Reason/observation/experimentation applied to the natural universe (Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo); paved the way for the Enlightenment .

1.2.4 The Enlightenment: The Age of Reason

Enlightenment (“age of reason”) again involves man using reason, observation and experimentation—but now applied not to the natural universe but to improve the working of society, meaning specifically the reform of governance .

KEY CONCEPT

Distinction drawn: In the scientific revolution, non-human/natural phenomena were the object of inquiry; in the Enlightenment, man himself became the object of inquiry to other men—scholars studied “what is the nature of man” in order to work out how governance could be improved . The instructor described Enlightenment thinkers as elites who met and debated in **salons** (informal gatherings/cafes) in France—compared to modern-day coffee-shop discussions among the educated .

QUICK REVISION

- **Enlightenment (1600–1800):** Reason applied to reform of governance/society (not the natural universe); for the first time, man himself becomes the object of study .

1.2.5 Civil Society**KEY CONCEPT**

Civil society—defined as anything that falls between family and state: media (print, digital, social), research institutions, NGOs, pressure groups, university professors/academics, scientists, resident welfare associations (RWAs), and ordinary individuals critical of government on social media .

- **Function of civil society:** To keep a check and balance on the power of the state .
- The concept of civil society is traced to the same French salons where Enlightenment elites first began speaking against/critiquing governance—the instructor draws a direct line from those salons to present-day newspaper editorials (*The Hindu*, *The Indian Express*) and social media commentary critiquing government policy .

QUICK REVISION

- **Civil society:** Anything between family and state (media, NGOs, research bodies, academics); function is to check and balance state power; traced to the French salons .

1.2.6 Enlightenment Scholars and the Critique of Monarchy

All Enlightenment scholars discussed were concerned with one shared question: how can governance (and later, economy and gender relations) be improved through the application of reason .

Each is discussed below as engaging with the French monarchical system of the time .

Thomas Hobbes

KEY CONCEPT

Context: Wrote during the English civil wars; his book is *Leviathan* .

- **Hobbes's view of human nature:** Men are inherently lazy, stupid, greedy and selfish .
- Without government, Hobbes argued, life would be “*solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short*” (quoted by the instructor as Hobbes's own formulation) .
- **His prescription:** A strong monarch is needed to keep these impulses in check and maintain social order .
- **Important nuance:** Although Hobbes supported monarchy, he did *not* support the divine right of rule (i.e., the idea that a monarch's authority comes from God/a lineage sanctioned by God)—which is why he is still counted among Enlightenment (not purely traditionalist) thinkers .

John Locke

KEY CONCEPT

- **Locke's view of human nature:** Men are not stupid or selfish but moral beings, possessing natural rights to **life, liberty and property** .
- Because no one, in Locke's time, held private property (land ownership was in the name of the crown/king, who distributed it only to nobles, not the masses), Locke's argument was in effect that people were being deprived of a right they should naturally have .
- Locke held that the duty of the monarch is only to protect these natural rights (life and property)—this exchange (people accept government in return for protection of natural rights) is the origin of the idea of a **social contract** between men and the state .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Social contract explained by analogy: Paying taxes (direct or indirect) to government in exchange for government action (infrastructure, public goals) is a modern-day form of the same bargain—citizens give up a portion of freedom in exchange for social order and protection; this is why fundamental rights are conditional, not absolute .

Hobbes vs Locke on revolt: Hobbes held the monarch has full right to crush any revolt; Locke held that if the monarch fails to protect people's rights, the people have a right to revolt—the monarch cannot suppress a revolt born of failing to honour the social contract .

Jean-Jacques Rousseau

KEY CONCEPT

Concept: General will—the will of the majority; directly linked by the instructor to the modern concept of democracy .

- **Rousseau's view of human nature:** Man is essentially wise and good, “born free,” but it is society that puts him into chains—illustrated by the idea that a newborn has no concept of nationality, caste, class, sexuality, religion, ethnicity or race, but acquires and becomes bound

by all of these through socialisation .

- Rousseau also wrote about the rights of women and women's education, but the instructor flagged this as a reflection of a patriarchal mindset: Rousseau's proposed education for women was oriented toward being a good housewife, not toward the fuller rights he proposed for men .

Voltaire

KEY CONCEPT

- **Position:** Called for religion to be “crushed”—meaning that there should be no exploitation of man in the name of religion/God, since man cannot empirically verify God and has, in the instructor's words, “been fooled for thousands of years” by rule justified through religion .
- Also a strong supporter of freedom of speech, with the paraphrased line attributed to him: he may disagree with what someone says, but would defend, to the point of death, their right to say it .

EXAMPLE

The instructor connected Voltaire's critique of religiously justified hierarchy to the Hindu Varna system (Brahmins at the top, followed by Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Shudras) and named the Buddha as the historical Indian figure who first challenged this order—noting that the Hindi word for enlightenment, *Nirvana*, derives from this association .

Montesquieu (*Baron de Montesquieu*)

KEY CONCEPT

- **Position:** Governance improves when power is not concentrated in one person—under absolute monarchy, one king held legislative power (made laws), executive power (implemented laws, appointed anyone without merit-based selection), and judicial power (acted as judge) all at once, which the instructor calls despotism/autocracy .
- **Proposed solution: Separation of powers**—three distinct branches of government: legislature (formulates laws through debate/deliberation, e.g., Parliament), executive (implements laws once passed as acts), and judiciary .
- The instructor added a practical note for GS/polity: in practice an IAS officer may act across all three functions at different times (e.g., a District Magistrate exercising judicial powers), so the separation is not always a watertight compartment in practice .

Adam Smith

KEY CONCEPT

Adam Smith is described as part of the Scottish Enlightenment, itself part of the broader European Enlightenment . His book: *Wealth of Nations* .

- **Laissez-faire**—“let it be free”—a free-market economy not intervened in by government; linked to the modern term *neoliberalism*, meaning expansion of free markets with minimum government role . The instructor illustrated with import duty: a fruit that should cost

Rs. 50 costs Rs. 200 after import duty, pushing consumers toward “indigenous” goods—he notes Smith would not approve, since protectionism (tariffs, farm subsidies) works against free-market principles .

- **Invisible hand**—self-interested individuals (e.g., entrepreneurs seeking profit) unintentionally benefit society as a whole . Illustrated with Coca-Cola vs Pepsi: competing to capture market share by lowering prices benefits consumers (choice, lower prices) and creates employment—benefits arise without either firm intending to serve society directly, and only where government does not intervene .
- **Post-Fordism** (mentioned in passing, to be developed later in the syllabus under work/economy): an era where products are customised to individual consumer preference (e.g., a custom-assembled computer, a personalised printed t-shirt or mug) .

CRITICAL POINT

Herbert Spencer, described as a “social Darwinist,” applied laissez-faire thinking to society itself: no protection or subsidy should be given to the poor; only the fittest should survive . The instructor stressed that the phrase “survival of the fittest” was coined by Spencer, not by Charles Darwin, though Spencer was influenced by both Darwin and Adam Smith . The term “social Darwinist project” is used in media commentary (e.g., *The Hindu*, *The Indian Express*) to describe situations where government does not protect people (e.g., during crises such as lockdowns), leaving survival to chance .

Mary Wollstonecraft

KEY CONCEPT

Book: *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (also referenced by the instructor as *A Serious Proposal to the Ladies*) .

- **Position:** Society consists equally of women, and if men can read, write and study, so can women . She is described by the instructor as the mother/founder of feminism—the first Enlightenment scholar to speak assertively, exclusively, about women’s rights and women’s education (as distinct from Rousseau’s more limited, housewife-oriented proposal) .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

A warm-up matching exercise was given, asking students to match each of the following ideas to its scholar :

- Leviathan* / social contract / “life would be solitary, poor, nasty, brutish and short” without government → **Hobbes** .
- Improving the status of women, “if all men are born free, how is it that all women are born slaves?” → **Wollstonecraft** .
- Civilization corrupts, man is born free but everywhere in chains, government improved through the general will → **Rousseau** .
- A French writer who studied political liberty, was impressed by the British system, and held that “power should be a check to power” → **Montesquieu** .

QUICK REVISION

- **Hobbes:** Monarchy, men are stupid/selfish, rejects divine right .
- **Locke:** Natural rights, social contract, right to revolt .
- **Rousseau:** General will/democracy, man born free .
- **Voltaire:** Anti-clericalism, freedom of speech .
- **Montesquieu:** Separation of powers .
- **Adam Smith:** Laissez-faire, invisible hand, post-Fordism (Spencer/social Darwinism nearby) .
- **Wollstonecraft:** Women's rights, founder of feminism .

1.2.7 Feudal Land Ownership: Europe and India Compared**GOVERNMENT & POLICY**

- In feudal Europe, land was owned by the crown (the king), not by individuals; a noble who received land from the king had no hereditary right to pass it to his son, so there was little incentive to invest in or improve the land—land therefore stayed unproductive .
- **Comparison made to India:** During the Mughal era there was likewise no concept of private land ownership—land ownership was, similarly, in the name of the crown .
- **Scholar cited: François Bernier**, a physician-traveller (not a historian or sociologist) who visited India during the reign of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb and drew the comparison between feudal Europe and feudal India .
- Private land ownership arrived in India only under British rule, which introduced the **Zamindari system**; the earlier **Jagirdari system** had existed under the Sultanate (before the Mughals) . **Difference:** Zamindari was hereditary (a zamindar could pass land to his son and collected revenue for the Empire); Jagirdari had no such hereditary right .
- Because Zamindari lacked strong incentive for investment (among other reasons), productivity stayed low, contributing—alongside the same dynamic in France—to conditions of famine .

QUICK REVISION

- Feudal Europe and Mughal India both had crown-owned (not private) land (François Bernier's comparison); India got private ownership only under British rule (hereditary Zamindari; earlier non-hereditary Jagirdari under the Sultanate) .

1.2.8 The French Revolution: Background and the Estates System

The instructor framed the ideas of Enlightenment scholars as reforms proposed against the actual French monarchical system they lived under, and set out the structure of pre-revolutionary French society, which was divided into three “estates” .

Estate	Composition	% Pop.	% Land	Taxes Paid
First Estate	Catholic Church officials and clergy	1%	10%	None
Second Estate	Nobility and aristocracy (earls, dukes, knights, barons)	2%	20%	None
Third Estate	Bourgeoisie (educated city lawyers, doctors, businessmen) and peasants/farmers	97%	70%	All taxes, plus tithes (unevenly distributed; many peasants landless)

DATA & FACTS

- Together, the first and second estates—3% of the population—owned 30% of the land and paid no tax; the third estate—97% of the population—held the remaining 70% of the land (very unevenly, with many peasants entirely landless) and bore the full tax burden .
- **Tithe**—a mandatory contribution of one-tenth (1/10) of one's produce or earnings to the Church, paid by ordinary people (e.g., a farmer's harvest, a businessman's earnings) .
- A cartoon of the period was described: the third estate depicted as a horse carrying the burden of the first and second estates seated upon it .

CRITICAL POINT

- The third estate was described in the lecture as “everything” in terms of population and productive/tax contribution, yet had “nothing” in terms of political voice, and “desired to be something”—the instructor named **Abbé Sieyès** as the figure who inspired the third estate to seek political power .

Economic and Political Causes

DATA & FACTS

Economic causes cited:

- Extravagant royal spending**—termed “Madame Deficit,” referring to the fiscal profligacy attributed to Queen Marie Antoinette's extravagant expenses on exotic fruits, clothes and jewellery (the instructor noted this framing itself reflects a patriarchal tendency to single out the Queen for blame) .
- The Seven Years' War** between France and Britain for global supremacy, which drained the treasury .
- Famine**—soldiers went hungry even during the war .

Political context: King Louis XVI is described as an absolute monarch but a weak ruler who attempted reforms that mostly failed due to resistance from the nobility, and who incurred huge

debt partly linked to the palace of Versailles .

EXAMPLE

A period proverb quoted by the instructor: *“The king in his castle, the poor at his gate; God made them highly and lowly, and ordered their estates”*—used to show how religious framing (“God has ordered these estates”) discouraged any challenge to the existing order, in the way the instructor said caste hierarchy was maintained in India “until Ambedkar voiced out their opinion” .

QUICK REVISION

- **French estates:** 1st (clergy, 1% pop., 10% land, no tax), 2nd (nobility, 2% pop., 20% land, no tax), 3rd (bourgeoisie + peasants, 97% pop., 70% land, all taxes + tithes) .
- **Causes:** Enlightenment ideas + Madame Deficit + Seven Years’ War + famine .

1.2.9 The French Revolution: Estates General to Republic

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **Estates General**—the rarely-convened body (equivalent to a parliamentary session) in which all three estates met . Each estate had only one vote regardless of population, so the first and second estates (allied with each other) always outvoted the third estate 2-to-1, despite representing only 3% of the population .
- **Tennis Court Oath**—members of the third estate broke away and formed their own **National Assembly**, a direct challenge to the monarch and the existing hierarchical/ruling structure, asserting the right to make their own rules .
- The National Assembly issued the **Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen**, proposing that everyone should have the right to life, property and vote—though the instructor noted that in practice women and slaves were still excluded from voting and not considered active citizens .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **First proposal accepted by the National Assembly:** “**Law of clergy**,” i.e., a secular state—the monarch/King Louis’s family would no longer rule in the name of God; religion and rule were to be separated .
- **Outcome of the Revolution:** Transition from absolute monarchy to a republic . The instructor noted this transition was not immediate or smooth—it took a long time for a stable republic to emerge, and the French Revolution is understood by the instructor to have recurred more than once (1789/1791 and again in the 1800s), though it is usually studied as a single 1790s event .

What the French Revolution Contributed to Modernity

KEY CONCEPT

1. **Democracy**—ideas on government (rights to life, liberty, property; Rousseau’s general will; Montesquieu’s separation of power) directly inspired calls for democratic government .
2. **Communism (the seed of it)**—the National Assembly proposed that all land and institutions (banks etc.) confiscated from the first/second estates be nationalised and equally redistributed rather than concentrated as before; the instructor called this the advent of communism/an egalitarian society, while noting that the boundary between socialism and communism is highly blurred and would be discussed later .
3. **Nationalism**—a group of people bound by allegiance to a common thought process/common codes can be considered a “nation,” which need not correspond to a “state” (territory + political administration) . The third estate coming to see itself as a unified nation, having been “united” in shared exploitation, is presented as the origin of modern nationalism; the instructor drew a parallel to Indian nationalism as, similarly, a by-product of the shared experience of colonialism .
4. **Citizenship**—the idea that all persons, once made citizens, hold equal rights irrespective of any prior estate, caste, lineage, gender, religion or race (the instructor cited Article 14 of the Indian Constitution as a present-day parallel) .

QUICK REVISION

- Estates General (one vote per estate) → Tennis Court Oath → National Assembly → Declaration of the Rights of Man → secular state/republic .
- French Revolution gave modernity: democracy, the seed of communism, nationalism, and citizenship .

1.2.10 The Idea of Modernity: A Consolidated Model

The instructor drew a single flowchart :

Middle Ages → Renaissance → Scientific Renaissance → Enlightenment → French Revolution → Industrial Revolution

Social changes in Europe are the cause; modernity is their consequence .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Modernity is defined as the decline (not death) of traditional beliefs, ideas and institutions**—those institutions weaken but do not disappear entirely .
- **René Descartes** is introduced here as a philosopher straddling the scientific revolution/Enlightenment: his statement “*the only thing that cannot be doubted is doubt itself*” is read as establishing that man’s capacity to think/doubt proves his own existence—leading to his famous line, “*I think, therefore I am*” (*Cogito, ergo sum*), directly challenging the Catholic Church’s view that only the soul, not the individual man, exists .

KEY CONCEPT

The consolidated “blueprint” of the elements of modernity, as drawn by the instructor from all events studied, was given as (not in strict chronological order) :

1. **Humanism** (philosophy of the Renaissance), encompassing individualism and secularism
2. **Rationality**—man is a rational, thinking being, not merely a soul awaiting the afterlife
3. **Empiricism**—belief only in what can be sensed (seen, heard, touched); the basis of science
4. **Science**—rationality and empiricism together
5. **Reason** (from the Enlightenment)
6. **Democracy**
7. **Freedom of speech / expression**
8. **Gender equality / feminism** (from Wollstonecraft)
9. **Nationalism** (from the French Revolution)
10. **Citizenship**
11. **Republic / the state**
12. **Nuclear family** (an unintended consequence of the Industrial Revolution, discussed below)
13. **Industrial economy / urbanisation / social class** as the primary modern identity (replacing estate, caste, or lineage)

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor stressed there is no fixed, universally agreed number of elements of modernity (“it all depends from book to book”)—what matters is the overall structure and that all of these elements recur across later units of the syllabus (politics and society, family and kinship, religion, work and economy) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Modernity = decline (not death) of traditional institutions .**
- Descartes’ “I think, therefore I am” as the philosophical marker of individual existence .
- Modernity’s 13-point blueprint spans humanism, rationality, empiricism, science, reason, democracy, free speech, gender equality, nationalism, citizenship, republic, nuclear family, and industrial economy/urbanisation/class .

1.2.11 The Industrial Revolution**KEY CONCEPT**

Industrial Revolution: A period, beginning around 1750 in England, marked by the shift from man-made (hand/craft) production to machine-made, mass production . Unlike the other events discussed, the instructor stresses it has no clear end date—it is ongoing (“Industrial Revolution 4.0” today) .

Cottage industry—small-scale, home-based production in which family members together manufacture goods, illustrated with beedi-making and Lijjat papad, both largely made by women at home .

- The instructor tied the possibility of industrial invention (steam engine, electric bulb, the Wright brothers' first flight, Thomas Alva Edison's inventions) back to the earlier chain of events: none of this would have been possible without the scientific revolution, which in turn would not have been possible without the Renaissance .

1.2.12 Pre-Industrial vs Post-Industrial Society

The instructor set out a point-by-point comparison, noting it helps understand not just the technological changes brought by the Industrial Revolution but the social changes that followed from them .

Feature	Pre-Industrial Revolution	Post-Industrial Revolution
Economic system	Agrarian economy / feudalism (land as primary source of livelihood)	Industrial economy / capitalism (mass production through factories/machines)
Scale of industry	Cottage industry, small scale (home-based, e.g., beedi, Lijjat papad)	Heavy-scale industry (steel, big dams, assembly lines)
Division of labour	Simple division of labour (tasks divided informally within the family)	Complex division of labour, based on specialisation/degrees/skills, requiring integration of hundreds of specialised workers
Source of power	Water mills / wind mills	Coal and steam (steam engine allowed factories to run all day and night)
Economic motive	Subsistence economy (production for one's own livelihood, not profit)	Profit-centric economy (mass production/consumption for commercial profit)
Home and work-place	Unified—home was the workplace	Separated—workplace (factory) distinct from home; this separation was also sexual in nature (home increasingly managed by women, factory work increasingly sought by men)
Family structure	Joint family system	Nuclear family system (linked to rural-to-urban migration/urbanisation for job opportunities)

CRITICAL POINT

- The instructor connected the specialisation point back to **alienation**: a man who might once have made an entire car by himself now, under complex division of labour, only makes a single nut for the wheel throughout his working life—specialisation, in this reading, has “killed” man’s ability to explore his fuller potential .

QUICK REVISION

- Pre → Post Industrial shifts:** Agrarian/feudal → industrial/capitalist; cottage → heavy industry; simple → complex division of labour; water/wind → coal/steam; subsistence → profit economy; unified → separated home/work; joint → nuclear family .

1.2.13 Social Evils of the Industrial Revolution and Marx's Response

Alongside its benefits (urban expansion, job opportunities, railways, aeroplanes), the instructor listed several “social and economic costs” of the Industrial Revolution, urging students not to treat these as purely individual failings but as structural consequences .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Slum development**—poverty around industrial corridors framed as a structural issue, not an individual family's failing; giving money or books to a child begging is, in this reading, treating a structural problem as an individual one .
- **Class inequality**—widened because only some could access new opportunities (education, mobility), while others remained constrained by family circumstance, gender, religion or caste .
- **Overcrowding of urban centres** (illustrated with the example of Gurgaon) .
- **Industrial pollution** .
- **Exploitation of workers**—with far more job-seekers than available jobs, a “reserve army” of unemployed people became available as cheap labour, and those who were employed lived in fear of being replaced .
- **Degradation of work**—a traditional craftsperson (e.g., a potter) who once had full control over the shape, quality and quantity of what they made lost that control once absorbed into industrial production, where supervisors dictate output and a single item passes through many specialised hands; the traditional guild system (specialised craft streets/areas) declined as machine-made goods, cheaper and branded, out-competed hand-made goods .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Karl Marx wrote the *Communist Manifesto* in response to these unintended, exploitative consequences of the Industrial Revolution—workers who once had full control over their labour were now treated as cheap labour, working long hours with no concept of minimum wage or fixed working hours (unlike today's standards) .

The *Manifesto*'s closing call, paraphrased by the instructor: workers of the world should unite, since they have nothing to lose but their (exploitative) chains, and should overthrow the industrialist/bourgeois class .

Marx is also described as calling the French Revolution itself a “bourgeois revolution”—in his reading, it was the bourgeoisie (not the peasantry) within the third estate who ultimately gained the most from it .

QUICK REVISION

- **Social evils of industrialisation:** Slums, class inequality, overcrowding, pollution, worker exploitation, degradation of craft work—Marx responded with the *Communist Manifesto*, calling workers to unite and overthrow the bourgeoisie .

1.2.14 *Conservative Reaction to Modernity*

The instructor introduced this section by asking whether changes such as the shift from joint to nuclear family, or the arrival of secularism, are “good” or “bad”—stressing that in sociology there is no absolute answer: what is celebrated by one perspective is opposed by another, depending on one’s social location and ideology .

KEY CONCEPT

Counter-Enlightenment—a period/school of thought that emerged in response to (against) the ideas of the Enlightenment, the French Revolution and the Industrial Revolution .

- Conservatives believed modernity undermines (downgrades the importance of) traditional beliefs and institutions such as patriarchy, religion/the Church, monogamous marriage, and monarchy, and wanted to restore that earlier order .

CRITICAL POINT

Why conservatives wanted to restore the old order: The period after the French Revolution was not orderly—it was marked by chaos, turmoil, and what the instructor (borrowing from Durkheim) called **normlessness** . The Reign of Terror (c. 1794 onward) saw mass executions of those who had opposed the Revolution, including King Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette themselves .

- **Conservatives argued:** If this chaos and bloodshed is what modernity/democracy brings, is it worth celebrating? They wanted a return to a time of “proper order,” even though (in the instructor’s own assessment) a society, like an adult, cannot simply be returned to its earlier/“infant” stage .
- Conservatives were also unhappy with expanded women’s rights (e.g., the right to divorce, gained after the French Revolution) and framed rising divorce rates as a threat to family as an institution; the instructor illustrated the underlying tension with feminist theorising of a parallel “sexual contract” between men and women (paralleling Hobbes/Locke/Rousseau’s social contract between men and the state) once work in the home came to be seen as assigned by sex .

Key Conservative Scholars Named

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **Louis de Bonald and Joseph de Maistre**—described as extreme conservatives, i.e., those who wanted to fully restore the pre-modern order (monarchy, patriarchy, Church authority) as it had existed—which the instructor compares to asking an adult to literally become a child again .
- **Auguste Comte**—named as conservative despite being strongly associated with science; the instructor stressed science and conservatism are not opposites (citing Einstein’s line, paraphrased: science without religion is “lame,” religion without science is “blind”) .
- **Emile Durkheim**—named explicitly in the syllabus as conservative; discussed in detail below .

- **Henri de Saint-Simon**—named alongside Comte as another conservative-leaning figure of this transitional period .

CRITICAL POINT

Durkheim's specific discontents (as presented): He was depressed by several forms of social disorder :

- (i) **Anti-Semitism** (hatred against Jews, which he observed being carried out amid the same era's wars, including the Franco-Prussian war, and which the instructor also links forward to Hitler's targeting of Jews in Germany) ;
- (ii) **Church-state discord**, i.e., secularism/the separation of church and state, which he was not happy with ;
- (iii) **Urbanization**, because it weakens family ties—illustrated with the example of a child moving abroad (e.g., into the Indian Foreign Service) and the family's mixed feelings of pride and quiet unhappiness at the resulting distance .

QUICK REVISION

- **Counter-Enlightenment/conservatives (de Bonald, de Maistre = extreme; Comte, Durkheim, Saint-Simon):** Sought restoration of tradition via reform, alarmed by post-Revolution disorder (Reign of Terror); Durkheim specifically opposed anti-Semitism, church-state separation, and urbanisation's effect on family .

1.2.15 The Radical Reaction: Karl Marx

KEY CONCEPT

Where conservatives sought a return to the pre-modern order through reform, Marx is presented as the radical reaction: he held that workers should overthrow the industrialist/bourgeois class outright, and that meaningful social change comes only through revolution, not gradual reform .

- Marx read the French Revolution itself as a bourgeois revolution and, more broadly, urged workers to revolt against the bourgeoisie who, in his reading, exploited them without paying what they were truly owed .

CRITICAL POINT

Conservatives vs radicals on why they differ:

- **Conservatives** believe revolution creates only more disorder (“how much more disorder do you want, after you’ve already killed the king, queen, nobility?”) and that social reform, not revolution, restores order .
- **Radicals (Marxists)** hold that reform is a way of preventing (delaying/defusing) revolutionary change rather than truly resolving exploitation—illustrated by an example of a company, police and government acting in a “tight nexus” (“cash nexus”) to pacify a labour strike with promised talks rather than addressing exploitation .

QUICK REVISION

- **Radicals (Marx):** Social change comes only through revolution, not reform; reform is seen as delaying real change (“cash nexus” of state, police and capital) .

1.2.16 The Emergence of Sociology

Having covered the elements of modernity and the two broad reactions to it (conservative and radical), the instructor closed the unit by explaining how sociology itself emerged from this context .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Structural functionalists**—those who, in response to the problems of modernity, believed change should come via reform, not revolution . The instructor’s analogy: society evolves like a natural human body; when the body/society is hurt, the response is to treat and heal (reform), not to hunt down and eliminate whoever caused the injury (revolution) .
- **Marxists**—the radicals, discussed above, who reject reform in favour of revolutionary change; the instructor’s stated reason for their scepticism of reform: in the name of reform, revolutionary change is prevented/deferred rather than truly delivered .

CRITICAL POINT

Sociology emerged, in the instructor’s framing, for two purposes:

1. **To find the social laws that can restore order in society**—just as physics has laws like the law of gravity or planetary motion, sociologists (“scientists of society”) sought equivalent laws governing society ; and
2. **To study the social changes and social evils associated with modernity .**

Positivism—introduced briefly as the philosophy/method through which social laws governing society can be discovered, associated here specifically with **Auguste Comte** . The instructor described positivists as analogous to meteorologists who predict weather, or as scholars who might, in principle, be able to predict geopolitical outcomes (e.g., when a conflict will resolve) once the underlying “laws” governing a society are known .

Both structural functionalism and Marxism are described as positivist philosophies in this specific sense: both are engaged in trying to discover laws that govern the movement of society, even though they differ sharply on whether reform or revolution is the right response to those laws .

CRITICAL POINT

The instructor’s closing reflection: Having discovered “man” in the Renaissance and then set man to studying the natural universe (scientific revolution) and to reforming governance (Enlightenment), sociology represents a further, self-referential step—**man studying man**—to the point where the instructor remarks that the sociologist studying society risks becoming a kind of new authority (“new God”) in his or her own right, and that for committed Marxists specifically, Marx himself can function almost as a quasi-religious authority (“Marxism is a religion” in that sense) .

QUICK REVISION

- Sociology emerged to find social laws (positivism, Comte) that could restore social order and to study modernity's social evils; structural functionalism (reform) and Marxism (revolution) are both, in this sense, positivist philosophies.

1.3 Full-Topic Revision Sheet

1.3.1 Topic 1 Revision — The Sociological Perspective

QUICK REVISION

- **Sociological perspective:** Seeing the system/force/structure behind individuals, not just the individuals themselves (solar system, gravity, benzene analogies)[cite: 1, 2].
- **Conspicuous consumption:** Buying to display status, not for use-value (Starbucks example).
- **Poverty/child labour read structurally:** Inequality, unemployment, malnutrition, cheap labour—not individual failing.
- **Division of labour (Adam Smith, *Wealth of Nations*)** vs **sexual division of labour** (task assignment by gender, not skill).
- **Media reproduces patriarchy; alienation and emotional labour** (Marx) describe the loss of control/authenticity in modern work.
- **Gender and occupation:** Segregation by sex in imagined roles (army officer); gated communities show voluntary class segregation.
- **Hidden curriculum:** School teaches authority/discipline/conformity beyond the official syllabus; surveillance sustains conformity and deters deviance.
- **Caste stratification (India)** compared to the French estates system as a bridge to the historical unit; **heteronormativity** and **deviance** introduced via the family picture.

1.3.2 Topic 2 Revision — Modernity, Social Changes in Europe & Emergence of Sociology

QUICK REVISION

- **Middle Ages:** God-centric, Church-controlled world view; heresy/blasphemy charges suppressed challenge.
- **Renaissance (1400–1600):** Humanism = individualism + secularism; Copernicus (heliocentrism), Kepler (elliptical orbits), Galileo, da Vinci, Shakespeare.
- **Scientific Revolution = “scientific renaissance”:** Reason/observation/experimentation applied to the natural universe; paved the way for the Enlightenment.
- **Enlightenment (1600–1800):** Reason applied to reform of governance/society; man becomes object of study; civil society originates in salons.
- **Thinkers compared:** Hobbes (monarchy, men are stupid/selfish, no divine right) vs Locke

(natural rights, social contract, right to revolt) vs Rousseau (general will/democracy, man born free) vs Voltaire (anti-clericalism, free speech) vs Montesquieu (separation of powers) vs Adam Smith (laissez-faire, invisible hand, post-Fordism; Spencer/social Darwinism nearby) vs Wollstonecraft (women's rights, founder of feminism).

- **Feudal land:** Crown-owned in both feudal Europe and Mughal India (François Bernier); private ownership in India arrived only under British rule (Zamindari, hereditary; earlier Jagirdari, non-hereditary).
- **French Estates:** 1st (clergy, 1% pop., 10% land, no tax), 2nd (nobility, 2% pop., 20% land, no tax), 3rd (bourgeoisie + peasants, 97% pop., 70% land, all taxes + tithes).
- **Causes of French Revolution:** Enlightenment ideas + Madame Deficit + Seven Years' War + famine; Estates General → Tennis Court Oath → National Assembly → Declaration of the Rights of Man → secular state/republic.
- **French Revolution gave modernity:** Democracy, the seed of communism, nationalism, citizenship.
- **Modernity blueprint:** Humanism (individualism + secularism), rationality, empiricism, science, reason, democracy, free speech, gender equality, nationalism, citizenship, republic, nuclear family, industrial economy/urbanisation/class.
- **Industrial Revolution (from 1750, ongoing):** Agrarian/feudal → industrial/capitalist; cottage industry → heavy industry; simple → complex division of labour; water/wind → coal/steam; subsistence → profit economy; unified → separated home/work; joint → nuclear family.
- **Social evils of industrialisation:** Slums, class inequality, overcrowding, pollution, worker exploitation, degradation of (craft) work—Marx responded with the *Communist Manifesto*.
- **Counter-Enlightenment/conservatives (de Bonald, de Maistre = extreme; Comte, Durkheim, Saint-Simon):** Sought restoration via reform, alarmed by post-Revolution disorder (Reign of Terror); Durkheim specifically opposed anti-Semitism, church-state separation, and urbanisation's effect on family.
- **Radicals (Marx):** Sought revolution, not reform, believing reform merely delays real change.
- **Sociology emerged:** To find social laws (positivism, Comte) that could restore social order and to study modernity's social evils; structural functionalism (reform) and Marxism (revolution) are both, in this sense, positivist philosophies.

Emergence, Theoretical Foundations, Common Sense & Scope of Sociology

2.1 Emergence of Sociology, Positivism & Structural Functionalism

2.1.1 Approach to Sociology Answer Writing (UPSC Mains)

DATA & FACTS

- **UPSC Civil Services Mains, Sociology Optional:** Total time 3 hours; 28 questions given, 19 to be attempted .
- Of the 19 attempted: 13 are 10-mark questions and 6 are 20-mark questions .
- **Time available:** Approximately 8 minutes for a 10-mark question and 11–12 minutes for a 20-mark question—an average of about 10 minutes per question across the paper .
- In the exam hall, aspirants compete against time, not against other candidates—comparing preparation with peers (e.g., on group chats) creates unnecessary anxiety, which should be controlled .

The Four-Step Method for Any Question Whether a question carries 10 or 20 marks, the approach (not the content) comes first . The same four steps apply to every question :

1. **Step 1 — Identify the keywords** in the question, before reading the question as a whole .
2. **Step 2 — Define each identified keyword** precisely .
3. **Step 3 — Read the full question** only after defining the keywords, to see the relationship/pattern being asked about .
4. **Step 4 — Identify the pattern:** Most questions follow a causation pattern (“How did A lead to B”) . Causation means a cause–effect relationship: the cause is the independent variable and the effect is the dependent variable (e.g., smoking = independent variable, cancer = dependent variable) .
5. Where a question has no explicit causation (e.g., “Define A” or “What factors lead to A”), the same logic applies: A becomes the dependent variable and its factors become the independent variables .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Worked example (asked by UPSC in a previous year): “How did the intellectual forces lead to the emergence of sociology? Discuss.” (10 marks)

- **Keywords identified:** ‘Intellectual forces’ and ‘emergence of sociology’ .
- **Keyword 1 defined:** Intellectual forces are forces characterised by a change in ideas or thinking .
- **Pattern:** Causation—intellectual forces (independent variable) led to the emergence of sociology (dependent variable) .

Answer Length & Diagram Use

- A 10-mark answer should run to roughly 150 words—about one page (both sides), i.e., two written sides .
- A short, clean diagram helps orient both the writer and the examiner :

Middle Ages → Intellectual Forces → Modernity → Conservative/Radical Reaction → Emergence of Sociology

UPSC does not award separate marks for diagrams, but they demonstrate clarity of thought and individuality .

CRITICAL POINT

- Write in keywords, not long explanatory paragraphs—keywords are the aspirant’s real weapon in a 150-word answer .
- Examiners evaluate a very large number of scripts in limited time and are themselves specialists evaluating aspirants, not sociology postgraduates—long paragraphs risk irritating the examiner and losing marks rather than gaining them .

QUICK REVISION

- **UPSC Sociology Optional:** 3 hrs, 19/28 questions, $13 \times 10\text{-mark} + 6 \times 20\text{-mark}$, ~ 10 min/question average .
- **Four-step method:** Identify keywords → define keywords → read the question → spot the pattern (usually causation: independent variable = cause, dependent variable = effect) .
- 10-mark answer ≈ 150 words / 2 sides; write in precise keywords, not long prose; diagrams aid clarity though not separately marked .

2.1.2 Intellectual Forces Leading to the Emergence of Sociology

KEY CONCEPT

- **Intellectual forces:** Forces characterised by a change in ideas or thinking (as distinct from material/economic forces) .
- **Renaissance:** Its biggest contribution was the “invention of man and his potential”—as the authority of God/religion declined or was questioned, man as a rational, capable individual was ‘discovered’ .
 - Key terms for writing: **humanism, individualism, secularism** .
- **Scientific Renaissance:** The manifestation of man’s discovered potential in exploring the

natural world, through observation and experimentation (e.g., Galileo Galilei) .

- **Enlightenment:** The same spirit of curiosity and reason, now turned toward the social world; Enlightenment scholars, influenced by the scientific revolution, sought a scientific/rational form of governance for society .
- **French Revolution:** Treated as an effect/outcome of Enlightenment ideas .
- **Counter-Enlightenment:** The conservative reaction that resisted the Enlightenment/French Revolution's changes; resistance to an idea is itself a form of intellectual change, so Counter-Enlightenment also counts as an intellectual force .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Industrial Revolution should NOT be listed as an intellectual force**—it is a material force, not a change in ideas/thinking .
- **Analogy:** Education is an idea (intellectual force); a textbook is a concrete/material object—part of education but not itself an intellectual force .
- Conservative reaction to the French Revolution and Enlightenment gave rise to '**French sociology**', which was conservative in character—it favoured reform, not revolution .

QUICK REVISION

- **Sequence:** Renaissance → Scientific Renaissance → Enlightenment → French Revolution → Counter-Enlightenment (conservative reaction) → Emergence of Sociology .
- **Renaissance keywords:** Humanism, individualism, secularism .
- Industrial Revolution = material force, **NOT** an intellectual force—common error to avoid in writing .

2.1.3 Auguste Comte, 'Intellectual Disorder' and Positivism

Auguste Comte was a positivist scholar; the duty of a positivist scholar is to uncover the laws that govern the social world, just as natural laws (e.g., day following night) govern the natural world .

KEY CONCEPT

Intellectual disorder (Comte): Even though society had entered the scientific age (around 1800), people continued to explain the world in religious and metaphysical (abstract) terms rather than scientific terms—this persistence of pre-scientific thought amid a scientific age is what Comte called intellectual disorder .

- Comte, writing in the context of the French Revolution and Enlightenment, observed visible disorder around him (executions, revolts) and, as a self-styled 'scientist of society', claimed he could identify why disorder existed and predict when order would be restored .
- **Reason for disorder, per Comte:** Religious and metaphysical explanations still competed with scientific explanations in the popular mind—order would return only once one single form of knowledge (scientific knowledge) was accepted by everyone without dispute .

CRITICAL POINT

- Comte did not ‘undermine’ or condemn religion as such—he was himself a conservative who did not like religion or monarchy being challenged; he was scientifically describing the co-existence of religious/metaphysical and scientific thought as the cause of disorder, not attacking religion .
- **Modern illustration cited:** Ashis Nandy and T. N. Madan have argued that although India is constitutionally secular, Indians remain deeply religious in practice—offered as an example of persisting non-scientific thought .

Law of (Three) Stages Comte held that every society passes through three stages, analogous to the stages of a human life (infancy, adulthood, old age) :

1. **Theological stage (up to c. 1300 AD):** Everything is explained in religious terms (e.g., ‘obey the priestly class to reach heaven’); corresponds to the medieval/dark ages, before the Renaissance .
2. **Metaphysical stage (c. 1300–1800 AD):** An abstract, in-between stage: society has moved past pure religious explanation but has not yet reached concrete scientific explanation . The intellectual forces from Renaissance to Counter-Enlightenment unfolded within this ~ 500-year stage .
3. **Scientific stage (from c. 1800 onward):** Everything is explained through scientific facts rather than religion or abstraction .

EXAMPLE

- **Rain example across the three stages:**
 - *Theological stage:* Perform rituals/havan to bring rain .
 - *Metaphysical stage:* Reject ritual but simply wait, without yet knowing the scientific cause .
 - *Scientific stage:* Spraying silver iodide (AgI) on clouds to induce artificial rain .
- **‘Man the conqueror’** is the idea of the scientific stage: the same man once thought ‘cursed’ by asteroids sent by God can now, in the scientific stage, deflect an asteroid .

Comte’s Vision for Sociology & Positivism

- Comte believed sociology could: (1) help societies advance into the scientific stage; (2) help society understand the reasons for disorder; (3) help study the laws governing social order and social disorder .
- Positivism, per Comte, is the philosophy that can help discover these laws; its underlying assumption is that society can be studied scientifically .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Comte’s thesis:** “Much as the natural world is governed by laws of physics, so does society [have its own laws]” .
- The biggest challenge for a sociologist, unlike a doctor (who can see/dissect the human body) or a geologist (who can see/cut rocks), is that society itself cannot be directly seen—only

fragments of it (individuals, organisations) are visible .

CRITICAL POINT

- Because sociology studies something not directly visible, Comte called sociology the ‘**Queen of Sciences**’—uncovering laws of an invisible social world is a tougher challenge than studying a visible natural object .
- Critics have called positivism a new form of religion, and positivists a new form of clergy—flagged as a critical debate .
- **Predictive science:** Besides uncovering laws, positivists claim to predict the future of the social world, just as natural scientists predict natural events .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **Marxism as a positivist philosophy:** It too claims to uncover laws of the social world and to predict—Marx predicted that revolution is inevitable, that the working class will overthrow the bourgeoisie and establish socialism, followed by communism .
- **Personal example (Teacher’s experience at DRDO, Jodhpur):** Working on a repetitive, highly specialised alloy-development task for months raised the question of whether this was Marx’s ‘alienation’—doing a specialised, repetitive task can make one feel like “a cog in the machine” .
- **Contrast offered:** The IAS is considered the one service (besides the IFS) that avoids alienation, because officers rotate across very different departments (e.g., Education one year, Mines the next) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Intellectual disorder:** Persistence of religious/metaphysical thought despite society having entered the scientific age . Comte diagnosed this co-existence as the cause of disorder .
- **Law of Three Stages:** Theological (–1300) → Metaphysical (1300–1800) → Scientific (1800–) .
- **Comte:** Sociology should study laws of social order/disorder; positivism assumes society can be studied scientifically and is predictive .
- **‘Queen of Sciences’:** Sociology is so named because society cannot be seen as a whole .
- **Marxism:** Positivist philosophy predicting inevitable revolution → socialism → communism .

2.1.4 Precursors to Sociology

KEY CONCEPT

A **precursor** is a discipline that existed prior to sociology and addressed, in a partial way, questions that sociology would later take up as a full discipline .

1. **Philosophy of History:** Held that society moves in a linear fashion, from a simple to a complex stage .

2. **Biological Theory of Evolution:** Compared society to a human body: just as the body grows from infancy to adulthood through multiple organs (heart, liver, kidney, brain—all equally important), society too consists of multiple, equally important parts (economy, religion, family, media, state, law) .
 - **Herbert Spencer** is credited as the scholar who first compared human body and society in this way (later termed the ‘**organic analogy**’) .
3. **Survey of Social Conditions:** Through survey-based study, it was discovered for the first time that poverty is not a creation of God/fate but is socially constructed—specifically, a structural condition arising from industrialisation (e.g., slum development) .

EXAMPLE

- **Illustration:** Dalits are, on data, relatively poorer than upper-caste groups—not because of any ‘natural’ deficiency, but because of caste as a social factor (itself rooted in religion), showing poverty to be structurally caused rather than natural .
- **Hymn reflecting older pre-survey view:** “*The rich man in his castle, the poor man at his gate, God made them high and lowly, and ordered their estate*” .
- **Modern policy classification:** Government poverty classifications such as *Antyodaya Anna Yojana* and BPL/APL categories—poverty is now studied and classified, not attributed to divine will .
- **Exam note:** In an answer on the emergence of sociology, combining the intellectual forces with these three precursors accounts for roughly 60–70 words of the 150 words expected .

QUICK REVISION

- **Three precursors:** Philosophy of History (simple → complex), Biological Theory of Evolution (organic analogy—Herbert Spencer), Survey of Social Conditions (poverty as structurally/socially constructed) .
- Combine intellectual forces + 3 precursors for a complete 10-marker on the emergence of sociology .

2.1.5 Doubts Addressed (Day 1)

DATA & FACTS

- **American sociology** (covered under Unit 4) includes three syllabus scholars: Talcott Parsons, Robert K. Merton, and George Herbert Mead .
- **Nobel Prize in Sociology:** Only one sociologist has ever won a Nobel Prize—**Jane Addams**, a female sociologist who worked on poverty and slums in America (awarded the Nobel Peace Prize) .
- **Philosophy of History (re-explained):** History/society moves from simple to complex—e.g., France once had one dominant religion and one form of family; today, with religious/social diversity, the state must be secular (equal distance from all religions) to survive .

- **Social thought vs. sociology:** Social thought is a very general term (how anyone thinks about society), not a discipline in itself; sociology is a formal, scientific discipline .
- **Why Comte called disorder ‘intellectual’:** If, even after enlightenment/scientific progress, society still relies on religious or caste-based belief for legitimacy, that persistence of pre-scientific thinking is itself the disorder—just as constitutional morality requires everyone to actually believe in the constitution, not merely have it exist on paper .
- **Why early sociologists wanted sociology to be scientific:** The dominant mode of thought was scientific observation and experimentation (Galileo, Kepler, Copernicus) and the rational, doubting man; sociology’s founders wanted the same rigour to uncover the laws governing society .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Metanarrative:** Grand, totalising belief systems (“*badi badi baatein*”)—e.g., Marxism’s promise of moving the world toward egalitarianism . Such ideologies are increasingly seen as having ‘failed’ in practice: even self-declared communist parties today often support positions that do not strictly follow their own ideology, showing ground reality has diverged from the grand ideological narrative .
- **Nuclear family as a concept:** A. M. Shah (sociologist, Delhi School of Economics, colleague of André Bétaille) argued that the concept of the ‘nuclear family’, in its strict Western sense of complete disconnection from extended kin, does not really exist in India—even when Indian children live away from parents, daily contact with parents typically continues .

QUICK REVISION

- American sociology scholars: Parsons, Merton, Mead .
- Only Nobel laureate sociologist: Jane Addams (poverty/slum work, USA) .
- Metanarrative = grand totalising ideological belief that has lost practical traction .
- A. M. Shah: Western-style disconnected ‘nuclear family’ does not truly exist in India .

2.1.6 Structural Functionalism (Introduction)

CRITICAL POINT

- **Synonymous terms:** Structural functionalism $\equiv$ functionalism $\equiv$ structural theory $\equiv$ consensus theory $\equiv$ consensus structuralism—all refer to the same overarching theory .
- **Key scholars:** Herbert Spencer, Auguste Comte, Émile Durkheim .
- **Core idea:** Society is analogous to the human body . The body has multiple organs (brain, heart, lungs, liver, kidney), each performing a function needed for survival; society similarly has multiple parts/organs (religion, economy, law, family, state, media), each performing a vital function for social survival .

EXAMPLE

- **Function of religion:** Provides norms/ethics for a moral life . Example—the Ten Command-

ments in Christianity; the five precepts (*Panchsheel*) in Buddhism (no killing, no stealing, no lying, no intoxicants, no sexual misconduct); Jain teachings similarly .

- **Classroom illustration:** If all students share the same religious norms (e.g., Buddhist norms against alcohol), order is maintained; introducing one member with very different norms creates conflict—shared norms sustain social order .
- **Social equilibrium:** The state of maintained order that results when all social organs function properly—borrowed from the biological concept of **homeostasis** .
- **Function of law:** Prevents deviance and activates when norms/order are broken . *Personal example:* Waiting at a red light while another rider jumps it; the rule-breaker is later caught by police, restoring faith that law maintains order .
- **Pathology:** When an organ of society malfunctions or stops functioning .
- **Cure for pathology:** Social reforms, not revolution—revolution is compared to an organ transplant (a last resort, not the first step) .

CRITICAL POINT

- If organs fail altogether, society becomes ‘disabled’—disorder results .
- **Economic malfunctions:** Recession, inflation, hyperinflation, stagflation .
- **Lockdown illustration:** The COVID-19 lockdown is framed as the state/law ‘organ’ functioning to prevent greater systemic collapse (more deaths) .
- **French Revolution (revisited):** When religion (questioned for the first time) and economy (weakened by the Seven Years’ War and support for the American Revolution) both malfunctioned together, the wider social order collapsed into anarchy .

QUICK REVISION

- Structural functionalism = consensus theory; society = human body (organs maintain social equilibrium / homeostasis) .
- Pathology = organ malfunction; cure = social reform (revolution is an extreme last resort) .
- Coinciding malfunction of multiple organs (religion + economy) leads to social collapse/anarchy .

2.2 Marxism, Sociological Imagination & Total Institutions

2.2.1 Marxism

COMPARISON

- **Structural Functionalists:** Hold that all parts/organs of society (religion, economy, state, family, media, law) are equally important, each contributing its own function to maintain society (e.g., economy distributes resources, investment, jobs, and growth) .

- **Karl Marx:** Disagrees—in the human body, one organ (the brain) controls all others and is most important. By the same logic (organic analogy), in society, the **economy is the brain** and is therefore the most important organ; all other organs are secondary and controlled by the economy.

KEY CONCEPT

Marx's model of society rests on two core claims:

1. **Base and Superstructure:** Economy is the **base** of society; all other institutions (religion, law, family, state—termed the '**superstructure**') are secondary and determined/controlled by the economic base.
2. **Two-Class Model:** Society consists fundamentally of two classes: the **bourgeoisie** and the **proletariat**.

Bourgeoisie, Proletariat & Means of Production

- Every historical epoch runs on a specific means of production. In the feudal era, land was the main source of livelihood—the dominant group controlled land (zamindars/feudal lords); the dependent group worked the land for wages (kisans/peasants).
- With the Industrial Revolution, the economy shifted from agrarian (primary sector) to manufacturing (secondary sector); mass production required machines, and the dominant group became those who owned industries/factories.
- **Bourgeoisie:** Those who own the means of production (owners of capital/industry).
- **Proletariat (working class):** Those who do not own the means of production and depend entirely on selling their labour power for wages.

EXAMPLE

Worked example (Motorcycle design):

- A talented engineer designs a new motorcycle and sells the design to a company owner for a one-time payment of Rs. 2,00,000.
- The company manufactures and sells 1,00,000 units at Rs. 80,000 each—generating a total revenue of Rs. 800 crore ($80,000 \times 1,00,000 = 8,00,00,00,000$).
- The designer receives only Rs. 2 lakh, while the bourgeoisie owner captures the massive ongoing surplus value/profit generated by that labour.

How the Superstructure Supports the Bourgeoisie

- **Family:** When the exploited designer complains about being underpaid relative to corporate profits, the family (spouse/parents) pacifies him (e.g., advising him to gift his boss on Diwali, or focus on job security), preventing revolt and returning him quietly to work. Family thus functions to maintain capitalist stability.
- **Religion:** When a worker seeks a raise or promotion and is told by the employer to read the *Bhagavad Gita* ("*karam karo, phal ki chinta mat karo*"—do your duty, do not worry about the fruits/rewards), religion is invoked as an ideological tool to induce patient subservience.

without challenging structural exploitation .

- **Law:** An ordinary person stealing Rs. 1,00,000 is swiftly arrested and jailed, whereas large-scale corporate fraud and corruption by economic elites rarely results in equal punishment . Economist **Kaushik Basu** (former Chief Economic Advisor, GoI) termed this the '**Sanskritisation of corruption**'—elite corruption is normalised and shielded .
- **State:** During the COVID-19 lockdown, multiple state governments suspended labour laws (e.g., minimum-wage guarantees, working-hour regulations under the Factory Act 1948/1961, and the Maternity Benefit Act) .
 - *Justification:* Attracting Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) and improving India's rank on the World Bank's Ease of Doing Business Index .
 - *Capital flight constraint:* Raising wages or labour protections prompts multinational capital to relocate to countries with cheaper labour, severely constraining the state's capacity to act purely in workers' interests .
- **Conclusion (Marx):** Superstructural institutions promote values that conceal exploitation . Only when workers develop '**true consciousness**' (as opposed to false consciousness) can they unite to overthrow capitalism through revolution, establishing an egalitarian socialist/communist society where workers collectively control the means of production .

COMPARISON

Both structural functionalism and Marxism emerged as theoretical reactions coinciding with the rise of modernity (modern state, formal law, and nuclear family are all products of modernity) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Marx's model:** Economy = Base (the brain); Religion, law, family, state = Superstructure (serves the bourgeoisie) .
- **Classes:** Bourgeoisie (owners of means of production) vs. Proletariat (sellers of labour power) .
- Superstructural institutions pacify dissent, legitimate inequality, and conceal surplus-value extraction .
- **Transformation:** Requires moving from false consciousness to **true consciousness** → revolution → worker ownership of means of production .

2.2.2 Sociological Imagination — Personal Trouble vs. Public Issue

EXAMPLE

- **Jewellery shop example:** A shop assistant earning Rs. 40,000 per month steals jewellery worth Rs. 3,00,000 . Common sense brands him a 'thief' . From a Marxist perspective, the real thief is the owner who appropriates the massive surplus value produced by the assistant's labour while paying a subsistence wage .
- **Societal values:** A society obsessed with material success (e.g., the 'American Dream' glorified through mass media and cinema) structurally propels deprived individuals toward crime; the

root cause lies in social values, not individual pathology .

Personal Trouble vs. Public Issue

EXAMPLE

- **Infertility:** One couple unable to conceive is a personal trouble (medical consultation); when millions face infertility, it becomes a public issue (declining fertility rates, state demographic policies like China's former one-child policy) .
- **Unemployment:** One person unemployed is a personal trouble; when 50 million people are unemployed, it is a structural public issue of economic organisation .

KEY CONCEPT

Sociological Imagination (C. Wright Mills): The capacity to shift from one perspective to another—to understand that what appears to be an individual's personal trouble is rooted in public issues and structural arrangements of society .

- **Critique of liberal democracy:** Formal legal equality (e.g., Article 14 of the Indian Constitution) fosters the illusion of equal opportunity, encouraging society to blame individuals for structural failures .
- **Suicide:** A single suicide appears as a personal tragedy; but 8–9 million suicides globally each year reflect deep structural causes . Marriage acts as an integrating institution that reduces suicide risk by embedding individuals in supportive networks .
- **Workplace boredom:** An individual feeling bored is a personal trouble; hundreds of millions experiencing chronic monotony reflects the public issue of **alienation** under extreme division of labour .

QUICK REVISION

- **Sociological imagination (C. Wright Mills):** Personal troubles $\equiv$ public issues rooted in social structure .
- **Applications:** Unemployment, infertility / declining fertility, suicide rates, and workplace alienation .

2.2.3 Finding Patterns in Different Institutions — Surveillance & Foucault

COMPARISON

Common sense views school, factory, and prison as entirely unrelated . A sociological perspective identifies a shared structural pattern: each institution contains a population of 'inmates' (students, workers, prisoners) subject to hierarchy, surveillance, and disciplinary power .

KEY CONCEPT

Michel Foucault and Disciplinary Power:

- **The Panopticon:** Designed by Jeremy Bentham as an architectural model for prisons (a

central watchtower surrounded by peripheral cells) . Inmates can see the tower but cannot see inside it, creating the permanent illusion of being watched .

- **Disciplinary power vs. Sovereign power:** Historically, power was ‘sovereign’—spectacular, violent, and episodic (public executions, gallows) . Modern power is ‘disciplinary’—subtle, invisible, continuous, and internalised through surveillance (e.g., motorists slowing down at CCTV signs regardless of whether cameras are active) .

EXAMPLE

In schools, the principal’s office or staff room on an elevated floor with one-way vision mirrors the Panopticon watchtower, enforcing student discipline through potential visibility .

QUICK REVISION

- **Foucault’s Panopticon (Bentham):** Constant visibility/illusion of surveillance creates internalised self-discipline .
- **Shift in power:** Sovereign power (public spectacles of execution) → Disciplinary power (surveillance in schools, factories, prisons) .

2.2.4 Total Institutions (Erving Goffman)

KEY CONCEPT

Total Institutions (Erving Goffman): Places of residence and work where a large number of like-situated individuals, cut off from the wider community for an appreciable period of time, lead an enclosed, formally administered round of life .

- **Examples:** Mental asylums, boarding schools (e.g., Doon School, Mayo College, Wellington College), cult organisations (e.g., Brahma Kumaris headquarters at Mount Abu), and military cantonments/prisons .
- **Shared characteristics:**
 1. *Physical isolation:* Geographically segregated on city outskirts or remote hills .
 2. *Distinct internal rules:* Autonomous rule systems governing all daily conduct .
 3. *Enforced uniformity:* Stripping of personal identity markers (surrender of phones, civil clothes, watches) and imposition of standardised uniforms, schedules, and speech patterns .
- **Mortification of the self:** The systematic erosion and alteration of an individual’s prior civilian identity and self-image upon entering a total institution .

QUICK REVISION

- **Total institutions (Goffman):** Isolated, strictly regulated environments (prisons, asylums, boarding schools, cantonments) .
- Key outcome = **mortification of self** via enforced uniformity and isolation .

2.2.5 Common Sense vs. Sociology (Introduction)

KEY CONCEPT

- **Common sense:** Naturalised, unexamined assumptions, subjective opinions, and localized folklore .
- **Sociology:** A systematic body of knowledge grounded in empirical evidence, scientific methodology, data classification, and verification of validity and reliability to generate theoretical models .
- Distinctively, social theories often carry ‘-ism’ labels (Marxism, Positivism, Functionalism), representing comprehensive theoretical frameworks .

Universal Sociological Theories

KEY CONCEPT

- **Alienation (Marx):** Universal across sectors . A specialised PhD graduate or corporate employee becomes alienated from broader human capacities through hyper-specialisation . The IAS avoids alienation through cross-departmental administrative rotations, unlike single-domain services like the IRS . A homemaker restricted purely to domestic chores similarly suffers alienation from wider social potentials .
- **Reference Group Theory:** Coined by Herbert Hyman and developed by Robert K. Merton . Individuals evaluate their achievements against a chosen standard group, experience **relative deprivation**, and conform to the reference group’s norms and routines (e.g., UPSC aspirants adopting the study schedules of successful toppers) .

QUICK REVISION

- Common sense = assumption/opinion; Sociology = empirical scientific methodology .
- Universal theories: Marx’s **Alienation** (hyper-specialisation) and Merton’s **Reference Group Theory** (relative deprivation and emulation) .

2.3 Common Sense vs. Sociology, Scope & Schools of Thought

2.3.1 Common Sense vs. Sociology: Studying the Same Object Differently

COMPARISON

- **Constable:** Executes administrative orders to apprehend an offender .
- **IPS Officer / Administrator:** Formulates district policies and policing strategies to reduce crime rates .
- **Psychologist:** Studies internal cognitive traits, deviance, and the ‘criminal mind’ .
- **Sociologist:** Investigates why crime exists as a structural phenomenon, how social norms define deviance, and who possesses the power to criminalise specific acts .

- **Relativity of crime:** Killing another human is murder in civil society, but celebrated as valour in warfare against an enemy soldier—demonstrating that criminality is a socially constructed definition .

Common Sense is Local and Temporal — Not Universal

EXAMPLE

- **Temporal variability:** Slavery was universally accepted for centuries but is now a heinous crime; women's disenfranchisement was once standard; homosexuality was criminalised historically, decriminalised in the UK/Europe around 2014, with same-sex marriage battles continuing today .
- **Spatial/cultural variability:** Dietary taboos against chicken on Tuesdays exist in North India but not in South or North-East India; the matrilineal **Khasi** of Meghalaya trace property through daughters; the **Mosuo** tribe of Yunnan (China) practice walking marriages with no formal marriage institution or paternal co-residence .
- **Sociological theory** seeks universal structural explanations across these disparate manifestations .

QUICK REVISION

- Common sense is time-bound (temporal) and place-bound (local/particular) .
- Sociology analyzes how definitions of reality (e.g., crime, family, marriage) are socially constructed and historically contingent .

2.3.2 Comparative Method: Caste and Race

COMPARISON

Common sense treats caste (ritual hierarchy) and race (biological phenotype) as completely separate categories . The comparative method reveals shared structural characteristics :

1. **Endogamy:** Strict rules requiring marriage within the designated sub-group .
2. **Commensality restrictions:** Taboos against inter-dining and physical proximity .
3. **Segregated rules and status hierarchies:** Rigid caste/racial codes enforced by dominant groups .

Sociologist **Oliver Cromwell Cox** famously observed that “*race is nothing but coloured caste*” .

QUICK REVISION

- **Comparative method:** Uncovers structural parallels between caste and race (endogamy, commensal taboos, occupational closure) .
- **Oliver Cox:** Race is structurally equivalent to a system of coloured caste .

2.3.3 Functions of Institutions & Public Issues

KEY CONCEPT

Structural functionalists uncover systemic functions invisible to common-sense perception .

- **Function of Law:** Functions like the biological **nervous system**—enforcing social discipline, resolving disputes, defining boundaries of deviance, and re-establishing social equilibrium .

EXAMPLE

Population Growth as a Public Issue:

- A family having five children appears as a personal choice . When aggregate data shows national expansion (e.g., India adding millions annually), it is a structural public issue .
- Sociological inquiry identifies the root cause not merely as ‘illiteracy’ (a statistical correlation), but as deeply entrenched patriarchal values manifesting as ‘**son-meta preference**’—continuing childbearing until male heirs are born .

QUICK REVISION

- Law acts as the nervous system of society, containing deviance .
- Demographic growth is structurally explained through patriarchy and son-meta preference rather than simple illiteracy .

2.3.4 Unpaid Labour, Data as Work & Defamiliarisation

CRITICAL POINT

- **Data as Unpaid Work:** Browsing digital platforms (Facebook, Amazon, Myntra) is experienced as leisure, but user activity generates commercial data harvested for corporate profitability—unpaid digital labour .
- **Unpaid Domestic Work:** Devaluing housework as non-productive is a patriarchal social construct unsupported by physical energy expenditure .
 - **Selma James (1972):** Launched the ‘*Wages for Housework*’ campaign .
 - **Policy impact:** In January 2021, Kamal Haasan’s political party in Tamil Nadu included wages for housewives in its electoral manifesto, triggering widespread emulation by rival political parties .
- **Defamiliarisation:** A concept formulated by **Zygmunt Bauman**—sociology acts to make the familiar strange, breaking through common-sense naturalisations to reveal underlying social construction .

QUICK REVISION

- Digital engagement and domestic chores represent unrecognised, unpaid labour .
- **Defamiliarisation (Zygmunt Bauman):** Revealing that what appears ‘natural’ is socially constructed .

2.3.5 Scope of Sociology

Sociology examines everything from interpersonal interactions to macro-historical processes .

EXAMPLE

- **Micro:** Classroom theatrical role performances (Shakespeare: “*All the world’s a stage*”) .
- **Macro:** Global inequality, such as dependency theories arguing European industrial development occurred via colonial underdevelopment of India .

CRITICAL POINT

- Sociology emerged to study the crises and transformations of modernity, leading to two core debates: (1) What is the legitimate boundary/scope of the discipline? (2) How does sociology study subjects already covered by economics or psychology?
- *Open question on science:* Is Yoga a science? The Indian Medical Association (IMA) often classifies AYUSH practices as pseudo-science; evaluating such claims requires first defining the rigorous criteria of scientific epistemology .

QUICK REVISION

- Scope ranges from micro-interaction to macro-structural dependency .
- Core task: Distinguishing sociological methodology from sister social sciences .

2.3.6 Synthetic School vs. Formalist School

COMPARISON

- **Synthetic School (Mainly French — Comte, Durkheim, Hobhouse, Ginsberg):** Believed sociology must synthesize all social sciences, studying society as an integrated totality—“everything under the sun” .
- **Formalist / Specialistic School (Mainly German — Simmel, Weber, Tönnies, Von Wiese):** Argued sociology should be a distinct, specialised science studying specific forms of social interaction and human action rather than society in its entirety .

Durkheim’s Three Branches of Sociology (Synthetic School)

1. **Social Morphology:** Demography, population density, geographical distribution, sex ratio, fertility, and mortality .
2. **Social Physiology:** Dynamic social institutions—religion, law, economy, politics, and culture .
3. **General Sociology:** Formulating universal sociological laws and synthesizing overarching social principles .
4. *Note:* **Social Pathology** is often recognized as a branch studying societal breakdowns, criminality, communal violence, and domestic abuse .

Morris Ginsberg’s Classification (Synthetic School) Ginsberg divided sociology into four distinct branches :

1. **Social Morphology:** Population dynamics and social structures .
2. **Social Control:** Law, religion, morals, customs, and conventions .
3. **Social Processes:** Interactions such as cooperation, competition, conflict, and assimilation .
4. **Social Pathology:** Maladjustments, poverty, crime, and social disintegration .

Formalist Contributions: Tönnies and Simmel

COMPARISON

Ferdinand Tönnies: Typology of Human Association

- **Gemeinschaft (Community / Pre-industrial):** Characterised by primary relationships, high intimacy, emotional bonds, collective consciousness (“we-feeling”), and traditional rural life (Gandhian village model) .
- **Gesellschaft (Association / Post-industrial):** Characterised by contractual relations, individualism (“I-feeling”), impersonal exchange, instrumental rationality, and the urban ‘**blasé attitude**’ (indifference toward others in urban environments) .

KEY CONCEPT

Georg Simmel: Forms of Social Interaction Simmel argued sociology should study the **forms of association** rather than the specific content . Universal recurring forms include:

- Cooperation and Conflict
- Centralisation and Decentralisation
- Superordination and Subordination

QUICK REVISION

- **Synthetic School (Comte, Durkheim):** Sociology is an encyclopedic synthesis . Durkheim’s branches: Morphology, Physiology, General Sociology .
- **Formalist School (Simmel, Weber, Tönnies):** Specific forms of interaction .
- **Tönnies:** Gemeinschaft (community/we-feeling) vs. Gesellschaft (association/blasé attitude) .
- **Simmel:** Focus on forms (cooperation/conflict, hierarchy) rather than content .

2.4 Social Action Theory, Caste Dynamics & Sociology vs. Psychology

2.4.1 Sociology Becoming Part of Common Sense

CRITICAL POINT

While sociology critiques common sense, sociological concepts diffuse into public discourse, becoming commonsensical over generations :

- **‘Defence mechanism’** — Coined by Sigmund Freud, now ubiquitous in daily speech .

- **'Role model'** — Formulated by Robert K. Merton, now standard vocabulary .
- **'Vote bank'** — Coined by Indian sociologist M. N. Srinivas, now central to political journalism .
- **Anthony Giddens** conceptualised this process as the reflexive appropriation of sociological knowledge by lay actors .

QUICK REVISION

- Concepts coined in sociology/psychology (defence mechanism, role model, vote bank) regularly pass into everyday common sense (Anthony Giddens) .

2.4.2 Caste: Consensus and Conflict Perspectives

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Decentralisation and Conflict (Simmel's Forms): The **Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act, 2005** granted equal coparcenary property rights to daughters . This legal decentralisation of inheritance from sons-only to sons-and-daughters disrupted traditional patriarchal centralisation, creating new intra-familial conflicts over property despite customary familial affection .

COMPARISON

Dual Nature of Caste Organisation:

- **Consensus / Functional Model:** The traditional *Chaturvarna* division of labour (Brahmins = knowledge, Kshatriyas = protection, Vaishyas = trade, Shudras = service) functioned cooperatively without direct economic competition . Early Gandhi highlighted this functional interdependence .
- **Conflict Model:** Rigid caste stratification enforces severe systemic oppression, untouchability, commensal bans, and temple-entry denials (historically against Dalits; gendered exclusions as in the Sabarimala dispute) . Gandhi's perspective shifted toward anti-untouchability following B. R. Ambedkar's assertions around the Poona Pact (1932) .

QUICK REVISION

- Hindu Succession Amendment illustrates how institutional decentralisation generates new relational conflict .
- Caste can be viewed through consensus (non-competitive division of labour) or conflict (structural dominance and ritual exclusion) .

2.4.3 Institutions in Transition: Gemeinschaft to Gesellschaft

COMPARISON

- **Popular Culture:** 1990s Bollywood cinema portrayed multi-generational joint families led by patriarchal elders (*Gemeinschaft*); contemporary cinema features individualistic, career-driven protagonists (*Gesellschaft*) .

- **Gender Relations:** Subjugated notions of female obligation (“*Dharam Patni*”) have given way to individual rights, legal autonomy, and collective resistance (the **#MeToo** movement representing the shift from ‘we’ to ‘me/I’).
- **Family Formations:** Emergence of ‘**Living Apart Together**’ (**LAT**)—couples maintaining separate domestic residences due to dual professional careers (e.g., civil servant couples in different postings).

QUICK REVISION

- The transition to *Gesellschaft* manifests in delayed marriages, rising divorce rates, individual careerism, and non-traditional family structures.

2.4.4 Max Weber and Social Action Theory

KEY CONCEPT

Social Action (Max Weber — Formalist School): Action is ‘social’ insofar as its subjective meaning takes account of the behaviour of others and is thereby oriented in its course.

- Structural functionalism and Marxism analyze macro-structures; Weber focuses on the micro-level **subjective meanings and motives** of individual actors.
- *Institutional contrast:* Functionalism sees marriage as ensuring societal reproduction; Weber examines individual motives (e.g., securing permanent residency/visas, emotional intimacy, or financial security).

CRITICAL POINT

The Hathras Case & Religious Conversion as Social Action:

- Following the Hathras atrocity (the gang rape of a Dalit woman by upper-caste men), affected Dalit villagers converted to Buddhism as a deliberate act of political and religious protest.
- Functionalism cannot explain this phenomenon (since it views religion purely as a source of social harmony/order); conflict theory and social action theory explain it as an assertion of dignity and resistance against caste hierarchy.
- **Intersectionality:** Dalit women face compound oppression across the dual axes of caste hierarchy and gender subjugation.
- **Dr. B. R. Ambedkar:** Challenged the theological foundations of Hinduism (author of *Buddha and Karl Marx*); established the **Navayana** (‘new vehicle’) school of Buddhism, rejecting traditional Hinayana/Mahayana/Vajrayana quietism and redefining spiritual liberation as social emancipation.

Macro, Meso, and Micro Levels of Sociological Analysis

KEY CONCEPT

1. **Macro-Sociology:** Grand structures, total systems, economy, state, and global patterns (Structural Functionalism, Marxism).

2. **Meso-Sociology:** Intermediate institutions, formal organisations, communities, and forms of relationship (Simmel, Tönnies) .
3. **Micro-Sociology:** Individual social action, face-to-face interaction, and subjective meanings (Weber, Goffman, Mead) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Max Weber:** Social action focuses on micro-level subjective meanings and motives .
- **Ambedkar & Navayana:** Reinterpretation of Buddhism as emancipatory social action against caste .
- Sociological scope operates across **Macro** (structures), **Meso** (groups/forms), and **Micro** (action/meanings) .

2.4.5 Sociology vs. Psychology

COMPARISON

- **Psychology:** Studies individual cognition, mental states, neuro-biological systems, emotions, personality development, and internal pathologies in isolation from wider social structures .
- **Sociology:** Analyzes how social structures, institutions, and collective norms shape individual action and consciousness (examines the public/structural roots of personal problems) .

Freudian Psychoanalysis vs. Sociological Self

KEY CONCEPT

- **Sigmund Freud:** The psyche comprises the **Id** (instinctual, irrational, aggressive impulses), **Ego** (rational executive mediator), and **Superego** (internalised moral conscience) . Investigated via psychoanalysis (free association, dream analysis) . Freud viewed personality development as an internal psychic struggle largely independent of wider social variation .
- **Sociological Response (The Social Self):** George Herbert Mead demonstrated that the self develops socially through language and role-taking:

Self = 'I' (spontaneous, impulsive ego) + 'Me' (socialised, internalised expectations of society)

Consumer choices (e.g., buying an iPhone for social validation) reflect the socially conditioned 'Me' .

Theoretical Bridges: Roles and Social Psychology

KEY CONCEPT

- **Roles as building blocks:** Individuals do not act in a vacuum; they enact socially defined **roles** (doctor, parent, student, civil servant) .
- **Role Conflict:** Incompatible demands arising from holding two or more distinct roles simultaneously (e.g., an army officer balancing frontline military deployment with parental care; working a full-time job while preparing for UPSC) .

- **Role Strain:** Stress experienced within a single role due to conflicting or excessive expectations (e.g., Sachin Tendulkar facing overwhelming pressure while pursuing his 100th international century) .
- **Social Psychology:** The interdisciplinary bridge investigating how individual mental functioning is conditioned by group dynamics .

QUICK REVISION

- **Psychology** focuses on internal mental dynamics; **Sociology** focuses on social structures and context .
- Freud's Id/Ego/Superego countered by Mead's Social Self ('I' and 'Me') .
- Bridges: Social action theory, **role conflict** (between roles), and **role strain** (within a single role) .

2.5 Suicide, Impression Management, History & Economics

2.5.1 Suicide: Psychological vs. Sociological Perspective (Durkheim)

COMPARISON

- **Psychological approach:** Investigates idiosyncratic clinical factors—mental depression, neurosis, chemical imbalances, or private distress .
- **Sociological approach (Émile Durkheim):** Disregards individual psychological profiles to examine aggregate suicide rates across distinct social groups and institutions .

Durkheimian Demographic Patterns Durkheim's empirical study revealed systematic group-level regularities :

- **Unmarried vs. Married:** Single individuals exhibit higher suicide rates than married individuals .
- **Gender:** Men display higher suicide rates than women .
- **Peace vs. War:** Suicide rates consistently decline during periods of national wartime (e.g., during the Kargil War) and rise during peacetime .
- **Religion:** Protestants display higher suicide rates than Catholics due to differences in ecclesiastical integration .

KEY CONCEPT

Social Integration as an Explanatory Variable: Suicide rates vary inversely with the degree of social integration . Marriage binds the individual into a reciprocal web of domestic obligations; wartime generates intense collective solidarity and patriotism against a common adversary, submerging individual despair into national cohesion .

QUICK REVISION

- Durkheim proved suicide is a social fact governed by degrees of **social integration** and **social regulation** .
- Higher rates among single individuals, men, and peacetime societies .

2.5.2 'Individuals Do Not Exist, Only Roles Exist' & Impression Management**KEY CONCEPT**

Dramaturgical Perspective (Erving Goffman): Social life is staged like a theatrical performance where individuals manage impressions to project desired identities .

- **Front Stage:** Formal social settings where individuals perform before an audience according to strict scripts and role expectations (e.g., lecturing in class, meeting clients, answering a phone call from parents while outside) .
- **Backstage:** Private spaces where performers can drop their public facade, relax, express hidden emotions, and rehearse future performances (e.g., lounging alone at home) .
- **Impression Management:** The deliberate cognitive and behavioural adjustments made by an individual to control the information received by others in social interactions .

QUICK REVISION

- **Goffman's Dramaturgy:** Social life = performance; Front stage (public performance) vs. Backstage (private relaxation) .
- **Impression management:** Continual tailoring of behaviour across social situations .

2.5.3 Sociology vs. History**COMPARISON**

- **Traditional History:** Chronological, descriptive documentation of unique past events, political regimes, treaties, and individual leaders (ancient, medieval, modern) .
- **Sociology:** Analytical, generalizing study of modern social structures, institutional evolution, patterns of human association, and recurring structural transformations .

Competing Historiographies of the French Revolution Historical facts do not speak for themselves; theoretical perspectives determine their meaning :

- **Marxist Historiography (Georges Lefebvre, Karl Marx):** The revolution was a classic bourgeois transformation where the rising capitalist class overturned feudal nobility, using popular peasant discontent to seize state power .
- **Revisionist Historiography (Alfred Cobban):** Challenges the Marxist thesis, demonstrating that the revolutionary leadership comprised educated professionals, jurists, and civil servants rather than industrial capitalists .
- **Conspiracy / Intellectualist View:** Frames the revolution as an orchestrated campaign by Enlightenment intellectuals against Church hegemony .

Feminist Historiography

CRITICAL POINT

Mainstream nationalist historical narratives focus almost exclusively on male figures (Gandhi, Nehru, Patel, Ambedkar) while obscuring women's mass mobilization .

- **Dandi Salt March (1930):** Mahatma Gandhi initially opposed women's active participation in the march; women were included only following the fierce intervention of **Sarojini Naidu** . Historical interpretations diverge on whether Gandhi sought to protect women from police brutality or reflected patriarchal assumptions about female capability .

Vertical vs. Horizontal Mobilisation

COMPARISON

- **Vertical Mobilisation:** An elite, Western-educated upper-caste leader mobilising subaltern masses from above (e.g., Gandhi during the Champaran Satyagraha of 1917)—which can inadvertently reinforce the assumption that subalterns require elite patronage .
- **Horizontal Mobilisation:** Subaltern groups mobilising autonomously under their own leadership to assert structural rights (e.g., **Periyar E. V. Ramasamy's Self-Respect Movement** in Tamil Nadu against Brahminical ritual dominance) .

Structural Representation Data: Upper castes continue to hold disproportionate representation in higher bureaucracy and Parliament (~ 80% of nominated Rajya Sabha members historically) . Scholar **Kancha Ilaiah** polemically termed the IAS the '*Indian Brahminical Service*' .

Subaltern, Colonialist, Orientalist, and Nationalist Historiography

KEY CONCEPT

- **Subaltern Historiography (Ranajit Guha, Shahid Amin):** Reconstructs history from the perspective of marginalized social groups (peasants, tribals, women, Dalits) ignored by elite historiography .
 - **Shahid Amin (Gorakhpur, 1921–22):** Analyzed the 'making of the Mahatma', showing that local peasant myths, religious visions, and rumours transformed Gandhi into a messianic figure, challenging the simplistic narrative that the title was merely conferred by Rabindranath Tagore .
 - **Literary Subaltern Voices:** Mulk Raj Anand (*Coolie, Untouchable*) and Arundhati Roy (*The God of Small Things*) center subaltern experiences; R. K. Narayan portrays everyday life .
- **Colonialist Historiography (James Mill):** Periodised Indian history into Hindu, Muslim, and British eras, presenting colonial rule as a 'civilising mission' .
- **Orientalist Historiography (William Jones, Max Müller):** Celebrated ancient Sanskrit texts and Indian classical philosophy (founding of the Asiatic Society) .
- **Nationalist Historiography (Jawaharlal Nehru — *Discovery of India*):** Emphasised civilisational unity, composite culture, and anti-colonial resistance .

KEY CONCEPT

Mutual Dependence of Sociology and History: “*Sociology is rootless without history; history is fruitless without sociology*” (formulated by Charles Tilly) .

- **Historical Sociology:** Examines institutional trajectories over time (e.g., how caste transitioned from an occupational hierarchy into a vehicle for modern democratic political mobilization) .
- **Comparative Revolution Theory (Theda Skocpol):** Whereas historians focus on the differences between the French, Russian, Chinese, and American revolutions, Skocpol’s *States and Social Revolutions* identified a common structural causality: state breakdown caused by the coincidence of **international geopolitical/financial pressure** and **domestic peasant revolt** .

QUICK REVISION

- Historiography proves facts require theoretical interpretation (Marxist, Revisionist, Feminist, Subaltern, Colonialist, Nationalist) .
- **Tilly:** Sociology is rootless without history; history is fruitless without sociology .
- **Theda Skocpol:** Common structural patterns of revolution (external pressure + internal revolt) .

2.5.4 Sociology vs. Economics**COMPARISON**

- **Classical Economics:** Assumes markets are autonomous, self-regulating systems operating via pure price mechanisms of supply and demand, ‘disembedded’ from social relations .
- **Sociology:** Assumes economic actions are deeply **embedded** in social networks, political structures, cultural values, and state institutions .
- **Empirical instances of state market regulation:** The *Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana* during the pandemic, post-2008 regulatory interventions across global capital markets, and the Reserve Bank of India’s regulatory frameworks managing non-performing assets (NPAs) .

Homo Economicus vs. Bounded Rationality**KEY CONCEPT**

- **Homo Economicus:** Classical economic model of man as a perfectly rational, atomistic, profit-maximizing, utility-calculating actor .
- **Sociological Limitations:** Cannot explain altruism, charity, voluntary sacrifice, unpaid care work, or caste-based occupational stratification where lower castes remain clustered in hazardous occupations despite formal legal market access .
- **Veblen Goods & Conspicuous Consumption (Thorstein Veblen):** Goods purchased primarily to signal wealth and social prestige (e.g., luxury iPhones, high-end watches, five-star hospitality), directly violating the economic law of demand .

- **Bounded Rationality:** Economic decisions are framed, bounded, and directed by social norms, peer pressure, and institutional contexts .

Max Weber: *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*

KEY CONCEPT

Where economics explains capitalism through capital accumulation and technical innovations, Max Weber identified religious ideas as a primary catalyst :

- Weber demonstrated that modern rational capitalism emerged predominantly in regions dominated by **Calvinist / Protestant asceticism** .
- **Maxims of Benjamin Franklin:** “*Time is money*” and “*Work is worship*” encapsulated a religiously sanctioned work ethic .
- Diligent labour in one’s worldly calling (the ‘calling’) and systematic reinvestment of wealth—rather than lavish indulgence—functioned as psychological signs of divine salvation (doctrine of predestination), laying the cultural foundations for modern industrial capitalism .

QUICK REVISION

- **Embeddedness:** Economy is situated within social, cultural, and political institutions (critique of disembedded self-regulating markets) .
- **Veblen Goods & Conspicuous Consumption:** Status-signaling violates classical price-demand mechanics .
- **Weber’s Protestant Ethic:** Protestant asceticism provided the ethical ethos that stimulated modern industrial capitalism .

Sociology as Science: Methodologies, Positivism & Critiques

3.1 Answer Writing Practice and the Foundations of Reasoning

3.1.1 *Setting the Frame: Science as a Way of Life*

Unit 1 is now complete . Unit 2 is mainly about how you think—it is about you . The unit opens with a single question: what do we understand by science? Is science only about those laboratory experiments we have been seeing since childhood?

- Laboratory work—the white rat, laser radiation, and similar images—is scientific experiment . It is not the whole of science .
- People generally say religion is a way of life . Science is also a way of life . The question that follows is: how does science govern our lives, every single day?

KEY CONCEPT

- Science is not confined to the laboratory . Like religion, it is a way of life—a way of thinking that we practise daily without noticing it .
- The laboratory image (white rat, laser radiation) belongs to scientific experiment, which is only one part of science .

QUICK REVISION

- Unit 2 is about how you think .
- Science is a way of life, not only laboratory experiment .
- Central question of the unit: how does science govern our everyday lives?

3.1.2 *The Classroom Exercise: “Is Sociology Common Sense?”*

Before entering Unit 2, an answer-writing exercise was set in class . Students were asked to take out one A4 sheet and write the question: “*Is sociology common sense?*”

- The instruction was not to think about the answer as it will be after Unit 2 . Students had to write with the existing, preliminary knowledge available from Unit 1 alone .
- Once Unit 2 is done, a full-fledged understanding will develop . The purpose here was to check how the question would be solved with the knowledge already in hand .
- It is a 10-mark question, which means the answer must not exceed 150 words . The exercise

was timed, and roughly 8 minutes were available .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- “*Is sociology common sense?*”—treated as a 10-mark question (150-word limit) .
- The same question will be returned to after Unit 2 and again after Unit 4, to show how the content of the answer changes as knowledge grows .

QUICK REVISION

- Exercise question: is sociology common sense?
- 10 marks → 150 words, written in about 8 minutes .
- Answer to be attempted with Unit 1 knowledge only .

3.1.3 Step 1 and 2 — Identify the Keywords, Then Define Them

The approach to the question was demonstrated step by step . The order matters: you do not read the question first .

1. **Identify (encircle) the keywords:** Here the keywords are *common sense*, *sociology*—and also *is* . In effect the whole question is a keyword . “Is A equal to B?” is again a question of causation .
2. **Define the keywords:**
 - *Sociology*: Remember, there is no one definition of sociology . The line written was: sociology is a scientific study of society and human behaviour . Since it is a 10-mark question, the definition is kept to very few lines .
 - *Common sense*: A set of knowledge characterised by opinions, assumptions, biases or values .
 - Unit 2, which is all about what makes something scientific, has not yet been covered . Even so, with a basic understanding of science one can say that common sense is not scientific—because opinions, assumptions and biases are not scientific, even if the exact meaning of “scientific” is not yet known .
3. **Now read the question:** Having defined both A and B, the question asks you to draw a relation between them; only after drawing that relation can you say whether they are equal or not .

CRITICAL POINT

- The sequence is keywords → definitions → read the question, not the other way round .
- “Is A equal to B?” is a question of causation; both terms must be defined before a relation can be drawn .
- Honest use of limited knowledge is acceptable: you may say common sense is not scientific even while admitting the exact meaning of scientific is yet to be studied .

QUICK REVISION

- Three steps: identify keywords, define keywords, then read the question .
- Sociology = scientific study of society and human behaviour (no single definition exists) .
- Common sense = set of knowledge characterised by opinions, assumptions, biases or values—not scientific .

3.1.4 Building the Body: Sociology as a Scientific Study

With sociology defined as scientific and common sense as not scientific, the first conclusion that arises is that both are opposite . The examiner has not stated that sociology is common sense; he has only asked . So the answer moves forward line by line .

The reasoning chain written in the answer

1. Sociology, at least in its initial phase, aimed to study society as a system governed by laws (third line, after the two definitions) .
2. Auguste Comte developed the law of three stages . Early sociologists like Comte held that the social world, just like the natural world, is governed by laws .
3. He was heavily inspired by Enlightenment scholars / the Enlightenment era, which believed in the study of society with reason and experimentation .

Everything is thus in sync—each sentence follows from the one before it . The answer is not haphazard .

André Bêteille and the new scholars

- Study of society with reason and experimentation is the core of sociology . From there the answer moves to newer scholars .
- **André Bêteille:** Sociology is a systematic study governed by data collection, classification, cause–effect and comparison .
- He also believed that sociologists study the function of an institution to the larger system .

CRITICAL POINT

- At this point the word limit begins to press . Data collection, classification, cause–effect, reason, experimentation, observation cannot all be expanded—some importance must still be given to common sense .
- The deliberate decision taken in class: stop here on “sociology as scientific study” and move on .

Why these features separate sociology from common sense

- An individual does not have the ability to compare seemingly different institutions; and even if he compares, he cannot arrive at a generalisation that a pattern runs through them .
 - The comparative method is not something an ordinary individual develops . He has not developed the critical thinking that allows him to compare school with country, or caste with class . To him these are incomparable entities—“you cannot compare caste and class,

both are different”; “you cannot compare religion, race and caste” .

- A common-sensical person cannot see that each institution, just like each organ in the human body, has a function in the maintenance of the whole .
 - Each organ has a function in maintaining the body; similarly each institution contributes to the overall functioning of society . This is not how a common-sense man or woman thinks .
- One line then closes this half of the answer: *“These are not found in common sense thinking.”* Sociological thinking is very different from common sense thinking .

EXAMPLE

Organic analogy used informally: each organ of the human body has a function in maintaining the body; each institution similarly contributes to the functioning of society—a link a common-sense observer does not make .

CRITICAL POINT

- Underline important keywords as you write, to make the answer visible to the examiner .
- Do not use black, pink or red pens . A blue pen is more than sufficient—simply underline what you have already written with it .

QUICK REVISION

- Initial-phase sociology: society as a system governed by laws—Comte, law of three stages, Enlightenment inspiration .
- André Bêteille: sociology = systematic study via data collection, classification, cause–effect, comparison; institutions studied for their function to the larger system .
- Common sense lacks the comparative method, generalisation, and the sense of institutional function .
- Answer discipline: underline keywords with the blue pen only .

3.1.5 The Turn: Writing “However” and Bringing in Social Action

So far the answer has established that sociology is not at all like common sense—an indirect “No” . But the answer cannot stop at a yes or a no . Both have to be written .

KEY CONCEPT

- When you have to shift to another line of thinking—that is, to reject what you have just argued—you must begin with one word: **“However”** .
- The moment you write “however”, you force yourself to write something opposite to what you have written . You will automatically feel the force, because you cannot repeat the same thing after it .

The “however” half of the answer

- However, later sociologists argued that human behaviour is highly complex and cannot be theorised . You cannot make a theory out of human behaviour; you cannot predict what a

society or a person is going to do next .

- And therefore social action should be studied without bothering about laws or theories—that is, why an individual does whatever he does .
- The one scholar available for social action at this stage is **Max Weber** . With Unit 1 knowledge we know only that social action means the study of meanings and motives of individuals, given by Weber—and nothing else .
- Concluding line of this half: the study of social action brings sociology closer to common sense .

EXAMPLE

The burning building: A building catches fire . Some people run away . Others, instead of running away, jump to the third floor and try to rescue those inside, risking their own lives . You may theorise that people will run away—but then how do you explain those who climb up without thinking about their own lives? Human behaviour cannot be scientifically theorised in this way .

CRITICAL POINT

- Initial sociologists were hell-bent on developing laws . Later, Weber realised that theorising a law out of human behaviour was misplaced, and focused on the individual—on the meanings and motives we attribute to our actions and to institutions .
- It is not only about institutions contributing to the functioning of society; individuals also look at institutions in a very unique fashion, which the earlier writers did not study .

QUICK REVISION

- “However” is the pivot word that forces the counter-argument .
- Later sociologists: human behaviour is highly complex and cannot be theorised .
- Hence social action—Weber—study of meanings and motives, without bothering about laws .
- Social action brings sociology closer to common sense .

3.1.6 Writing the Conclusion and the Lesson on Form over Content

Having written both “no” and “yes”, the answer cannot leave the examiner without a position . A both-yes-and-no answer reads as an inability to decide—and, as was put in class, an administrator who cannot make decisions will not be selected . A balanced conclusion is therefore required .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Conclusion line as dictated:** *In conclusion, the very journey of the scope of sociology, ranging from the study of institutions to the study of social action, reflects the growth of the discipline just like a human body.*
- Our body matures after a certain point of time; sociology also matured later on . Initially it insisted on one thing only—the childhood insistence on one particular chocolate—and later it grew out of that insistence .

- Just as human behaviour matures, a discipline also matures . That is why there is ever-evolving research in every discipline, and every year people who have contributed immensely to the growth of a discipline are rewarded—for instance, those who receive the Nobel Prize in one area or another .
- The whole trajectory shows nothing but a journey of maturity . In this way you have evaded a flat yes or no and still reflected a mature position .

What was deliberately left out — and why

- The answer did not talk about Zygmunt Bauman, defamiliarisation, or several other scholars who could have been introduced .
- When a countdown is running and so much information has to be compressed into 8 minutes, your brain automatically starts filtering what is important and what is not .
- This filtering depends on revision :
 - *Revised once*: You cannot develop a structure and may start writing haphazardly .
 - *Revised multiple times*: You feel confusion: should this scholar go here, is it relevant, or should I skip it?
 - *Third stage*: The mind is absolutely clear about what the structure should be; whatever comes to mind, you write . At this stage you do not think about content, you think about the form of the content .

KEY CONCEPT

- Just as formalist scholars talk more about the form of a relationship than its content, an answer is judged on form .
- If the form—presentation and clarity of thought—is reflected in what you have written, you will get marks irrespective of which scholar you used, unless the scholar used is completely wrong .
- **Structure is more important than content .**

CRITICAL POINT

- This exercise makes you realise on your own that there is no point in reading multiple sources; it only creates more difficulty .
- **The formula stated:** Limited information + Unlimited revision = Clarity of thought .
- The same question will be revisited after Unit 2, and again after Unit 4 . Each time, the content of the answer changes—showing that the more you learn, the more your thinking and your approach to the question change .
- **On working in teams:** Although you are competitive with each other, at this stage you should cooperate . Competition can come after clearing the examination; without friends pointing out your mistakes, improvement is limited, since a teacher cannot always be present .

QUICK REVISION

- Never end on a bare yes or no—give a balanced conclusion .
- Conclusion device used: the journey of sociology from institutions to social action = maturity of a discipline, like a maturing human body .
- Structure/form > content in answer writing .
- Limited information, unlimited revision = clarity of thought .

3.1.7 Entering Unit 2 — Syllabus Map and Scope of the Discipline

The name of the unit is **Sociology as Science** . The first topic in the syllabus is science, scientific method and critique—so it is necessary first to understand what science is, then the scientific method, and only then to criticise the scientific method .

- In Unit 1 there was a great deal of talk about observation, reasoning, experimentation . Scientific method is a term already encountered while reading the handouts, and so is empiricism—but only as a preliminary idea . All these words will now be tackled .
- Social action theory, structural functionalism and Marxism also belong to this unit; a preliminary idea of each already exists .

Sociology versus other disciplines — what will and will not be covered

- For anthropology versus sociology, read NCERT Class 11, *Introducing Sociology*, Chapter 1—the comparison is contained in about one page .
- Philosophy and political science comparisons will not be taken up separately . In earlier batches they were explained, but the input–output ratio is poor: hardly a 10 or 20 mark question comes from this area, once in a blue moon .
 - *Sociology versus philosophy* has never been asked by UPSC . Philosophy is the mother of all sciences—a position attributed in class to the scholar **M. T. Cicero**—and it would be unfair to ask you to compare the son with the mother .
 - *Political science*: Such questions used to be asked long ago . Today the interest is in how you understand the larger discipline and how sociology and other disciplines interact with each other .
- **Interdisciplinarity** is more important today, and will be dealt with in Unit 2 . A student of a humanities university has to take one more discipline besides the main one—a sociology postgraduate may have to study environmental science or psychology in one semester or another . We no longer talk about conflict between disciplines .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- Sociology versus philosophy—never asked by UPSC .
- Sociology versus political science—asked long ago; today the framing has shifted to interdisciplinarity and disciplinary interaction .

QUICK REVISION

- Unit name: Sociology as Science; first sub-topic: science, scientific method and critique .
- Unit 2 also carries social action theory, structural functionalism and Marxism .
- Anthropology vs sociology → NCERT Class 11 *Introducing Sociology*, Chapter 1 .
- Philosophy/political science comparisons skipped; interdisciplinarity is the current framing .

3.1.8 Reasoning in Everyday Life: The Car That Would Not Start

Before science can be defined, reasoning has to be understood . Reasoning is not something found in a laboratory; it is something all of us do every day, at home and outside . Student responses in the chat box described it as the cause of something, “everything has a cause”, rational thought, employing rational thinking, an analytical approach . In earlier times, the cause of the way we organised our lives was religion .

EXAMPLE**The car that will not start:**

- I have a car; I try to switch it on and it does not turn on . The moment I observe this, I begin to reason: why?
- The explanations—the so-called reasons—that come to mind: (1) the battery is dead; (2) the car has run out of fuel; (3) the engine is dead; (4) I am sitting in the wrong car—it looks so much like mine; (5) the keys in my hand are not the right ones .
- This whole process of trying to work out why the car is not functioning is nothing but reasoning .
- The first thought was that the battery must be dead . You do not consider everything at once: you start with one explanation, treat it as true, and work on it .
- So the second step is: change the battery .
- Third question—why did I change the battery? Because I believed the problem lay with the battery . In doing so I am also making a prediction: if I change the battery, everything will be right . The whole process implies prediction .
- Whether that reason is right or wrong is yet to be tested . You have assumed it to be the cause—and that assumption is nothing but a hypothesis .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Hypothesis (as dictated):** Any statement or any assumption which is yet to be tested .
- Five possible reasons behind the car not working = five hypotheses (hypothesis 1 to hypothesis 5) .
- The battery is changed—and the car still does not function . That means the hypothesis you went with was wrong; the cause is something else . When the assumption was tested, it turned out not to be a valid reason .
- You then move to the next reason: petrol . This is the **alternative hypothesis**—the alternative reason . The car is pushed to the petrol station with the help of friends, the tank is filled

full—and the car still does not function .

QUICK REVISION

- Reasoning = working out the possible causes of an observed problem .
- Car example: five possible causes = five hypotheses .
- Hypothesis = any statement or assumption yet to be tested .
- A failed test → move to the alternative hypothesis .

3.1.9 Hypothesis, Prediction, Experimentation — The Steps of Reasoning

The same structure was then demonstrated with a problem the students themselves had faced, to show that this is how we think in everyday life . Identification of the problem comes first; only then does reasoning begin .

EXAMPLE

The live stream problem:

- The problem identified: the live stream was not working properly .
- Possible causes, each of them a hypothesis because none is yet tested: (1) something is wrong at the technical team's end; (2) my internet connection could be slow; (3) something is wrong with my device; (4) something is internally wrong with the internet service provider in that region—isolated places such as the North-East or Jammu & Kashmir, where users feel lag; (5) the browser is not the right one .
- If the ISP hypothesis is taken as the cause, the corrective step is to change the ISP or buy higher bandwidth—which itself implies the prediction that the issue will then stop . The change is made; the problem persists; the hypothesis is nullified .
- Because the hypothesis has been nullified, the technical team would not agree that the problem is at their end . A hypothesis that has been nullified is called the **null hypothesis** .
- When you nullify a hypothesis, the next step is to think of the alternative hypothesis .

The dictated definition of reasoning The concept of reasoning consists of :

1. Development of hypothesis
2. Prediction
3. Experimentation
4. Confirmation or rejection of the hypothesis

Changing the ISP is an experiment . Changing the battery is an experiment . Both are done to see whether the prediction is correct or not—so once you predict, you also experiment .

CRITICAL POINT

- Do we always think like this? No . Sometimes yes, many times no .
- When the car is not functioning you follow these steps . When you are not functioning—a

poor performance in a test, a sports event, a music competition—you do not .

- Instead of introspection, you start listening to toppers, relying on what others have to say . When the car failed you did not search for a video; you called a mechanic or did it yourself .
- To doubt is part of human nature—but the doubt raised by poor performance is usually answered by others' opinions rather than by testing .

QUICK REVISION

- Steps of reasoning: hypothesis → prediction → experimentation → confirmation or rejection .
- A hypothesis that fails the test = null hypothesis; the next one taken up = alternative hypothesis .
- Problem identification always precedes reasoning .

3.1.10 Reasoning in History: The Middle Ages and the Break From It

The question was then widened from the individual to humanity . Did humanity follow these steps in the middle ages? Nobody used to experiment to check whether what the church was telling them was right or wrong .

- The church held that life on the earth is inconsequential; one should be ready to go to heaven; for that one must come to church every day, pay heed to what is taught, and be the child of God . This temporary existence given by God is something to be thankful for .
- Suppose I am told I am destined to go to heaven . Can I test it? If I had no doubt and did not question, then there is no point in talking about hypothesis—and with no hypothesis there is no prediction and no experimentation, which are the later stages .

CRITICAL POINT

- The chain fails at the first link: no doubt → no hypothesis → no prediction → no experimentation .
- A claim such as “you are destined to go to heaven” cannot be put to any test at all .
- It is only during the middle ages, or right after them, that some charismatic personalities dared to challenge this notion and talked about testing it—about experimentation, prediction and the rest .
- These are the things that make us what we are: the man who doubts, who reasons—a **rational being** . Someone who thinks, doubts, tests the given information, experiments, predicts and observes, all by himself .

EXAMPLE

- Names cited: Copernicus, Galileo Galilei, Isaac Newton—that is why they became famous .
- And likewise Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, Voltaire, Mary Wollstonecraft, Adam Smith .
- They too had multiple hypotheses, predicted and experimented with them, and finally said, for instance, that capitalism is better than mercantilism, or that the sun is at the centre, not

the earth—observed through the telescope, with multiple calculations to support it .

- The point: they used to predict and observe everything by themselves .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Dictated line:** *“The essence of science lies in reasoning.”*
- It follows that to be scientific means to have a hypothesis that can be tested, that a prediction can be made on, and that can be experimented on .

QUICK REVISION

- Middle ages: religious explanation, no doubt, no testing—hence no hypothesis, prediction or experimentation .
- The break came with figures who insisted on testing: Copernicus, Galileo, Newton; Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, Voltaire, Wollstonecraft, Adam Smith .
- The essence of science lies in reasoning .

3.1.11 Scientific Method and the Test of Testability

What was covered in this session was described as an itinerary for Unit 2—the basic ingredients you must have before the actual cooking begins .

EXAMPLE

Itinerary analogy: When you travel to a place such as Mussoorie, you know what luggage should be with you and which spots you will visit—the whole travel plan is your itinerary . Today’s class is the itinerary for Unit 2; the basic ingredients before you make the dish .

KEY CONCEPT

Scientific method (as defined in class): A method which involves systematic steps to carry out experiment and to reach the truth .

- The car example was exactly this: a systematic plan, prediction, and each step cross-checked and experimented on . Many predictions failed, and finally, when all the steps had been nullified, a new car had to be bought .
- That was scientific method carried out without the white coat a scientist wears in a lab . One can observe, predict, experiment and finally reach the truth without being a scientist . So do not be afraid of the words science or scientific method—it is simply a way of life .
- Unfortunately this way of life was absent in the middle ages, when religion was the only way of life and intellectual thinking was highly religious; everything was explained in a religious fashion .

EXAMPLE

If a car had failed to start in the middle ages, the explanation would have been: it is the curse of God . This too is a hypothesis, since it is yet to be tested . The problem is that you can never test

whether you have been cursed—whereas battery, engine, fuel and the car itself can all be tested .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Dictated criterion:** *In order for a statement, a theory or a hypothesis to be called scientific, it should be testable.*
- Anything we speak in everyday life can be scientific—only and only if it is testable .

EXAMPLE

“*I am coughing a lot; I think I have contracted coronavirus.*” Is this scientific? Yes—because it can be tested . That was one hypothesis . A second hypothesis was also in mind: it may be casual—a cold drink taken over something hot, a natural reaction of the body, nothing to worry about . The test at the clinic found no coronavirus . But that does not by itself mean you do not have it—the problem may lie with the experimentation, which is a further layer, deliberately left for later .

KEY CONCEPT

A theory, statement or hypothesis can be tested through two methods :

1. **Induction** or inductive reasoning
2. **Deduction** or deductive reasoning

QUICK REVISION

- Scientific method = systematic steps to carry out experiment and reach the truth .
- You do not have to be a scientist, or be in a laboratory, to follow it .
- Testability is the criterion: a statement, theory or hypothesis is scientific only if it can be tested .
- Two methods of testing: induction and deduction .

3.1.12 Inductive Reasoning and the Problem of Hasty Generalisation

EXAMPLE

The white swan story:

- Suppose I am a European . One fine day I go out of my house, sit by a lake and see beautiful swans—and when the word swan is spoken, a white swan is what comes to mind .
- I photograph them, and over the next days, months and up to the next year I keep seeing white swans—in England, in Norway, everywhere . After about 100 swans, I develop the generalisation: *all swans are white* .
- I have gone from the specific (100 swans actually seen) to the general (all swans) .
- Then one day I go to New Zealand—or Australia—and see a black bird which I am told is also a swan . That is the shock: swans are black as well .
- The same reasoning runs through everyday life . You meet a few people from a minority

community for the first time, observe how they behave, pray and eat, and then make a generalised statement about all of them . Social media is nothing but a reflection of our inductive reasoning .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Dictated problem:** The biggest problem with inductive reasoning is **hasty generalisation** .
- This was articulated by **David Hume**—a scholar of the Scottish Enlightenment, who talked about scepticism, doubt and empiricism .

The dictated characteristics of inductive reasoning

- This method of reasoning involves moving away from the **specific towards the general**, and finally a theory is developed .
- Inductive reasoning involves: Data collection → Classification → Theorisation .
- Which means there is no method involved to test inductive reasoning . Generalisation is developed without testing, purely on the basis of observation .
- Before saying “all swans are white”, the statement was never tested . Data was simply collected—four white swans one day, ten the next, seventeen the day after—and then generalised .
- If experiments are done at all, they are done to prove what you already think is right . Having assumed that all swans are white, you collect data only to prove yourself right and avoid anything like a black swan, because it invalidates your theory .

EXAMPLE

The prelims example: In the examination you see a question whose answer you do not know and you mark option C . You come home and start collecting data to prove that C is right . If someone says B is correct, you produce multiple sources to show him that he is wrong and you are right . Is this scientific? No . You are collecting data to prove yourself right while avoiding anything that could prove you wrong .

CRITICAL POINT

That is why inductive reasoning, which was initially very popular, has today been discarded: people tend to collect data to prove their theory right and avoid the other picture, so you do not get the absolute or objective reality .

QUICK REVISION

- Induction moves from the specific to the general; theory is built at the end .
- Sequence: data collection → classification → theorisation; no testing involved .
- Core defect: hasty generalisation—David Hume (Scottish Enlightenment; scepticism, doubt, empiricism) .
- Black swan, minority stereotyping, option-C data collection—all illustrations of the same error

3.1.13 Deductive (Hypothetico-Deductive) Reasoning

The first example of the class—the car, with its prediction, experimentation and testing—was deductive reasoning all along .

- Write the heading as deductive or hypothetico-deductive; both are one and the same . In some classical books the hypothetico-deductive method is described as being coined by **Karl Popper**, and other books may use other names; for our purposes the two terms are treated as identical to avoid confusion .
- **Dictated:** This method of reasoning, unlike the inductive method, is based on testing . The claim could be right or could be wrong, but it has to be tested .
- Having seen ten or twenty swans does not entitle us to be certain that all swans are white . We have to test—to go to multiple countries—instead of limiting ourselves to Europe and declaring from there that all swans are white .

CRITICAL POINT

- This is exactly the kind of generalisation Europeans made about non-European people while sitting in Europe .
- **Armchair philosophers:** Those who sit in their chair and theorise about the world without having gone anywhere outside their own location . This is inductive reasoning, nothing else .

QUICK REVISION

- Deductive = hypothetico-deductive (in some books associated with Karl Popper) .
- Unlike induction, it is based on testing a hypothesis you already hold .
- Armchair philosophy = generalising about the world without leaving your location = induction .

3.1.14 Verifiability, Falsifiability and the Provisional Nature of Science

KEY CONCEPT

Dictated conclusion: *In conclusion, the inductive method is based on the verifiability principle and the deductive (hypothetico-deductive) method is based on the falsifiability principle.*

- **Verifiability** is only a more flowery word for the same swan story: 10 white swans, then 20, then 30, then 100; the generalisation “all swans are white” follows; and thereafter, wherever I go, I try only to prove this statement right .
- Having concluded, I keep verifying and am not ready to refute; I avoid any evidence that contradicts my theory . No scientist likes to be contradicted—every scientist would want a theory that explains everything around them .
- However, this should be avoided, and that is why people now follow deductive reasoning more than inductive reasoning . Even in the natural sciences we rely more on the test .

EXAMPLE

Einstein's theory of relativity: Its essence, as stated in class: *nothing in the world travels faster than light* . Is the statement testable? Yes . If you find something travelling faster than light, the statement is rejected—but that too shows it was tested . If you find nothing faster, the statement remains valid, again because it was tested . That is why the theory of relativity is scientific—because it is testable .

CRITICAL POINT

- Something being scientific does not mean it is absolute truth . It only implies that it is testable .
- Therefore **scientific knowledge is always provisional—temporary** .

DATA & FACTS

- In 2011, scientists from Italy reported sub-atomic particles travelling faster than light (quantum physics) . They could not prove it .
- The failure to prove is a separate matter; what the episode shows is that the statement is testable .

The dictated chain

- A statement that is scientific only implies that it is testable .
- If something is testable, it means it can be falsified as well .
- And if something can be falsified, that means that knowledge is provisional—the so-called scientific knowledge is provisional, temporary .

Newton, Einstein and falsification

- Is Newton's law of gravitation testable? Of course—and therefore scientific .
- The problem is that Einstein believed Newtonian physics cannot explain everything in nature . Newton's theory could not explain why the orbit around Mercury is formed as it is; there are many things it cannot explain .
- At that point of time Newtonian physics was believed to be absolutely scientific and was the dominant paradigm in the sciences, able to explain everything . Newton was virtually a god figure: if Newton had said something, it was absolutely right—until Einstein came in and rejected many of his theories .
- Why could Einstein reject them? Because those theories were testable—that is, they could be falsified .

EXAMPLE

Space-time sheet: To Newton, gravitation is a force . Einstein said clearly that gravity is not a force . Take a sheet of paper as space and drop a ball on it: the sheet folds into that shape . To Newton this illustrates gravity; to Einstein it is space compression—the warping of space—and no such force as gravity exists . Einstein's own theory of relativity is likewise regarded as falsifiable—it

can be falsified if we find something travelling faster than light . People have found candidate phenomena; they have not been able to prove them .

DATA & FACTS

- There was a time when we had knowledge of nine planets; that was not absolute . Today we study eight, and the ninth was found not to be a planet at all .
- For any body to be called a planet, certain criteria must be met; if they are not met, it is not a planet . Science too grows and matures over time .

KEY CONCEPT

Prediction, observation and experimentation are the basic postulates—the basic features—of scientific method . A method is called scientific only if through it you can test something: that is, falsify, predict, or experiment in order to test . Whether or not you wear a white suit, and whether you are in a car or in a lab, does not matter .

QUICK REVISION

- Induction → verifiability; deduction → falsifiability .
- Scientific ≠ true . Scientific = testable, hence falsifiable, hence provisional .
- Relativity is scientific because testable; Newton could be rejected because his theory was falsifiable .
- Nine planets → eight planets: science matures; knowledge is temporary .

3.1.15 Doubts Discussed in Session 1

1. Can you explain social psychology with reference to Unit 1?

- Social psychology is more about the study of group behaviour .
- Conventionally, sociology is about structures—family, religion—and their impact on individuals . Psychology is about the individual only: why you are a criminal, what is wrong with you; not religion, economy or globalisation .
- Social psychology asks why a certain group behaves as it does, or how an individual is influenced by his peers and classmates .

EXAMPLE

On a messaging application there are multiple sociology channels and groups where people discuss answer writing and share answers for review . You tag someone whose identity you do not really know and ask him to review your answer, because he has presented himself as someone reliable . That group then influences your behaviour: you see people discussing economy or inequality or some other book, and you also want that book, those notes, or that person's help . The “group” need not be an online group—your family and your classroom influence your behaviour in the same way . Social psychology therefore falls directly in between the larger structural study of sociology and the micro study of psychology .

2. *Is the theory of the presence of life on other planets scientific?*

- First, a related question: India is habitable; Pakistan is habitable; China is habitable; Europe is habitable—and from these four cases I conclude that the Earth is habitable . What kind of reasoning is this? It is inductive, because I move from the specific to the general .
- The generalisation is unsafe: Antarctica is not habitable; deserts and other natural landscapes do not offer conditions conducive to survival (the Sentinelese Island was mentioned and set aside as a controversial case) . So the Earth in itself is not habitable, though for the sake of argument we accept that it is .
- Next I begin looking for Earth-like planets in the outer world . A newspaper reports that a planet very similar to Earth, many light years away, appears to have Earth-like conditions . Is that report scientific? The question is simply: can it be tested? It can—one could go there and see whether one can live there . There must, of course, be criteria to test something by .

EXAMPLE

Life on Mars: If it is claimed that Mars is suitable for us, can it be tested? Of course . You send a rover; experiments are done with animals sent up, to see how they react—whether they lack oxygen, whether water can be found . A machine on the rover collects samples of Martian soil; that data is processed in laboratories on Earth to see whether elements such as nitrogen—the basic element required for human existence, the building block of protein—are present; oxygen and hydrogen come later . If some elements are missing, further rover missions follow, until all the elements required for human life are verified or ruled out . Everything depends on rigorous experimentation . The answer to the doubt: yes—the only measure of whether something is scientific is whether it can be falsified, that is, tested .

3. *Why should we define social action in an answer on sociology and common sense?* Because when you study social action you are studying the common sense of the individual . Every individual attaches meaning to his or her action, and even to institutions .

EXAMPLE

Family is undoubtedly socialising you—but the individual also uses the family to gain benefits in the outer circle . If you belong to a family of administrators or bureaucrats, you are regarded as superior among your friends . How we use family is therefore equally important . Just as it is important for a structural functionalist to analyse how family contributes to the system, it is important for the sociologist of social action to understand how the individual uses family . “*If you are the son of a king, an emperor, a bureaucrat or a prime minister, you will act like this*”—that is common sense . But we are studying this common sense too . That is why social action brings sociology closer to common sense .

4. *Are hypothesis and reasoning the same or different?* Hypothesis is a part of reasoning . You reasoned out multiple causes behind the failure of your car; all those reasons or causes were hypotheses only, none of them yet tested or proven right . You try to prove one of them right; if it is not, you come up with another—this may be the cause—and so it goes on .

5. *What is romantic ethics?* Some words in the handouts are not yet covered; that is natural .

EXAMPLE

You have just bought a lipstick . The next day you look at an online cosmetics store and come across shades better than the one you purchased, and you now want those too . It is not the difference that makes you buy—it is the novelty . The same with gaming consoles: if I have one generation and the next is released, I want it; and then the one after that . If you have one smartphone model you want the next .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Romanticism** = falling in love with something new; it is human nature to want the latest gadgets and products .
- **Romantic ethics** creates the spirit of consumerism: we seek novel experiences and products .
- Economists study only that GDP has increased; what went into that increase—our fetish for something new—cannot be mathematised, graphed or made statistical . You cannot compute desire; there is no percentage of desire .

6. Can we say the inductive method creates new theories and the deductive method reforms old theories? Yes—there is no doubt about it . The ability to test theories is purely deductive; the ability to develop new theories is purely inductive—you observe a few things and generalise, a theory built purely on observation .

EXAMPLE

Why did you think in the first place that the battery could be the reason? Because since childhood you had seen two or three cars that would not start because of the battery . From those specific instances you developed a general expectation—that is inductive reasoning . The first hypothesis was therefore itself produced by induction, and was then tested through the deductive process .

7. Can we say inductive knowledge is closer to common sense? Let us not say anything like that for the time being . You will automatically get the answer by the end of this unit .

8. Does that not mean that the values and morals of a person will affect theory and study? Yes—values and morals affect our theories, especially in the social world . In the natural world theories are believed highly objective and unaffected by scientists' values—but they are affected too: experiences shape results, and worldview and social location influence the outcome . You will realise this fully in the critique of scientific method: those who employ scientific method and call themselves scientists are not always objective .

EXAMPLE

Eugenics: Described in class as a science which deals with the study of race . It was used to justify the superiority of the white race: the subject appears scientific, but science was being used by the researcher to justify superiority over so-called uncivilised people . Having declared them uncivilised, a discipline was invented to justify the declaration . Science cannot always be objective .

QUICK REVISION

- Social psychology = group behaviour, between sociology and psychology .
- Life on other planets is scientific because testable (rover, soil samples, nitrogen) .
- Social action = the individual's own common sense → sociology closer to common sense .
- Hypothesis is part of reasoning; induction builds theory, deduction tests it .
- Romantic ethics → novelty → consumerism; desire cannot be computed .
- Scientists' values and social location shape results—eugenics .

3.2 Features of Science, Norms of Science and the Scientific Method

3.2.1 Opening Question: *Is Mathematics a Philosophy?*

The session opened with a deliberately simple question: is mathematics a philosophy? To those who answered no, a basic counter-question was put—if mathematics is not philosophy, then why do we write PhD in mathematics? What is the full form of PhD? Doctor of Philosophy . On that reasoning, mathematics should be philosophy .

- Philosophy is the mother of all sciences . Sociology therefore cannot pose any challenge to philosophy; sociology is too young to resist or protest against it . Philosophy has existed since human life came into existence .
- Philosophy is not a subject—not a three-year BA programme . It is a set of knowledge: a systematic set of knowledge, not common sense, having its own unique method, its own history of origin in the form of a discipline, and its own contributions .
- Those contributions have enhanced and enriched the way we look at the world around us—all of them made by philosophers .

KEY CONCEPT

- Mathematics is a philosophy in this sense: a systematic set of knowledge with its own method and history .
- Philosophy = mother of all sciences; sociology is too young a discipline to be set against it .

QUICK REVISION

- PhD = Doctor of Philosophy—the argument used to show mathematics is philosophy .
- Philosophy is a systematic set of knowledge, not a course; it is the mother of all sciences .

3.2.2 *How the Question Is Framed: The Problem With Survey Data*

The question was not asked neutrally . It was asked with a particular expression and emphasis—is mathematics a philosophy?—and that manner of asking may itself have pushed some students towards answering no .

CRITICAL POINT

- This is not a problem with one instance . It is the problem with surveys: the way questions are framed, and the way they are posed by the person asking, also influences the data collected .
- Had the data been gathered on “is mathematics philosophy?” while asking it in that dismissive tone, the maximum responses would have been “no”—and that would not mean mathematics is not philosophy .
- So merely collecting data does not mean the theory is valid; merely observing and collecting data does not mean you will reach the true conclusion .

QUICK REVISION

- Question framing and the questioner’s manner influence survey data .
- Data collection by itself guarantees neither validity nor truth .

3.2.3 What Is Science? The Five Features

Science, as said in the previous session, is a way of life . But for the answer sheet the definition to be written is: **science is a body of knowledge characterised by certain features** . Five features were dictated:

1. **Testability:** Anything dealt with in science should be testable . If it is not testable, it is not scientific . When you test something, you are actually following scientific method .
2. **Empirical:** Empiricism means observation with your senses . Only if a thing comes to your observation through your senses can you call it empirical .
 - There are many studies where direct observation is impossible—you cannot observe a chemical reaction at the molecular level with the naked eye . But if you observe it under a microscope, that is still empirical observation, because you are observing through your own eyes with the help of a scientific instrument that lets you observe more closely .
3. **Objectivity:** The values, biases and opinions of the scientist conducting the research should be kept aside . The research should be completely value neutral or value free—the two terms need not be worried about at this stage .
 - Objectivity = the act of observing without biases, opinions or values . Empiricism means observation; that observation must be objective—not marred or affected by the researcher’s values, biases or opinions . Only then can we reach the objective truth or objective finding .
4. **Cumulative:** Cumulative means the knowledge has added to something already known . Just as we speak of accumulation—gathering, building up—cumulative knowledge builds on already existing knowledge . You would not have arrived at this knowledge had there not been a knowledge prior to it .
5. **Theoretical:** Whatever data you have collected through observation or empiricism, and whatever you have analysed from cumulative knowledge, is finally made into a theory that can explain the world or the laws which govern the natural world .
 - That is the role of theory: we take the help of theories to explain why something happens in nature . Theory is therefore obviously a feature of science .

EXAMPLE

It is easy for us today to talk about the structure of the universe—whether the sun or the earth is at the centre . But Copernicus could not have developed the heliocentric model if there had been no prior model placing something—the earth—at the centre . Only by rejecting it could he advance his own knowledge . That is why a scientific theory always comes as the result of the refutation of an already existing theory . Science builds up .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Five features of science to be remembered:** Testability, empiricism, objectivity, cumulative, theoretical .
- **Definition to write:** Science is a body of knowledge characterised by testability, empiricism, objectivity, cumulativeness and theory .

QUICK REVISION

- Testability—untestable means unscientific .
- Empirical—observation through the senses; instrument-aided observation still counts .
- Objectivity—observing without biases, opinions or values (value neutral / value free) .
- Cumulative—builds on and refutes prior knowledge (Copernicus needed geocentrism to reject) .
- Theoretical—data finally becomes theory explaining the world .

3.2.4 Testability Examined: Hypnosis and Aliens**EXAMPLE**

The hypnosis episode: A friend tried hypnosis on me . Knowing in advance what he intended, I acted as if I had been hypnotised—so he could not really hypnotise me . After an hour-long session he declared that hypnosis works, and told a third person what was supposedly going on in my mind, what kind of man I am, what my ambitions are—everything “hidden in the unconscious layer” and revealed through hypnosis . Can that ever be tested? There is no test available to check whether what he observed through hypnosis was actually going on in my unconscious mind . It cannot be analysed in a graph or given any visual appearance that would prove it . If I cannot test it, I can never falsify it; if I cannot falsify it, I cannot call hypnosis scientific—even though it is defended by pointing to Sigmund Freud and psychoanalysis, and to psychology as a scientific discipline .

EXAMPLE

“Aliens exist in the outer world”: Such news is sometimes carried even in scientific journals . How would you test it? Just as a mathematician begins with an assumption—let us assume $x = 1$ —the assumption must then be testable; in mathematics there are formulas to test it . Here there are none . Suppose we say: let us go and explore that place . Till what time will you explore it? From a very high altitude you photograph an object and say it looks like a human-like

figure—but first descend to that place . And who told you that aliens look like human beings? That is one more assumption . Because something looks human, we call it an alien of the outer world . Our observation is being influenced by assumptions, biases and opinions . If it cannot be tested, it is not scientific . As simple as that .

CRITICAL POINT

A question was left deliberately open at this stage: is yoga a science? Students were told their answer will change once the features of science are properly applied, and that the body of knowledge must be completely objective—not called scientific out of emotion merely because yoga is a gift of India to the world .

QUICK REVISION

- Hypnosis: claims about unconscious content cannot be tested → cannot be falsified → not scientific .
- “Aliens exist” is untestable and rests on the further assumption that aliens look human .
- Objectivity forbids calling something scientific out of national or emotional attachment .

3.2.5 Norms Governing Science — Merton's Kudos Principle

After the features of science come the norms governing science . Four norms were dictated:

1. **Communalism:** This word does not carry its everyday Indian meaning here . Communalism means that whatever scientific contributions or discoveries scientists come up with belong to the world; nobody should restrict anyone's access to a contribution that advances humanity .
 - *Dictated definition:* Communalism is a norm in sciences according to which any scientific invention or discovery should be shared with the larger community, that is, the world .
2. **Universalism:** Whether you are a black scientist, a female scientist, a Dalit scientist, an American or African scientist, a disabled scientist, a lesbian or gay scientist—at the end of the day you are a scientist only . Science does not discriminate; if you have discovered something you will be celebrated, irrespective of your social location .
 - *Dictated definition:* Universalism is defined as acknowledgement of the scientific contribution irrespective of the social location of the scientists . It simply means that the age, colour, caste, creed, sex, sexuality, religion or nationality of the scientist do not matter .
3. **Disinterestedness:** If I am a scientist and I have invented something, it should not be used for my personal or private gain .
 - Research is possible because of funds given by the state—for instance to a scientist in DRDO or CSIR . If you come up with an invention or discovery, you should be thankful to the state, and whatever you have developed cannot be used for personal gain; it has to be shared with everyone .
 - Disinterested therefore means you are not interested in using the thing to pursue your private interest—you are altruist, not interested in your own self but in the welfare of the masses . It is very similar to communalism .

4. **Organised Scepticism:** Scientists as a community should be ready for criticism—for someone to criticise their finding or find loopholes in it—without feeling angry . They maintain restraint and say: thank you, I will work on that .

- The reasoning behind the norm: we are not working for ourselves, we are working for the world; so criticism is largely for the welfare of communities and societies and should not be taken to heart .
- When Einstein criticised Newton, Newton did not feel angry . When scientists criticise each other they do not take it to heart—whereas when social scientists criticise each other it is another game altogether .

EXAMPLE

- **Communalism example:** If I am Thomas Alva Edison and I have invented the electric bulb, that bulb is everyone's property, because it contributes to the advancement of humanity . If I am Alexander Graham Bell and I invented the telephone, my invention must be shared with the world community .
- **Universalism example (DNA structure):** Who discovered the structure of DNA? The immediate answer given by everyone is Watson and Crick, because they received the Nobel Prize . It was in fact Rosalind Franklin, a female scientist . There was a dispute going on between the three; scientists too are human beings; and at the end of the day the award went to the other two . The very speed of the classroom answer shows that discrimination exists in the scientific community .
- **Universalism example (Einstein):** Albert Einstein—many of his claims were initially refused or rejected by British and French scientists . Einstein was a German, and a war was going on between England and Germany; the French and the English had decided to boycott Germans, so even a great innovation would be rejected purely because it came from Germany . And if science does not discriminate, how do you explain the overpopulation of men and underpopulation of women in STEM fields—science, technology, engineering, mathematics? Science often does discriminate .

CRITICAL POINT

Is it a law or only a norm? It is a norm . Norms can be broken—and so can laws—but breaking a norm does not send you to jail, while breaking a law does . Example given: Bill Gates decided not to share the vaccine formula with the underdeveloped world, the third-world nations including India . The norm of communalism was thereby broken—and that is precisely why it became news .

KEY CONCEPT

- These four norms were formulated by **Robert K. Merton**, also called a sociologist of science, who is in the syllabus .
- They are collectively known as the **CUDOS / KUDOS principle**—the acronym formed from the initials of the four norms (Communalism, Universalism, Disinterestedness, Organised Scepticism) .

- The norms are valid for both natural science and social science; both are science only .

Norm	What it requires	How it is broken
Communalism	Discoveries belong to the world community and must be shared	Withholding a vaccine formula from poorer nations
Universalism	Contribution acknowledged irrespective of social location—age, colour, caste, creed, sex, sexuality, religion, nationality	Credit for the DNA structure denied to Franklin; rejection of Einstein for being German; gender gap in STEM
Disinterestedness	No private or personal gain from state-funded research; altruism	Using an invention to pursue private interest
Organised Scepticism	Readiness to be criticised, with restraint	Taking criticism to heart, as often happens among social scientists

QUICK REVISION

- Four norms—Communalism, Universalism, Disinterestedness, Organised Scepticism = KUDOS principle, given by Robert Merton .
- They are norms, not laws: breakable without legal penalty .
- Each was illustrated by a case of its violation .

3.2.6 The Scientific Method: From Observation to Publication

The car example was revisited to formalise the steps: I went out of my house intending a casual round; I saw that my car was not working . That was observation .

1. **Observation:** Car is not working .
2. **Hypothesis:** Many possible reasons came to mind; I believed the battery was the issue .
3. **Prediction:** If I replace the battery, everything will be fine .
4. **Experimentation:** I obtained a battery from my brother and replaced the old one .
5. **Confirmation:** The car now works; my hypothesis was right . Had it not worked, the hypothesis would have been nullified (null hypothesis) and I would have moved to the alternative hypothesis—perhaps the engine—and tested it by the same steps .

CRITICAL POINT

- Your finding can be confirmed or disconfirmed . Would you cry if your hypothesis were disconfirmed? No—you should be glad that you now know this is not the cause .
- Every time a hypothesis is discarded you are moving closer to the truth . Celebrate validation, but do not grieve over rejection; have patience instead .

KEY CONCEPT

Dictated definition: *Scientific method consists of systematic steps to collect and analyse data in an objective and theoretical fashion, to conclude the finding or to reach the truth.* These steps are followed not only by natural scientists but by everyone who claims a scientific approach and belongs to the scientific community—sociologist, psychologist, economist, geographer, mathematician, chemist or physicist. The steps remain similar for all of them.

Step 1 — Observe and define the problem First you observe the problem, which automatically implies defining it. Otherwise there would be no reason to follow the method at all.

EXAMPLE

In the time of Copernicus the central problem was: what exists at the centre of the universe—the earth or the sun? That was the problem he identified and defined. Put formally: Copernicus identified the problem with the geocentric theory.

Step 2 — Review the literature

- *Dictated:* This step involves investigation of the already existing literature in order to find the mistakes or the research gap.
- Copernicus, before developing his own thesis, went through the work of Ptolemy, a great astronomer, and of Aristotle—reading everyone else to see what they had to say on the model and why.
- When your car was not working you also went through manuals and handouts, or looked up a video. Literature does not mean text only: you are reviewing the work already done by others on the same issue, and how they tackled it.

Framing the research question precisely

- For higher studies you will be asked what topic you will work on, and the topic must be defined precisely and specifically—not vague or open-ended.
- You cannot say “I want to study why India has poverty”—an individual cannot study the whole of India. Better: why poverty exists in a particular district, or a particular village in a state—that is feasible.
- More precise still: “*Why does poverty exist among the Dalits of village A?*” Open-ended questions are not encouraged; a supervisor will accept you only when the research question is narrow and clear.

EXAMPLE

You go to the university library, and search on Google Scholar, which tells you what has already been researched and what scope is left. Thousands of pages appear. Going through them, you find that studies exist on poverty among women, or among children, or among a particular caste group—but nobody has yet studied why poverty exists among the Dalits of village A. That is your **research gap**, and this is what you can now research on.

CRITICAL POINT

An aside on the research culture: people often do research in order to avail their fellowship . Scientific spirit is not yet there . A PhD that can be completed in three years abroad takes a minimum of five years in India, because the Junior Research Fellowship (JRF) is valid for five years, along with accommodation and other resources .

Step 3 — Formulation of hypothesis

- Hypothesis, as already known, is any assumption that is yet to be tested . *Dictated:* Having gone through tons of literature, the researcher develops one hypothesis .
- After reading articles and journals by different scholars—some published in *Economic and Political Weekly* (EPW), some with a ministry of labour—you will have developed certain assumptions . Every mathematician or scientist starts with an assumption; so do you .
- The hypothesis framed here: “Poverty exists among the Dalits of village A because of lack of education.” Is it right or wrong? It is yet to be tested—exactly as with the battery .

CRITICAL POINT

In the social sciences, and especially in sociology, we do not solve the problem—we study the causes of the problem . Initial sociologists had the ambition to solve problems . Today we do not .

Step 4 — Data collection and analysis Data is collected through two routes :

- **Primary source:** I myself go to the village and observe empirically, through my own senses . This is field study .
- **Secondary source:** Someone else’s work: what was already done at the review-of-literature stage . Newspaper reports, journals, science journals, EPW . This is book study or armchair study; the two terms are the same . Note that those authors may themselves have relied on secondary literature .

EXAMPLE**Going to the field:**

- You take a flight to the state capital, then a train or bus, and reach the village . You stay at least a year, rent a house, and maintain cordial relations without letting people know you are an outsider from the city—because a close-knit village would not share personal or intimate information with an outsider .
- Asking directions: you cannot ask where the “depressed” or “oppressed classes” live; you have to speak as people in the field speak, and ask where the Dalit residential colony is . You are warned not to go there, that you will be “polluted” .
- You knock at a Dalit household and ask for a glass of water . The question itself carries a normative order you may not be aware of; the door is shut . Days pass . You begin by befriending the children, giving them small change for sweets, without even knowing their language .
- The problem is multi-fold: you do not know their language, their norms, or anything about

them—you only know that you must finish the research and submit it .

- In the field, data is collected through **interviews, surveys, a questionnaire, or participant observation** . (These recur in Unit 3 as well.)
- To answer why Dalits are poor in this village, you first have to know who the Dalits are, what their education is, what the composition of the Dalit population is, and how many there are—and Dalits are not a homogeneous category; Dalit women and their issues are also there .

Classification and pattern

- After collection comes classification, to make the data simpler—exactly as you make a flow chart or a table when you understand a topic .
- Classification is how we make sense: unless you classify binary opposites such as good and evil, you cannot differentiate between them; each exists because the other does .
- Having interviewed, surveyed and questioned, say, 1000 Dalit people, you classify by gender—for example 700 male and 300 female—and then further, by education: of 700, 600 up to class five and 100 with no education . Classification is already the beginning of analysis .
- Sociologists always look out for a pattern in the classified data . The simplified data used in class:

Category	Education (Max.)	Sexuality	Class / Economic Status
Dalit male	Under class five: 500 males; 500 who studied till class twelve	All recorded as straight	Largely middle class—sanitation and similar occupations; better placed than those with no schooling
Dalit female	Under class five: 100 females; largely no education	All recorded as straight	Lower class; mainly working in other households to earn their bread—domestic help is largely drawn from the Dalit caste

KEY CONCEPT

Going back to the research question after analysis, the answer is not only lack of education . The answer is also **patriarchy** .

- Dalit males did receive at least some education; Dalit females did not . So behind the poverty of Dalit women lies lack of education—but behind that lack of education lies Dalit patriarchy .
- In the pattern that emerges, the Dalit woman is **doubly oppressed**—she is Dalit and a woman . Dalit is generally considered the depressed class by Ambedkar; the Dalit woman is further depressed than that depressed class . This may explain why women are placed at the worst end of the spectrum among Dalits .

Step 5 — Publication of the findings

- The findings are finally submitted and published: either publishers approach you, or you submit your research to a publication house .
- If your research is relevant to their journal it will be published; if it is not scientific enough—not based on any data, only common sense—it will never be accepted . You must show that it is rigorous, extensive research with data to back the theory and the findings .

EXAMPLE

An article on the platform economy—a study of app-based drivers, conducted with a colleague from a school of economics—was published by a national labour institute under the Ministry of Labour, because it was based on data and scientific research and fitted their scientific paradigm .

QUICK REVISION

- Method as practised: observation → hypothesis → prediction → experimentation → confirmation/disconfirmation .
- Method as formalised: define the problem → review the literature (find the research gap) → formulate hypothesis → collect and analyse data → publish findings .
- Definition: systematic steps to collect and analyse data in an objective and theoretical fashion to reach the truth .
- Primary source = field study; secondary source = book/armchair study .
- Worked case: poverty among Dalits of village A → hypothesis of lack of education → finding of patriarchy and the double oppression of the Dalit woman .

3.2.7 Critique of Scientific Method I — Karl Popper and Demarcation Principle

The last component of sub-unit 2A is the critique of scientific method . We have studied science and the scientific method, which natural and social scientists both practise . The question now is: is scientific method scientific? This is the biggest problem, especially in the social sciences .

- **Karl Popper**, one of the greatest philosophers of science, gave the **demarcation principle**—the principle which demarcates science from pseudoscience .

CRITICAL POINT

- What is pseudoscience? The term appears in the newspapers—for instance the Indian Medical Association calling yoga a pseudoscience, that is, not science .
- **An answer-writing caution given here:** Avoid political personalities in your answers . Write “the Indian Medical Association called yoga a pseudoscience”, not a sentence naming political leaders or their ventures . Write in a scientific or administrative fashion .

Popper’s criteria One simple criterion follows from the five features already learnt: testability, empiricism, objectivity, theoretical, cumulative—if something does not have these features, it is pseudoscience . Popper made it simpler still . Science, according to Popper, has two important elements :

1. We follow the **falsifiability approach** .

2. We follow **deductive reasoning** .

True science is the one which follows falsifiability and deductive reasoning, because both imply testability . If you can falsify something, you are testing it; and science involves rigorous testing .

EXAMPLE

Kekulé and the benzene ring:

- Kekulé discovered the structure of benzene in a dream—he saw snakes running around a campfire, woke up, and drew exactly what he had seen; the cyclical ring, with the snakes standing for the double bonds .
- But the dream by itself did not settle the matter: it had to be tested rigorously in the laboratory . He conducted experiments and concluded that without the double bonds the reaction would not have proceeded—hence the double bonds exist, and how many .
- Would Popper call it scientific? Definitely .
- And is it inductive or deductive? Deductive—because you already have a hypothesis and then test whether it is right or wrong . In induction you develop the hypothesis after observations (10, 20, 30 white swans and then the generalisation); there was no test there . In deduction you always test something you saw—in a dream, or heard from someone .

EXAMPLE

The dream of a deity:

- Someone says a deity appeared in his dream and instructed him to build a temple at a particular place, and calls his friends to begin . He cannot prove that the vision occurred . If you cannot prove something, how can it be scientific?
- And this is exactly how a conflict between science and religion arises . Science runs on empiricism, and doubt is the central feature of science . When you doubt religious people they start hating you; when you doubt in science, we celebrate—because doubt is the step one must take before advancing a new theory .
- Pseudoscience, by contrast, does not falsify anything—it only verifies . Told that his claim is nonsense, the man calls a friend who says he too dreamt of the deity the day before yesterday . Two dreams are then treated as proof that the deity exists . That is verifiability and inductive reasoning—and, in Popper's terms, pseudoscience . Religion goes with the verifiability approach .

The dictated critique of the classical scientific method

- Scientific method itself evolved; it was not developed overnight, but out of multiple experiments .
- Karl Popper argued: the problem with the classical scientific method is that it runs on the verifiability approach and inductive reasoning—which cannot be falsified .
- Rather, scientific method should follow deductive reasoning and the falsifiability approach .
- Pseudo means false: whosoever follows the verifiability-plus-induction route is doing false science .

QUICK REVISION

- Karl Popper—demarcation principle: separates science from pseudoscience .
- Science = falsifiability + deductive reasoning; pseudoscience = verifiability + inductive reasoning .
- Classical scientific method is criticised for resting on verification and induction .
- Kekulé’s benzene ring: a dream became science because it was rigorously tested—a deductive process .

3.2.8 Science and Pseudoscience: Worked Examples

Case	Verdict given in class	Reason
Astronomy vs. Astrology	Astronomy is science; astrology is pseudoscience	Only one of the two admits testing and falsification
Hypnosis	Pseudoscience	Claims about unconscious content cannot be tested
Crop circles	Pseudoscience—later revised to “neither science nor pseudoscience”	The claim that a spaceship descended and produced the circles can never be tested; the belief exists but cannot be assessed at all
Einstein’s relativity	Science	Testable—and therefore falsifiable
Newton’s gravitation	Science	Testable; and it was in fact falsified by Einstein

CRITICAL POINT

- A clarification insisted upon: if you are not able to test something, that does not mean it is nonsense .
- There are many theories in science that can never be tested . **Imre Lakatos**, a critic of Karl Popper, holds that many untestable theories are still part of science .
- Quantum physics—we cannot prove what happens there . String theory—we cannot prove that strings exist, yet the community accepts it . Time travel likewise cannot be tested .
- Going strictly by Popper’s criterion, string theory would have to be called pseudoscience because it cannot be tested .
- On yoga, the discussion was deliberately postponed in this session; students were told to keep the Popperian criterion of science versus pseudoscience in mind and they would come very close to the answer without reading any book or journal .

QUICK REVISION

- Astronomy = science; astrology, hypnosis = pseudoscience .
- Crop circles: untestable, and later described as neither science nor pseudoscience .
- Lakatos criticises Popper: quantum physics, string theory and time travel are untestable yet remain part of science .
- Untestable does not automatically mean nonsense .

3.2.9 Critique of Scientific Method II — Paul Feyerabend

The second critic taken up was **Paul Feyerabend**, who held that we celebrate the scientific method far more than it deserves .

DATA & FACTS

Approximately 60% of scientific discoveries are chance experiments—nobody intentionally discovered those things, and nobody had planned them . They were discovered by chance, and only afterwards claimed as achievement .

EXAMPLE

Newton under the apple tree: At the time the law of gravitation was discovered, there was an epidemic and the university could not be attended—study was from home . One day, bored, he went out and sat under the apple orchard, and an apple fell by accident . Did he follow the scientific method? No . He never set out from home planning to develop a law of gravitation . It was a chance experiment .

KEY CONCEPT

Such chance discoveries are called **serendipity**—literally, a happy accident: discovering something beautiful by chance .

EXAMPLE

- **Alfred Nobel:** In whose name the Nobel Prize is given, had never planned to develop gelatin . He cut his finger with a knife and applied a solution to stop the bleeding—the idea behind what we today call a bandage . He then thought that just as a bandage heals a wound and holds two ends together, there could be a substance that holds together and stabilises compounds such as nitrocellulose, making them inactive for the time being until diffused . The actual problem he was working on was why two chemical compounds were not reacting with each other, why they repelled one another . Nothing was planned or systematic; the solution was left overnight and the result was discovered .
- **Louis Pasteur:** Likewise developed a vaccine—the vaccine for chicken pox (or rabies/anthrax), as stated in class—by a chance circumstance .
- **Srinivasa Ramanujan:** Developed a great many mathematical equations, most of which, he said, came to him in a dream, told to him by a goddess; and by chance they turned out to be

true . He followed no scientific method—no theorising, observing or data collection .

- The psychologist **Kevin Dunbar** was also named in this connection .

The dictated propositions of Feyerabend

- Feyerabend argues: science does not go by scientific method . Rather, it goes by the “**anything goes**” principle . He is clearly mocking and ridiculing science: science does not have any method .
- He also believes there is no one scientific method that everybody follows—which means science is characterised by **methodological pluralism** .
- If multiple methods are available, and if more often than not discoveries come without following any method at all, then what is science? How is it different from religion, which also goes by an “anything goes” principle?
- Feyerabend argues that to regard science over and above religion is nothing but **epistemological anarchism** .

CRITICAL POINT

A study note given in class: there is no need to go and read up every scholar in detail . Many scholars will be covered, and there will not be time to research each one individually .

QUICK REVISION

- Paul Feyerabend—second critique of scientific method .
- About 60% of scientific discoveries are chance experiments—serendipity (happy accident): Newton, Nobel, Pasteur, Ramanujan .
- Science does not go by scientific method; it goes by the “anything goes” principle .
- Methodological pluralism—no single method that all follow .
- Ranking science above religion = epistemological anarchism .

3.2.10 Doubts Discussed in Session 2

1. If Nobel thought about a solution, how can it be chance? It was still a chance experiment . He never had the ambition to develop gelatin; the problem he was actually working on was why two compounds—nitrocellulose and another solution—were not reacting and were repelling each other . The bandage analogy occurred to him; the solution was left overnight and the result appeared . Nothing was planned; nothing proceeded in a systematic fashion of the kind we study—review the literature, collect data, classify, then take it to the laboratory . It went very randomly .

2. Chanting in COVID treatment — is it pseudoscience? The question referred to a claim that the effect of chanting on coronavirus patients would be tested . How would you test the effect of chanting? How would you test the efficacy of a preacher’s recitation to someone who has contracted the virus, merely because two days after the sessions the person feels better? How would you prove that it was only because of the chanting? These are circumstantial evidences, and science rejects circumstantial evidence . Science needs empirical, testable, objective evidence .

3. Please explain epistemological anarchism When you regard science as supreme as a body of knowledge and religion as nonsense, that is epistemological anarchism—because, more often than not, in around 60 to 70% of cases, science is also based on belief, and most of its experiments happen by chance .

4. Does gravitational force exist? Newton versus Einstein Science says yes—but scientific knowledge is always provisional and must be testable . Newton said gravitation exists; Einstein rejected it, and we accept the rejection . There is now a conflict in the scientific community over this, which leads into Thomas Kuhn .

- *Newton's position:* The apple fell downward, not upward, because the earth attracted it; similarly all bodies in the universe attract each other, and this explains gravitation .
- *Einstein's question to Newton:* If all bodies attract each other, why does the planet Mercury have so different an orbit—as if it did not belong to our solar system? All other planets show orbits in symmetry; Mercury is deviant . Newton cannot explain this .

EXAMPLE

Einstein's answer: We have a four-dimensional space-time fabric . Place the sun on that fabric and its mass creates a depression—as any object placed on a sheet of paper creates a depression . Because the sun is the heaviest mass, the depression it creates is very heavy, and the ripples from that depression are what displace Mercury's orbit from the simple path expected of it . Gravitation as a force does not exist . What exists is the warping of space and time; the object warps the space-time fabric, and we call the effect a force as though it were external to them .

COMPARISON

- Newton explained everything in relation to the larger universe: all planets are governed by certain laws; every object is a part of the universe governed by external forces such as the laws of physics .
- Einstein showed that each object also has a consequence for the larger universe—the mass of the sun creates the depression that wobbles Mercury's orbit .
- The parallel drawn in class: whether your family governs you, or whether you can also change the structure of the family .

If you say gravitation is a force, some people will accept you—but after 200 years people will not . Imagine being asked in the Renaissance period whether the earth is at the centre and answering yes; you never knew that after 200 years you would be proven wrong . Similarly, the time of Einstein has come; Newtonian physics is being said goodbye to . That shows that science does not give us objective results: the results and findings of science are subject to the scientific community and their acceptance . Today many young scientists are in love with Einstein while the older generation is still very much with Newton—a conflict to be taken up with Thomas Kuhn .

5. Does a discovery made by accident follow inductive reasoning? Not even inductive reasoning—forget the concept of reasoning altogether .

EXAMPLE

You are sitting at a café having a cold coffee and garlic bread, and out of nowhere a school friend you have not seen for ten or twelve years walks by. That was by chance; it was not planned. Is there any reasoning involved in it—inductive or deductive? No, nothing. Everything is by chance. This is what happens with scientists: many discoveries happen by chance—these are chance experiments (serendipity).

6. Since scientific knowledge is provisional, is it reliable? If something is provisional, it is not permanent; if it is not permanent, it cannot be called reliable. It can, however, be tested—or it may not even be tested.

- When would knowledge be called absolute rather than provisional? In earlier times people said God exists and must be obeyed; there was no challenge and no question, and the knowledge was believed to be absolute.
- Today nothing can be asserted with absolutism. “The earth exists” is not provisional; but “an Earth-like planet also exists in our universe” is provisional—it is yet to be tested, and therefore not reliable.
- It also depends on who is conducting the research and what findings they come up with—including who funds them and what interests those funders have. A Marxist reading would say it is the material economic conditions that explain why a particular scientific exploration happened at all, and whose interests it secures. In the social world nothing is simple.

7. Newton’s theory was rejected by Einstein — then how is it scientific? Scientific does not mean absolute truth. Scientific only means that it can be tested. We tested Newton’s theory; it came out to be false—Einstein did it; it was not really a force but the warping of space and time. Would you still call Newton scientific? Yes—precisely because we could test it. Nothing is scientific because it is absolute or right; it is scientific only if it is testable.

QUICK REVISION

- Chance discovery involves no reasoning at all—neither inductive nor deductive.
- Chanting claims rest on circumstantial evidence, which science rejects.
- Newton → Einstein: Mercury’s orbit unexplained; gravity is not a force but the warping of space-time.
- Science’s findings depend on the acceptance of the scientific community—the bridge to Thomas Kuhn.
- Provisional knowledge is not reliable—but it remains scientific as long as it is testable.

3.3 Provisional Knowledge, Kuhn, Feminist Critique & Theoretical Strands

3.3.1 Testing Everyday Statements: Light, Sound and Photons

The session began where the previous one ended—with the critique of scientific method—by putting a series of ordinary statements to the test of testability .

“Light travels faster than sound” The statement is scientific because it can be tested .

EXAMPLE

It is raining; suddenly a huge thunderbolt is seen, and only afterwards the sound of the burst is heard (the gap was exaggerated in class to a minute; in fact it is five or six seconds) . The bolt itself was the result of the collision between clouds, but the light was seen first . That clearly shows light travels faster than sound—something you can experiment with yourself, which is why it is a scientific statement, and it has been proven right .

“Nothing travels faster than light” Asked 50 years ago, everyone would have answered yes . Asked today, the class was confused .

EXAMPLE

A religious teacher, told this statement, replied that it is wrong: God is everywhere . If God is everywhere, then God is travelling faster than light—how else would you explain presence at two different places at the same point of time? On the one hand we say nothing travels faster than light; on the other we say God is present everywhere—and we accept both as valid .

Today the statement itself is doubted: quantum physics tells us sub-atomic particles travel faster than light . But has it been proven? Not yet . If such a question were asked from a textbook it would be a chaotic situation; you could not reach an absolute answer, which is why it would not be asked . And if such a statement is printed, after four or five years the textbooks will be revised—new knowledge given, old knowledge discarded .

	Position	Who / When	Status
“Light consists of particles”	Light consists of particles	Newton, in his book <i>Optics</i> , 1704	Old knowledge; rejected from textbooks
	Light consists of waves	Thomas Young—proved through the double slit experiment	Replaced the particle view
	Light consists of photons	Quantum physics—the latest theory	Neither particles, nor waves

Which of them is right—waves, particles, both, photons, all of the above, or none? No answer can be given . Tomorrow someone will cancel this thesis too and a new knowledge will develop .

CRITICAL POINT

- The point being pressed: science is not objective or absolute, and it does not have a monopoly over truth, though it claims one .
- If the answers given by scientists keep changing, are we not studying myth in the name of science? The question was put to the class in exactly that form .
- The person who studied the earlier position finds that training rendered obsolete (the teacher noted having completed a technical degree and lost belief in science, feeling that only wrong information had been learnt) .

QUICK REVISION

- Light travels faster than sound—testable, hence scientific, and proven .
- “Nothing travels faster than light” is now contested by quantum physics (unproven) .
- Particles (Newton, *Optics*, 1704) → waves (Thomas Young, double slit experiment) → photons (quantum physics) .
- Science has no monopoly over truth; textbooks are revised as knowledge changes .

3.3.2 Falling Bodies: Aristotle to Einstein

A mobile phone and a pen were held up: dropped together, which falls first? The history of that one question was then traced .

Scholar	Claim	Explanation offered
Aristotle	The heavier object falls first	The heavier object has innate, natural, internal properties that make it fall before the lighter one
Galileo Galilei	Both fall together, irrespective of mass	Performed the experiment from the Tower of Pisa; both attain a specific constant acceleration
Isaac Newton	Both fall together	Explained by the force of gravity, which is external to the masses and exerts a pull on them
Albert Einstein	Gravity as a force does not exist	Only the warping of space and time

At each stage the earlier authority was rejected: Aristotle was rejected by Galileo, who did not simply listen to Aristotle but performed an experiment; Galileo’s acceleration was recast by Newton as force; Newton’s force was dissolved by Einstein . Is Einstein correct? Today you think so . Tomorrow he too may be rejected . Will you ever be in a position to say who is right and who is wrong?

QUICK REVISION

- Aristotle (innate properties) → Galileo (Tower of Pisa; constant acceleration) → Newton (force of gravity) → Einstein (warping of space-time) .
- Every dominant answer was overturned by the next—including, possibly, the present one .

3.3.3 Gravitational Waves and the Tests That Confirmed Einstein

Imagine the universe as a sheet of paper . Place the sun on it and a bend is created—as any mass placed on a sheet creates a bend .

- That bend creates ripples, exactly as a stone thrown into a lake creates ripples . All the other objects—planets, stars, asteroids—feel the consequence of those ripples, and their positions are displaced accordingly .
- So it is not a downward motion or a pull maintaining the balance of the universe: it is a wave—a **gravitational wave** . This is what Einstein told us before he died .

DATA & FACTS

- **The LIGO experiment:** An L-shaped tunnel, a very heavy apparatus, built specifically to verify what Einstein had said . The year was recalled as around 2016 (possibly 2016, 2017 or 2018—stated as uncertain in class) . Einstein was right; the waves were found .
- **The 1919 solar eclipse experiment:** If the space-time fabric is bent by mass and energy, then light thrown across the universe must also bend . That light really bends was proven in 1919 .

KEY CONCEPT

- First conclusion of the story: a theory is scientific only when it is testable .
- Second conclusion: no scientific knowledge is absolute—these are only provisional, temporary statements .
- And who taught us this lesson? **Karl Popper** .

QUICK REVISION

- Sun on the space-time sheet → bend → ripples → gravitational waves .
- Confirmed by the LIGO experiment (around 2016) and, for the bending of light, the 1919 solar eclipse experiment .
- Scientific = testable; scientific knowledge = provisional . Lesson from Karl Popper .

3.3.4 Is Marxism Scientific or Pseudoscience?

A statement was put to the class: the whole economic system will collapse one day due to inherent contradictions in the economy; societies will be ruled by workers; the industrialists will be overthrown by the workers, who have been exploited enough, and the working class will decide the policy of the state . Can you test this statement? No . Therefore, judged by the criterion in hand, Marxism is pseudoscience .

CRITICAL POINT

- But if you told Marx that his theory is pseudoscientific, he would say the same of yours; and if you sat with him for ten hours you would come to believe his theory is scientific .
- When you called his theory pseudoscience you were looking at it through the lens of Karl Popper . Remove that lens, put on the lens of Marxist scholars, and the theory becomes scientific .
- So is there any objective reality in this world? Perspectives only .

QUICK REVISION

- The Marxist prediction of collapse cannot be tested → pseudoscience by Popper's criterion .
- The verdict depends on the lens used—there are only perspectives .

3.3.5 Thomas Kuhn — Science as a Social Process

Thomas Kuhn was introduced as the biggest figure among these thinkers—a sociologist of science, and also a philosopher and historian of science . Note that he is a philosopher of science as a body of knowledge, not merely of natural science .

1. **First proposition (dictated):** “*Science is a social process.*” It was noted in class that this statement itself can appear in the examination in coming years .
2. **Second proposition (dictated):** Any theory is valid only so far, until it is superseded by another one . That is, the validity of theory is provisional . There is no absolute theory: after some point this theory will be rejected by another, and people will then treat the new one as more scientific, or as the absolute truth—and this keeps happening .
3. **Third proposition (dictated):** A scientist operates within a **dominant paradigm**—a scientist meaning both natural scientists and social scientists .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Dominant paradigm** = any set of theory or belief which is accepted as absolutely true, and which has rejected the theory that existed before it .
- Until Einstein rejected Newton, the dominant paradigm was Newtonian physics .
- The technical vocabulary—paradigm, dominant paradigm—was deliberately kept simple at first so that the idea is understood before the term .

EXAMPLE

Before Galileo rejected Aristotelian physics, Aristotelian physics was the dominant paradigm; in those times people read that heavier objects fall first . After Aristotle came Galileo; after Galileo, Newton—and the dominant paradigm of the world was gravitational force . Today the dominant paradigm is Einstein . But this transition is not smooth . You will always face chaos . If after this class you go out and tell someone that gravity as a force does not exist, he will laugh at you . A dominant paradigm is valid for a very limited period; it has an expiry date . It expires when a new perspective develops which counters it .

QUICK REVISION

- Thomas Kuhn—sociologist, philosopher and historian of science .
- Science is a social process; any theory is valid only until superseded; a scientist operates within a dominant paradigm .
- Dominant paradigm = a set of theory or belief accepted as absolutely true, having rejected its predecessor; it expires when countered .

3.3.6 The Structure of Scientific Revolutions

Kuhn's book is *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* . The revolution he speaks of is an upheaval in the world of science—a belief system changing wholly, a paradigm collapsing . Newton is gone, and with him the theory that gravity is a force; Einstein has arrived . That is revolution .

EXAMPLE

When the geocentric theory was first challenged by the heliocentric model: the geocentric view had been given by Greek astronomers—Ptolemy and Aristotle—and the church accepted what they said . These were astronomers, not astrologers, and astronomy we regard as scientific . It was rejected when Copernicus came . But until Copernicus came, was it not the dominant paradigm? Yes it was—and in Kuhn's language, for that period it was **normal science** . Just as today we accept Einstein's theory as correct and Einsteinian physics is normal science, at that time geocentric theory was normal science .

The Kuhnian Cycle

Normal Science → Crisis → Revolutionary Science → New Normal Science

1. **Normal science:** The accepted body of theory of the time .
2. **Crisis:** People begin criticising that so-called normal science .
3. **Revolutionary science:** Emerges out of the crisis .
4. The revolutionary science becomes the new normal science; it will again be rejected, crisis will follow, and a new revolutionary science will develop .

CRITICAL POINT

Why is the transition violent? If you have developed a theory over ten years and someone appears from nowhere to say you are wrong, you will not accept the criticism easily . This is why the church declared Galileo Galilei and Copernicus heretics . None of these people accepted the challenge easily .

COMPARISON

A parallel from German philosophy: Hegel says the world is nothing but the product of **dialectics between ideas**—one idea exists, another comes, the first goes away, the new one dominates, and next year yet another replaces it . This is how the world progresses and how we come to know what is true . This is known as the law of dialectics .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

All this is useful beyond sociology—particularly in the essay paper, where one essay must compulsorily be written on a philosophical topic, and topics such as science versus religion recur. Command over the history of science or the philosophy of science gives you the whole background for such an essay.

QUICK REVISION

- Book: *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*.
- Cycle: normal science → crisis → revolutionary science → new normal science.
- Geocentrism (Ptolemy, Aristotle, backed by the church) was normal science until Copernicus; Galileo and Copernicus were declared heretics.
- Parallel: Hegel's law of dialectics.

3.3.7 Who Decides the Dominant Paradigm?

The question was put directly: who decides that Einstein is right and Newton wrong? Not you and not I. The **scientific community** decides.

- What is the scientific community? Institutions such as IEEE, NASA, ISRO, DRDO—the bodies which decide whether Newton or Einstein is right.
- Only after that decision is a communication sent to the textbook authorities—include this chapter in class eight from next year onwards, the content has been revised—and the new position enters the textbooks of school students, who read it as settled fact.

CRITICAL POINT

How is the decision actually taken? In class it was described satirically: they sit together in a closed, air-conditioned chamber, take many cups of tea and plates of snacks, deliberate on whether Einstein seems scientific, and finally decide to go ahead with Einstein. From the next day onwards Einstein is the father of physics and the dominant paradigm. After twenty years, when asked whether gravity exists, students will answer that gravity as a force does not exist, it is the warping of space—and by then a new scientist may have rejected warping too.

KEY CONCEPT

- **Dictated:** *Unless the scientific community decides and agrees upon their decision, the theory is not considered scientific.*
- Is science not a social process, then? It is—and not only because a community sits on the fate of science, but also because science is very temporal and spatial: what was valid a hundred years back is not valid today.
- Just as the human body matures and grows, science also grows. Every day scientists refute the theses in which they had reposed faith for years, and come forward with a new one on which all of them agree; that then becomes part of your syllabus, while we are taught that science is highly objective and absolute. There is no absolute truth; all knowledge is provisional.

QUICK REVISION

- The scientific community (IEEE, NASA, ISRO, DRDO) decides what counts as scientific; textbooks follow .
- Dictated: unless the scientific community decides and agrees, a theory is not considered scientific .
- Science is a social process because it is community-sanctioned and temporally and spatially limited .

3.3.8 Feminist Critique of Scientific Method

The last critique of scientific method taken up in this session was the feminist one . The scholars named were **Donna Haraway**, **Sandra Harding** and **Evelyn Fox Keller** .

KEY CONCEPT

- **The feminist claim:** Science, or scientific method, is sexist and patriarchal—it reaffirms or reproduces sexism in society .
- Two disciplines are especially in view because both call themselves scientific: **biology** and **psychology** .

Biology I — Active sperm, passive egg

- Biology speaks of the “active sperm”—the term is still in use . Why should the sperm be called active? And when the egg is called passive, the egg is displayed as sitting there, waiting to be reached—projecting a docile woman .
- This is a sexist belief among scientists which makes them write such terms for sperm and egg; it is the reproduction of the patriarchal mindset scientists carry .
- Some may say the sperm is active because it has to travel . That theory too was rejected—as stated in class, the sperm does not travel .

Biology II — Charles Darwin

- Darwin wrote *The Descent of Man* . Darwin is regarded as a very important scholar; without him there would have been no subject like biology .
- Darwin held that in the course of evolution man naturally evolves superior to women—this is how societies evolve naturally . Everything in the claim rests on that word .
- After reading “natural, natural selection, natural” repeatedly, you begin to reproduce the same knowledge . It becomes part of your common sense, and you repeat it to your friends: have you not read Darwin—it is natural . Fox Keller and Donna Haraway reply that nothing is natural .
- Darwin also said that if two lists were made, of men and of women, in artistry, poetry, drama and theatrics, the lists would bear no comparison, and man would emerge superior—in sport, literary work, dance and music alike, men dominate .

EXAMPLE

Antoinette Brown Blackwell—described in class as the first feminist critic of Darwin, officially—wrote a letter to Darwin about his theories, telling him they were nonsense and highly patriarchal . Darwin replied: “*Dear Mr. Antoinette.*” What does that show? That in his mind a woman could not have sent such a letter, could not have criticised his scientific theories—it would have to be a man . That is the so-called “natural” at work . In her next letter she pointed out that she is not Mr but Mrs—and therefore his “natural” thesis is rejected .

Psychology — Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung

- Sigmund Freud gave the theory of the **Oedipus complex**: when a male child is born, he begins to feel sexual attraction towards his mother . Is this scientific by Popper’s criterion? Can it be tested that as a two-year-old male child you felt sexual attraction towards your mother? No .

CRITICAL POINT

- That is why, to Karl Popper, Freud and Marx were the biggest enemies of science—and both called their theories scientific: Marx called his *scientific socialism*, Freud’s work is generally regarded as *scientific psychoanalysis* . Popper rejected both .
- And where is the father while this is happening? Freud says the father is killed, avenged or hated by the male child .
- **The feminist reading**: In this story the mother is absent . She is projected as someone simply waiting for the male child to feel attraction—as though she will not scold him, will not socialise him, will not train him, and sits idle .
- Women are projected as objects without a voice of their own . Reading Freud you always read an antagonistic relation between the male child and the father—a fight over the mother, as if the mother is an object to be claimed by one or the other . This normalises the belief in society that a woman is something to be caught or fought for . That is the feminist critique of scientific method .
- **Carl Jung** then gave the **Electra complex**—the exact opposite of the Oedipus complex: the female child feeling sexual attraction towards the father . Jung thereby criticised Freud by reversing the whole theory, which could be equally valid .

Numbers, socialisation and detached observation

- Look at the IITs, DRDO, ISRO or NASA: how many women would you find? The norm of universalism says social location does not matter, yet in the real world women are not highly active in the sciences . Science does discriminate .

EXAMPLE

A recollection offered in class: through twelve years of school all the teachers were women, so one was socialised into believing that teachers in society are female . On joining college, seeing a male teacher was itself disorienting .

CRITICAL POINT

- The last feminist critique concerns the values enshrined in the scientific method: objectivity, empiricism, experimentation, rationality .
- When you give too much importance to rationality, objectivity and empiricism, you lack empathy—you lack emotions and the human values that are natural .
- **Personality test example:** The personality test taken after the mains is generally regarded as a scientific method of evaluating personality, and is believed to yield the best assessment . Feminists would say the method being employed is highly patriarchal: you are asked to read ethics in order to develop empathy, and then are not expected to manifest empathy or be expressive; you are wanted to be serious rather than smiling . In such an encounter you feel exactly what women feel in the ordinary power relation between men and women .
- So the scientific method lacks human values, and what it produces is a **detached observation**—the person interested in knowing another person stays highly detached from him in order to maintain so-called objectivity . And detached observation is not observation .

QUICK REVISION

- Feminist scholars: Donna Haraway, Sandra Harding, Evelyn Fox Keller—science is sexist and patriarchal and reproduces sexism .
- Biology: active sperm / passive egg; Darwin’s “natural” superiority of man—answered by Antoinette Brown Blackwell (“Dear Mr. Antoinette”) .
- Psychology: Freud’s Oedipus complex (untestable; Popper rejected Freud and Marx); the mother as a voiceless object; Jung’s Electra complex .
- Institutional under-representation of women; and the method’s exclusion of empathy—detached observation is not observation .

3.3.9 Yoga: Science or Pseudoscience?

The question deferred earlier was answered when a student pressed it . To answer it there is no choice but to take the help of Karl Popper .

- Yoga is not only about the exercise we do; yoga has multiple philosophies, and there is a Ministry of AYUSH covering Ayurveda, Yoga, Unani, Siddha, Sowa-Rigpa and Homoeopathy .

EXAMPLE

During the lockdown, people collectively banged plates and lit candles at an appointed hour . The stated rationale was that this would generate a collective consciousness and help us move beyond that phase—a yogic practice of collective consciousness . Durkheim’s collective consciousness, to be taught later, is the concept in the background . Compare the temple: you come out feeling relaxed and peaceful—not because of the building but because of the collective consciousness of that gathering and the act of closing your eyes together . An article was referred to discussing Popper’s idea and how we failed as a scientific age, since in a scientific age we believed such practices could carry us over a chaotic phase . This was pseudoscience .

CRITICAL POINT

Even taking yoga purely as exercise: can you ever prove that you were healed only because of the exercise, with no other external factor at work? You would not be able to prove it. Therefore, to Karl Popper, yoga is not science—and this is why a scientific body, the Indian Medical Association, says the same: it is pseudoscience.

QUICK REVISION

- Judged by Popper: yoga is pseudoscience—the healing claim cannot be isolated from external factors and cannot be falsified.
- Yoga is more than exercise; it carries multiple philosophies (Ministry of AYUSH).
- Lockdown collective rituals framed as collective consciousness—Durkheim in the background.

3.3.10 Major Theoretical Strands: The Macro or Structural Approach

Sub-unit 2B is **major theoretical strands of research methodology**—that is, the major theoretical perspectives of research methodology (which overlaps with sub-unit 2E). The first strand is the **macro or structural approach**.

- If I say that family is a unit that helps society maintain itself, that it socialises the young and perpetuates the norms and values required for socialisation—then I am speaking as a structural functionalist.
- If I say that religion is a unit which helps society get over a crisis situation—as when, during the lockdown, people became far more religious, mythological serials were aired, and forwarded messages and statuses turned to matters of faith—that is the same approach.
- In the macro or structural approach you always talk about the function of each and every unit in the maintenance of society.

The three dictated points

1. Structural approach is an approach which **regards structure as superior to individuals**.
2. It also projects **individuals as passive robots**, because no agency is given to them; all the structures in society govern society and the individuals.
3. This approach **fails to look at how individuals attach meaning** to these institutions.

EXAMPLE

Asked about the function of marriage, the standard answer given is: maintenance and continuity of society. But consider someone marrying in order to obtain a passport. In ancient Indian empires the practice of marriage was used to make political alliances with other rulers—not to continue society. Suppose you become an administrative officer: a legislator may seek to marry his daughter or son to you. How is he looking at marriage? As a chance for his child to improve their standard of living, and as a chance to forge an alliance with the bureaucracy. And you may accept, seeing it as a chance to enter politics. How we use and look at the institution of marriage is what this approach does not talk about; it talks only of the function of marriage, and of religion,

to the system .

QUICK REVISION

- Macro/structural approach = the function of each unit in the maintenance of society .
- Three points: structure superior to individuals; individuals as passive robots; fails to see how individuals attach meaning to institutions .
- Marriage, religion and law are read only through their function to the system .

3.3.11 *Positivism*

The most dominant of the structural approaches is **positivism**, or positivist methodology . Being a structural approach, the three points above apply to it as well; what follows is what is special to it :

1. Positivism assumes society is governed by laws . The assumption came from the influence of Enlightenment philosophers . Auguste Comte was in fact very critical of the Enlightenment scholars, but one thing that inspired him was their talk of reasoning—from which he went on to speak of laws operating in the social world as well .
2. These laws govern how individuals, groups or societies think in each era .
3. **Law of three stages:** In each era individuals, groups or societies think according to the law—the theological stage (religious beliefs), the metaphysical stage (abstract beliefs), and the positive stage (scientific beliefs) .
4. They also regard each unit as contributing to the functioning of the system .

QUICK REVISION

- Positivism = the dominant structural approach .
- Society is governed by laws; those laws govern how each era thinks; law of three stages—theological, metaphysical, positive; each unit contributes to the system .
- Comte was critical of the Enlightenment yet inspired by its emphasis on reasoning .

3.3.12 *Structural Functionalism*

Three points were dictated for structural functionalism :

1. Structural functionalism, being a positivist theory, also believes society is governed by laws .
2. **Which law?** Herbert Spencer is generally regarded as the father of structural functionalism, and through the **organic analogy**—human bodies and societies are very much similar, and just as the human body evolves, society also evolves—the law operating here is the **law of evolution** . Society is governed by the law of evolution, which implies that each structure of society also evolves .
3. This theory largely believes that each social institution or structure contributes to the maintenance of the system, which also implies that each institution plays a **positive function only**—the positive function being that the maintenance of society is supreme .

EXAMPLE

- **Evolution of structures:** The family disintegrating from joint to nuclear .
- **Religion:** In earlier times the church disintegrated, and today we have fragments—cults, spiritual figures, and books on elevating the mind or the power of the mind, through which you can become your own guru or your own religion . Religion is no longer found in the church alone: it appears on television at five in the morning and again in the evening . This too is a fragmented form of religion .

CRITICAL POINT

Do not bring Robert K. Merton into this discussion at this stage . Here we are discussing structural functionalism as the dominant paradigm of one period; Merton is exceptional and is treated separately .

QUICK REVISION

- Structural functionalism is a positivist theory—society governed by laws .
- The law here is the law of evolution; Spencer as father of the school; organic analogy .
- Each institution contributes to the maintenance of the system and therefore plays a positive function only .

3.3.13 Marxism as a Positivist Philosophy

- Marxism is also a positivist philosophy, and being a positivist philosophy it also believes that society is governed by laws .
- However, unlike structural functionalists, Marxism believes that institutions function not for the maintenance of society but **to secure the interest of the capitalist class** .
- **Which law governs society according to Marx? The law of dialectics** .

CRITICAL POINT

- Do not say dialectical materialism here—dialectical materialism is also right, but the word required at this point is law .
- The laws of dialectics were postulated by **Friedrich Engels**—not Hegel—and Marx applied these laws .
- Some argue Marxism is only partially positivist . There are many journals on this debate; it is deliberately left aside so that the discussion does not become endless .
- A chart placing all these strands together was made in class to help locate exactly where each perspective belongs .

QUICK REVISION

- Marxism is positivist: society governed by laws—the law of dialectics (postulated by Engels, applied by Marx) .

- Difference from structural functionalism: institutions secure the interest of the capitalist class, not the maintenance of society .

3.3.14 *The Micro Approach and Non-Positivism*

1. Unlike the macro approach, this approach emphasises the **role of individuals** . The examples of marrying a legislator's son or daughter belong here—the concern is with you, not with institutions governing society .
2. However, that does not mean that this approach rejects structures altogether . It is just that they place more importance on the role of individuals .
3. Therefore, individuals are portrayed not as passive robots but as **active players** .

KEY CONCEPT

- The theoretical perspectives dealt with in the micro or action approach are called **non-positivism**—non-positivist methodologies .
- If in positivism the first line was “society is governed by laws”, then here we write: *society is not governed by laws* . Rather, individuals in society are actively shaping their lives . We are not simply objects governed by the laws of physics .

QUICK REVISION

- Micro approach: role of individuals emphasised, structures not rejected outright .
- Individuals = active players, not passive robots .
- The perspectives here are called non-positivist methodologies; society is not governed by laws .

3.3.15 *Social Action Theory — Max Weber*

- Max Weber gave the theory of social action, and he believed that it is the **meanings and motives** of the individual actors that should be studied by sociologists .
- If every actor has his own meaning and motive behind any action, then individuals are clearly not governed by laws: they have their own active mindset, and behind everything they do there is a specific meaning and motive which only they know .
- The theory was given by Weber so as to study the meanings and motives of the individual actors . However, Weber believed that sociology should study not only the cause of social action but also its **consequences** .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Cause of social action** = the individual's meanings and motives .
- **Consequence of social action** = structure .
- Diagram: Many individuals with meanings/motives (cause) → Social Action → Structure (consequence) .

EXAMPLE

How did India become a nation state? At one point of time it was the British Indian Empire; we were not the nation state we are today. The nation state is a structure—a modern structure. It was built up by the social action of the individuals involved in the nationalist movement: their involvement, and the meanings and motives behind that involvement, led to the formation of the nation state. When millions of individuals are mobilised through social action, large-scale structural change occurs.

QUICK REVISION

- Weber's social action theory: study the meanings and motives of individual actors.
- Cause of social action = meanings and motives; consequence of social action = structure.
- Illustration: the nation state as the structural consequence of the nationalist movement's mass social action.

3.3.16 Phenomenology — Alfred Schutz

Phenomenology developed after the social action approach—remember the sequence: first came Max Weber.

- Phenomenology is mainly a philosophical school, developed by **Edmund Husserl** in philosophy. It was introduced into sociology by **Alfred Schutz**, who was Husserl's student.

EXAMPLE

The red rose: If I give a red rose to a girl, it means I am proposing to her—this is what we understand, because it is what we have seen around us and in films. The important question is: when and how did we come to know this, and why did we come to believe it—that red means love, that red equals proposal? We take it for granted. It is part of our common sense. And sociology challenges what is taken for granted. Give a purple rose instead and nobody can say what you are trying to do; we get confused, because we do not know the meaning attached to it.

KEY CONCEPT

Phenomenology is an epistemological school according to which there is no objective reality in the social world.

EXAMPLE

- **Bargaining:** In the street vegetable market you are told a price and you bargain, calling it costly. In a shopping mall the same or a higher price is paid without a second's bargaining, cash handed over or card swiped. Is there any objective, rational law that explains this behaviour? These are only socially constructed norms.
- **Classroom as illusion:** The classroom runs because you carry the norm that when the teacher is explaining, students are silent; the moment that norm is disrupted, the classroom as a structure is not possible. If instead of teaching we start playing cricket in it, the same room

converts into a cricket ground . It is a classroom only so long as all of us agree that it is .

- **The officer's social order:** When you become an administrative officer and sit in the official car, someone opens the door and the gate for you and greets you . Imagine nobody there: you would have to open the door yourself . You carry the order in your mind that as an officer you have all these privileges—but this is illusion, created so that you keep believing you are an officer . The moment those people are gone, you are not . Along with the bungalow, the lawn, the gardener: this is social order, constructed to make you believe .

CRITICAL POINT

- The postmodern scholar **Jean Baudrillard** holds that in the age of information you cannot differentiate between content and advertisement—advertisement becomes content .
- **The line to write:** *Social world is an illusion. What we call social order becomes possible only when all of us agree upon it and share it.*
- When the red rose made sense to you, it was because you agree that red means love . The same red on the road means stop—there you do not read the red as a proposal from the traffic policeman . The meaning of anything is not objective; it is highly contextual .
- Psychological thrillers such as *Mulholland Drive*, *Shutter Island* and *Inception* fascinate us because they destroy our social order—they shatter the way we think in the real world, and that is why they make us anxious .

QUICK REVISION

- Phenomenology: philosophical school of Edmund Husserl, brought into sociology by Alfred Schutz (his student); developed after Weber's social action .
- Epistemological school: there is no objective reality in the social world .
- Social world is an illusion; social order exists only because all of us agree upon and share it .
- Meaning is contextual, not objective—red as love, red as stop .

3.4 Non-Positivist Methodologies: Phenomenology, Ethnomethodology, Symbolic Interactionism & Dramaturgy

3.4.1 Phenomenology Restated: The Four Propositions

EXAMPLE

An ordinary evening: You return home after work or study . Your parents ask how the preparation is going; you say everything is perfect . Your mother asks what you would like to eat; you say anything . You eat, you say it was nice . You study, call friends, watch videos, and sleep with a target for 5 a.m. Did you find anything bizarre or abnormal? No . Everything is very normal—it is part of common sense . And yet, according to phenomenologists, none of these things was

objective reality . Every conversation, the food on the table, the bed made ready—all of it looks orderly, and all of it is illusion .

The four propositions to be written

1. **Objectivity does not exist** in the social world .
2. **Social order is an illusion** .
3. We tend to **typify** phenomena—to classify things in order to make sense of them .
4. We use a **stock of knowledge** to make sense of the world .

EXAMPLE

- **Agreed value of money:** We agree that a currency note is a fifty or a hundred; otherwise the note has no value at all . It is only the agreement we have bestowed on objects and individuals that makes the world seem to make sense .
- **Family as agreement:** You agree that she is your mother; you agree that he is your father; you agree that this is your house—everything goes by agreement .
- **Reading an event:** When a death is found in certain circumstances, the first reaction is to call it suicide—because all of us have agreed to read it that way . It could equally have been murder, arranged to give the impression of suicide . There is no objective reality in the reading itself .

QUICK REVISION

- Four propositions: objectivity does not exist in the social world; social order is an illusion; we typify phenomena; we use a stock of knowledge .
- Order exists only by shared agreement—currency, family, classroom, the meaning of red .
- Even the reading of an event (suicide or murder) is an agreed interpretation, not an objective fact .

3.4.2 Objectivity as Illusion: Reading the Crime Data

DATA & FACTS

According to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) report of 2020 or 2021, as stated in class, Delhi and Kerala had the highest crime rate . You read this on the front page and take it as objective reality . It is not . The same figure carries entirely different meanings depending on who reads it .

Reader	Interpretation of “Delhi has highest crime rate”
The ordinary reader	Delhi and Kerala are not safe places to live in .
The state government	Shows the accuracy, precision and honesty of recording; administration works efficiently and does not conceal facts .
A political opponent	Delhi is not a safe place—the figure is used against the administration .
Under-reporting reading	Other states are heavily under-reporting crime; Delhi and Kerala register accurately . This is political data, not factual data .
Feminist reading	The prior question is: how do you define crime?
Marxist reading	Reflects bourgeois mentality: targets migrant workers; industrialists who exploit and deny minimum wages are never counted as criminals .

The feminist question: What counts as crime?

- Crime is itself a social phenomenon . In India the concept of marital rape does not exist in law; in Western countries, where individualism is stronger, marital rape is recognised as a crime .
- The difference rests on how marriage is conceived: in Western countries marriage is regarded as a contract, and anything which violates that contract amounts to crime . In India marriage is regarded as a sacred institution—a bond of seven generations, made in heaven .
- So when such an act occurs within a marriage in India, the family and even the officials treat it as no crime at all—and because it is not considered a crime, it is never reported, and therefore never enters the crime data of Delhi or Kerala .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Uma Chakravarti is cited:** When a woman is in the custody of police officials and they molest or sexually abuse her, it is regarded as a crime . When the same act occurs in the household, it is not regarded as crime . The act is the same . The victim is the same . Only the players have changed—in-laws in place of police officials . How, then, do you define crime?
- **Law is not objective reality:** Law evolves . Marital rape may be recognised as an offence twenty years from now . There was a point of time when homosexuality was an offence; today it is not . Phenomenology therefore says: objectivity does not exist . We somehow make things objective by forcefully accepting that they exist; otherwise nothing exists as such .

QUICK REVISION

- The same crime figure yields five different readings—ordinary, governmental, oppositional, feminist, Marxist .
- Feminist question: how is crime defined? Marital rape unrecognised in India (sacred bond)

- vs. West (contract)—never enters data .
- Uma Chakravarti: identical act, identical victim; only players change—custody vs. household .
- Law itself evolves and is not objective .

3.4.3 Ethnomethodology — Harold Garfinkel

Ethnomethodology was formulated by the American sociologist **Harold Garfinkel** .

KEY CONCEPT

Ethnomethodology—the study of the methods used by people to make sense of their everyday lives .

- *Ethno* means people; *methodology* means methods (simplified for general understanding) .

EXAMPLE

Garfinkel's classroom project (The Lodger Experiment):

- Garfinkel told his students to go home and act as an outsider / boarder—not as a son or daughter to their own parents .
- A student does so . His mother offers dinner; he eats, and upon finishing asks: *"Nice; how much should I pay? What is the bill?"*
- The mother is shocked and asks whether he has gone mad; she says she will not allow him to go back to the city . She is desperate and anxious to restore the order—the norm that you do not ask your mother for a bill .
- The next day students reported: one had been slapped; another's mother was very upset and cried . Garfinkel's response: *"Very good—these are the symbols showing that the mother is desperate to restore what she thinks is the social order of the family."*
- **Why Garfinkel did this:** To reveal that what you think of as an objective social order does not really exist—and that even if you tamper with it, the order will be aggressively restored by individuals themselves .

EXAMPLE

The teacher's phone call breach: A student called asking for an explanation of ethnomethodology . On the call he was asked: *"Which pizza would you like to have—medium or large?"* He apologised for a wrong number and hung up . He called again; this time he was asked: *"Where have you been, man? Let us go out for drinks."* The student had an internal order of how a call with a teacher proceeds (greeting, decorum, question) . That order was disturbed, and he tried to restore it by concluding he dialled a wrong number . This order has no objective reality; we construct it daily .

KEY CONCEPT

- Every day we construct the family . The family does not exist as an independent entity . Every time you ask your mother how her health is or speak respectfully to your father, you construct

family .

- **Dictated core:** *Ethnomethodology agrees with phenomenology that social order is an illusion. However, ethnomethodology performs experiments to reveal the chaos underlying the social order. It is, in that sense, more experimental phenomenology.*

QUICK REVISION

- Harold Garfinkel—ethnomethodology = study of methods people use to make sense of everyday lives .
- The lodger/bill experiment: the order is broken, and the other person becomes anxious to restore it .
- Agrees with phenomenology that order is illusion, but performs experiments to reveal the chaos beneath it .
- Family does not exist as a thing; it is constructed daily through performances .

3.4.4 The Experiments: Breaching, Conversation Analysis, Documentary Method

Ethnomethodologists use specific methods to reveal how order is maintained :

1. **Breaching experiment:** Deliberately disrupting standard social expectations to observe how actors react to restore order .
 - *Tic-tac-toe:* An opponent places a mark outside the grid lines, breaching the order; you restore order by calling him mad or illiterate .
 - *The bookshop:* Asking for ten successive book titles, having the shopkeeper bring each, and then walking away without buying; the shopkeeper restores order through angry protest .
2. **Conversation analysis:** Examining the micro-structure of spoken talk and sequential turn-taking that make conversations appear normal (e.g., greetings, pauses, tone) .
 - *Unlaughed joke:* Cracking a joke where the listener refuses to laugh; the breach reveals that laughing is an expected social convention, not an objective necessity .
3. **Documentary method:** Members of society select specific aspects of a situation, interpret them as evidence of an underlying pattern (a “document”), and then use that pattern to interpret all subsequent actions .
 - *The officer making a visitor wait:* An administrative officer sits idle but asks an assistant to make a visitor wait for 25 minutes . Why? Because the mental “document” of bureaucracy dictates that an officer must look busy and inaccessible . We reproduce these performances to sustain the appearance of an officer’s authority .

QUICK REVISION

- Two experimental tools: breaching experiments and conversation analysis .
- Documentary method: actors carry internal scripts/templates from socialisation and reproduce them .
- Illustrations: the bill, tic-tac-toe, the bookshop, the unlaughed joke, the officer making a

visitor wait .

3.4.5 Symbolic Interactionism

The lines to be written for symbolic interactionism :

1. The world consists of **symbols**, and individuals make sense of the world by interpreting the symbols . Everything is symbol; there is no reality apart from it .
2. Social order is the result of individuals interpreting the symbols in a **uniform fashion** .
3. A symbol in itself does not have any inherent meaning; rather, we as **active players attach meaning** to those symbols .

EXAMPLE

- **Classroom objects:** The laptop, pen, notebook, books, table, chair, T-shirt, watch, hairstyle, and hand gestures are all symbols that we collectively decode .
- **Gated bungalow:** A huge gate is a symbol signifying: *stay away, elites reside here* .
- **Advertisements:** An instant noodle or chocolate ad appears while studying, symbolising comfort/craving, triggering consumption .
- **Study material:** Buying a specific book because it symbolises success in clearing the examination .

CRITICAL POINT

- **Meanings of symbols are contextual:** A thumbs-up gesture that signifies “all the best” in India may be read as an obscene insult in parts of Russia or the Middle East .
- **George Herbert Mead:** Formulated Symbolic Interactionism .
- **Tradition grouping:** Symbolic interactionism and ethnomethodology are phenomenological schools . All three reject objective social structures, demonstrating that order is constructed daily via symbols and mutual expectations .

QUICK REVISION

- World consists of symbols; individuals make sense by interpreting them .
- Social order = symbols interpreted in a uniform fashion .
- Symbols have no inherent meaning—active players attach it; meaning is contextual .
- Given by George Herbert Mead; SI and ethnomethodology are phenomenological schools .

3.4.6 One Phenomenon, Five Perspectives: Two People Decide to Marry

To demonstrate the analytical distinctions between perspectives, the same social phenomenon—A falls in love with B and decides to marry—is examined across five frameworks :

1. Auguste Comte — Positivism

- It was natural, and a part of the evolutionary process .

- Marriage forms families, and families are the units responsible for the maintenance of order .
- The two individuals are simply passive robots forming a family, fulfilling the need of the larger society to produce tomorrow's labour force and maintain social stability .

2. Max Weber — Social Action

- Rejects overarching laws; focuses on individual **meanings and motives** .
- The man marries this woman because she is the daughter of a high-ranking official, providing social capital, business networks, and political entry . The woman seeks security and status preservation .
- Love is a subjective meaning constructed by active actors pursuing utilitarian and status goals .

3. Alfred Schutz — Phenomenology

- Love, marriage, and family are complete illusions with no objective reality .
- The sacredness of marriage is manufactured through external rituals: exchanging rings, booking wedding halls, printing invitation cards, and lavish catering expenditure .
- It is the shared subjective belief that one is married that creates the appearance of reality .

4. Harold Garfinkel — Ethnomethodology

- Marriage is an ongoing, fragile interactional construction .
- *Breaching illustration*: A student stages a complete one-month marriage ceremony as a class project, and at the end of the reception informs the bride it was merely an experiment for 300 marks . The resulting tears, shock, and parental interventions reveal the desperate social machinery deployed to restore the illusion of order .

5. George Herbert Mead — Symbolic Interactionism

- Marriage is sustained through an interconnected web of decoded symbols .
- The wedding invitation card, the DJ music, the decorated pandal, the stage lighting, the couple's welcome photograph, the banquet food, the *sindoor*, and the *mangalsutra* are symbols .
- When hundreds of guests agree on what these symbols represent, the orderly social phenomenon of a "wedding" emerges .

QUICK REVISION

- **Comte (Positivism)**: Evolutionary necessity, family reproduces labour for social maintenance .
- **Weber (Social Action)**: Subjective motives (status, political connections, utilitarian security) .
- **Schutz (Phenomenology)**: Manufactured illusion via rituals, ring exchanges, and shared belief .
- **Garfinkel (Ethnomethodology)**: Fragile social order revealed by breaching matrimonial expectations .

- **Mead (Symbolic Interactionism):** Uniform decoding of symbols (*sindoor*, *mangalsutra*, *pandal*, *cards*) .

3.4.7 Dramaturgy — Erving Goffman

KEY CONCEPT

Dramaturgy (Erving Goffman): As Shakespeare wrote, “*All the world’s a stage, and all the men and women merely players.*”

- Social interaction is analyzed as a theatrical performance where actors follow scripts, adhere to role expectations, and adjust behaviour to specific settings .
- **The Proposal as Drama:** A young man seeks advice from friends on proposing . He is given a pre-written script (e.g., “*The moment you entered my life, everything changed*”) . He takes her to dinner and delivers his lines . She acts her part (blushing, replying “*How cute*”) . Both fulfill culturally scripted role expectations .
- Individuals are active players who switch roles across contexts (nervous lover → disciplined student → authoritative district magistrate) . We are not robots; we hold our own remote control .

CRITICAL POINT

- These perspectives are analytical frameworks for the exam, not personal philosophies to turn you into a cynic or nihilist .
- Avoid directly copying classroom examples; cultivate the skill of observing your own everyday surroundings through these lenses .

QUICK REVISION

- Dramaturgy—Erving Goffman; theatrical model of social interaction .
- Scripted performances and contextual role switching prove individuals are active agents, not passive robots .

3.4.8 Conclusion: Grounds on Which Non-Positivism Critiques Positivism

KEY CONCEPT

Dictated conclusion: *In conclusion, non-positivism critiques positivism on the grounds that individuals are not passive actors or governed by laws. Rather, they are involved in:*

1. Ascribing **meanings and motives** to their actions—(**Max Weber**) ;
2. Interpreting the **meaning of symbols** to make sense of their everyday lives—(**George Herbert Mead / Symbolic Interactionism**) ;
3. Performing their roles by doing **impression management**—(**Erving Goffman**) ;
4. Creating an **orderly pattern** which they feel is required to make social order possible in that context .

Impression Management and Contextual Order

- **Front stage vs. Backstage:** Asking friends for proposal tips was backstage preparation; delivering the proposal with confidence was front stage performance .
- Because an individual performs different roles before different audiences, a hundred people can hold a hundred distinct opinions about the same individual .
- *The airplane wedding breach:* During the lockdown, a couple married inside an airplane, violating the conventional “document” of weddings, creating media sensation until public discourse rationalised it .
- Positivism describes only structural functions and passive recipients; non-positivism centers human agency and meaning construction .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

These perspectives are essential for UPSC questions on *Sociology vs. Common Sense*, *Sociology vs. Psychology*, and the core methodology debates in Unit 2 and Unit 4 .

QUICK REVISION

- Non-positivism critiques positivism via: Weber (motives), Mead (symbols), Goffman (impression management), and phenomenologists (contextual pattern creation) .
- Positivism = macro-structures and passive robots; Non-positivism = micro-agency and active meaning-makers .

3.4.9 Doubts Discussed in Session 4

1. How do Schutz and Weber relate in the marriage example?

- Weber introduced social action; Schutz developed phenomenology out of social action . Schutz regarded Weber’s work as indispensable for breaking positivism’s obsession with structural laws .
- **Weber** focuses on the actor’s **intentions** (meanings and motives—why this specific person marries for status or capital) .
- **Schutz** goes deeper, investigating the **epistemological construction of meaning** (how marriage is taken for granted as a real institution via shared typifications) .

EXAMPLE

Arranged marriage ritual: A matchmaking meeting involves tea, snacks, polite family queries, and references to district work . Inside the culture, the ritual makes perfect sense; to an outsider unfamiliar with the codes, it appears as an inexplicable violation of personal privacy . The reality of the meeting is entirely socially constructed .

2. Further breaching examples discussed

EXAMPLE

- **National anthem in a fast-food restaurant:** Playing the national anthem while people are

eating burgers breaches restaurant decorum, causing acute confusion .

- **National anthem in movie theatres:** Audiences stand automatically, not necessarily out of spontaneous devotion, but because standing is enforced by social expectations and fear of being labeled deviant .
- **Reversing traffic lights:** If everyone stopped on green and moved on red, instant panic and accidents would follow until actors aggressively tried to re-establish the normative rule .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber = intentions/motives; Schutz = construction of shared meaning .
- Breaching examples (anthem in restaurant/cinema, reversing traffic lights) confirm that social order is maintained by active convention, not natural law .

3.5 Applying the Perspectives, Positivism in Depth and Its Critique

3.5.1 Applying the Perspectives I — Is the Nation Real or an Illusion?

For phenomenology and ethnomethodology, the concept of the nation is a socially constructed illusion . The nation does not exist as a physical object; it exists because we continuously perform and accept its symbols .

EXAMPLE

Constructing Indian national identity:

- In primary school, you attend morning assembly at 8:30 a.m., singing the national anthem listing Punjab, Sindh, Gujarat, Maratha .
- In history class, you are taught about Gandhi, Nehru, Ambedkar, and the freedom struggle .
- Geography maps demarcate territorial boundaries . By age 25, the nation feels like an absolute, concrete reality . The same construction applies to the USA, Israel, or Palestine .

KEY CONCEPT

Banal Nationalism (Michael Billig): The everyday, routine habits, language, national anthems, flag hoisting, and representations that continuously reproduce national consciousness .

CRITICAL POINT

George Orwell's *Animal Farm*: “All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others.” In formal theory, constitutional democracy promises equal opportunity; in practice, privileged networks dominate . Aspirants competing for civil services are striving to become “more equal” within the formal system .

QUICK REVISION

- Nation is a socially constructed illusion sustained by repetition .
- Daily rituals (anthems, maps, history lessons) generate **banal nationalism** .

3.5.2 Applying the Perspectives II — Sex, Gender and Performance**KEY CONCEPT**

- **Sex is biological and real; Gender is socially constructed and performative.**
- These theories do not deny your physical body or biological organs; they deny that the cultural meanings attached to them are natural or fixed .

EXAMPLE**Performing Masculinity and Femininity:**

- *The crowded bakery:* Shouting aggressively to get bread displays masculine dominance .
- *Festival greetings:* Speaking gently and warmly displays emotional traits culturally coded as feminine .
- *A woman riding a heavy motorcycle:* Displaying tough, assertive behaviour disrupts traditional gender scripts .

KEY CONCEPT

Gender as a Fluid Performance (Judith Butler): Gender is not an innate essence . It is a continuous performative spectrum along which individuals toggle . **It is not your gender that determines your performance; your performance decides your gender.**

EXAMPLE

Indira Gandhi was described as “*the only man in her cabinet*” because her assertive decision-making aligned with traits culturally reserved for men .

QUICK REVISION

- Sex = biological fact; Gender = performative spectrum .
- Performance determines gender, not biology .
- Nation, gender, family, and religion are continuously sustained through repetitive performance .

3.5.3 Positivism: The Philosophy and Its Laws**KEY CONCEPT**

Positivism is the epistemological philosophy which asserts that society, individuals, groups, and human thought are governed by invariant **social laws** analogous to natural laws .

- For pure positivism, individual consciousness is secondary; individuals are components of a

larger organism governed by structural laws they cannot alter .

- Just as gravity operates invisibly in physics, social laws govern historical progress and social integration .

3.5.4 The Law of Three Stages

Auguste Comte formulated the **Law of Three Stages**, arguing that human thought and social organisation pass through three sequential epochs :

Stage	Period	Mode of Thinking & Social Structure
Theological Stage	Up to c. 1300 AD	Religious explanations: Natural and social events attributed to gods, spirits, or divine will; feudal hierarchy and absolute monarchy legitimated by divine order .
Metaphysical Stage	c. 1300–1800 AD	Abstract philosophical concepts: Transition era; nature, reason, and abstract rights replace personified gods, but religion persists alongside early science .
Positive (Scientific) Stage	c. 1800 onward	Empirical and scientific laws: Explanations based on observation, experimentation, and invariant laws; emergence of industrial society and sociology .

QUICK REVISION

- Law of Three Stages: Theological (–1300) → Metaphysical (1300–1800) → Positive (1800–) .
- The law determines both intellectual modes of thought and social structures .

3.5.5 Social Statics and Social Dynamics

Comte divided sociology into two foundational branches :

1. **Social Statics (Law of Coexistence):** The study of the conditions of order, stability, and harmony among social institutions (religion, family, state, property) .
2. **Social Dynamics (Law of Succession):** The study of the laws of social progress, historical evolution, and systemic transformation .

The Historical Dialectic of Statics and Dynamics

- *Up to 1300 AD:* Social statics dominated (stable theological feudal order) .
- *1300 to 1800 AD:* Intellectual crises (Renaissance, scientific revolution, Enlightenment) created institutional friction, initiating social dynamics .
- *Revolutions (1750–1790s):* Industrial and French Revolutions destroyed feudal statics, produc-

ing temporary anarchy .

- *1800 onward*: Emergence of the positive stage restoring social statics on a scientific foundation .

CRITICAL POINT

- Comte's framework is an analytical evolutionary model, not an assertion that traditional inequalities (caste, patriarchy) have vanished empirically .
- Modern societies focus on systemic reforms within constitutional frameworks rather than total violent revolutions .
- Social change is an evolutionary wave governed by structural laws, not the creation of isolated individuals .

QUICK REVISION

- Social Statics = order/coexistence; Social Dynamics = progress/evolution .
- Historical cycle: Feudal statics → Enlightenment dynamics → Revolutionary crisis → Positive scientific order .

3.5.6 *Prediction: The Power Comte Claimed for Sociology*

KEY CONCEPT

Comte's Maxim: *"From science comes prevision; from prevision comes action."*

- Scientific discovery of social laws enables sociology to **predict** future social developments and engineer institutional reforms to eliminate social pathologies (poverty, crime, war, inequality) .
- *Meteorological analogy*: Just as a meteorologist predicts a cyclone to save lives through planned evacuations, the sociologist predicts social crises to restore equilibrium .

QUICK REVISION

- Positivism claims predictive capacity for sociology to guide social engineering and resolve crises .

3.5.7 *Applying Scientific Method to Society — "We Are Apples"*

CRITICAL POINT

- Positivism assumes the methodology of natural sciences applies directly to human society .
- **The fundamental flaw**: An apple falling from a tree does not have consciousness, reflexivity, or subjective intent; it is governed purely by external gravity .
- Positivism treats human beings as "apples"—passive objects governed by external social forces, ignoring consciousness and agency .

KEY CONCEPT

Immanuel Kant on Enlightenment: “*Sapere Aude*”—Have the courage to use your own reason and intelligence rather than blindly following traditional authorities or external dogmas .

QUICK REVISION

- Positivism treats human beings as “apples” governed by external laws .
- Ignores human consciousness, meaning, and reflexivity .
- Kant: Enlightenment is thinking autonomously with your own reason .

3.5.8 Positivism, Non-Positivism and Anti-Positivism**KEY CONCEPT**

Definitional Distinctions for Answer Writing:

- **Non-Positivist Methodology (Singular):** Refers specifically to **Max Weber’s Social Action Theory** .
- **Non-Positivist Methodologies (Plural) / Anti-Positivism:** Refers to **Phenomenology, Ethnomethodology, Symbolic Interactionism, and Dramaturgy** .

Perspective		Do individuals exist?	Do structures exist?
Positivism		No (passive recipients)	Yes (real and law-governed)
Non-Positivism	(Max Weber)	Yes (actors have meanings/motives)	Yes (structures arise as consequences of social actions)
Anti-Positivism	(Phenomenology, Ethnomethodology, Dramaturgy)	Yes (active, manipulative agents)	No (structures are socially constructed illusions)

CRITICAL POINT

Statements like “nation is illusion” or “gender is illusion” are specific anti-positivist perspectives, not absolute ontological truths . Sociology is multi-paradigmatic .

QUICK REVISION

- Positivism = structures only; Non-positivism (Weber) = individuals + structures; Anti-positivism = individuals only (structures are illusions) .

3.5.9 Critique of Positivism and the Opening of Critical Theory

Non-positivism is not the sole critique of positivism . A complete evaluation requires introducing **Critical Theory** (the Frankfurt School) :

- **First-Generation Critical Theorists: Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer** .
- **Core Critique:** Positivism is not value-neutral science; it functions as an ideology of domination that justifies the status quo, reduces humans to instruments, and legitimates technocratic control .
- *Note on generations:* **Jürgen Habermas** belongs to the second generation of critical theorists (not the first) .

QUICK REVISION

- Critical Theory (Adorno and Horkheimer—1st generation) critiques positivism as an ideology of domination .
- Habermas = 2nd generation critical theorist .

3.6 Answer-Writing Toolkit

3.6.1 How to Attack the Question

1. **Encircle Keywords First:** In “*Is sociology common sense?*”, identify *sociology*, *common sense*, and *is* .
2. **Define Keywords Succinctly:** Provide brief, crisp definitions suited to the marks .
3. **Establish the Analytical Relationship:** Connect the defined terms before declaring an evaluative verdict .
4. **Maintain Sequential Flow:** Ensure every sentence logically proceeds from the preceding one .
5. **Use “However” for Dialectical Pivot:** Force a balanced transition to counter-perspectives using “However” .
6. **Deliver a Mature, Balanced Conclusion:** Avoid flat “yes” or “no” verdicts; characterize shifts as the intellectual maturity of the discipline .

3.6.2 Presentation, Length and Language

- **Word Limit Discipline:** 10 marks $\approx$ 150 words; 20 marks $\approx$ 250 words .
- **Underline Keywords:** Use your standard blue pen only (no red, pink, or black pens) .
- **Form Over Content:** Structural clarity, logical scaffolding, and legible presentation yield high marks .
- **Formula for Success:** Limited Information + Unlimited Revision = Clarity of Thought .
- **Administrative Neutrality:** Avoid naming living political figures; attribute institutional statements to bodies (e.g., “*The Indian Medical Association classified...*”) .

3.6.3 Exam Framing, Sources and Statements to Remember

- *Sociology vs. Philosophy*: Never asked by UPSC (Philosophy is the mother of all sciences) .
- *Sociology vs. Political Science*: Now evaluated through the lens of interdisciplinarity .
- *Sociology vs. Anthropology*: Refer to NCERT Class 11 *Introducing Sociology*, Chapter 1 .
- **Key Exam Statement**: “*Science is a social process*” (Thomas Kuhn) .
- **Terminology Rule**: Non-positivist methodology (singular) = Max Weber; Non-positivist methodologies (plural) = Anti-positivism (Phenomenology, Ethnomethodology, SI, Dramaturgy) .
- Use the philosophy and history of science (Popper, Kuhn, Feyerabend) to construct high-scoring philosophical essays in UPSC Mains .

Critiques of Positivism, Objectivity & Émile Durkheim

4.1 Critical Theory — A Critique of Positivism

4.1.1 *Origins: The Frankfurt School and the Marx–Freud Synthesis*

Critical Theory is discussed here specifically as it bears on the critique of positivism, not as a full account of the Frankfurt School's wider scholarship .

- Critical Theory was formulated by **Theodor Adorno** and **Max Horkheimer** .
- **Theoretical Background — Karl Marx:** Marx argued that the profit-driven capitalist economic system would inevitably collapse due to internal contradictions and be replaced by an egalitarian, sustenance-driven (profitless) communist economy through proletarian revolution .
 - *Example used in class:* An iPhone priced at Rs. 80,000 costs only about Rs. 6,000–7,000 to manufacture; the massive surplus gap is profit, the core driving motive of capitalism .
- **The Problem Critical Theory Set Out to Explain:** The Russian (1917) and Chinese (1949) revolutions occurred, but the classless, profitless, truly emancipated society Marx envisaged never materialised—those regimes were state-bureaucratic rather than communist in the strict Marxian sense .
- **Main Objective:** To understand why the Marxian revolution and genuine emancipation never occurred in advanced industrial societies .
- **Institutional Base:** A dedicated research institution called the **Frankfurt School** (Institute for Social Research, established in Frankfurt, Germany) was founded to investigate these questions .
- **Methodological Synthesis:** Adorno and Horkheimer fused **Karl Marx** and **Sigmund Freud**—combining Marx's critique of political economy and economic determinism with Freud's psychoanalysis of the unconscious mind—to explain how capitalism psychologically conditions individuals to prevent revolution .

KEY CONCEPT

Critical Theory (Frankfurt School): Fuses Marxist political economy with Freudian psychoanalysis to answer why the predicted socialist revolution failed to occur in advanced capitalist societies .

4.1.2 *The Cultural Industry and Pseudo-Individualization*

The critique is built through concrete manifestations of modern mass consumer goods and media :

- **Empirical Illusion of Choice in Everyday Goods:** Jeans of different brands (Calvin Klein, Levi's, Jack & Jones, G-Star) appear distinct through marketing, yet to direct sensory experience and utility they are fundamentally identical. The same applies to smartphones (standardised underlying hardware marketed as unique lifestyle choices).
- **Pseudo-Individualism / Pseudo-Individualization (Adorno's Concept):** The process by which mass-produced, standardized cultural goods (music, films, fashion) are packaged with superficial variations so consumers believe they are expressing unique individual taste when they are consuming uniform products.
 - *Illustration with Pop Artists:* Across both female and male commercial singers, despite manufactured differences in visual styling or gothic branding, the underlying chord progressions, lyrical themes, and musical structures follow identical templates.
- **The Assembly Line of Culture:** Just as consumer commodities roll off industrial assembly lines, cultural celebrities are produced through structured audition pipelines (e.g., *X-Factor*, *Indian Idol*), where standardized formulas are stamped with the illusion of an "X-factor".
- **Cultural Industry Defined:** Music, cinema, radio, fashion magazines, television, and streaming platforms (Netflix, Amazon Prime) that envelop individuals continuously throughout the day (during commutes, meals, and before sleep), rendering escape nearly impossible.
- **Corporate Ownership:** Cultural production is monopolised by a handful of massive media conglomerates (e.g., Disney, Viacom) representing the ruling capitalist class.
- **Standardised Formulaic Templates:** Media corporations replicate proven commercial templates (e.g., Rihanna, Lady Gaga, Britney Spears stylistic tropes), reproducing them globally across vernacular industries (e.g., Punjabi/Haryanvi music videos repeating formulaic patterns of luxury cars, cash, liquor, and commodified women).

EXAMPLE

North Indian Music Video Pattern: Recurring motifs of luxury cars, piles of cash, foreign liquor, and commodified lifestyle tropes across popular music videos illustrate standardized, mass-reproduced cultural commodities masquerading as authentic individual artistic expression.

Consequences of the Cultural Industry

- **Massification and Loss of Critical Agency:** Consuming identical mass-culture commodities reduces autonomous individuals to conformist "masses". Social peer pressure around trending media (e.g., "*Have you watched Game of Thrones, The Family Man, or Mirzapur?*") reinforces collective conformity.
- **Secular Idolatry:** During the Enlightenment, traditional religion was challenged by critical reason; today, people uncritically idolise pop celebrities, superhero franchises (*Superman*), and media icons, filling the emotional vacuum left by religion. (Paraphrasing Friedrich Nietzsche: "*Old gods are dead, and new idols have taken their place*".)
- **Entertainment as Systematic Pacification:** After exhausting, alienated workdays, workers consume passive entertainment, experience temporary escapist relaxation, and report back to work the next morning without questioning structural exploitation. The cultural industry pacifies dissent and cripples revolutionary class consciousness.

4.1.3 Critical Theory's Critique of Positivism

KEY CONCEPT

Positivism Recap: Asserts that society evolves naturally according to invariant social laws for the maintenance of order and equilibrium (Auguste Comte's aim of identifying when order is restored) .

The Core Critique

- **Positivism is Status-Quoist and Pro-Establishment:** If social evolution is presented as a natural, law-governed, self-correcting process, individuals are taught that deliberate collective resistance is unnecessary because systemic crises resolve automatically .
- **Suppression of Revolutionary Consciousness:** By framing existing institutions as functional parts of an evolving social organism, positivism discourages critical questioning, legitimates the authority of the capitalist state, and reinforces the status quo .

CRITICAL POINT

Core Charge Against Positivism: By insisting that society evolves naturally through impersonal, objective laws, positivism eliminates human agency, discourages critique, and serves as an ideological tool of the ruling establishment rather than an instrument of human emancipation .

- **Blindness to Engineered Conformity:** Because positivism denies autonomous individual agency and focuses purely on macro-order, it cannot comprehend how the cultural industry manufactures ideological conformity .
- **Reversal of Enlightenment Rationality:** While the Enlightenment championed scepticism and active critical thinking (*Cogito, ergo sum* — “I think, therefore I am”), modern mass consumer capitalism reduces existence to passive consumption: “*I shop, therefore I am*” or “*I stream, therefore I am*” .
- **Nomenclature:** These scholars are variously referred to as **Neo-Marxists**, **Cultural Marxists**, **Frankfurt School theorists**, or **Critical Theorists** .

QUICK REVISION

- Critical Theory (Adorno & Horkheimer, Frankfurt School) fuses Marx's political economy with Freud's psychoanalysis to explain the absence of revolution .
- The cultural industry mass-produces standardized cultural commodities via pseudo-individualization, turning critical citizens into conformist masses .
- Positivism is critiqued as status-quoist and pro-establishment because it treats social order and evolution as natural, automatic, and unchallengeable .
- Synonymous terms: Neo-Marxism / Cultural Marxism / Frankfurt School / Critical Theory .

4.2 Post-Positivism

4.2.1 Karl Popper and the Revision of Positivism

Post-positivism represents an epistemological revision and critique of classical positivism, associated principally with the philosophy of **Karl Popper**.

Dimension	Positivism	Post-Positivism
Nature of Social Reality	Fully objective, absolute, and external to actors.	Intersubjective and complex; even researchers are influenced by values.
Researcher's Task	Maintain absolute value-freedom and detached observation.	Acknowledge, reflexively disclose, and account for personal biases.
Cause–Effect Relation	Discovers direct, mono-causal, invariant social laws.	Rejects mono-causality; social phenomena are inherently multi-causal.
Logic of Reasoning	Inductive logic (observation → general law).	Deductive / Hypothetico-Deductive logic (falsification).

Epistemological Nuances of Post-Positivism

- **Social Location of the Researcher:** A researcher's structural position (gender, caste, class, race, region, sexuality) inevitably shapes topic selection and conceptual framing.
 - Female scholars frequently research domestic violence, care work, and marital rape;
 - Dalit scholars examine caste violence, untouchability, and Ambedkarite mobilisation;
 - Regional origins influence research agendas (e.g., Nandini Sundar's field research on Adivasi rights and anti-insurgency in Bastar).
 - Post-positivists mandate that researchers transparently state their social location and methodological assumptions.
- **Multi-Causality of Social Reality:** In natural sciences, a single physical force (e.g., gravity) accounts for an event (a falling apple). In the social world, complex outcomes like suicide, crime, or divorce stem from intersecting variables (economic distress, mental depression, social isolation, domestic conflict). Asserting a mono-causal explanation (e.g., "poverty alone causes crime") is a reductionist distortion.

CRITICAL POINT

Post-positivism does not abandon the scientific quest for empirical generalisations; rather, it refines positivism by replacing naive absolutism with reflexivity, tentative fallibilism, and multi-causal explanations.

4.2.2 Nudge Theory as an Illustration of Post-Positivism

Nudge Theory, formulated by behavioural economist **Richard Thaler**, illustrates post-positivist principles applied to human behaviour .

- **Cascade / Domino Analogy:** If ten bicycles stand in a line, pushing the first creates a cascading chain reaction that fells the rest; similarly, altering an environmental cue can steer broader behavioural patterns .
- **Definition:** A nudge is any aspect of choice architecture that alters people's behaviour in a predictable way without forbidding options or changing economic incentives significantly .

EXAMPLE

Pandemic Mask-Compliance: During the COVID-19 pandemic, large populations wore masks primarily to avoid immediate administrative fines (e.g., Rs. 20,000 spot penalties) rather than deep virological conviction—the legal/financial penalty acted as an administrative nudge steering public behaviour . Commercial advertising operates on identical behavioural nudges .

Post-Positivist Attributes of Nudge Theory

- It rejects positivist determinism: humans are not passive robots governed by rigid, predictable laws .
- It rejects anti-positivist nihilism: human behaviour is not entirely random or untheorisable .
- It occupies a reflexive middle ground: human behaviour is probabilistically regular, conditioned by social cues, and modifiable through structured institutional design .

QUICK REVISION

- Post-positivism (Karl Popper) revises positivism: replaces objectivity with intersubjectivity, induction with deduction, and mono-causality with multi-causality .
- Researchers must reflexively disclose how their social location shapes their scholarship .
- Nudge Theory (Richard Thaler) exemplifies post-positivism by showing that human behaviour is probabilistically regular and steerable without being rigidly law-bound .

4.3 Fact, Value and Objectivity

4.3.1 Positivism, Non-Positivism and the Fact–Value Question

The debate centers on a core analytical problem: *“Fact and value cannot be separated in the social world. Do you agree?”* (conceptually identical to *“Objectivity does not exist in the social world”*) .

COMPARISON

- **Positivist Position:** The social world is fully objective and governed by invariant laws analogous to nature (Newton's falling apple) . Social facts can be observed through detached empiricism and generalized into laws . Values are irrelevant biases that can and must be

excised from scientific inquiry—hence, **facts and values are completely separable** .

- **Non-Positivist Position:** Human actors continuously ascribe subjective meanings, values, and motives to their actions . The researcher is also a social actor embedded in a cultural context; therefore, **facts and values are inextricably linked and cannot be separated** .

Working Definitions

- **Fact:** Any empirical statement, observation, or data point that is verified as value-free and objective .
- **Value:** Any statement, preference, belief, or interpretation grounded in subjective bias, moral judgement, or ideological orientation . (Data is not merely quantitative figures; qualitative categories like gender, caste, and ethnicity also constitute data .)

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Standard 150-Word Structure for “Fact and Value Cannot Be Separated”:

1. *Introduction:* Define ‘fact’ (value-free empirical data) and ‘value’ (subjective norms/biases) .
2. *Positivist Thesis:* Auguste Comte and Émile Durkheim claim social facts are objective ‘things’ governed by laws, allowing complete separation of facts from values via scientific method .
3. *Methodological Critique:* Demonstrate that every stage of research (topic choice, literature selection, hypothesis formulation, funding) is shaped by values .
4. *Conclusion:* Frame the transition from naive value-freedom to reflexive value-neutrality (Max Weber) as the intellectual maturity of sociology .

4.3.2 Objectivity: Meaning and Problems in Social Research

Objectivity: A condition where empirical observation and theoretical analysis are completely devoid of the researcher’s personal values, biases, emotional preferences, and ethical judgements . (e.g., “I own a smartphone” is an objective fact; “I own the best smartphone in the world” is a subjective value judgement .)

How Values Infiltrate Every Stage of the Scientific Method

1. **Topic Selection:** Never purely objective; an Adivasi/tribal researcher is more inclined to study forest rights or Naxalism; personal background directs academic interest .
2. **Review of Literature:** The selection of theoretical frameworks (Marxist, functionalist, radical feminist, conservative) is a value-laden choice that directs subsequent inquiry .
3. **Formulation of Hypothesis:** Grounded in the researcher’s conceptual orientation .
 - *Worked Example (Patriarchal Bargain):* A feminist researcher studying domestic violence through radical feminist theory (Shulamith Firestone, Simone de Beauvoir, Mary Wollstonecraft) may hypothesize that mothers-in-law enforce domestic subjugation because they struck a ‘**patriarchal bargain**’ in their youth to secure future household authority . Critics from other paradigms may dismiss this hypothesis as ideologically biased .
4. **Durkheim’s Suicide Study as Personal Case:** Durkheim’s selection of suicide as an empirical research topic was motivated by the suicide of his close friend Victor Hommay, proving that

even positivist milestones originate in subjective personal experiences .

CRITICAL POINT

Corporate Funding as a Distortion of Objectivity:

- During public anti-tobacco campaigns, industry-funded reports appeared claiming indoor air pollution was far more lethal than cigarette smoking, or suggesting smokers had statistical resistance to respiratory infections .
- Fast-food and beverage giants (Coca-Cola, McDonald's), facing European “fat taxes” (e.g., in Denmark and Sweden), sponsored extensive health, yoga, and kinesiology research at universities (e.g., UCLA, University of Texas) to redirect public blame from dietary sugar to sedentary lifestyle habits .

Objectivity as an Illusion (Gunnar Myrdal and Alvin Gouldner) Both Gunnar Myrdal and Alvin Gouldner argued that pure value-free objectivity in social sciences is an impossible myth .

- *Illustration (Suicide Statistics)*: Official crime statistics (NCRB/NSSO) recording student suicides rest on initial spot assessments by police officers (observing a ceiling fan, a note, a locked door) who classify ambiguous deaths as suicides, which are subsequently published as “objective data” . Subjective interpretation is embedded in data from the start .

4.3.3 Value-Free versus Value-Neutral Sociology (Max Weber)

Max Weber recognized that total elimination of values is impossible because topic selection is inherently guided by **value-relevance** (*Wertbeziehung*) . He therefore replaced the impossible standard of *value-free* sociology with **value-neutral** sociology (*Wertfreiheit*) .

Concept	Whose values are eliminated?	Theoretical Alignment
Value-Free Sociology	Both the researcher's values and the subjects' values are treated as zero/irrelevant; complete separation of knower from known .	Classical Positivism (Comte, early Durkheim) .
Value-Neutral Sociology	Only the researcher's personal biases must be kept in check during data collection/analysis; the subjective values, meanings, and motives of the subjects are faithfully recorded .	Non-Positivism (Max Weber) .

4.3.4 Further Critiques of Objectivity

- **David Marsland's Critique**: Marsland argued that sociology as taught in universities operates as left-wing, anti-capitalist propaganda . By framing capitalist economic structures exclusively

through concepts of exploitation, surplus extraction, alienation, false consciousness, and pseudo-individualization, sociology indoctrinates students against free markets . (However, Marsland’s own neo-liberal/neo-right stance confirms that his critique is equally value-laden .)

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

10-Mark Answer Structure for “Is Sociology a Science?”:

1. *Define Science*: State core criteria (empirical observation, testability, theoretical formulation, objectivity, cumulative growth) .
2. *Positivist Affirmation*: To Comte and Durkheim, sociology is a science because it treats social facts as things, uncovers invariant laws (Law of Three Stages), and uses the comparative method .
3. *Anti-Positivist Rejection*: To phenomenologists and interactionists, sociology cannot be a natural science because social reality is a socially constructed illusion, human agency cannot be reduced to deterministic laws, and objectivity is unattainable .
4. *Postmodern Resolution*: Cite **Jean-François Lyotard** (*The Postmodern Condition* / “End of Meta-Narratives”)—rather than sociology desperately seeking validation under the banner of natural science, the tag of “science” itself is deconstructed as an authoritarian meta-narrative; sociology must embrace humanistic reflexivity .

QUICK REVISION

- Positivists claim facts and values are separable; non-positivists argue they are inextricably linked .
- Values infiltrate research at topic selection, literature review, hypothesis formulation, and corporate funding .
- Myrdal and Gouldner: Objectivity is an illusion .
- Weber: Value-free (zero values for all) vs. Value-neutral (researcher restrains own bias, records subjects’ values) .
- Marsland: Sociology is value-loaded left-wing critique; Lyotard: Science is an unmasked meta-narrative .

4.4 Émile Durkheim — Life, Context and Anomie

4.4.1 Life and Formative Influences

- **Syllabus Positioning**: Unit 4 contains three European classical pillars—Émile Durkheim, Karl Marx, Max Weber—followed by three American successors: Talcott Parsons (structural functionalism), Robert K. Merton (middle-range functionalism), and George Herbert Mead (symbolic interactionism) .
- **Biographical Timeline**: Born 1858, died 1917, spanning France’s Third Republic and the era of post-war social reconstruction .

- **Early Life:** Born in Épinal (Lorraine), France, into a devout Jewish family; his father was an eighth-generation Rabbi . Durkheim was destined for the rabbinate but broke family tradition to pursue secular philosophy .
- **Formative Trauma:** Lost his father before age twenty, an experience of personal suffering that shaped his intellectual maturity .
- **Academic Ascent:** At age 21 (in 1879), cleared the elite entrance examination to the **École Normale Supérieure (ENS)** in Paris, entering as one of the youngest scholars of his cohort .
- **Context of the ENS:** Founded in 1794 during the French Revolution to train high-level state administrators and professors grounded in Enlightenment critical reasoning and scientific temper .
- **Intellectual Frustration:** Dissatisfied with ENS professors who taught abstract metaphysics and history dressed as philosophy rather than practical scientific tools for social reform .
- **Academic Career:** After underperforming in the administrative examinations, became a professor of philosophy and moral education at the **University of Bordeaux**, where he later taught the first French university courses in sociology .

QUICK REVISION

- Émile Durkheim (1858–1917): Born in Épinal to a rabbinical Jewish family; father died before he turned 20 .
- Cleared École Normale Supérieure at 21 (1879); rejected abstract metaphysics; appointed professor of moral education and sociology at University of Bordeaux .

4.4.2 France in Transition: Enlightenment, Revolution, Industrial Revolution

Traditional Pre-Revolutionary Order

- Integrated by shared religious dogma; absolute monarchy and patriarchal authority were legitimated by divine right .
- Society was structured as an Estate System (First Estate = Clergy; Second Estate = Nobility; Third Estate = Commoners/Peasants), sustained by an agrarian feudal economy .
- Religion served as the social “cement” legitimating fixed status (analogous to the Hindu *Chaturvarna* cosmic narrative of Brahmins from the head, Kshatriyas from the arms, Vaishyas from the thighs, and Shudras from the feet of the cosmic creator) .

The Three Modern Disruptive Forces

1. **The Enlightenment:** Promoted secular rationality, scientific empiricism, and radical critique of ecclesiastical authority .
2. **The French Revolution (1789):** Demolished the absolute monarchy and the feudal Estate System .
3. **The Industrial Revolution:** Replaced the traditional agrarian economy with mechanized urban factory production .

Institutional Lag and Moral Vacuum The destruction of the old order outpaced the creation of new institutions:

- *Ideals proclaimed:* Reason replacing religion; democracy replacing monarchy; gender equality replacing patriarchy; republican citizenship replacing estates; industrial capitalism replacing agrarian feudalism .
- *Historical Reality:* It took over a century to stabilize democratic institutions . The intervening period created a severe **moral vacuum** characterized by church–state conflict, industrial labour strikes (miserable working conditions, slums, lack of minimum wages), political instability, and rising European anti-Semitism during the Franco-Prussian War era .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The Franco-Prussian War and rising anti-Semitic hostility across Europe formed the immediate backdrop of Durkheim's sociology; though viewing France as more liberal than Germany, he witnessed persistent communal hatred against Jewish citizens .

4.4.3 Anomie

KEY CONCEPT

Anomie (derived from Greek: *a* [absence] + *nomos* [norms/rules]): A state of normlessness, moral deregulation, and social rootlessness where old traditional values have disintegrated before a new, coherent normative system has developed to regulate individual desires .

Manifestations of Anomic Breakdown

- Spiking crime rates, increasing incidence of rape (as women's legal rights clashed with entrenched domestic patriarchy), widespread alcoholism, urban homelessness, industrial unrest, and escalating suicide rates .
- **The Underlying Cause:** Unregulated, hyper-individualism weakened the **collective consciousness** (the totality of shared beliefs and sentiments common to average members of society) .
- **Durkheim's Ideological Stance:** Politically liberal (strongly supported individual human rights, liberty, and the Republic) but socially conservative (deeply alarmed by social disorder and the erosion of moral consensus) .
- **Durkheim's Central Problematic:** *Individualism is irreversible and welcome, but it has eroded social solidarity—what moral force can reconcile modern individual liberty with social cohesion?* This question drove his doctoral dissertation, *The Division of Labour in Society* (1893) .

QUICK REVISION

- Disruption of traditional order created an institutional lag and moral vacuum .
- **Anomie** = normlessness caused by the rapid collapse of traditional norms without replacement values .
- Manifestations: rising crime, suicide, alcoholism, industrial strikes, and weakened collective consciousness .
- Durkheim (politically liberal, socially conservative) sought to reconcile modern individualism with organic social cohesion .

4.5 Division of Labour in Society

4.5.1 Adam Smith: Division of Labour as an Economic Force

- **Text:** Adam Smith, *An Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations* (1776) .
- **Thesis:** National prosperity is driven by the economic **division of labour**, which multiplies labour productivity through task specialization .

EXAMPLE

Adam Smith's Pin-Making Factory: A single unspecialized artisan might struggle to produce one pin a day; a coordinated factory of ten workers dividing pin manufacturing into eighteen distinct operations produces tens of thousands of pins daily .

- **Economic Philosophy:** Classical *laissez-faire*—unfettered, self-interested individuals pursuing private profits in a free market unintentionally advance societal wealth through capital accumulation and employment generation .

4.5.2 Durkheim: Division of Labour as a Moral Force

Durkheim fundamentally rejected Smith's purely economic and utilitarian interpretation .

KEY CONCEPT

Division of Labour as a Moral Force: To Durkheim, the primary function of the division of labour is not economic output, but **social integration**—it creates a new basis of moral solidarity by making specialized individuals mutually dependent on one another .

- **Illustration:** A specialized surgeon and an IAS district collector perform completely different functions, yet each depends on the other (healthcare for the administrator; administrative permissions/infrastructure for the doctor) . This mutual functional dependence creates social cohesion .
- Division of labour serves as the modern functional substitute for the lost religious collective consciousness, preventing unchecked individualism from destroying society .

4.5.3 Mechanical and Organic Solidarity

Feature	Mechanical Solidarity (Traditional)	Organic Solidarity (Modern Industrial)
Basis of Solidarity	Similarity of individuals; uniformity of lifestyle .	Functional interdependence arising from specialization and differences .
Collective Consciousness	Extremely strong, rigid, and engulfs individual personality .	Weakened; provides space for individual autonomy and secular ethics .
Source of Beliefs	Monolithic religious dogma .	Pluralistic, secular, constitutional value systems .
Occupation & Status	Ascribed by birth, caste, or estate lineage .	Achieved through individual talent, training, and merit .
Legal System (Indicator)	Repressive Law (punitive, severe, exemplary) .	Restitutive Law (restorative, civil, contractual) .

4.5.4 Material Density and Dynamic (Moral) Density

Durkheim explained the historical transition from mechanical to organic solidarity through an evolutionary, demographic model :

1. **Urban Migration:** Industrialization draws rural agrarian populations into urban centers .
2. **Rising Material Density:** The physical concentration of population size and demographic density increases .
3. **Intensified Competition (Struggle for Existence):** High material density creates acute competition over scarce jobs and resources .
4. **Task Specialization:** To avoid destructive conflict, generalized roles split into specialized sub-tasks . (e.g., a single Xerox shop operator vacancy splits into paper managers, technicians, graphic designers, and binders as demand scales) .
5. **Dynamic (Moral) Density:** The frequency, intensity, and moral interdependence of social interactions among specialized actors .
6. **Emergence of Organic Solidarity:** Specialization establishes mutual dependence, producing organic solidarity .

DATA & FACTS

Migration → ↑ Material Density → Competition → Specialisation → ↑ Dynamic Density → Organic Solidarity

Durkheim identified rising **dynamic (moral) density** as the primary causal mechanism driving the shift from mechanical to organic solidarity .

Methodological Underpinnings

- **Evolutionism (Comte & Spencer):** Society evolves unilinearly from simple/homogeneous to complex/differentiated forms .
- **Organicism:** Society functions like a biological organism where specialised organs maintain equilibrium; social disorder is an organic “pathology” that division of labour naturally repairs like white blood cells .
- **Positivism:** The entire evolutionary transformation occurs via objective, natural laws .

4.5.5 Abnormal Division of Labour

Organic solidarity emerges naturally only under a **normal division of labour** . In transitional societies, pathological or **abnormal forms of division of labour** arise, blocking solidarity like an obstruction in a pipeline :

(a) Anomic Division of Labour Occurs when specialized economic functions lack adequate moral and legal regulation . Workers perform monotonous, repetitive tasks in unregulated capitalist factories without recognition, leading to extreme alienation and industrial conflict .

EXAMPLE

Modern corporations institute “Employee of the Year” recognitions and civil services award performance medals to combat anomic alienation; during early industrialization, workers were treated as unrecognized cogs .

(b) Forced Division of Labour Occurs when the distribution of occupations does not correspond to the natural distribution of talents, but is enforced through hereditary privilege, caste hierarchy, class barriers, or gender discrimination . The traditional Indian caste system, which fixes occupational roles by birth rather than talent, is a classic forced division of labour .

(c) Inadequately Coordinated Division of Labour Occurs when specialized roles within an enterprise are poorly integrated, causing bureaucratic friction, ego clashes, and organizational breakdown .

COMPARISON

Durkheim versus Karl Marx on Industrial Crisis:

- **Émile Durkheim:** Industrial exploitation and alienation are temporary, abnormal pathologies remediable through state regulation, professional ethics, and institutional reform .
- **Karl Marx:** Industrial exploitation is an inherent, structural contradiction of capitalism that cannot be reformed away; it can only be resolved through proletarian revolution .

4.5.6 Restoring Solidarity: State, Professional Associations, Moral Education

Durkheim proposed three institutional mechanisms to eliminate abnormal division of labour and foster organic solidarity :

1. **The State as a Moral Organ:** The state is the brain and moral compass of the social organism . As a welfare state, it enacts social justice legislation, provides public health and education, builds infrastructure, and integrates diverse citizens (e.g., *Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana*, universal vaccination programs, Right to Education Act / National Education Policy) .
2. **Professional / Occupational Associations (Corporations):** Industry-wide federations uniting employers and workers to establish ethical codes of conduct, regulate fair wages, resolve workplace disputes, and recognize outstanding professional contributions .
3. **Secular Moral Education:** Schools must socialize children into civic morality and social responsibility from early childhood, ensuring ethical behavior is internalised rather than maintained solely through external fear .

CRITICAL POINT

Durkheimian Socialism versus Marxist Socialism: Durkheim's vision is a guild-based moral corporatism where the state is an inherently benevolent moral organ . To Marx, the capitalist state is an instrument of class domination that cannot act as a neutral moral mediator .

4.5.7 Measuring Solidarity: Law as Indicator Species

Because social solidarity is an invisible, intangible moral phenomenon, Durkheim operationalized **law** as its objective, external indicator (borrowing the biological concept of an **indicator species**) .

Solidarity	Collective science	Con-	Type of Law	Nature of Sanction
Mechanical	Extremely intense and diffuse .		Repressive Law (Penal Code) .	Severe bodily harm, public execution, or total expulsion; avenges the outraged collective moral conscience .
Organic	Differentiated and specialised .		Restitutive Law (Civil, Commercial, Administrative) .	Fines, contractual damages, and rehabilitation; restores the pre-existing state of functional cooperation .

KEY CONCEPT

Law as an Indicator: The predominance of **repressive law** indicates mechanical solidarity; the predominance of **restitutive law** indicates organic solidarity . In modern societies, ordering that unmasked citizens be shot on sight would spark massive outrage; modern societies rely instead on restitutive fines .

4.5.8 The Jajmani System — A Critique of the Model

Applying Durkheim's dichotomy rigidly to the Indian subcontinent reveals severe limitations :

- **The Jajmani System:** Traditional village arrangements where service castes (*Kamin*) provide

specialized functional services (barbering, leatherwork, carpentry) to landowning patron castes (*Jajman*) in return for hereditary shares of harvested grain .

- **Durkheimian Reading (Consensus / Functional):** Resembles **organic solidarity** inside a traditional pre-industrial setting, because specialized castes exchange complementary services to sustain village self-sufficiency (aligning with Mahatma Gandhi's idealization of *Varnashram Dharma*) .
- **Marxian / Critical Reading (Conflict):** The system represents hereditary **forced division of labour** and feudal exploitation, where religious ideology operates as the "opium of the masses" to enforce untouchability (aligning with Dr. B. R. Ambedkar's critique of caste as a *graded hierarchy of oppression*) .

COMPARISON

The Jajmani debate demonstrates that mechanical/organic solidarity and traditional/modern society are **analytical ideal types/models**, not literal reflections of empirical reality .

4.5.9 Critique of Durkheim's Objectivity

- **Philosophical Roots:** *The Division of Labour in Society* was originally Durkheim's doctoral dissertation in philosophy, completed before the institutional establishment of academic sociology .
- **M. C. Kennedy's Critique:** Kennedy argued that Durkheim operates as a '**moralist sociologist**' rather than a '**sociologist of morals**'—he was actively prescribing a moral agenda for the French Republic rather than conducting value-free scientific inquiry .

QUICK REVISION

- Adam Smith: Division of labour is an economic force (pin factory); Durkheim: Division of labour is a moral force generating solidarity .
- Mechanical (similarity, repressive law) vs. Organic (interdependence, restitutive law) .
- Material density + moral density → organic solidarity .
- Abnormal division of labour: Anomic, Forced, Inadequately Coordinated .
- Reforms: Welfare state, professional associations, secular moral education .
- Jajmani critique shows that solidarity concepts are analytical models .
- M. C. Kennedy: Durkheim was a moralist sociologist .

4.6 Social Facts

4.6.1 Meaning, Purpose and Examples of Social Fact

- **Text:** Émile Durkheim, *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895) . Written after founding the first European Department of Sociology at the University of Bordeaux .

KEY CONCEPT

Social Fact Defined: “A social fact is any way of acting, thinking, or feeling, whether fixed or not, capable of exercising over the individual an external constraint; or, which is general over the whole of a given society whilst having an existence of its own, independent of its individual manifestations.”

Ontological Status: Sui Generis Reality

- **The Whole Exceeds the Sum of Parts:** Just as disassembling the human body into individual chemical organs destroys life, society is not a mere collection of atomized individuals . Society is a **sui generis** reality (a reality unique to itself) .
- **External and Coercive Constraints:** An individual in a classroom cannot suddenly sing or play guitar; devotees fall silent inside temples; a partner feels bound by relationship norms . These constraining structures are social facts .
- **Concrete Instances:** The nation-state, religious dogma, caste codes, family obligations, language, currency, legal codes, and sports teams (e.g., an Indian cricket captain like Virat Kohli is strictly constrained by team strategy and public expectations) .

Two Primary Objectives of Durkheim's Project

1. **Disciplinary Demarcation:** To distinguish sociology from psychology (which studies the individual mind) and philosophy (which deals with abstract moral deductions) .
2. **Establish Empirical Science:** To prove that invisible social forces (like gravity in physics) can be scientifically investigated through their observable effects .

4.6.2 General Features of Social Facts

1. **Externality:** Social facts exist outside individual consciousness (predating birth and outlasting death) .
2. **Coercion / Constraint:** They exercise coercive moral or legal sanctions over anyone who attempts to violate them .
3. **Generality:** They are diffused throughout the collective society, not idiosyncratic to one person .
4. **Independence:** They possess an objective reality independent of individual wills .

4.6.3 Rule of Observing Social Facts**CRITICAL POINT**

The Golden Rule: “Treat social facts as things.” (*Traiter les faits sociaux comme des choses*) .

- Sociologists must approach social facts as external empirical objects, shedding all pre-notions (*prénotions*), personal prejudices, and moral values .
- A sociologist studying crime or deviance must observe with the same value-neutral detachment as a biologist studying a specimen or a physician examining a physical ailment .

4.6.4 Rule of Classifying Normal and Pathological Facts

Durkheim established objective criteria to distinguish between healthy and diseased states of society :

- **Normal Social Fact:** A social fact that is present universally across societies of a given type at a given evolutionary stage .
- **Pathological Social Fact:** A social fact that deviates significantly from statistical frequency, being abnormally high or low .

Crime as a Normal Social Fact

- Crime exists in every known human society without exception (USA, India, Finland, China) .
- Therefore, crime within a typical statistical threshold is **normal, necessary, and useful** . It becomes pathological only when its rate surges abnormally high or drops unnaturally low .
- **Crime is Relative to Collective Sentiments:** Crime is simply an act that offends the strong, defined states of the collective consciousness in a particular space and time .
 - Socrates was executed under Athenian law for corrupting the youth, yet his philosophical deviance laid the foundations of Western thought ;
 - Galileo was condemned as a heretic for heliocentrism ;
 - Nelson Mandela and Martin Luther King Jr. were branded as criminals for challenging apartheid and segregation .

CRITICAL POINT

Deviance is an indispensable prerequisite for moral evolution and social change; without deviant departures from collective sentiments, society would freeze in rigid stagnation .

- **Temporal and Spatial Relativity:** Monarchy and slavery were once normal social facts; today they are pathological . Patriarchy, long considered normal, is actively dismantled by successive waves of feminism .

4.6.5 Rule of Constructing Social Types

Societies cannot be studied in chaotic isolation . Sociologists classify societies into **social types** / **species** (*morphologie sociale*) based on their degree of structural complexity (from simple, unsegmented hordes/clans to polysegmental, modern industrial societies) . Within societies, facts are categorized across sociological types (gender, caste, religion, marital status) .

4.6.6 Rule of Explaining Cause and Function of Social Facts

1. The Cause of a Social Fact

KEY CONCEPT

The Methodological Injunction: “The determining cause of a social fact must be sought among the antecedent social facts and not among the states of the individual consciousness.”

EXAMPLE

Sabarimala Case Explained via Social Facts: A woman entering the Sabarimala shrine was socially defined as deviance . The sociologist does not explain this through the psychology of the woman or the priests . The deviance is explained by an antecedent social fact—the *collective sentiment regarding ritual purity* . That sentiment is caused by a prior social fact—*religious institutional dogma* . That dogma is caused by an even broader social fact—*structural patriarchy* . The explanation moves strictly from social fact to social fact .

2. The Function of a Social Fact Because crime is a normal social fact, it must serve vital social functions :

1. **Reinforces Collective Cohesion:** Spectacular crimes trigger shared outrage, uniting diverse citizens in moral solidarity . (e.g., the 2012 Nirbhaya case in Delhi unified the nation in demands for legal amendments and surveillance infrastructure) .
2. **Clarifies Normative Boundaries:** Punishing an offender publicly reaffirms to society what is acceptable and unacceptable . (e.g., being fined for eating while driving clarifies traffic norms) .
3. **Anticipates Future Morality:** Deviance tests the boundaries of law, preparing society for necessary legislative reforms (anti-slavery advocacy was once criminal, now basic morality) .

4.6.7 Rule of Testing Social Facts: The Comparative Method

- Sociologists cannot perform direct laboratory experiments on society .
- Sociology relies on **indirect experimentation** via **concomitant variation** (derived from John Stuart Mill's logic) .
 - *Analogy:* Adding measured quantities of lead to water increases toxicity proportionally, proving a direct causal relationship .
- **Application to Social Data:** Comparing suicide or crime rates across demographic categories (married vs. single, Protestants vs. Catholics, peace vs. wartime) reveals that social integration varies inversely with deviance .

KEY CONCEPT

Durkheim's Famous Dictum: "*Comparative sociology is not a particular branch of sociology; it is sociology itself.*" The comparative method uses inductive reasoning to discover universal invariant social laws .

QUICK REVISION

- Social facts are external, coercive, general, and independent ways of acting, thinking, or feeling .
- Rule 1: Treat social facts as things; shed all pre-notions .
- Rule 2: Normal facts are statistically universal; crime is normal and functional (unites society, draws boundaries, anticipates future morality) .
- Rule 3: Construct social types from simple to complex .

- Rule 4: The cause of a social fact is always another social fact; never reduce society to individual psychology .
- Rule 5: Test through concomitant variation and the comparative method .

4.7 Answer-Writing Toolkit

4.7.1 General Approach to Any Theory Question

1. **Encircle Keywords First:** Mark core terms and determine their exact structural hierarchy .
2. **Decipher the Core Demand:** Restate the question in simple language before drafting .
3. **Define Core Concepts:** Open with precise definitions .
4. **Build Supporting Scaffolding:** Integrate scholars, theories, flowcharts, and empirical examples .
5. **Execute Dialectical Pivot:** Use structural connectors (“However”, “Therefore”) to transition into counter-critiques .
6. **Deliver a Balanced Conclusion:** Synthesize perspectives without a flat yes/no verdict .

4.7.2 PYQ 1: “Is sociology a value-free science? Discuss.” (10 Marks / 150 Words)

- **Definition:** Define value-free science (inquiry devoid of moral, ideological, or personal biases) .
- **Positivist Stance:** Comte and Durkheim asserted sociology is value-free by treating social facts as things governed by objective laws .
- **The Pivot (“However”):**
 1. Researcher values guide topic selection (Durkheim’s study of suicide motivated by personal tragedy) ;
 2. Corporate funding distorts research agendas (tobacco and fast-food industry studies) ;
 3. Hypotheses reflect social location (radical feminist concepts like the patriarchal bargain) .
- **Theoretical Critique:** David Marsland notes sociological paradigms (Marxism, feminism) are inherently value-loaded .
- **Conclusion:** Sociology is not purely value-free; it achieves rigor through Max Weber’s **value-neutrality** .

4.7.3 PYQ 2: “Phenomenological perspectives in sociology reject many of the assumptions of positivism. Comment.”

- **Keywords:** Positivist assumptions vs. Phenomenological rejection .
- **Positivist Assumptions:** Society is an objective reality, governed by invariant natural laws, progressing unilinearly, where individuals are passive recipients .
- **Phenomenological Rebuttals:**
 - Social reality is not objective, but an **intersubjective illusion** constructed via shared

typifications (Alfred Schutz) ;

- Social order is actively negotiated through the documentary method and conversational rules, not natural laws (Harold Garfinkel) ;
- Human beings are active meaning-makers, not deterministic apples .
- **Presentation:** Contrast through a structured comparison table or sequential dialectical paragraphs .

4.7.4 PYQ 3: “Is sociology a science?”

- **Step 1 — Define Science:** Establish core criteria (empirical observation, testability, falsifiability, cumulative theory) .
- **Step 2 — Positivist Affirmation:** Yes, sociology employs the comparative method, studies social facts as things, and formulates general laws .
- **Step 3 — Non-Positivist Refutation:** No, social reality is subjective, fluid, and non-deterministic; human agency cannot be measured like physical matter .
- **Step 4 — Postmodern Twist:** Jean-François Lyotard (*The Postmodern Condition*) deconstructs the claim of science as an authoritarian meta-narrative; sociology’s value lies in humanistic reflexivity .

4.7.5 General Exam-Strategy Points

- **Precision Over Volume:** A 10-mark answer requires clear, high-density keywords, not padded prose .
- **Study Toppers’ Structural Copies:** Observe how successful candidates scaffold definitions, diagrams, and quick conclusions .
- **Syllabus Horizon:** Focus on post-2013 UPSC question patterns (10/20 mark formats) .

Religion, Suicide, and the Foundations of Marxism

5.1 Emile Durkheim — Elementary Forms of Religious Life

5.1.1 The “Person from Mars” Method and the Melanesian Totem Story

KEY CONCEPT

- To study religion sociologically, Durkheim insists the researcher must approach it as someone who has “descended from Mars” — stripped entirely of every preconceived notion, cultural baggage, or theological bias regarding what religion is .
- This directly operationalizes **Rule 1 of Durkheim’s Rules of Sociological Method**: treat social facts as things, and observe them objectively, free from ideological pre-notions (*prénotions*) .

In his illustrative methodological thought-experiment, Durkheim imagines landing on a Melanesian island (a cluster of islands situated southeast of Indonesia) and observing an indigenous clan from behind a tree without any prior knowledge of their language, rituals, or social customs :

- One night, the clan members gathered together wearing garments crafted from leopard skin . They held hands, directed their gaze skyward, and chanted an indecipherable invocation collectively for several minutes before falling into complete silence .
- As the gathering dispersed, a small object was revealed at the exact physical centre of the assembly: a symbolic figure shaped like a leopard, constructed simply out of woven grass .
- On a subsequent night, the very same group of people tracked down, hunted, and ritually killed a living, flesh-and-blood leopard .
- Upon subsequently learning the clan’s language, the ethnographer records that this entire complex of collective assembly, veneration, and sacrifice is precisely what the clan designates as its “religion” .

The exact same underlying structure was observed on an adjacent island, this time organized around the crocodile: a collective gathering, synchronized chanting, participants entering an altered, ecstatic state of consciousness, followed by the ritual slaying of an actual crocodile at the culmination of the ceremony .

EXAMPLE

Common Structural Features Across Both Islands:

- Physical collective gathering of the dispersed clan members .
- Synchronized collective chanting and rhythmic vocalization .
- A central symbolic representation or emblem (the **totem**) placed at the focal point of assembly .
- Participants entering a heightened, trance-like state of psychological transcendence .
- Even an outside, detached observer experiences visceral physiological reactions (such as “goosebumps”) purely from being proximate to the assembled crowd, despite having no personal membership in the belief system .

This observational stance was extended to a modern listening experiment: analyzing audio recordings of (1) the British national anthem sung by thousands of fans at a football stadium, and (2) the industrial metal track “*Du Hast*” by the German band Rammstein . Stripped of visual and cultural biases, both auditory phenomena generate the distinct sociological signature of religion: a structured set of practices and collective energy through which an assembled group constitutes itself as a shared moral community .

5.1.2 Competing Definitions of Religion

Before formulating his sociological definition, Durkheim examined existing disciplinary definitions of religion, demonstrating that each imports an inherent, non-sociological value bias :

- **Natural Scientist:** Dismisses religion as pseudoscience or an irrational myth reflecting “primitive mentality”; God is rejected because the entity cannot be subjected to empirical laboratory testing or physical observation .
- **Psychologist (Sigmund Freud):** Views religion as an illusion and wish-fulfilment — an unconscious yearning for an omnipotent, protective father figure rooted in the unresolved guilt of the primal horde (the patricide of the dominant father) . Compulsive, repetitive prayer is equated with obsessive-compulsive neurosis .
- **Philosopher (Ludwig Feuerbach):** Conceives religion as an external projection of idealized human capacities; humanity projects its own finest attributes (omniscience, omnipotence, infinite love) onto an external entity termed “God,” against which real humans are rendered inadequate and alienated .
- **Theologian:** Seeks a transcendent universalism across divergent faiths (Hinduism, Sikhism, Buddhism, Islam, Christianity; comparing the *Quran* and the *Bhagavad Gita*) to declare that “God is essentially One” .
- **Anthropologist (E. B. Tylor):** Reduces religion to an intellectual error termed **animism** (the belief in spiritual beings inhabiting natural objects) and arranges religions along a unilinear evolutionary ladder from primitive superstition to modern monotheism .

CRITICAL POINT

Every one of these formulations imposes the definer’s external value judgment — whether scientific superiority, psychological pathology, humanist alienation, theological universalism, or evolutionary hierarchy . Durkheim’s objective method strictly avoids imposing an outside verdict;

it investigates empirically what the practitioners themselves treat as sacred and how that belief functions within the collectivity .

5.1.3 *Durkheim's Definition: The Sacred and the Profane*

KEY CONCEPT

Durkheim's Sociological Definition of Religion:

“A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden — beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them.”

Notably, this definition completely omits any required reference to God, spirits, supernatural forces, or divine intervention .

Durkheim observed that across all human societies, religious phenomena invariably exhibit three invariant structural elements: **collective beliefs**, **collective thinking**, and **collective action** .

The Anatomy of the “Sacred”

- The **sacred** is defined by exclusion: it encompasses anything set apart, elevated, and strictly protected by social prohibitions (taboos) from mundane, everyday utilitarian life (the **profane**) .
- **Forbidden Nature:** The sacred is so intensely invested with collective sentiment that any desecration, unauthorized handling, or insult by an outsider provokes collective moral outrage . Examples include:
 - A father who guards an automobile gifted to his child from being casually driven by acquaintances .
 - A dedicated football supporter who reacts fiercely against any public mockery of their club emblem during a match .
 - A citizen who will not tolerate disrespect toward the national flag .
- The visceral, goosebump-inducing euphoria felt inside a dense crowd (e.g., at a Lucky Ali live concert, a Rammstein show, a stadium during the final over of a cricket championship, or during the national anthem on Independence Day) is functionally identical to the transcendent state recorded among tribal worshippers . Sacredness is an attribute conferred by collective emotional investment, not an intrinsic physical property of the object .

EXAMPLE

An ordinary pen is entirely profane and utilitarian . However, if that pen was a cherished parting gift from one's late father, it is immediately removed from ordinary circulation . It becomes irreplaceable and “sacred” to the individual, even though its physical chemical composition remains completely unchanged .

5.1.4 *Totemism among the Arunta Clan*

Durkheim did not conduct direct ethnographic fieldwork . Instead, working systematically from his desk, he analyzed the comprehensive field ethnographies of **Baldwin Spencer and F.J.**

Gillen regarding the **Arunta (Arrernte) tribe** of Central Australia (and comparable groups in the Melanesian cultural sphere) . The Arunta society was organized into localized exogamous clans, each identifying with a specific animal or plant emblem (such as the kangaroo, leopard, crocodile, or witchetty grub) .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Totem:** A specific animal species, plant, or physical emblem adopted by a clan as its collective sacred representation and identity marker .
- **Arbitrary Substratum:** The physical totem has no inherent biological or chemical sacredness; sacredness is projected upon it by the gathered clan .
- **Symbolic Representation:** The totem does not need to be a living creature; it is frequently represented through stylized carvings on wood or stone (*churingas*) or crafted from grass .
- **The Totemic Principle:** The totem represents both the clan identity and the anonymous, impersonal sacred force underpinning clan life . Therefore, when the clan worships the totem, it is unwittingly worshipping its own collective power and social body . **God and society are one and the same.**

EXAMPLE

The Logic of Ritual Sacrifice: Addressing why clans periodically sacrifice their revered totemic animal (comparable to historical animal-sacrifice rituals at sites like the Kamakhya Temple), Durkheim notes that sacrifice is not an act of routine contempt or casual violence . It represents the solemn, belief-driven consummation of a sacred cycle, wherein the collectivity ingests and rejuvenates the sacred energy linking every clan member to the totemic source .

5.1.5 Collective Effervescence — The Cause of Religion

Durkheim applies his foundational methodological postulate: “**The determining cause of a social fact must be sought among the antecedent social facts, and not among the states of the individual consciousness.**” Consequently, the origin of religion cannot be reduced to individual dreams, psychological anxiety, or fear of nature . It is generated by a prior non-material social fact: **collective effervescence** .

- **Non-Material Social Facts:** Institutionalized, non-physical forces of social reality, including collective consciousness, collective effervescence, social currents (integration and regulation), shared values, and moral norms .
- **Material Social Facts:** Morphological and structural features of society, including legal codes, architectural forms, religious institutions, political states, demographic structures, caste hierarchies, and language systems . (“Material” here signifies structural crystallization, not mere physical tangibility) .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Collective Effervescence:** The intensely charged, electrified emotional state that overtakes individuals when assembled in close physical proximity for a shared collective purpose . In

this heightened state, individual self-consciousness dissolves, and members experience a sense of transcendence, feeling transported into communion with an external power greater than themselves .

- **Causal Sequence:**

Periodic Clan Assembly → Collective Effervescence → Projection onto Totem → Institutionalized Religion

- **Empirical Analogy:** Tens of thousands of spectators chanting “Sachin, Sachin” in unison inside a packed cricket stadium generate precisely the same ecstatic effervescence and transcendent solidarity as tribal members chanting around a sacred totemic altar .

CRITICAL POINT

Because social facts must be explained strictly by other social facts and never reduced to individual psychology, collective effervescence cannot be manufactured by an isolated individual sitting in seclusion . The physical co-presence and interaction of the assembly are indispensable .

5.1.6 Functions of Religion

Durkheim attributes three indispensable integrative functions to religion:

1. **Social Integration and Solidarity:** Religion binds individuals into a unified social fabric, renewing social bonds periodically, just as the division of labour generates interdependence in organic societies .
2. **Infusion of Morality (Coercive Control):** Inside the charged collective gathering, individuals internalize societal rules as sacred moral imperatives . The community acts as an external moral force constraining egoistic impulses .
3. **Cognitive Categorization (Sacred vs. Profane):** Religion creates the fundamental architecture of human thought by establishing the primal boundary between the sacred and the profane, ordering human experience and space .

QUICK REVISION

- **Definition:** A unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, uniting adherents into a moral community (Church) .
- **Causal Mechanism:** Physical assembly → collective effervescence → sacred totem → religion .
- **Core Functions:** Social solidarity, moral coercion/regulation, cognitive differentiation of sacred/profane .
- **Core Epigram:** “Religion is nothing but society apotheosized.” Worshipping the sacred totem is simply society worshipping its own collective existence .

5.1.7 Modern Totems and “Society Apotheosized”

Following the European Enlightenment, the French Revolution, and the rise of industrial capitalism, early positivists assumed that religious thinking was disappearing permanently in favour of

unbridled rational individualism . Durkheim challenged this secularization thesis, famously observing:

“The old gods are growing old or already dead, and others are not yet born.”

Modern societies do not abandon the sacred; they fabricate novel, secularized totems to sustain collective solidarity :

- **Modern Secular Totems:** The Nation-State, the written Constitution, the National Flag, the National Anthem, national animal symbols, and international sporting fixtures (e.g., millions watching a nail-biting cricket final together) .
- When citizens stand solemnly and sing the national anthem before the flag, they are engaging in a modern totemic rite: they are re-affirming their commitment to the collectivity and worshipping the collective self .

KEY CONCEPT

The “Cult of the Individual” and Modern Totemism: Durkheim anticipated that modern complex societies would increasingly sanctify the human individual . Individual autonomy, human rights, and personal choice themselves become the supreme sacred object . For example, young adults resisting arranged marriage norms may rally around the shared ideal of romantic self-determination, with a consensual live-in relationship functioning as a modern totemic symbol of individual freedom .

5.1.8 Religion as a Force of Division and Conflict

CRITICAL POINT

- While Durkheim emphasized the cohesive, integrating function of religion within a single clan, religion simultaneously acts as an explosive force of inter-group division and violent conflict .
- Attempting to impose one group’s sacred totem (e.g., the leopard, the crocodile, or the cow) upon a population adhering to an alternative totem sparks intense hostility, because sacred values are non-negotiable .
- **Contemporary Conflict:** The long-standing Israel–Palestine conflict represents, at its structural core, an intractable “**war over the sacred**” — competing claims over sacred territory, monuments, and historical narratives .
- **UPSC Exam Note:** In an examination answer, Durkheim’s functional integration must be presented as the primary thesis, while religious conflict, sectarian violence, and dysfunctions must be systematically integrated into the critical evaluation section .

5.1.9 Material and Non-Material Social Facts

KEY CONCEPT

Foundational Explanatory Rule: A material social fact must be explained through the operation of antecedent non-material social facts . For instance:

- A widespread non-material consensus (**collective consciousness**) on the necessity for political autonomy gives rise to the material social fact of a sovereign **nation-state** .

Material Social Facts	Non-Material Social Facts
Structural, architectural, and morphological components of society.	Institutionalized mentalities, moral currents, and normative orientations.
Not necessarily tangible to the eye; refers to crystallized social structures.	Intangible social currents operating across the collective body.
Examples: Legal codes, state institutions, organized religious bodies, caste structures, gender regimes, architectural layouts, and language systems.	Examples: Collective consciousness, collective effervescence, social currents of integration and regulation, values, mores, and ethical norms.

- Ephemeral non-material waves of **collective effervescence** crystallize into the permanent material social fact of an organized **church or religious institution** .

5.1.10 Applying Durkheim to Contemporary Movements

Durkheim's totemic framework can be applied to diverse modern socio-political phenomena without normative bias :

- **ISIS / Radical Caliphate Mobilization:**
 - **Sacralized Notion:** Absolute divine sovereignty (*Hakimiyya*), radical anti-western identity, and the geographic re-establishment of a historic Caliphate spanning Syria, Iraq, Lebanon, and Jordan .
 - **Rituals:** Rigorous military drills, synchronized weapons training, and collective recitations, generating intense collective effervescence among recruits .
 - **Sociological Neutrality:** A sociologist does not evaluate theological validity (“our religion is enlightened, yours is primitive”); sociological analysis examines the empirical mechanics of sacredness and group cohesion, even while legal frameworks judge the criminal means employed .
- **Chipko Movement and Sacred Groves:**
 - **Totem:** The living forest tree (e.g., sacred groves in Northeast India and Arunachal Pradesh, officially protected by local governance) .
 - **Sacralized Idea:** Ecological sustainability and cosmic kinship — trees are embraced as kin, transcending mere commercial timber value .
- **Global Environmental and Climate Movements:**
 - **Totem:** The icon of Planet Earth / The Blue Marble .
 - **Sacralized Ideas:** Planetary conservation, inter-generational justice, ecological balance, and the Gandhian principle of the “voluntary limitation of wants” .
- **India Against Corruption (Anna Hazare Movement, 2012):**
 - **Collective Belief:** A corruption-free Indian republic and moral public governance .
 - **Totemic Representations:** Large stage backdrops depicting Mahatma Gandhi, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, and B. R. Ambedkar, which served as sacred focal points for the assembled crowds .

- **LGBTQ+ Pride Mobilization:**

- **Totem:** The Rainbow Flag .
- **Sacralized Ideas:** Universal human dignity, gender equality, bodily autonomy, and constitutional morality .

QUICK REVISION

To analyze any contemporary movement through Durkheim's framework:

1. Identify the central **emblem/totem** .
2. Isolate the core **sacralized idea/value** it embodies .
3. Analyze the **collective gathering** and **effervescence** that charge the symbol with sacred authority .

5.2 Emile Durkheim — Suicide (*Le Suicide*)

5.2.1 Why a Sociologist Studies Suicide

KEY CONCEPT

Durkheim deliberately selected suicide (*Le Suicide*, 1897) for empirical investigation because it appeared to be the most private, deeply personal, and psychologically isolated act an individual could possibly commit . His objective was to demonstrate the power of the **sociological imagination** (later formulated by C. Wright Mills): to prove that what appears to be a purely personal trouble is in reality a structural public issue driven by social forces .

While the tragic suicide of his close friend, Victor Hommay, provided immediate personal impetus, Durkheim's primary objective was epistemological and methodological :

- **Psychological Fallacy:** Psychologists ask, “Why did individual *X* commit suicide?” and search for causes internal to the individual psyche (neurochemistry, emotional trauma, clinical depression, or personal failure) .
- **Sociological Position:** Sociologists study suicide **rates** across whole populations . Social facts are external to the individual and exert a coercive influence over actors . The suicide rate is a distinct property of the social structure itself .

5.2.2 Pre-Durkheimian Explanations of Suicide

Durkheim systematically reviewed and refuted existing non-sociological explanations of suicide:

1. **Alcoholism (Skog's Hypothesis):** It was argued that alcohol abuse caused suicide . Durkheim showed statistically that regions with high alcohol consumption did not correlate with high suicide rates . Alcoholism is an individual pathology, not a structural cause .
2. **Climatic and Geographical Factors:** Theories suggested that high temperatures or long winter nights induced suicide . Durkheim proved that while suicides peaked in spring and summer, this was caused by increased social interaction and intensity during longer daylight hours, not

the physical temperature itself .

3. **Imitation (*Psychological Contagion* — Gabriel Tarde):** Tarde claimed suicide spreads through interpersonal imitation (comparable to modern phenomena like the “Blue Whale” online game) . Durkheim mapped suicide statistics across geographic regions and demonstrated that suicide does not radiate outwards from epicentres like infectious epidemics; geographical proximity does not explain distribution .

CRITICAL POINT

Durkheim rejected all individualistic, biological, and environmental determinisms . If suicide rates vary systematically across societies and remain stable over time within a given society, **the cause must reside in the structural condition of the society itself** .

5.2.3 *Durkheim’s Statistical Observations*

Country	Suicide Rate (per 1,00,000 inhabitants)
England	67
France	135
Denmark	275

These statistical variations generated three core research questions that established the sociology of suicide :

1. **Cross-National Variation:** Why does the suicide rate differ markedly between countries (e.g., Denmark’s rate being more than four times that of England) ?
2. **Temporal Stability:** Why does the suicide rate within a particular country remain remarkably constant year after year ?
3. **Intra-Societal Demographic Variation:** Why do suicide rates vary consistently across different social groups within the same society (men vs. women, Protestants vs. Catholics, single vs. married individuals) ?

5.2.4 *Rapid Industrialization and Social Cohesion*

At the time of Durkheim’s study, Denmark was undergoing rapid, sudden industrialization and urbanization compared to the gradual, paced transformation in England . Rapid modernization tears apart traditional community bonds faster than new institutions can develop .

EXAMPLE

Modern Urban Parallel — Bengaluru as a Global City: Urban scholars (including Ramachandra Guha) have analyzed Bengaluru as a contemporary case study of rapid modernization . Categorized alongside Mumbai as a global city (per Saskia Sassen’s framework), its rapid integration into 24/7 transnational commercial schedules has fueled nightlife economies and fast-food cultures, accompanied by social fragmentation, weakening kinship ties, rising clinical anxiety, and elevated suicide indices .

KEY CONCEPT

General Law of Modernization: Sudden, rapid industrialization or urbanization weakens social integration and moral regulation, causing a rise in suicide rates . When structural rates spike, the explanation cannot be reduced to personal character flaws; if 50,000 individuals are unemployed or distressed in a city of 1,00,000, the phenomenon is structural, not a collection of personal failures .

5.2.5 Method: Classification, Correlation, and Multivariate Analysis

Durkheim's *Le Suicide* represents a classic application of the positivist scientific method in sociology :

1. **Data Collection:** Compiled official suicide records from police registers and coroner offices across European jurisdictions .
2. **Data Classification:** Categorized rates according to key demographic variables: age, gender, marital status, religious denomination, military vs. civilian status, and economic cycles .
3. **Correlation vs. Causation Caution:** Recognized that in social life, direct causal linkages are complex because individuals hold overlapping identities (e.g., an individual is simultaneously male, Protestant, and working-class) . Simple bivariate correlations risk generating spurious conclusions .
4. **Multivariate Concomitant Variation:** To isolate the operative causal factor, Durkheim compared sub-groups while systematically holding other variables constant (e.g., comparing Protestant working-class males against Protestant working-class females to isolate the specific impact of gender) .

DATA & FACTS

Durkheim's Key Statistical Findings and Sociological Explanations:

- **Married < Single/Unmarried:** Marriage integrates the individual into a domestic web of reciprocal obligations and family ties, lowering the suicide rate . Unmarried individuals lack this protective integrative fabric .
- **Catholics < Protestants:** The Catholic Church emphasizes shared dogma, sacramental authority, and communal rituals, providing strong social integration and viewing suicide as a mortal sin . Protestantism encourages individual interpretation of scripture, personal responsibility, and free inquiry, leading to lower social integration .
- **Females < Males:** In nineteenth-century Europe, women were anchored within domestic networks and community ties, whereas men were exposed to competitive workplace pressures and market fluctuations .
- **Young < Elderly:** Younger individuals typically maintain dense peer groups and active social connections, whereas the elderly often face social isolation and retirement from productive roles .
- **War Time < Peace Time:** External national crises and wars dramatically increase social integration by uniting the population against a common adversary (e.g., heightened cohesion during wartime), which drops back down during ordinary peacetime .

5.2.6 The Two Laws of Suicide

KEY CONCEPT

Following years of empirical analysis, Durkheim formulated two general laws of suicide :

- 1. **First Law:** The suicide rate increases with sudden economic transitions — occurring during both sharp economic depressions and sudden economic booms .
- 2. **Second Law:** The suicide rate varies inversely with the degree of integration of the social groups of which the individual forms a part .

5.2.7 Typology of Suicide

Durkheim constructed a four-fold typology of suicide mapped across two fundamental social axes: **Integration** (the strength of the social fabric linking the individual to the group) and **Regulation** (the degree of moral and social control exerted over individual desires) .

Type	Social Force	Description and Manifestation
Altruistic	High Integration	Occurs when an individual is so completely absorbed into a group that they sacrifice their life for the collective cause or moral duty . Examples: Japanese Kamikaze pilots in WWII, military personnel undertaking fatal missions, self-immolation protests, or radicalized insurgents sacrificing themselves for a caliphate .
Egoistic	Low Integration	Occurs when an individual is insufficiently integrated into social groups, leading to extreme isolation, detachment, and meaninglessness . Examples: Isolated elderly individuals, unmarried persons living alone, or marginalized university students facing systemic discrimination and alienation .
Fatalistic	High Regulation	Occurs when an individual faces extreme, unyielding social regulation and oppressive discipline that thoroughly crushes personal agency and hope . Examples: Slaves under brutal masters, prisoners in solitary confinement, or individuals trapped in abusive, inescapable domestic relationships .
Anomic	Low Regulation	Occurs when societal norms and moral limits suddenly break down (anomie = normlessness), leaving individual desires unchecked during rapid economic booms, sudden financial bankruptcies, or major social disruptions . Examples: Bankrupt investors during a market crash, overnight lottery winners whose social horizons are dislocated, or debt-ridden farmers facing unregulated market shocks .

CRITICAL POINT

While Durkheim presented these four categories as conceptually distinct, concrete empirical events often display elements of multiple types simultaneously (e.g., an individual experiencing both social isolation [egoism] and normlessness [anomie] following sudden unemployment) .

5.2.8 Conclusion — Suicide as a Social Fact

Durkheim’s study demonstrated that suicide rates constitute an objective **social fact**:

- Suicide rates exhibit regularities that cannot be explained by summing individual psychological choices .
- The temporal stability of suicide rates proves that a society possesses a collective moral constitution that predetermines its annual quota of voluntary deaths .
- *Le Suicide* stands as a foundation of positivist sociology, validating the use of statistical methodology to study social phenomena .

QUICK REVISION

- **Three Core Questions:** Cross-national variation, temporal constancy, intra-societal demographic variation .
- **Methodology:** Police statistics → Classification → Concomitant multivariate analysis .
- **The Two Axes:** Integration (Altruistic vs. Egoistic) and Regulation (Fatalistic vs. Anomic) .

5.3 Applying Durkheim to Contemporary India, and Critique

5.3.1 COVID-19 through a Durkheimian Lens

Durkheim, Marx, and Weber remain foundational because their frameworks provide powerful analytical tools for contemporary crises . The COVID-19 pandemic serves as a live demonstration of Durkheim's sociology of suicide and solidarity :

- **Anomic Disruption:** The sudden imposition of nationwide lockdowns brought immediate economic disruption, sudden loss of daily livelihoods, and mass reverse migration of informal workers, generating severe anomic distress .
- **Altruistic Sacrifices:** Frontline healthcare professionals (honoured as “medical warriors”) and essential workers knowingly risked infection and mortality to sustain public health, demonstrating altruistic devotion to the collective welfare .
- **Egoistic Isolation:** Strict quarantine measures and prolonged physical distancing severed essential social ties . Studies noted that roughly 15% of lockdown suicides were driven primarily by intense loneliness and sudden loss of social integration rather than the viral infection itself .
- **Restoration of Organic Solidarity:** The swift adoption of remote telecommunications and “work from home” platforms served as a functional mechanism that reconstituted organic solidarity and economic interdependence despite physical isolation .

DATA & FACTS

The collective banging of utensils (*thali*) and coordinated evening applause for medical personnel during lockdown operated sociologically as synchronized collective rituals . These assemblies generated collective effervescence, rallying the populace around a modern secular totem: the frontline healthcare worker .

CRITICAL POINT

The “Shadow Pandemic”: Feminist scholars emphasize that lockdowns intensified domestic isolation for millions of women . Pre-existing domestic confinement combined with heightened economic stress triggered a worldwide surge in domestic violence, demonstrating that domestic spaces can become zones of oppressive regulation and fatalistic distress .

5.3.2 Farmer Suicides — Empirical Case Studies (B. B. Mohanty, EPW)

Drawing on empirical research published in the *Economic and Political Weekly* (EPW) by **B. B. Mohanty**, sociological analyses of agrarian distress provide a deeper structural perspective than the administrative accounts found in magazines like *Yojana* or *Kurukshetra* .

DATA & FACTS

- Over the period from 1995 to 2011, approximately 3,00,000 Indian farmers died by suicide, with disproportionately high concentrations in Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Punjab .
- While surface-level policy reports attribute these deaths entirely to crop failures and debt, sociological inquiry reveals deeper causes rooted in growing social isolation, individualized risks, and the erosion of village safety nets .

Case Study 1: Egoism Leading Directly into Anomie

- A marginal farmer, “K”, belonging to the Mahad caste in Maharashtra, chose to convert to Neo-Buddhism .
- His father and elder brother opposed the conversion, leading to a family split; his brother separated his household, and his immediate family faced ongoing social ridicule . Crucially, a local dominant-caste landlord cancelled his 9-acre land lease and re-allocated it to his estranged brother .
- Following his father’s sudden death, the village blamed K’s conversion for the tragedy . Subsequent personal misfortunes followed: the death of his younger son, chronic family illness, and two consecutive years of severe crop failures (1996–1997) .
- Isolated from caste-based solidarity networks and deprived of informal credit or mutual aid (egoism), he turned to unadvised, high-interest informal loans (anomie), culminating in suicide .

CRITICAL POINT

This case proves empirically that **Durkheim’s suicide types are not mutually exclusive in concrete social reality** . Extreme social isolation and discrimination (egoism) directly precipitated reckless, unregulated debt choices and normlessness (anomie) .

Case Study 2: Family Separation and Individualized Risk

- A young cultivator separated from his joint household to farm an independent 4-acre share . He incurred a formal bank crop loan of Rs. 14,000 (which his father ultimately had to settle), took on additional unregulated private debt, and struggled with severe alcohol dependency .

- Lacking an experienced family advisory network to guide his cropping investments, he faced compounding losses and committed suicide on 25 September 2004 .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

UPSC Answer-Writing Strategy: Do not restrict answers on Durkheim's suicide theory exclusively to agrarian distress, as this is an overused example . Differentiate your response by integrating contemporary dimensions: COVID-19 lockdown trends, isolation among gig-economy workers, and institutional dropout patterns among marginalized students in elite technical institutions (e.g., IITs) .

5.3.3 Critique of Durkheim

1. **Jack Gibbs — Problem of Unmeasurability and Non-Falsifiability:** Gibbs argues that while Durkheim claimed to discover scientific laws of human behaviour, core concepts such as “social integration” and “moral regulation” are never directly operationalized or measured . Because these variables cannot be precisely quantified or tested, Durkheim's causal claims risk being unfalsifiable, descriptive narratives rather than natural-science laws .
2. **J. Maxwell Atkinson — Ethnomethodological / Phenomenological Critique:** Atkinson points out that official suicide statistics are not unmediated social facts . They are social constructions produced through the interpretive work of coroners, police officers, and medical personnel . Whether an ambiguous death (e.g., drowning or drug overdose) is registered as an “accident,” “homicide,” or “suicide” depends on social interpretations (suicide notes, family testimony, societal stigma), making official data subjective .
3. **B. B. Mohanty — Non-Exclusivity of Typologies:** Empirical studies demonstrate that real-world cases regularly combine multiple suicide types (e.g., egoistic isolation compounding anomic economic dislocation), challenging Durkheim's rigid four-part typology .
4. **Feminist Critique (Jennifer M. Lehman) — Patriarchal Bias:** Durkheim's theories of solidarity and the division of labour concentrate almost entirely on male experiences in the public economic sphere . He downplays the structural subordination of women in the private domestic sphere, wrongly assuming their domestic confinement naturally protected them from anomie .
5. **Empirical Measurement of Solidarities:** Durkheim provides no empirical scale to measure the transition from mechanical to organic solidarity . Modern societies display both forms simultaneously (e.g., South–South political solidarity based on shared historical identity [mechanical] operating alongside complex international supply-chain trade [organic]) .
6. **Anthony Giddens — Absence of Human Agency (Structuration Theory):** In *New Rules of Sociological Method*, Giddens argues that Durkheim's determinism treats human beings as passive cultural dopes pushed by external structures . Giddens proposes the “**duality of structure**”: structures constrain agents, but agents continuously produce, reproduce, and transform structures through reflexive agency .

KEY CONCEPT

Structuration and Changing Social Institutions: If social structures were purely external and

coercive, traditional institutions like the joint family could never change . Yet, individual agency has continuously altered the family form, giving rise to diverse arrangements such as urban single-person households, cohabiting couples, and live-in partnerships .

- **Robert Bellah — Civil Religion:** Extending Durkheim rather than rejecting him, Bellah demonstrates that even individualistic, secular nations (like the United States) are bound together by an institutionalized “civil religion” complete with sacred founding myths, national shrines, and totemic rituals .
- **Jack Goody — Fluidity of the Sacred/Profane Divide:** Goody notes that the boundary between the sacred and profane is fluid and context-dependent . A historic cathedral may serve as a profane tourist site or film set during the week, and immediately revert to a sacred sanctuary during Sunday worship .

5.3.4 Was Durkheim a Positivist? A Rule-by-Rule Assessment

QUICK REVISION

The Five Methodological Steps of Durkheimian Positivism:

1. **Rule 1:** Treat social facts as things (eliminate all pre-notions) .
2. **Rule 2:** Differentiate between normal and pathological social phenomena .
3. **Rule 3:** Classify societies into structural types (social morphology) .
4. **Rule 4:** Explain the determining cause and function of a social fact strictly through other social facts .
5. **Rule 5:** Formulate general, predictive sociological laws (achieved in *Suicide*) .

5.4 Answer-Writing Toolkit

5.4.1 Model Structure for a 150-Word / 10-Mark Answer

Question Demonstration: “What are the methodological challenges in observing social facts as things?” (UPSC 10 Marks / 150 Words)

1. **Direct Definition (1.5 Marks / ≈ 25 Words):** Define a social fact precisely: ways of feeling, thinking, and acting that are external to the individual and endowed with a coercive power over the actor (e.g., legal systems, moral codes, religious institutions) .
2. **Contextual Attribution (1.5 Marks / ≈ 20 Words):** Cite Émile Durkheim’s *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895), wherein he proposed treating social facts as “things” to establish sociology as an objective, empirical science on par with the natural sciences .
3. **Core Analytical Body — The Methodological Challenges (5 Marks / ≈ 80 Words):**
 - **Entanglement of Facts and Values:** Sociologists are themselves embedded members of society; researcher biases, religious identities, and political commitments inevitably influence data selection and interpretation .
 - **Unmeasurability of Non-Material Facts:** Subjective phenomena such as social cohesion,

Work	Methodological Rules Applied	Positivist Status and Evaluation
<i>The Division of Labour in Society</i> (1893)	None of the formal empirical rules; no systematic statistical data collected or classified .	Non-Positivist: Written as a doctoral dissertation rooted in social philosophy, moral theory, and historical deduction before sociology was formally established as an empirical discipline .
<i>The Rules of Sociological Method</i> (1895)	Formulates the normative rules: social facts as things, normal vs. pathological, classification of types, causal-functional analysis .	Positivist in Intent: Functions as a methodological manifesto outlining how natural-science principles should be applied to sociology, though it remains a theoretical treatise rather than an empirical study .
<i>The Elementary Forms of Religious Life</i> (1912)	Applied Rules 1–4 (objective definition of sacred, functional explanation), but formulated no universal mathematical laws .	Descriptive/Hermeneutic: Broadly empirical through secondary ethnographic analysis, but interpretive in character rather than a positivist search for universal predictive laws .
<i>Suicide</i> (1897)	Rigorously applied all five methodological rules, culminating in universal causal laws .	Fully Positivist: Durkheim's most positivist work — treats rates as things, distinguishes normal from pathological rates, applies multivariate statistics, and generates universal laws of human behaviour .

collective effervescence, and moral regulation cannot be directly weighed, observed, or measured in a physical laboratory .

- **Subjectivity of the Normal vs. Pathological:** Classifying a rate as “normal” or “pathological” depends on social definitions and cultural consensus, not neutral biological standards .
 - **Interpretive Nature of Social Data:** As phenomenologists point out, institutional data (such as crime or suicide statistics) represent administrative interpretations rather than pure objective facts .
4. **Dialectical Synthesis / Conclusion (2 Marks / ≈ 25 Words):** Conclude constructively: While post-positivists (such as Lyotard and Giddens) emphasize the limits of pure objectivity, Durkheim’s rule remains foundational for moving sociology beyond armchair philosophy into rigorous empirical research .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Key Examination Directives:

- Prioritize a clean, analytical structure over decorative rhetoric .
- When analyzing empirical problems (such as farmer suicides or urban distress), avoid forcing every scenario into all four suicide categories; accurately identify the specific operative mechanisms supported by the evidence .
- Keep in mind that raw scores undergo optional-subject normalization in the UPSC evaluation process; structural clarity and conceptual accuracy are essential for high-scoring answers .

5.5 Karl Marx — The Hegelian Background

5.5.1 *Life and Intellectual Formation of Karl Marx*

- Karl Marx was born in 1818 in Trier, Rhineland (Prussia/Germany), into a middle-class Jewish family that converted to Lutheranism to avoid anti-Semitic legal restrictions . Marx died in 1883 in London. (Note: The year 1917 marks the death of Durkheim, who began his major publications in the 1890s well after Marx’s death) .
- During his initial university studies at Bonn, Marx demonstrated an interest in literature and philosophy . His father subsequently transferred him to the University of Berlin, the centre of German philosophical thought dominated by the intellectual legacy of **G. W. F. Hegel** .
- In Berlin, Marx joined the **Young Hegelians (or the Doctors’ Club)**, an intellectual circle including Ludwig Feuerbach and Bruno Bauer, which adopted Hegel’s dialectical method while rejecting his conservative political and religious conclusions .
- Marx married **Jenny von Westphalen**, who came from an aristocratic Prussian family . Her father, Baron Ludwig von Westphalen, introduced the young Marx to the utopian socialist ideas of Henri de Saint-Simon .

CRITICAL POINT

The Impact of Material Hardship on Marx's Work: Exiled successively from Germany, France, and Belgium for his radical journalism, Marx lived in severe poverty in London, sustained by the financial support of his lifelong collaborator, **Friedrich Engels**. Three of his children died of malnutrition and untreated illnesses in their Soho lodgings, followed years later by the death of his wife and two more children. This first-hand experience of poverty shaped the passionate, uncompromising tone of his critique of capitalism and the bourgeois state.

5.5.2 Hegel's Philosophy of History**KEY CONCEPT**

Hegel's Dialectical Idealism: For Hegel, history is not a random sequence of events; it is the purposeful, teleological evolution of **Ideas** and human consciousness, guided by the unfolding of the **World Spirit** (*Weltgeist*) toward absolute freedom and self-awareness. Individual human beings are not the independent authors of history, but agents through whom the World Spirit realizes its destiny.

Hegel outlined a three-stage historical progression in the realization of human freedom :

1. **The Ancient Despotism Stage (The Orient):** Absolute despotism (e.g., Ancient China, Babylon, Egypt) where only one person — the ruler — is free, and all others are subjects lacking institutionalized freedom.
2. **The Greco-Roman World:** Classical antiquity introduces reason, logic, citizenship, and individual liberty for some (the citizens), while maintaining institutional slavery for others.
3. **The Modern Constitutional State (Post-French Revolution):** The constitutional monarchy synthesizes universal state authority with individual civil liberties, realizing human freedom in history.

DATA & FACTS

Hegel was skeptical of direct, unmediated democracy (viewing it as prone to populism and instability), arguing that a rational, constitutional monarchy represented the most balanced political structure.

World-Historical Figures In Hegel's framework, extraordinary historical leaders (e.g., Alexander the Great, Julius Caesar, Napoleon Bonaparte, Ashoka, or Akbar) are "**World-Historical Individuals**". They do not act out of independent autonomous goals; they are instruments through whom the World Spirit advances history to its next stage.

- Hegel personally observed Napoleon riding through the streets of Jena in 1806 following the defeat of the Prussian army, famously describing him as "*the World Soul on horseback*" — an embodiment of history taking a leap forward.

5.5.3 Idealism and Dialectical Idealism

KEY CONCEPT

- **Idealism:** The philosophical doctrine that consciousness, ideas, and reason are primary, while the material, physical world is an expression of consciousness .
- **Dialectics:** The mechanism of development through internal contradictions, opposition, and resolution .
- **Dialectical Idealism:** Society evolves through the clash of contradictory ideas, generating higher synthesis stages that preserve and elevate the elements of earlier stages (*Aufhebung*) .

The Dialectical Triad: Thesis, Antithesis, Synthesis

- **Thesis:** An established idea, institution, or social arrangement (e.g., absolute patriarchal authority or early political despotism) .
- **Antithesis:** An opposing idea or contradiction that emerges within the existing order (e.g., Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* challenging the patriarchal gender order) .
- **Synthesis:** The resolution arising from this conflict, reconciling the contradiction into a higher social form (e.g., the institutional recognition of women's legal rights), which over time becomes a new Thesis, continuing the dialectical cycle .

EXAMPLE

The Dialectic of Ancient Freedom: Athenian democracy privileged individual freedom (Thesis), but lacked the organized collective discipline of the Persian Empire (Antithesis), leading to military vulnerability . Subsequently, conquered populations internalized Greek ideals of reason and liberty, undermining imperial despotism and moving political history forward .

5.5.4 Napoleon as World-Historical Figure and the “End of History”

For Hegel, the post-Enlightenment constitutional state represented the highest possible reconciliation of individual liberty and sovereign law . Consequently, Hegel viewed his era as marking the conceptual “**End of History**” — no higher institutional form remained to be dialectically generated .

COMPARISON

Hegel and Francis Fukuyama: In *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), political theorist Francis Fukuyama adapted this Hegelian concept, arguing that the collapse of the Soviet Union marked the end of ideological evolution and the universalization of Western liberal democracy as the final form of human government .

5.5.5 Ludwig Feuerbach's Critique — Materialism and Alienation

KEY CONCEPT

Feuerbach's Materialist Inversion: In *The Essence of Christianity* (1841), Ludwig Feuerbach broke with Hegelian idealism, arguing that there is no metaphysical World Spirit driving history .
Humans are not created by God; God is an idealized projection of human nature .

- Human beings take their finest qualities — compassion, intelligence, creativity — and project them into an external, imaginary deity, declaring God to be omnipotent, omniscient, and all-loving .
- **Religious Alienation:** By endowing this external creation with all perfection, human beings strip themselves of their own dignity . The creator falls on their knees to worship their own creation, feeling weak, sinful, and dependent .
- Feuerbach's philosophy is strictly **materialist**: concrete, physical human beings are primary; ideas, consciousness, and religion are the social products of real human existence .

COMPARISON

- **Hegel (Idealist):** Consciousness / Ideas are primary; material reality is their outward manifestation .
- **Feuerbach (Materialist):** The physical human being is primary; ideas, spirituality, and deities are human mental projections .

5.5.6 Sigmund Freud on Religion

Influenced by Feuerbach's theory of human projection, Sigmund Freud developed a psychological critique of religion in works such as *The Future of an Illusion* :

- **Primal Horde Hypothesis:** In early human prehistory, the sons of the dominant primal horde patriarch killed their father to gain access to the women of the group . The resulting collective guilt became internalized across generations .
- **Projection of the Father Figure:** To assuage this inherited guilt and seek protection against the overwhelming forces of nature, humanity created an exalted, heavenly Father: God .
- **Collective Neurosis:** Repetitive, structured religious rituals, prayers, and confessions operate as collective defence mechanisms akin to obsessive-compulsive neurosis, designed to manage repressed guilt .

KEY CONCEPT

For Freud, religion is an illusion driven by unconscious wish-fulfilment; it has no independent metaphysical reality .

5.5.7 Marx’s Departure — “The Point Is to Change It”

CRITICAL POINT

In his *Theses on Feuerbach* (1845), Marx formulated his famous epistemological break:
“The philosophers have only interpreted the world in various ways; the point, however, is to change it.”
Marx recognized that purely philosophical critiques of religion and consciousness are insufficient; ending human suffering requires dismantling the material economic conditions that produce suffering in the first place .

- **Retained from Hegel:** The dynamic **Dialectical Method** (the recognition that history develops through internal contradictions, clashes, and structural transformations) .
- **Retained from Feuerbach:** The foundational principle of **Materialism** (the recognition that physical, economic conditions determine human thought, not vice versa) .

KEY CONCEPT

By combining Hegelian dialectics with materialist ontology, Marx created **Dialectical Materialism** — turning Hegel’s dialectic “right side up” to establish the theoretical foundation of Marxism .

5.6 Dialectical and Historical Materialism

5.6.1 Consciousness versus Being — Hegel and Marx Compared

Analytical Dimension	G. W. F. Hegel	Karl Marx
Primary Driver	Consciousness, Ideas, Reason, World Spirit (<i>Weltgeist</i>) .	Matter, Material production, Economic forces .
Foundational Premise	“Consciousness determines Being.”	“Social Being determines Consciousness.”
Definition of History	The progressive unfolding and self-realization of the Idea of Freedom .	The history of successive modes of production and class struggles .
Mechanism of Change	Dialectical contradictions between opposing ideas/philosophies .	Dialectical contradictions within the economic base (forces vs. relations of production) .
Base / Superstructure	Ideas, religion, law, and the state form the base; the material economy is a manifestation .	The economic mode of production is the Base; law, politics, religion, and philosophy form the Superstructure .

KEY CONCEPT

Marx’s Famous Epigram (from *A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy*, 1859):
“It is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but their social existence that determines their consciousness.”

5.6.2 Three Strands of Marxian Dialectics

Marxian historical materialism analyzes dialectical contradictions operating across three interconnected levels :

1. **Dialectics between Social Classes:** The struggle over economic surplus between opposing classes (masters vs. slaves, feudal lords vs. serfs, bourgeoisie vs. proletariat) .
2. **Dialectics between Forces and Relations of Production:** The contradiction that arises when developing productive technologies (**Forces of Production**) outgrow the existing legal, property, and ownership structures (**Relations of Production**) .
3. **Dialectics between Successive Modes of Production:** The structural transition from one socio-economic epoch to the next (Primitive Communism → Ancient Slave Society → Feudalism → Capitalism → Socialism / Communism) .

COMPARISON

For Hegel, the dialectic explained the development of ideas and philosophies . For Marx, the dialectic explained the real material contradictions within the economic structures of society .

Historical Illustration: The Transition Across Modes of Production

- **Ancient Slave Society (c. 300 AD):** Masters owned the direct producers (slaves) as property . Slaves were denied legal family rights, as maintaining slave families was costly for masters .
- **Internal Contradiction:** Expanding slave production concentrated large numbers of enslaved workers together in urban centres, creating the conditions for collective resistance and revolts that undermined the slave economy .
- **Feudal Mode of Production:** Replaced the slave mode with a new class structure: feudal lords and land-tied serfs . Over time, developing commerce, urban guilds, and merchant capital clashed with feudal land restrictions .
- **Capitalist Mode of Production:** The bourgeoisie overthrew feudal property relations, establishing industrial capitalism based on wage labour .
- **Marx's Break from Hegel:** Capitalism is not the final stage of history . Like all previous modes of production, capitalism contains its own structural contradictions and is destined to be replaced by socialism .

5.6.3 Engels' Three Laws of Dialectics

In works such as *Dialectics of Nature* and *Anti-Dühring*, Friedrich Engels systematized the dialectical method into three general laws that operate in both natural processes and human history :

1. The Law of the Transformation of Quantity into Quality (and Vice Versa)

- Incremental, quantitative changes accumulate gradually until they reach a critical threshold, producing a sudden, qualitative transformation .
- **Natural Examples:** Heating water degree by degree (quantitative) produces no change in state until it reaches 100°C, where it abruptly turns into steam (qualitative) ; a seed accumulates nutrients underground until a green sprout suddenly breaks through the soil .
- **Historical Example:** Gradual, daily increases in the exploitation of the working class build up

until they reach a tipping point, triggering a revolutionary uprising .

- **Indian National Movement:** Decades of organizing, constitutional petitions, and regional agitations (1857–1942) accumulated quantitative political awareness among the masses, culminating in the decisive qualitative shift toward complete independence through mass mobilizations like the Quit India Movement (1942) .

2. *The Law of the Interpenetration (Union and Conflict) of Opposites*

- Contradictory phenomena exist in a necessary unity; each opposite requires the other for its very existence, even while standing in fundamental conflict with it .
- **Scientific Examples:** Action and reaction in Newtonian mechanics; positive and negative electrical charges; differentiation and integration in calculus; nuclear fission and fusion .
- **Class Relations:** The bourgeoisie and the proletariat form a unified economic system; capitalists cannot exist without wage labourers to generate surplus value, and wage labourers depend on capitalists for wages . Yet their objective material interests remain in direct conflict .

3. *The Law of the Negation of the Negation*

- Development moves in a spiral: an initial social form is negated (replaced) by its opposite, which is subsequently negated by a higher form that synthesizes earlier developments on a more advanced level .
- Feudalism was negated by Capitalism; Capitalism will in turn be negated by Socialism (the “negation of the negation”) .
- This process is not a simple return to the past, but an advance to a higher stage (e.g., modern communism restores the collective ownership of primitive communism, but combines it with advanced industrial technology) .

5.6.4 *Basic Assumptions of Historical Materialism*

1. **Society is an Integrated Structural Whole:** No single institution (family, religion, law, or state) can be understood in isolation; all are structurally connected to the underlying mode of production . C. Wright Mills’ “sociological imagination” reflects this principle: personal troubles reflect wider public issues .
2. **Human Nature as “Species Being” (*Gattungswesen*):** Humans are inherently creative, productive beings who realize their potential through meaningful, self-directed labour . Unlike animals, humans transform nature to express their creative capacities (comparable to Hannah Arendt’s concept of *homo faber*) . Examples include artists like M. F. Husain or scientists like Albert Einstein, whose identities are defined by their creative labour . Under capitalism, this creative impulse is distorted into alienated, repetitive wage labour .
3. **History Evolves Through Material Conflict:** Human progress is driven by struggles over the production and distribution of the material means of subsistence .

5.6.5 *From Survival Needs to Social Relations of Production*

Marx constructs the logical development of historical materialism through a clear sequence of material steps :

1. **Primacy of Material Survival:** The first historical act of human beings is the securing of basic physical needs: food, water, clothing, and shelter .
2. **Labour as the Mediating Force:** Nature does not provide these necessities in ready-to-use form; humans must apply conscious physical labour to nature to produce their means of life .
3. **Inevitability of Social Relations of Production:** An isolated individual cannot produce all tools, shelter, and clothing alone . Humans must cooperate, entering into definite, necessary relationships independent of their individual will — the **Relations of Production** .
4. **Creation of New / Higher Needs:** The satisfaction of primary survival needs leads to the development of secondary, higher-order needs (e.g., moving from hunting small game to coordinating hunts for larger animals) .
5. **Evolution of the Means of Production:** To satisfy expanding needs, humans invent new, more advanced tools and technologies (**Means of Production**) .

5.6.6 *Emergence of Social Classes — The Cage Parable*

EXAMPLE

The Parable of the Lion Trap: Consider an early human community seeking to capture dangerous game (such as a lion) :

- One individual conceives the design for a large wooden trap/cage equipped with bait and a release mechanism, and directs the other members of the clan to construct it .
- When the trap succeeds, the status of the designer rises within the community . For subsequent collective tasks (e.g., trapping larger animals), the clan continues to rely on his technical expertise and designs .

KEY CONCEPT

The Origin of Class Stratification: Over time, those who hold ownership or control over the essential **Means of Production** (whether design knowledge, tools, fertile land, or industrial factories) assume a dominant social position .

- **Dominant Class:** Owns and controls the means of production .
- **Subordinate Class:** Owns only its own capacity to work (labour power) and must work under the direction of the property owners .

5.6.7 *Capitalism's Inherent Contradictions*

Marx identified structural contradictions within the capitalist mode of production that lead to periodic crises :

- **The Profit Motive and Mechanization:** In the search for higher profits and market share, industrial capitalists invest heavily in machinery and automated technologies . Machines do not take leave, demand wage increases, or form trade unions, allowing for massive increases in production output (e.g., producing 8,000 pairs of shoes in minutes) .
- **The Resulting Crisis: Overproduction and Under-consumption:** As machines displace human workers, overall industrial output surges . However, displaced and underpaid workers lose their purchasing power . The goods piling up in warehouses cannot be bought by the

working population, generating the twin crisis of **overproduction** and **under-consumption** .

CRITICAL POINT

This crisis illustrates the **Law of the Union and Conflict of Opposites**: the capitalist's drive to maximize output while cutting wage costs undermines the very consumer market needed to realize profits . Historical events like the Great Depression of the 1930s demonstrated this structural vulnerability of unregulated market capitalism .

- **The Mixed Economy Reality:** Contemporary economies are rarely purely capitalist or purely socialist; most modern states operate as mixed economies, where the public sector and regulatory frameworks exist alongside private enterprise to stabilize market crises .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Contemporary Relevance of Marxism: Modern debates over artificial intelligence, algorithmic automation, and workforce displacement represent a contemporary manifestation of this Marxian contradiction: automated systems increase productivity while risking technological unemployment and aggregate demand deficits .

Karl Marx — Historical Materialism, Class Struggle and Alienation

6.1 Historical Materialism and the Mode of Production

6.1.1 *Why Historical Materialism Comes First*

Before the theory itself, two preliminary points were made in class — one on how to take notes, and one on why this particular concept has to be mastered before anything else in Marx .

Note-making — there is no single correct method

- Some students prefer making notes on a computer, because they can edit them later and add material they find relevant while reading newspapers; that is very convenient for them .
- Many others, despite knowing how to type, save, open and close files, prefer writing with a pen in a notebook . It is not that they cannot operate a computer; they simply find writing more suitable .
- Therefore no one method can be recommended — whatever suits you, whatever is convenient to you .
 - Generally it is preferable to make notes on a device so that you can edit or add to them later; but that does not mean you have to . It is completely according to your convenience .

Why this concept is the foundation

- When Karl Marx — or for that matter any scholar in your syllabus — wrote a book, he never wrote it for a competitive examination . Scholars were free to write whatever they wanted, in whatever book .
- After their death, people arranged those books in chronological order, and then boards decided to lift portions of that material for an examination like this one .
- Consequently, elements of historical materialism appear inside the other three concepts as well — in class struggle (third concept), in mode of production (second concept), and in alienation (fourth concept) .
- That is why historical materialism is very important: if you do not understand this, you will not be able to understand the remaining three .

CRITICAL POINT

- Historical materialism is not one topic among four — it is the base on which mode of production, class struggle and alienation all rest . It must be finished first .

- Marx never wrote for an exam; the exam-friendly ordering of his work is a later, posthumous arrangement .

Engels on historical materialism

- Engels once said on historical materialism: just as Darwin developed the laws of organic development of nature, Marx developed the laws of the development of history .
- That is what historical materialism is about — how history developed .
- The phrase “historical materialism” was not coined by Marx himself; whatever he wrote was in German .
- Through this theory Marx presents his own version of how history developed, and this version later came to be regarded as the materialist interpretation of history . Why “materialist” becomes clear only at the end of the theory .

QUICK REVISION

- Engels’ formulation: Darwin → laws of organic development of nature; Marx → laws of development of history .
- “Historical materialism” is not Marx’s own phrase; his writing was in German .
- His account of historical development is the materialist interpretation of history .
- Master this before mode of production, class struggle and alienation — all three carry its elements .

6.1.2 The First Historical Act — Production and Primitive Communism

Marx begins the story at the very beginning of human society: what did the first human being actually do?

1. The first historical act in human society was production .
2. Why production? Because survival is important . In order to survive, man has to produce — food, cloth and shelter .
3. Food, cloth and shelter are not readily available in nature . Man has to transform nature through labour into material goods .
4. He could never do all of this by himself . He automatically had to cooperate with multiple people, and therefore it was inevitable to enter into social relations of production .
5. The primary needs then stand satisfied .

So although nature was transformed into material goods through labour, that labour was not individual labour — it was collective labour, and entering into social relations of production was unavoidable for man .

KEY CONCEPT

- First historical act = production, driven by the need to survive (food, cloth, shelter) .
- Nature does not supply these ready-made; labour transforms nature into material goods .

- Labour is collective, not individual — hence social relations of production are inevitable, not chosen .

The model this produces: primitive communism

- This model, according to Karl Marx, represented primitive communism — a very simple, sweet picture of society .
- Primitive means old, ancient — of that era .
- Communism here means the community gathered, produced and consumed — everything happening in a communal fashion .
 - “Communal” here does not mean religious conflict . It means community: gathered together, produced together, ate together, sat together around the campfire, danced together . Economic needs were fulfilled collectively .
- Up to this stage Marx says there was no inequality .
 - No inequality means no superior or inferior; no superior or inferior means no class; which simply means it was a classless society . There was no rich or poor — everybody was equal .
- The means of production at this stage were primitive tools — stone, bow, arrow .

EXAMPLE

The teacher advised drawing the diagram of this stage according to your own convenience and available space — the diagram is a personal memory aid, not a fixed format .

QUICK REVISION

- Sequence: survival → production → collective labour → social relations of production → primary needs satisfied .
- This stage = primitive communism: communal ownership, communal production and consumption .
- No inequality → no superior/inferior → no class → classless society; no rich, no poor .
- Means of production at this stage: stone, bow, arrow .

6.1.3 Secondary Needs, New Technology and the Birth of Ownership

- Once the primary needs are met, secondary needs develop — needs higher than primary: better food, better clothes, better shelter .
 - A need is a need and cloth is cloth; but “better” clothes means branded clothes, “better” food means branded food, a better house means a house in a branded location . Needs increased .

The lion and the iron cage

- Instead of a deer, they now want to hunt a lion . Hunting a lion is not easy, especially with the primitive tools these people had — stone, bow, arrow .
- A lion is a huge, violent, wild animal; the primitive tools are not sufficient . Something else

has to be developed to satisfy this new secondary need .

- So the means of production had to take an advanced form . The Stone Age is over; now comes the Iron Age — iron tools .
- A few people had the idea that advanced tools were needed . Those people built an iron trap — an iron cage — inserted a bait, the lion got trapped, and they ate the lion .

KEY CONCEPT

- The development of the means of production is nothing but technological advancement .
- Technological advancement then results in a change in the relations of production .

How ownership was born

- In primitive communism the relations of production were symmetrical: no inequality, everybody equally involved in production, no superior, no inferior, no rich, no poor — communal relations .
- With the advance in technology, only a few could develop the higher form of technology needed to satisfy the secondary needs . Those people became the owners .
- The next day, when others asked to borrow the iron cage to go hunting, that person said: “This is mine.” Even though all of them had collectively made it . This is how ownership came into existence .
 - There were no laws then . Today you are the owner of your house and the proof is a paper . In those times there was no paper, no state, no law — ownership was simply asserted: the idea is mine, so I am the owner .
- Relations of production therefore moved from symmetrical to asymmetrical: some people are owners of the means of production; the rest, who are not owners, are dependent on them for the iron cage . Unless you have the iron cage you cannot trap the lion and cannot fulfil your increased desire .

The chain to remember

- Change in means of production → change in relations of production .
- Means of production reflect changes in technology .
- Therefore: change in technology ultimately led to change in the relations of production .

QUICK REVISION

- Primary needs satisfied → secondary needs develop (better food, cloth, shelter) .
- Old tools cannot meet new needs → iron tools, the iron cage → technological advancement .
- Only a few could develop the new technology; they claimed it — this is the origin of ownership .
- Relations of production shift from symmetrical to asymmetrical: owners and dependants .
- Core line: change in technology → change in means of production → change in relations of production .

6.1.4 *The Laws of Dialectics Operating in the Social World*

At this point the teacher stopped the narrative to show that Marx is not telling a story at random — he is demonstrating how the laws of dialectics actually apply in the social world .

First law — quantitative change leading to qualitative change

- Question put to the class: your needs were primary and now they are secondary . Is this quantitative or qualitative change? Answer: it is quantitative .
- Why: till yesterday you were happy with one deer; now you want three deer, four deer . That is quantity increasing .
 - Momos example: you go to the market and pay for one plate of momos; after finishing it you want one more plate — that is quantitative . But when you have had momos every single day and get bored, and switch from momos to pizza — that is qualitative .
 - Similarly: from one deer to many deer is quantitative; from many deer to the lion is qualitative .
- Quantitative changes accumulating and then a sudden qualitative change — this is the first law . Marx is showing us how the laws are applied in the social world .
- Second application: change in technology — from stone to iron — is not quantitative, it is qualitative change .
- So there are two quantitative-to-qualitative transitions to keep in mind: primary to secondary need, and stone to iron technology .

CRITICAL POINT

- Do not treat the needs transition as qualitative at the first step — the accumulation (one deer → many deer) is quantitative; only the jump (deer → lion, momos → pizza) is qualitative .
- The whole point of the exercise: Marx is applying the laws of dialectics to real social development, not merely narrating history .

Second law — union of opposites, and conflict

- The result of quantitative change leading to qualitative change was the change in the relations of production . Relations that were earlier symmetrical are now hierarchical: one superior, one inferior .
- Yet both are important to each other . The owner of the cage needs those people — today the cage may have to be repaired, tomorrow a new cage may have to be made . And those people are dependent on him because he possesses the cage; he rents it out to them .
- This is union — the second law, first part: union of opposites .
- Conflict then arises: these people keep asking for the cage, and one fine day the owner refuses . So union is there and conflict is also there .
- In fact union implies conflict — you are in union precisely because of two opposite needs .
 - Marriage analogy: marriage is not just union, it is conflict as well . Two opposite needs are fulfilled by two opposite people . When two opposites attract, they also repel — because in the first place they were opposites . Action and reaction .

QUICK REVISION

- Primary → secondary needs = quantitative; deer → lion, momos → pizza = qualitative . First law in action .
- Stone → iron technology = qualitative change .
- Owner and dependant need each other → union of opposites (second law, first part) .
- Union implies conflict, because the union rests on two opposite needs — marriage is the analogy given .

6.1.5 From Primitive Communism to Slavery

- With technological change the relations of production change; with the relations of production changing, the mode of production changes .

What “mode of production” means

- Mode of production simply implies how society organises itself and satisfies its needs .
- The mode of production in the first era was communism: the means of production were communally owned and the relations of production were symmetrical . It is the community that shares and owns; no class exists; no one person owns anything; everybody is equal .

The shift to slavery

- So much has changed that the mode of production must also change . From primitive communism we enter a new mode where one group is superior because it owns the means of production and the second group is inferior — asymmetry .
- The new mode of production is slavery .
- Meaning: the people dependent on the iron cage have been enslaved . “I will keep asking them to make cages for me whenever I want, because if they do not listen to me I will not give them my iron cage and they will die hungry.”
- They have become slaves; the owner has become master . No more community, no more classless society — we now have classes: one master, all the others slaves .

COMPARISON

- Primitive communism → communal ownership of MoP, symmetrical ROP, classless .
- Slavery → private ownership of MoP by the master, asymmetrical ROP, two classes: master and slaves .

QUICK REVISION

- Mode of production = the way society organises itself to satisfy its needs .
- Communism as a mode: communal ownership + symmetrical relations + no class .
- Slavery as a mode: master owns the means of production; the dependent group is enslaved .
- Chain: technology → means of production → relations of production → mode of production .

6.1.6 *From Slavery to Feudalism*

- In slavery there are two classes — master and slaves . After some time, new needs develop again . The master has got bored of lion .

The discovery of precious stones and the birth of mining

- The slaves who went into the forest to hunt for the master came across something very shiny — what we today call pearls, diamonds, jewellery .
- The slave did not know what to do with it and took it to the master . The master became very happy — he did not know what it was, but he could figure out that it was very different from anything he had seen in his life .
- Visitors who came to the master admired it . The master then ordered the slaves to fetch more such stones — otherwise no iron cage .
- They had found stones on the top of the soil; they reasoned that deeper in the soil there would be more . So they started mining the soil — and that is how the mining industry came into existence .
 - This is exactly what Marx is talking about: how things we take for granted actually got developed in the first place .

New needs, new technology, new relations

- The master now wants precious stones, spices, and cloth made of silk rather than cloth made of leaf . His desires are changing; new needs are developing .
- With new needs, technology must again be developed — mining the soil by hand might take five years to find anything, so a faster technology is required . New needs → new technology, as simple as that .
 - The new technology consisted of basic tools . Compared with the technology we have attained they will always be called basic, but for that point of time they were quite advanced .
- Most needs are now fulfilled by land: land gives cash crops, precious stones, precious textiles .

EXAMPLE

Indigo: a very precious colour, the royal colour — royal blue . It is called “royal” because the very discovery of that blue happened in the age of masters and slaves, and the word royal is attached to it to this day .

- With the change in technology the relations of production change again . The masters are now not just masters — they have become owners of the land . The land belongs to the master, and the slaves are now serfs .
- So: landlords are those people who at one point of time were the masters; serfs and peasants are those people who at one point of time were slaves . Only the names of the classes have changed — the relation of production is very much asymmetrical still .
- From master–slave we have now entered feudal lord and serf, and with this comes the new mode of production: feudalism .

Mode of production	Who owned what	Classes
Primitive communism	No one person owned anything; the community was the owner	Classless
Ancient / slave society	The master owned all the tools — and, for the first time, owned human beings	Master and slaves
Feudalism	Ownership of land; along with land the lord also held the serfs	Feudal lord and serf

What each mode owned

CRITICAL POINT

- For the first time in human societies, under slavery man became the private property of another man . With the development of slavery, ownership of a human being came into existence .
- Feudalism means ownership of land — and along with the land, the serfs .

The summary lines dictated in class

1. Technological advancement leads to changes in the means of production .
2. Changes in the means of production lead to changes in the relations of production .
3. Changes in both relations of production (ROP) and means of production (MoP) lead to change in the mode of production .

Do not confuse “means” and “mode” of production . Mode of production was introduced here only because the word came up; it is explained fully in the next section .

QUICK REVISION

- New needs of the master (stones, spices, silk) → mining and new tools → land becomes the chief means of production .
- Masters become landlords; slaves become serfs; only the names of the classes change, the asymmetry persists .
- Slavery is the first society in which a human being becomes the private property of another human being .
- Three-line summary: technology → means of production → relations of production → (both together) mode of production .

6.1.7 Forms of Consciousness — How Inequality Gets Justified

The teacher flagged this as the most important thing in the whole topic .

- The question nobody asks: when the master said “this cage belongs to me, you cannot use it without my permission” — how did the slaves simply agree?
 - If a man tells his wife “this is my property, you do not have a single piece of claim in it”, it

is not a beautiful scenario — there is conflict . So how did the master justify his superior status over the slaves?

- Here comes what Hegel called the spirit, the world spirit, consciousness .
- Marx says: ideas were now developed to justify the superiority of one class over another class . Masters started developing ideas to answer “why should I obey you?”
- The masters consulted the priest — or, more simply, consulted all the other masters — and together they developed new ideas: let us justify his enslavement, his subordination, in the name of religion . If he does not obey us, he is committing sin; then he will not go to heaven .
- So: with asymmetrical relations developed new forms of consciousness, to justify class inequality .
 - “To justify class inequality” simply means to justify why I should be the owner and you should listen to me, and why what I say is right and you are wrong . To justify that, you had to back yourself with something that could testify to your statement — and that was religion, and law, and also the concept of family .

KEY CONCEPT

- Hegel: ideas come first . Marx: ideas are the result of material needs — matter is primary .
- Ideas are developed to justify a claim over matter; religion, law and family arise as forms of consciousness that legitimise class inequality .

Illustration 1 — how the Bible was read to justify slavery

- The teacher first laid down the principle: facts do not speak for themselves — you need someone to interpret the facts . The question is how the verses were *interpreted* .
- The passage read out in class was the story of Noah’s sons — Shem, Ham and Japheth . Noah planted a vineyard, became drunk and lay uncovered in his tent . Ham saw his father’s nakedness and told his brothers; Shem and Japheth walked backwards to cover him without looking . On waking, Noah cursed Ham’s son Canaan to be a servant of servants to his brethren, blessed Shem, and said Canaan shall be servant to both Shem and Japheth . Noah lived 350 years after the flood .
- The reading offered in class: the one shown as drunk and uncovered was cast as the slave, and the curse is treated as divine sanction — “God has said it” — so the servitude stands justified .
- The critical questions the teacher then raised against that reading:
 - What was so terrible about seeing Noah drunk?
 - Why curse Canaan rather than Ham?
 - How long was the servitude to last?
 - Surely Ham would have been the same colour as his brothers .
- This is one illustration of how Christian slaveholders used scripture to justify slavery . The source referred to in class for the interested student was a BBC piece titled “Attempts to justify slavery” .

Illustration 2 — the Laws of Manu

- The Manu Smriti extols both caste and class hierarchies, which in turn reinforce each other .
- It prescribes stringent punishments for transgressing the boundaries of birth-based professions, which if allowed will have terrible consequences .
- Chapter 8, shlokas 21–22 (as read in class): when a Shudra interprets the law for a king, his realm sinks like a cow in mud; the entire realm, stricken with famine and pestilence, quickly perishes when it is teeming with Shudras, overrun by infidels and devoid of twice-born people .
- Shloka 410: the king should make Shudras engage in the service of the twice-born .
- Shlokas 413–414: the Shudra was created solely to do slave labour for the Brahmin; even when released by his master, a Shudra is not freed from his slave status, for that is innate in him and nobody can remove it .
- The point being made: how religion — Christianity in one case, Hinduism in the other — and how law justified slavery .

CRITICAL POINT

- Slavery was legal . Today we call it a pathological social fact, but at one point of time it was a normal social fact .
- Things can be legal and unethical at the same time . Laws were developed, religion was developed, things were written down — all to justify one person's status and class position .

QUICK REVISION

- Central question: why did the subordinated accept subordination? Answer: forms of consciousness .
- Hegel = ideas first; Marx = ideas are the result of material needs, matter is primary .
- Religion, law and family develop as justifications of class inequality .
- Two illustrations given: scriptural readings used by Christian slaveholders, and the Manu Smriti on caste-class hierarchy and Shudra servitude .
- Slavery was legal — legality and ethics are two different things .

6.1.8 *The Motor of History and the Superstructure*

- The diagram drawn in class is not just a diagram — it is the motor of history . Looking at societies from the top, Marx has analysed the evolution of societies, the evolution of material conditions leading to new relations of production and a new mode of production .
- At the surface, this is thesis, antithesis, synthesis — a surface-level representation of the larger picture .

How the motor turns

1. With the development of higher needs, new technologies are developed to meet those needs .
2. With new technologies, new relations of production develop .
3. With new relations of production, a new mode of production comes into existence .

4. Every mode of production has some internal economic contradictions — exposed by higher needs or by the non-fulfilment of previous needs . Contradictions in the economy is the third law .
5. Then human history develops towards a new mode of production; a new economic system and new social relations come into existence — ancient to feudal, feudal to capitalism .

An ever-moving motor does not stop . With this, Marx established the law of development of human history .

KEY CONCEPT

Overall conclusion of the theory: history is not the manifestation of spirit . History is the product of humanity and of the material needs of humanity . With ever-increasing needs, forms of consciousness also develop to justify the relations of production built around those needs .

- And therefore Karl Marx says: “History of all society hitherto has been history of class struggle” — between masters and slaves, then lords and serfs, and then capitalism, where we are today .
- Whether we are still in capitalism or have progressed is something to be explored; but assume we are in so-called Marxian capitalism, as Marx described it during the Industrial Revolution . On that assumption there are only two classes: bourgeoisie and proletariat .
 - Proletariats are the working class — the teacher included himself and the students in it . The bourgeoisie are the owners of the coaching institutions and of firms; the people working in them are working-class people, dependent on the owners for survival .

Why the conflict does not become revolution

- Just like any other mode of production, capitalism too will have conflict between these two classes . But what stops a worker from fighting his director?
 - Livelihood compulsion and job security — of course, these things are there .
 - But one more thing: family . Because I belong to a family I cannot take any decision independently . The family will say: he is your director, he has been feeding you, he gave you a job, and this is what you are doing to him? These are the values we gave you, this is why we sent you to school and got you educated . So you go back and apologise — and give a gift at Diwali .
- Family is one system, one idea, which prevents revolution . It is a form of consciousness . You cannot see “family” — you can see your mother, you can see the house you live in, but family itself is consciousness . And this consciousness does not let you think independently .
 - Talk to working professionals who already have enough material needs met: they still work — because of family, because of what a friend of the father would say, because the father is retiring, because people ask “what are you doing these days, still studying?” These are forms of consciousness that never let you think independently .
- Media is also a form of consciousness, which will never let you think of bringing a revolution against your director . After a fight you open a video platform, watch a spiritual talk, listen to music that pleases your ears and pacifies your anger, or watch a movie — and all the anger is over .
 - This is what the critical theorists told us; that is why they are called neo-Marxists . This

is the cultural industry . It works to subdue consciousness, to standardise the thinking process, and to create false desires so as to make you passive robots using false desires and false means . This prevents revolution .

Infrastructure and superstructure

- Economy is the engine . Family, law, religion and nation are forms of consciousness .
- Because these forms of consciousness are situated on top of the economy — which is the engine of society — they constitute the superstructure; the economy is the infrastructure .
- The whole historical-materialism diagram was happening in the realm of the economy; the ideas were cropping up to justify what is there in the economy .
- Therefore the superstructure justifies the inequalities present in the infrastructure .

CRITICAL POINT

Conclusion line dictated for writing: the theory of historical materialism reflects how societies develop class characters — how societies develop social classes — and how the relations of production between these classes are justified by the forms of consciousness, that is, by the superstructure .

Marx's place in the disciplines

- The line quoted in class on descending “from heaven to earth” — that matter is primary and ideas are secondary — was attributed in the lecture to Hegel [as stated in lecture] .
- Criticism of Marx comes later; it is not an easy task to criticise Karl Marx . You may love Marx or hate Marx, but you cannot ignore Marx .
- Today any academician — economist, sociologist, psychologist, political scientist, philosopher — is placed on a left wing / right wing divide, and that division came from Marxism .
- Your position in academics is the product of the opposition or the support that you subscribe to regarding Marxism . Either you are a Marxist or you are not — which means your identity is somehow related to Marx . Even if you are not a Marxist, your identity is still a product of what people have agreed to believe is part of being a Marxist .

QUICK REVISION

- The motor of history: higher needs → new technology → new ROP → new MoP → internal contradictions → next mode .
- Every mode of production carries internal economic contradictions — this is the third law .
- History is not the manifestation of spirit; it is the product of humanity and its material needs .
- “History of all society hitherto has been history of class struggle” .
- Family, media, law, religion and nation = forms of consciousness = superstructure; economy = infrastructure .
- The superstructure justifies the inequalities present in the infrastructure .

6.1.9 *Doubts Taken in Class — Terminology and the Origin of Ownership*

Can we call infrastructure “base”?

- “Base” is simply an English word — of course it is a base, everything stands on it . But “infrastructure” is the word used by Marx .
- If you are using the word superstructure, use infrastructure . Do not use “economic base” — economic base is used in general language; it is of course right, but technically not sound .

Why could some people own the means of production and others could not?

- It is inevitable . Think of it this way: the day after tomorrow all of you will write the same test, but still some of you will be rank one, two, three and others will not .
- People will then ask to see the topper’s copy, or take his or her help: “how did you structure your answer, please help me” . The moment you are taking his help, you have become subject to whatever he or she tells you — and this is how hierarchy develops .
- This hierarchy is then legitimised in the form of the rank list .
- Talent also exists — that is very much true .
 - Linked forward: elite theory by Vilfredo Pareto — some people are born elites . To be taken up separately .

QUICK REVISION

- Use “infrastructure”, not “economic base”, when you are pairing it with “superstructure” .
- Differential ownership is treated as inevitable — hierarchy emerges from differential performance and is then legitimised (the rank list is the classroom analogue) .
- Forward link: Pareto’s elite theory — some people are born elites .

6.1.10 *Mode of Production — Full Definition*

The motor analogy

- Everything is happening in the motor, and the name of the motor is the mode of production . That is the motor of history .
- The motor is rotating; history is evolving with the rotation of the motor; and the rotation of the motor involves conflict between classes . New modes of production develop; new classes come with new needs and new technology .
- The motor is situated in the base . Just as the motor of your car sits in a corner of the engine — you never look at it, perhaps not in ten years — you are concerned only with the steering wheel, brakes, clutches, gears, seat and music player .
- The mode of production, like any engine, consists of many parts . It is run by two wires: means of production (the first wire) and relations of production (the second wire) .

The three definitions to write down

Mode of production

- Mode of production is defined as the way society organises itself to meet the needs of the

population .

- Capitalism is a way society organises itself to meet needs . Socialism is a way society organises itself to meet needs . Feudalism is a way society organises itself to meet needs . Primitive communism was also a way society organised itself to meet needs .
- Question raised in passing: are they really *our* needs, or has each need been manufactured as our need?

Means of production

- Means of production consist of technology, land, capital, machines and human labour (skilled, semi-skilled, unskilled — so-called talented or untalented) . Land is also a form of capital .
- Meaning: the means of production are the tools required to fulfil the needs .
 - Example given: if you want a branded pair of shoes, they will not fall from the sky . To manufacture them you must have skilled labourers, technological expertise, and the machine and assembly line .

Relations of production

- Relations of production are the relationship between the classes involved in the production process .
 - In the mode of production called communism the relations of production were symmetrical — the relation between classes was not unequal, because there was no class at all; it was a classless society .
 - Our needs increased; to gratify them technology increased; means of production reflect the change in technology; then relations of production changed; then classes came . So the relations of production change every time with the evolution of history .
- Next line: the relationships between the classes are the product of their relationship to the means of production . Some classes are owners of the means of production and some are not — and this is how the relationship between the classes is defined .

CRITICAL POINT

This is only the first layer of knowledge — new words, new terms . Do not get worried when you come across new words .

“Forces of production” — a translation artefact

- Marx was one, but Marxists are billions, because there is no one interpretation of Marx . Many people interpreted him according to their ideology, social location and education . When the author dies, interpretation begins .
- Force of production is a result of interpretation of the original writings . Marx in the original writings never described anything like “force of production”; the originals are in German, and translators rendered the same term as “means” in some places and “force” in others .
- Means of production and forces of production are not different . It is only a difference of literature — like the difference in pronunciation between American and British English .
 - Some say force of production = technology + human labour . But human labour is part of

the means of production as well, so there is no difference .

A note on abbreviations

- When you write MOP in capitals, mean Mode of Production; write means of production in small letters — so that later you can tell what you wrote .

QUICK REVISION

- Mode of production = the way society organises itself to meet the needs of the population .
- Means of production = technology, land, capital, machines, human labour — the tools required to fulfil needs .
- Relations of production = relationship between the classes involved in production, defined by their relationship to the means of production .
- The mode of production is the motor of history, run by two wires: means of production and relations of production .
- Forces of production = means of production; the difference is only one of translation and interpretation .

6.1.11 The Cycle of Modes of Production

- It is the same engine completing one cycle after another . Only the cycles are being completed; the engine is the same .
- Cycle 1: the mode of production was primitive communism . One cycle completed — new needs developed, new technology developed, relations of production changed with respect to the change in technology or means of production .
- Then comes the new mode of production: ancient society . Then feudalism . Then capitalism .

DATA & FACTS

- Marx died in the year 1883 .
- At that point there was no socialism of the kind Marx envisaged; he believed the world was living in the era of capitalism .
- Just like every previous mode of production collapsed because of inherent contradictions, capitalism will sow the seeds of its own destruction . Capitalism is destined — doomed — to collapse . And from the ruins, from the ashes of capitalism, will rise socialism, the new mode of production . This part is futuristic .

The crux line to write down

- All the modes of production developed as a result of inherent contradictions in the previous modes of production, which were the result of the contradiction between relations of production and means of production .

Where the line falls between history and prophecy

- Draw a line after capitalism . Till capitalism it was nothing but historical materialism . After capitalism it is prophecy . Marx becomes a prophet, telling the world that socialism is inevitable,

communism is inevitable .

Dialectics inside the cycle

- In all the modes of production we had thesis, antithesis, then synthesis . The synthesis becomes a new thesis; antithesis develops again due to inherent contradictions in ancient society, and the new synthesis is feudalism .
- Therefore feudalism is the negation of negation — the third law .
- Three forms of dialectics are going on simultaneously — it is a very big, very complex engine:
 - Dialectic between modes of production — feudalism could not have developed had there been no dialectic between the two previous modes .
 - Dialectic between relations of production and means of production within a mode of production .
 - Dialectic between the classes — for example between masters and slaves .

Socialism and communism are not the same

- Socialism is not equal to communism — these are two different things, and specifically to Karl Marx they are very different .
- Communism is the last stage — the end of history . And it is not merely communism; it is pure communism . The first was primitive, the last is pure .
 - “History repeats itself, first as tragedy, second as farce” — communism comes again, this time as pure communism .

The Asiatic mode of production

- There is one more mode of production which the teacher instructed students never to write along with the four: the Asiatic mode of production .
- Reasons: there is not enough literature available on it, and Marx himself never wrote extensively on it .
- The problem is with Indians and Asians: when Marx described the Asiatic mode of production he was writing about India and China; Indians got fascinated by his writings on India and started exploring it — but there is nothing more there .
- Marx never visited India and did not have a real idea of India . He had an orientalist, European vision of India: to him India was all about villages — self-sufficient villages .
 - If needs are limited (Gandhi’s “limit your needs”), needs never grow; if needs never grow, technology never grows; if technology never grows, the means of production never change; if means never change, relations of production never change; and classes never emerge . We remained self-sufficient .
 - It was colonialism — the British — that increased our needs, and then we jumped to capitalism .
- This is to be dealt with in Paper 2 . The four that matter: primitive, ancient, feudal, capitalist — plus socialism and then pure communism .

QUICK REVISION

- Same engine, successive cycles: primitive communism → ancient → feudal → capitalist → socialism → pure communism .
- Marx died in 1883, believing the era was capitalism; capitalism is doomed to collapse from its own inherent contradictions .
- Crux line: every mode of production arises from the inherent contradictions of the previous one — contradictions between relations and means of production .
- Till capitalism = historical materialism; after capitalism = prophecy .
- Feudalism is the negation of negation (third law); three dialectics run at once — between modes, between relations and means, and between classes .
- Socialism ≠ communism . Communism is the last stage, pure communism, the end of history .
- Asiatic mode of production: thin literature, Marx never wrote extensively, based on an orientalist view of India — do not list it with the four .

6.1.12 Feudalism in Detail**Definition dictated in class**

- Feudalism is a mode of production characterised by land as the primary means of production, in relation to which we have two social classes: landlords and serfs (S-E-R-F-S) — that is, landlords and peasants .
- Landlords are the owners of the land . Serfs do not own the land; serfs only work on the land .

Estate	Share of population	Control over land
First Estate	Hardly about 2% of the population	About 20% of the land [as stated in lecture]
Second Estate	About 4–5% of the population	Disproportionately large relative to numbers
Third Estate	More than 90% of the population	Largely landless; the little land held was concentrated among the elites of the third estate

The French Revolution estate system as illustration

- The three estates had disproportionate control over land relative to their population . The majority was in the third estate, and those people were largely landless — mostly peasants or landless labourers with no control over land .
- The king was the owner of the land — if not the real owner, at least the ceremonial, symbolic owner .

Why landlords appear

1. The king all by himself cannot manage so much land .
2. So he asks the landlords — the warrior class, the second-estate nobility — to manage the land

on his behalf . These are the lords, earls and dukes who now hold the king's land .

3. These landlords themselves are not going to till the soil and harvest, so they employ serfs and peasants from the third estate to work on the land granted to them by the first estate .
4. And this is how the relations of production evolve: means of production = land; classes = landlords and serfs; landlords exercise full power over serfs .

Who gets the produce

- Serfs are in no way owners of the land — they are only there to produce the crop from the land .
- After production, the maximum share of the crop is usurped / appropriated by the landlords and given to the king, because the land belongs to the king .
 - A certain share is kept in the pocket of the landlord; a certain share is given to the serfs; and the larger share goes to the king .
- The king is impressed by the services of the landlords and is very happy that they manage the land nicely . The landlords are also happy with the king, because the king reposes faith in them .
- What do the landlords give the king in return? Their services — including fighting for the king, which is also one form of service .
- That means the mutual needs of each other are what maintain and establish the relations of production . This is analysing the state system through Marxism .

QUICK REVISION

- Feudalism = mode of production with land as the primary means of production; classes = landlords and serfs/peasants .
- French Revolution estates: ~2% First Estate, ~4–5% Second Estate, >90% Third Estate, land control grossly disproportionate .
- The king is the ceremonial/symbolic owner; he delegates land management to the nobility, who employ serfs .
- Produce: largest share to the king via the landlord, a share retained by the landlord, a share to the serfs .
- Relations of production are held together by mutual need — land for service, service including warfare .

6.1.13 Peasant Struggles Read as Class Struggle

- The teacher noted this applies to any peasant struggle in India — there have been so many peasant movements .
- Examples named: Tebhaga Struggle, Indigo Revolt, Moplah Rebellion, Deccan Revolt — all peasant movements .

Tebhaga Struggle

- Tebhaga means two-thirds .

- In Bengal, the farmers were sowing their crops — whichever crop the landlords told them to produce .
 - Just as in Champaran those people were producing indigo because they were instructed to do so by the British . You were not producing out of your own will; you were producing because someone had told you to produce that thing only .
- This shows that the production process has become external to you — you are not able to produce what you want .
 - The same thing happened in slave society: slaves produced only what the masters told them to; slaves could not produce anything out of their own will; slaves were the private property of the masters .
- In Tebhaga, out of the whole produce, two-thirds was being given to the landlords . The peasants said two-thirds is a lot; we will give you only one-third, because otherwise we would have no means available to satisfy our needs . And since two-thirds is a lot, we will protest against you . That is why it was called the Tebhaga Struggle .

Who led it

- The protest was led by the Kisan Sabha . There is no English version of the name because that is the name; it is a farmers' or peasants' organisation .
- The Kisan Sabha was a branch — a pressure group — of the Communist Party of India . And the communists are those people who always fight for the oppressed .
- The Communist Party of India was leading the Tebhaga struggle against the landlords . This shows nothing but class struggle .

CRITICAL POINT

- You would never normally read Tebhaga as class struggle between peasants and landlords — but that is exactly what it is .
- Peasants refuse the two-thirds share, landlords do not agree, and struggle follows: class struggle between landlords and serfs .

Indigo Revolt, Champaran and the Moplah Rebellion

- The Indigo Revolt and the Champaran Satyagraha are two different events, but the Indigo Revolt too is nothing but class struggle .
- The Moplah Rebellion is also class struggle . The difference is only that of Hindu and Muslim — otherwise these are classes: zamindars and peasants . The main struggle is economic .
 - It was not just Hindu and Muslim — of course that dimension is there . But religion as a superstructural institution legitimises inequality: being Muslim in a so-called Hindu society, the oppression was legitimised . The detailed mechanism is taken up later .

QUICK REVISION

- Tebhaga = two-thirds; peasants demanded that the landlord's share be cut from two-thirds to one-third .

- Led by the Kisan Sabha, a pressure group / branch of the Communist Party of India .
- Production process external to the producer — the same feature seen in slavery and in Champaran indigo .
- Indigo Revolt, Champaran, Deccan Revolt, Moplah Rebellion — all readable as class struggle; in Moplah, religion is the superstructure legitimising an economic conflict .

6.1.14 The Collapse of Feudalism and the Bourgeois Revolution

- For any mode of production to collapse there must be a new form of needs, and corresponding to those new needs there must be new technology or new advancements .

What the new needs were — the trade evidence

- From South Indian history — Pallavas, Cholas, Pandyas — there was a point of time when the Roman Empire was indebted to the Pallavas . Also the Cheras / Chera dynasty, Kerala — “Keralaputra” .
- These were the people known as exporters of black gold — pepper .
 - The same pepper that we do not particularly value today, and some people even avoid, was a luxury item in those times . The only thing that could drain the wealth of Rome was that one black gold — pepper .
- Along with pepper: silk, textile and spices — South Indian history is rich in these details .
- The Roman Empire had fallen victim to the debts it had accumulated because of the large imports of these precious items . So increased needs ultimately led to the fall of the empire .

The process in France

- The needs of the nobility and the kings increased; with the population increasing, their needs also increased .
- A lot of land was given out to serfs; many things were now being produced from land; the number of hours invested in production of land also increased .
- With growing needs, the repercussions had to be faced by the people working on the ground — the serfs — because whatever they produced was going to meet the desires and needs of the nobility, the kings and the upper classes .

The chain of consequences

1. Gradually towns and townships started getting developed .
2. With ever-growing needs, technology changed; with technological change, production increased .
3. With increased production, industries and factories got established .
4. To seek more production of precious items, trade started — and then international trade .
5. When international trade happens, to seek more and more needs, colonialism happened . India was seen as the golden bird, and that wealth flowed towards the kings and queens who had these desires and needs .
6. This whole chain led to the rise of industries .

The birth of the merchant class

- The people in the third estate were the bourgeoisie — the middle class . It was they who became the owners of the factories established to meet ever-increasing needs in the name of mass production .
- And that is how the merchant class came into existence . Otherwise we had only landlords .
- These merchants got into conflict with the landlords and the nobility .
- And that is why Marx would say it is a bourgeois revolution . We read it as the third estate overthrowing the first estate, but it is actually bourgeois replacing monarchs and nobility . What does it show? Class struggle .
 - The teacher clarified that calling the French Revolution a bourgeois revolution is attributable not to Karl Marx per se but to Marxists .
- When the merchants became the owners of factories they became the bourgeoisie — not just a middle class any more; now the whole wealth was in their hands, because maximum production was happening in factories . The more you produce, the more you want, the more you become a millionaire .
- New forms of inequality came into existence: instead of serfs, we now had the working class . Most of those same serfs were now working for the bourgeoisie . The old serfs had become the new working class — the proletariat .

CRITICAL POINT

This is how you read history when you have put on the glasses of Marxism .

Doubts on this section

Does “inherent contradiction” in the French Revolution mean the conflict between nobility and merchants?

- Yes . The first conflict was landlords versus serfs . Then, when needs increased, the merchants became owners of factories, and class struggle happened again — this time between merchants and landlords, two powerful classes struggling with each other . And that is how aristocracy was replaced by industrial capitalist society .

Why did merchants and nobility struggle?

- Struggle for power . Struggle for resources . Because with the ownership of resources you gain power . Who holds the resources — that is what struggle is all about .
 - The same logic was illustrated with contemporary party politics: why are rival political parties in struggle? Power .

QUICK REVISION

- Collapse requires new needs plus new technology .
- Trade evidence: pepper as “black gold”, Roman indebtedness to South Indian dynasties, silk, spices, textiles .
- Chain: growing needs → towns → technology → production → factories → trade → interna-

tional trade → colonialism → rise of industries .

- Third-estate bourgeoisie become factory owners → merchant class → conflict with landlords and nobility .
- French Revolution as bourgeois revolution: bourgeois replacing monarchs and nobility, not simply third estate over first .
- Serfs become the proletariat; aristocracy is replaced by industrial capitalist society .
- Root of the struggle: power and resources .

6.1.15 *Capitalism, Socialism and Communism — Working Meanings*

Capitalism

- Capitalism is an economic system which has organised itself to meet certain needs and to extract profit out of it .
- The main motive is profit . It is profit which is running this motor . Without profit this motor will collapse .
- In capitalism we have industries — the industrial class, the bourgeoisie — and the people working for the industrial class, the proletariat .
 - Although in the real world we do not have these two binary opposites so cleanly; there are many complexities . But let us speak on Marx's behalf .

Socialism

- Socialism is also a mode of production which has organised itself to meet the needs . But in socialism the factories will not be owned by one industrialist class, or two or three private enterprises — the factories will be owned by the state .
- What we today call PSUs — public sector undertakings: ONGC, BHEL, SAIL, GAIL; Navratna and Maharatna categories . These are factories owned by the state — steel factories, lignite factories, and so on .
- There are some of the most important sectors where the state does not even allow private enterprise . That is also changing .
 - As reported in newspapers, most of the things which were considered sacred and not open to private investment are now also being sold to private players . Against this, many people object, saying the ruling party is right-wing capitalist . They believe the state should be the guardian of the weaker sections; and that if state enterprises are sold to private players, and if FDI and FII are allowed in the most important enterprises, then it is a threat to sovereignty or security . [Details deferred in class.]
- So socialism is simply state ownership of resources or of the industries — industries built to produce those resources, or to process them, or to distribute them .

From capitalism to socialism to communism

1. Marx believed capitalism will also fail, and from the ashes of capitalism, socialism will come . (How capitalism will fail is dealt with in the next class.)
2. In capitalism we have workers, and workers are oppressed — so much exploitation . These are

the workers who will head the state in socialism .

3. Socialism will establish the dictatorship of the proletariat . The proletariat, who were the exploited class in capitalism, will now head or take charge of socialism and form a state .
4. When they form the state, all the inequalities of capitalism will wither away — because all resources will be distributed equally among everyone by the state, headed by the working class . No one will be richer, no one poorer .
5. Once resources are equally distributed and produced with the help of cooperatives — regional rural banks, village cooperatives, cooperative societies — then comes communism, because the duty of the state is over . The state shall wither away .
6. Communism will be stateless and classless, and production will be “from each according to his ability, to each according to his needs” . This is the happy picture of communism .

KEY CONCEPT

Conclusion: socialism is an intermediary stage between capitalism and pure communism . Socialism is just a stage, not an end in itself . After socialism will come communism . Communism will be stateless; socialism has a state controlled by the working class carried over from capitalism .

Why this is the materialist interpretation of history

- Everything begins from the economy: needs arising, then classes coming, then conflict happening, then evolution happening . This is materialist .
- Hegel by contrast talks of ideas — monarchy, democracy, world spirit, some world-historical figure who will come and do something . But history does not change like that .
- Karl Marx goes into the details to tell us how these ideas are actually developed by the classes to justify their claim over limited resources, or to justify inequality in that mode of production . That is it .

QUICK REVISION

- Capitalism: economic system organised to meet needs and extract profit; profit is the sole driver of the motor .
- Socialism: state ownership of resources and industries — the PSU model; dictatorship of the proletariat .
- Equal distribution → state's duty over → state withers away → communism: stateless, classless, “from each according to his ability, to each according to his needs” .
- Socialism is an intermediary stage, not an end in itself .
- Materialist interpretation: economy → needs → classes → conflict → evolution; against Hegel's primacy of ideas .

6.1.16 Remaining Doubts from the Class

Relations of production in socialism

- Relations of production in socialism are between the state and the working class — state and workers, with the state headed by workers . State as one class; all the workers as the second .

Meaning of consciousness according to Marx

- It is the being which determines the consciousness — this is what Karl Marx says . From matter come the ideas .
- Therefore some people, reading Marx, would say it is false consciousness, and that true consciousness will come . How we measure something as true or false is a later detail .

Do the three laws function among the working class in socialism?

- The problem is that till the four stages, the motor was going on and history was being interpreted . After the four stages, Marx has become a prophet — and when you speak like a prophet, you do not speak with logic .
- This is also one of the criticisms of Marx: whatever he said till capitalism, he does not repeat in socialism and communism; it becomes an altogether different story .

How does the third law of dialectics define the origin and evolution of patriarchy in the family?

- Engels talks about the origin of the family in private property . Marriage and family will be taught separately, and the origin of patriarchy and family will be discussed there .
- This is historical sociology . When you talk about the origin of patriarchy, the origin of private property, the origin of class inequality — that is historical sociology, and it can be written in the History versus Sociology question .
 - Marxism would not have been possible if there was no Industrial Revolution . Marxism was a response to the Industrial Revolution . Therefore sociology is rootless without history, but history is fruitless without sociology — because reading the Industrial Revolution through the lens of Marx gives a flavour absent from other textbooks .

Commodity fetishism — brief introduction

- When Marx talks about fetishism he is talking about the fetishism of commodities .
 - Example: people with a particular brand of phone — a certain colour, a certain logo . This connects to conspicuous consumption, show-off, symbolic goods . You know that phone is not so different from a competitor's, but we have developed a fetish for that brand's products .
- Fetishism is actually the name of a religion — being in awe or reverence of something that seems very magical to you . So a brand seems magical to you; you will even buy its accessories at a high price, feeling there must be something inside it .
- Commodity fetishism is when you are not able to realise that the goods do not have any value per se — and yet you fall in love with those goods .

Are needs also a form of consciousness?

- No . Needs are needs . Our needs lead to the rise of certain technological advancements which are going to fulfil those needs .
- But today our needs are designed . Our needs are no longer natural — whatever you need today is a socially constructed need .
 - Through television they tell you that if you do not have this, then you are left behind .

Advertising uses nationalism — nation as a form of consciousness — to sell you commodities . You do not need that bike; but once it has been described as the heartbeat of the nation, you must buy it, otherwise you become anti-national . Needs are created .

Terminology caution

- Do not say “pure capitalism” . The term is pure communism .

QUICK REVISION

- Socialism’s ROP: state (headed by workers) and the workers .
- “It is the being which determines the consciousness” — matter first, ideas after; hence false consciousness .
- After capitalism Marx speaks as a prophet, not with logic — this is itself a standard criticism .
- Engels on the origin of the family in private property; the whole enquiry is historical sociology .
- Commodity fetishism: goods have no value per se, yet we revere them as magical — fetishism is originally the name of a religion .
- Needs are not consciousness, but today’s needs are socially constructed and manufactured, often through nationalism in advertising .

6.2 Understanding, Scientific Method and the Foundations of Class

6.2.1 Why the Paper Takes Time — Diagnosis from the First Test

- More than 110 students wrote the first test . Those who did not attempt it were asked to explain why — it is important to know the reason .
- Not attempting is not right, especially when it is your first test . Missing the first test shows a careless attitude — that you do not give importance to these units or to tests .
 - Context noted in class: the test fell on the date on which the prelims examination would have been conducted had it not been delayed .
- Learning alone will not help . Writing is where you implement the policies you have learned . If implementation is not good, something has to be worked out at the implementation stage .

The main problem reported: time constraint

- Most of the time is gone in the thinking process . Of the one and a half hours, at least 20–30 minutes cumulatively went in thinking — not in one go, but in fragments: five minutes of thinking, a few seconds of writing, then back into thinking .
- Spending 20–30 minutes thinking reflects one or two things:
 - Lack of revision . Though revision is not quantifiable — someone’s four revisions may equal someone else’s two .
 - The larger problem: lack of understanding . It is not about revision only; it is about understanding what you are already revising .

- When your understanding is crystal clear, revision will not take a lot of time . You can save a lot of revision time if your understanding is good .

QUICK REVISION

- 110+ students wrote the first test; time constraint was the common problem .
- 20–30 minutes lost to fragmented thinking during the paper .
- Two causes: lack of revision, and — the bigger one — lack of understanding .
- Good understanding shortens revision, not the other way round .

6.2.2 The Concrete Test of Understanding

Let us not talk in vague terms like “good understanding” and “lack of revision” . How do we get to know, concretely, whether we have understood?

- Test 1: Suppose you have read positivism many times . Can you explain it to your father or mother — to someone who does not know positivism?
 - “Teaching” here does not mean taking a one-hour lecture . If you can describe the concept in very simple language in two minutes, you have attained a good level of understanding .
- Test 2 (the harder one): think of the poorest person who could not afford education . Imagine explaining Marxism to a rickshaw puller . If you have that level of understanding, revision is nothing .
- Then you revise only to remember keywords and facts — you do not revise to understand, because understanding is already there .

EXAMPLE

Worked example — explaining positivism simply . Applying the natural-science method to the social world is part of positivism . But what is positivism exactly? Simple version: positivism says the social world has certain laws; society is driven by laws . It is not just the universe out there that is governed by laws — the social world is governed by laws too . The study of the laws of the social world is positivism .

- The next question will be: give me an example — which laws? How are our actions governed by laws? If you get stuck there, that is precisely what you need to work on .

How to run this process on your own

- You do not require other people for this . Revise three or four times, then sit for five minutes and ask: what have I read exactly, and how would I explain this?
- When you explain something to someone, you do not explain features — you explain the essence, the meaning of the term, in simple language .
- Whatever you were struggling with — the thoughts you could not answer — you scribble on paper . That forms your own mind map, and it will help you forever . Refer the mind map first, then handouts or class recordings for revision .

QUICK REVISION

- Test of understanding: explain it in simple language in two minutes to someone with no background — a parent, or a rickshaw puller .
- Explain the essence, not the features .
- Once understanding is secure, revision is only for keywords and facts .
- Scribble what you struggle with — that becomes your own permanent mind map .

6.2.3 Positivism Illustrated — Two Cases of the Nuclear Family**Case 1 — the actor at the centre**

- “I decided to stay in a nuclear family because I believe a nuclear family gives me freedom. In a joint family there is no freedom, because too many people are there who exercise control on you.”
 - And they derive their authority to exercise control because of lineage — because of the way the family has been running for generations: “this is the way we have been conducting ourselves, you cannot do this or that.”
- Who is at the centre of this whole statement — the nuclear family, or me? It is me . I am deciding . And it gives the other person the impression that I can decide my own fate .

Case 2 — the structure at the centre

- “With the development of industrialisation, families got broken down from joint to nuclear.”
- Now the question: is it my choice, or is it structurally that nuclear families are coming into existence? Is my choice itself the result of industrialisation?
- Who is bigger — me exercising my decision, or the structural process of industrialisation which actually gave me the power to choose, because industrialisation requires small families?
- Case 1 is all about me . Case 2 sounds like a law . “With industrialisation, joint families will break down into nuclear” — that is a law . And that is why we always talk about nuclear families in industrial societies .

EXAMPLE

Chemistry analogy: the joint family is one chemical substance . React it with a catalyst named industrialisation . What do you get? Nuclear families + individualism + fragments of the joint family .

Which case explains positivism?

- Case 2 . In the first case I am choosing whom I want to stay with . Case 2 tells me it is not you who is choosing — structures and larger forces are governing your very act of choosing . The idea that you are choosing at all reflects that the larger process has succeeded in creating individualism .

The 1920s counterfactual

- Imagine a hundred years back, in the 1920s . Nobody really had the power to break away

from a joint family, because there was nowhere to go:

- No job opportunities in urban centres of the kind we have today .
- No scope for migration; and even where migration existed, it was not at a mass level .
- The means of transport and communication were not there .
- You would not have received information about employment in an urban centre, because there was no newspaper as such — the printing press existed, but not as a mass phenomenon as it is today .
- So there was no point in breaking away . Today, if I break away from the joint family, it is only because of the power of individualism .
- But why I want to form a nuclear family is a separate matter of enquiry . I have attached certain meanings to the nuclear family — I believe it gives freedom . In that case it is I who am at the centre; another person may attach a different meaning to the nuclear family .

QUICK REVISION

- Case 1 = the individual at the centre; Case 2 = structure at the centre and sounds like a law .
- Case 2 is the positivist statement: larger forces govern even the act of choosing .
- Industrialisation as catalyst → nuclear families + individualism + fragments of the joint family .
- The 1920s had no urban jobs, mass migration, transport or mass press — so no structural possibility of breaking away .
- The meaning an actor attaches to the nuclear family is a separate line of enquiry .

6.2.4 Durkheim — Positivist in One Place, Not in Another

- Durkheim also gave us certain laws . On his study of suicide he states that suicide rates will increase with industrialisation — that is a law-like statement, a clear cause and effect . Reading that theory, Durkheim seems a positivist .
- But when reading his theory of religion, he does not seem a positivist scholar — because in religion he gives no laws . Although he tried to study religion in a scientific fashion, he did not develop laws out of it .
- To study something scientifically and to develop laws are two different things . Many scientists study everything in a scientific fashion; that does not mean they come up with a law every time .
 - When you conducted experiments in the school chemistry or physics lab, were you developing laws? No — you were conducting experiments, and those experiments were conducted in a scientific fashion .
- Law development is the higher stage . Durkheim did conduct a scientific study on the elementary forms of religion — that is not the same as producing a law .

CRITICAL POINT

A scholar is not positivist or non-positivist wholesale — the same scholar can be positivist in one work and not in another . Judge the work, not the name .

QUICK REVISION

- Durkheim on suicide → law-like, positivist . Durkheim on religion → scientific study, but no laws, so not positivist there .
- Studying scientifically ≠ producing laws; law-building is a higher stage .

6.2.5 Why “Elementary Forms”? — The Power of Basic Questions

- The questions that check your basic knowledge are the toughest ones . When the teacher said the paper would be the toughest, what he meant was that it would be very basic .
- Basic question: why did Durkheim study the elementary form of religion and not the modern form?
- Answer: in order to understand something complex, you first have to understand the basic . Religion is a very complex phenomenon; to understand it we must understand the basic .

EXAMPLE

- Why do scientists study the composition of asteroids? Ask the scientist and he will say: because I want to explain the origin of the universe — how the universe came into existence, how the earth got formed . To study that, he studies a small rocky particle .
- That scientist is also studying the elementary form of the existence of the universe . The asteroid, that rocky composition, is that elementary form .

Why this could not have been taught earlier

- If this had been said twenty days back, you would not have understood it . Things grow organically . This is the next layer .
- Knowledge is cumulative — it adds on to something that already exists . You will understand today because a base is already established in your mind .

Why the test mattered

- Before a test, we learn, we understand, we memorise — we do not think . Thinking is what takes 20–30 minutes on the day of the test, because you never thought before .
- When you write a test you start thinking on your own; you get into the roots of the complexities . And when you analyse the roots of those complex things, you realise: this was so easy . It is an organic process .

QUICK REVISION

- Basic questions are the toughest; a “tough” paper here means a basic paper .
- Durkheim studied the elementary form because the basic must be grasped before the complex — the asteroid/origin-of-universe analogy .
- Knowledge is cumulative and organic; the test is what forces the thinking that learning and memorising never do .

6.2.6 Always Write Examples

- Whenever you study anything theoretical, always look out for examples .
- Unless you have examples in your head to justify what you have written in theory, your answer will not reflect the level of understanding expected from a candidate .
- How else would the other person know that you have understanding? Only when you write examples .
- If you do not write examples, you are not showing your true potential to the examiner . Always make it a point to write examples .

QUICK REVISION

- Theory without examples cannot demonstrate understanding to an examiner .
- Collect examples as you study each theoretical point — this is an answer-writing requirement, not a decoration .

6.2.7 Where the Syllabus Sits — BA, BA Honours or MA?

- The sociology syllabus is very much in alignment with the BA — but not exactly the bachelor's level . It is more like an intermediary stage between BA and MA: it is BA honours .
- When you look at the syllabus you will see that the BA syllabus by itself, and the understanding you have at BA, is not sufficient .
- Over the last two years, questions have also been asked from areas taught at the MA level .

CRITICAL POINT

- Advice given: do not chase MA-level books for one stray question . Out of 20 questions, suppose one is from the MA level — if you start hunting for books to answer that one, you may end up missing the larger picture, that is, the 19 questions you are supposed to do .
- You would only get the answer to that one question asked; you would still not be prepared to tackle such questions in future .
- We do not have to ace all the questions — we attempt 19 out of 28, and we have choice in that respect [figures as stated in lecture] .

QUICK REVISION

- Syllabus level = BA honours: between BA and MA .
- Some recent questions come from MA-level areas .
- Do not sacrifice the 19 answerable questions chasing the one that is not .

6.2.8 Which Mode of Production Does India Have?

The question was deliberately asked without having been taught, to force independent thinking: “I do not really want to teach you everything — I want you to be always in a thinking process.”

- So we have all the modes of production — and it is not only us; many countries have all these modes .

Mode of production	Present in India?	Where / how
Primitive communism	Yes	Tribal communities — Gonds and other tribals
Feudal	Yes	UP and Bihar as a highly feudal belt; zamindari, land ownership and landlords; the landlord (“Chaudhari sahab”) mentality and feudal mindset in Haryana, UP and Bihar
Capitalist	Yes	The industrial and market economy
Socialist	Yes	State ownership and the welfare apparatus

- And that is why: no country is purely capitalist, no country is purely socialist . These are only models .
 - A related aside: ethnocentric behaviour — assertions of caste/community pride among groups such as Jats and Gujjars — has become highly visible only over the last ten years or so . Where did it come from? To be explained when ethnicity and ethnocentrism are taught .

Why “model” is the right word — the light analogy

- When you read the composition of light — particles, waves, photons — in reality you would not see only photons, only waves or only particles . You would see a mix .
- The wave paradigm tells us light is waves; the photon paradigm tells us light consists of photons . Each paradigm is a theoretical perspective; when you look through it, that is all you see .
- So in science also we have models . Study the universe through the Einsteinian perspective and you explain it with one model; through the Newtonian perspective, with a different model .
- Science too uses models to explain reality — and social scientists are no exception . They have Einstein, we have Marx; they have Newton, we have Max Weber .
 - And these are people you will meet outside sociology as well — in political science, in English and literature courses, in linguistics, in cultural theory, in anthropology, and in philosophy .

QUICK REVISION

- India contains all modes of production simultaneously — primitive communist, feudal, capitalist and socialist .
- No country is purely capitalist or purely socialist; modes of production are models, not descriptions .

- Light analogy: wave/particle/photon paradigms each show only what they are built to show .
- Science itself works with models; Marx and Weber are sociology's Einstein and Newton .

6.2.9 The Steps of the Scientific Method

Illustrated end-to-end with a single running example: how many environment questions will appear in the prelims?

1. Research question . You cannot follow a method unless you have a question to get an answer to . Here: what percentage of questions in the prelims will be from environment?
 2. Review of literature . To answer it, you first refer to the previous year questions — say five years of them . That is your literature review .
 3. Hypothesis . After reviewing, you form an assumption: approximately 30 questions will be from environment .
 4. Data collection . You appear in the examination and see 35 questions from environment . The data is: 35 questions .
 5. Verification of the hypothesis against that data .
- And then you become a prophet predicting the future — “every year 35 questions will come, mark my words” — and one year only two questions from environment appear .

CRITICAL POINT

The way you ask a question can itself influence the opinion of the people you are asking — linked forward to the Hawthorne effect, to be read separately .

QUICK REVISION

- Five steps: research question → review of literature → hypothesis → data collection → verification .
- The framing of the question can shape the response — Hawthorne effect flagged for later .

6.2.10 What “Scientific” Means — Testability and Falsifiability

Remove the preconceived notion

- Scientific does not mean something is absolutely true . If I say this is a scientific statement or a scientific theory, that does not mean the theory is absolutely correct .
- It only means that the theory or statement is testable . You can test it; it is not a random statement that cannot be tested .
- It is not scientific because it is absolutely true — because even in science there is no absolute truth . We do not have absolute theories or laws to explain the functioning of the universe .
 - Example: “every year 35 questions will come from environment in the examination” is a testable statement — therefore scientific .

Whose concept is this?

- When we say something is scientific or not scientific — is that according to Popper, or is it a universal concept? It is a universal concept .
- What is specific to Karl Popper is the science–pseudoscience demarcation principle . Every natural scientist discusses how we determine the scientificity of something, and when an experiment is to be called scientific .
- Even the greatest scientists in history agree there is no absolute truth in the natural world; they are still exploring, and science is still maturing .
- Science does not claim to have a monopoly of truth . Some individual scientists may sound arrogant, criticising social science, religion or magic — but science as a body of knowledge makes no such claim .
- Why? Because science rests on organised skepticism . Scientists accept criticism precisely because they know the knowledge they possess is not absolute; otherwise there would be no reason to accept criticism . They are humble enough to accept loopholes in their theories, because they are thinking of the contributions their theories make to the larger world rather than of themselves .

Testing a social-science statement

- Take: “Higher unemployment is the source of a higher crime rate.” Does this not sound like a law? It is a cause–effect relation — concomitant variation, exactly like “higher toxic substance in the water leads to a higher toxicity level of the water” .
- How would I test it? Go through the composition of all the criminals and see how many of them were unemployed .
 - If, out of a hundred criminals, 90 or more are unemployed, the theory is valid .
 - But if only 20 or 30 are unemployed and 70% are well employed — driving for ride-hailing services, working with delivery platforms, working in large consulting firms — they are also criminals: white-collar criminals .

KEY CONCEPT

- When we hear the word “crime” we start thinking of poor people stealing money or attacking someone . But the biggest crime is money laundering, and the biggest source of black money and money laundering happens at the level of white-collar people .
- That crime is the consequence of employment, not unemployment — you are employed in sectors where there is either no state regulation, or the regulation lacks stringent provisions .

Generalisation

- Is this not generalisation from 100 samples? Yes — and anything that seems to be a generalisation is fine as long as the generalisation is testable .
- You will find generalisation in natural science also, and they are able to test those generalisations .
 - Einstein believed the great solar eclipse of 1919 would tell him whether light bends . There is no other reason for him to wait for that eclipse — the idea was generalised in his mind . Nothing is wrong in that generalisation per se, as long as it is testable — and it was .

- But not every generalisation is testable . In the social world many things cannot be tested because of the way they are defined: how do you define crime? What is your criterion for categorising someone as employed or unemployed? The social world has this many subjectivities .
- Therefore, for something to be testable it must first be concretely defined .

Induction, deduction and the swans

- In inductive reasoning you go from the few to the general . Going to the general is not wrong; but if the generalisation is not testable, it is not scientific .
- “All swans are white” — you observed a few white swans and developed the generalisation . This is easily testable, and that is why it is scientific . It is wrong — that is a different thing — but it is scientific because it is testable .
- Did we test it initially? No . Deductive reasoning is about testing that which was hypothesised . And this is what Karl Popper’s version of science is all about .

Testing means trying to prove wrong

- Testing does not mean proving it right .
 - If I mark an answer in prelims and then search only for statements that prove my answer right — never considering that I may be wrong — that is not a test, however much it looks like one .
- Testable means falsifiable . Falsifiable means the statement, law or theory should have the capacity to be proven wrong . If you cannot prove something wrong, it is not scientific — anything at all can be proven right in this world; there is not even one thing that cannot be proven right .

Two contrasting examples

QUICK REVISION

- Scientific $\neq$ true . Scientific = testable .
- Testable = falsifiable = has the capacity to be proven wrong (Popper) .
- Popper’s own contribution is specifically the science–pseudoscience demarcation principle; “scientific” itself is a universal concept .
- Science rests on organised skepticism and claims no monopoly of truth .
- Induction goes few $\rightarrow$ general; deduction tests the hypothesis . “All swans are white” is scientific though false .
- Concrete definition is a precondition of testability — hence the difficulty in the social world .

6.2.11 Applying It to a Previous Year Question

The PYQ that was deferred

- There was one previous year question set aside for Unit 4: “Is non-positivist methodology scientific?”
- You cannot attempt that question properly if you do not know what “scientific” means . If you

know non-positivism but assume positivism = science, you will automatically conclude that non-positivism is not science .

- The question is actually very basic — and once your basics are strong, you will attempt it very nicely .

How to think through the unemployment–crime statement in an answer

- Which theoretical strand would say something like this? Obviously you cannot expect a phenomenologist to speak like this — phenomenology would never say there is one cause and effect in the social world . There are multiple causes behind multiple effects, and objectivity is an illusion .
- But here I can see a highly objective statement which looks like a cause–effect proposition, highly scientific, something that can be tested . That is a positivist statement .
- Positivism has two branches — functionalist and Marxist . Do we need to go into those details? You have the option of not going into them . But if you do:
 - You would not be talking about functionalism here [as stated in lecture] .
 - Marxism as a philosophy would not support this statement either . To Karl Marx, the bourgeoisie are the criminals — the owning class, the ruling class is the criminal, not the working class . If you have defined crime as crime committed by working-class people, it is not a Marxist statement; Marxism would never support it .
- At the surface, though — removing all subjectivities, not knowing how crime or unemployment have been defined — the statement reads as one given by a positivist scholar who believes in cause and effect in the social world . That much you can say without going into the nitty-gritties of functionalist versus Marxist .

CRITICAL POINT

A note on how to read the scholars: come out of the idea that you are reading a subject for 500 marks . Marx never wrote for sociology; he did not know that a subject would exist one day and that his philosophy would be labelled positivist .

The answer-writing method for such a question

1. Establish that the statement is testable, therefore scientific — and that “scientific” here means falsifiable, not true .
2. Think about possibilities beyond the given statement . You do not have to quote data or reports .
3. Ask: if it is falsifiable, what could be the possible reasons for the statement being wrong? A leads to B — but perhaps it is C that leads to B, or D, or E . Perhaps it is not higher unemployment but some other factor that is the source of a higher crime rate .

QUICK REVISION

- PYQ: “Is non-positivist methodology scientific?” — unanswerable without a clear meaning of “scientific” .
- A cause–effect, objective proposition = positivist; a phenomenologist would reject it outright .

- Marxism would also reject the unemployment–crime claim, because to Marx the owning class is the criminal class .
- Answer method: establish testability/falsifiability, then generate alternative explanations rather than citing data .

6.2.12 *Class Struggle Begins — What is Class?*

- Mode of production is over; the next concept is class struggle . But before understanding class struggle we should understand class, and what class means in the language of Marx .

The historical sequence recalled

- This evolution of history has its roots in material conditions — and that is clearly the materialist interpretation of history, done in terms of the struggle between classes .

How did classes come into existence?

1. Secondary needs develop after the gratification of the primary needs .
 2. Whoever developed the technology to satisfy those new needs possessed ownership over that means of production .
 3. Once they possessed ownership over the means of production, it changed the relations of production .
 4. Otherwise the relations of production were very much communal — harmonious, peaceful, everybody doing similar work, with similar food, clothing, lifestyle and shelter .
 5. The moment needs developed, class formation started happening . That class was the owner of the technology or means of production through which the new needs could be gratified .
- “Hitherto” means until now — that is, up to capitalism . So: the history of all societies hitherto has been the history of class struggle .

The definition

- Remember this: Marx himself never defined class . But from the writings of Marx we can conclude a definition .

KEY CONCEPT

Class, to Marx, is a group of people having similar relations to the means of production .

A note on the two words

- Bourgeoisie is a noun; bourgeois is the adjectival form . Bourgeoisie simply means the owner of the means of production — the industrialist class, the so-called capitalist class .

Applying the definition

- Bourgeoisie as a class: a group of people having similar relations to the means of production — and the similar relation is that all of them are owners of the means of production .
- Proletariat as a class: a group of people having similar relations to the means of production — the similar relation being that they do not own the means of production, and all of them are

selling their labour to the capitalist class .

EXAMPLE

- Take a person employed to cook noodles at someone's shop, and the teacher employed to teach one subject . One store is run by a man who has employed someone to cook; another, a level up, is run by a man who has employed someone to teach sociology .
- Both employees are the same — similarly placed in the social world . Neither is an owner, and the relation uniting them is that both are there to sell their labour .

QUICK REVISION

- Classless → master/slave → lord/serf → bourgeois/proletariat; the evolution is rooted in material conditions .
- Classes arise when the developers of new technology take ownership of the new means of production .
- “Hitherto” = until now, i.e. up to capitalism .
- Marx never defined class; the working definition: a group of people having similar relations to the means of production .
- Bourgeoisie = all owners; proletariat = all non-owners who sell their labour . Occupation and status are irrelevant to the classification .

6.2.13 *Class as Objective Experience and as Subjective Condition*

- There is a concept of the objective experience and the subjective condition of class . These are two different concepts .
- Class as objective experience simply means that the workers have realised that they are exploited — and they know how they are exploited .
- Class has a subjective condition when workers do not realise that they are exploited — when workers are living in false consciousness .

EXAMPLE

- Suppose today I am very happy: I am making enough money, I am able to do whatever I want, express myself, take time out to meet friends, enjoy every luxury I have seen on television . So I am happy .
- But to Karl Marx I am stupid — a highly idiotic person — because I am not able to realise that I have been exploited, and that I am exploited every day .
- Only Marx knows how exploitation takes place in such a sweet fashion that you would never realise you were exploited .

Note for the reader: in the following class the same pair of terms is presented with the labels attached the other way round — subjective dimension = class in itself, objective dimension = class for itself . Both formulations as delivered are preserved in these notes; see section 6.3.13 .

QUICK REVISION

- Objective experience of class = workers realise they are exploited and know how .
- Subjective condition of class = workers do not realise it; they live in false consciousness .
- Exploitation in capitalism is sweet-tasting — that is precisely why it is not noticed .

6.2.14 Labour Power, Use Value and Exchange Value

- When you get a job, what are you doing exactly? You are selling your labour .
- You get a certain amount per month only because you have also given something . What have you given the company in exchange? Your labour — and, to be more precise, your labour power .
- Labour power = the labour that is sold to the employer for a wage .
- If you are selling your labour power in exchange for a wage, then labour power is also a commodity . You sold your commodity and got Rs. 30,000 for it — exactly as you might have sold a car .

Every commodity has two values**EXAMPLE**

- I make two cups of noodles at home for myself and my brother . I opened the packet, boiled the water for three minutes, stood waiting, added the ingredients — I gave roughly ten minutes of my life . That is labour, and it has use value: I used my labour for my own purpose and for my brother .
- My brother is so impressed that he opens a shop for me . I now make exactly the same noodles, but charge Rs. 30 from every customer . The same labour, the moment it is performed for someone else, is charged for . The commodity now has exchange value .
- Terminology to fix: when you do labour only to fulfil your own needs, at home, without any commercial interest, that is regarded purely as labour . When you exchange the labour for money for commercial gain, that is known as labour power .

QUICK REVISION

- Labour power = labour sold to the employer for a wage; it is itself a commodity .
- Every commodity has use value and exchange value .
- Use value = fulfilment of human need; exchange value = commercial gain .
- Same act, different value: noodles at home vs noodles at the shop .

6.2.15 The Source of Profit**The question Marx set himself**

- What is the source of profit to the capitalist class? A very basic research question in his mind .
- Why did he want the answer? Because Marx read Adam Smith and David Ricardo — the two most popular economists of those times — and also Malthus and Say (Say's law) . These four were dealing with how the economy runs and what the source of profit to the capitalist class is

- Their position: the price of a commodity — how a pencil comes to cost Rs. 10 — is purely based on supply and demand, that is, on market forces .
- Marx's counter-question: if everything is purely decided by market forces, not by any individual, if it is completely in the hands of supply and demand, then how is it that despite this natural force, some people are able to appropriate profit and some are not? How is it that some become rich and some become poor? Is that also justified by the law of supply and demand — or is there something hidden?
- Marx believed something is hidden — there are many issues no other economist had dealt with .

KEY CONCEPT

The source of profit is the exchange value of labour power . Remember this statement forever .

- And the line behind it: labour has the power to create values more than the worth of itself — labour has the potential to create values more than its own worth .

Worked illustration

- You sold your commodity — labour power — to the company for Rs. 30,000 per month . But the company extracted values out of your labour worth Rs. 1 lakh .
- Take the content-developer case: salary Rs. 30,000 . The content was sold on the internet, in bookshops, to distributors and libraries, and garnered value worth Rs. 5 lakh .
 - Profit = Rs. 5,00,000 – Rs. 30,000 = Rs. 4.7 lakh .
 - The source of this profit is obviously the man who was given Rs. 30,000 . If he was not there, you would not have had this much profit .
- Therefore: if you have a lower exchange value, you will have higher returns . If you do not give enough wage or increment to the labourer, you will have a lot of profit in your hand .

What exploitation means

- Exploitation is not beating the workers . Remember this .
- Exploitation is the result of the difference between what the worker has got and what the worker has created . Created: Rs. 5 lakh . Received: Rs. 30,000 . Difference: Rs. 4.7 lakh .
- And this explains the rate of exploitation: the bigger the difference, the higher the rate of exploitation . If the creation were worth Rs. 10 lakh, the difference would be Rs. 9.7 lakh — showing that the person who got Rs. 30,000 is the most exploited man in that company .
- The degree of exploitation is easily calculable: what you are getting versus what you are producing . What you offer the company is far more worthy than the wage you get in return; the two are not in proportion to each other .

CRITICAL POINT

- Marxian economics is generally not taught in universities — specifically in highly right-wing universities — for the reason that it may develop sentiments the state would not want among

students . In some departments it is taught [as stated in lecture] .

- The details of Marxian economics are not important for us . What is important is the question Marx had in his mind .

QUICK REVISION

- Marx's research question: what is the source of profit to the capitalist class?
- Classical economists (Smith, Ricardo, Malthus, Say) answered: supply and demand . Marx asked why, then, some appropriate profit and some do not .
- Answer: the source of profit is the exchange value of labour power .
- Because labour creates value greater than its own worth .
- Exploitation = (value created) – (value received); rate of exploitation rises with that gap .

6.2.16 *The Working Day*

- To go into the micro details, take the wage per hour: Rs. 100 per hour, eight hours a day (9 a.m. to 5 p.m.) = Rs. 800 .
- Marx says: what you wanted to earn for your own needs or your own sustenance was already met in the first four hours .
- What are you doing in the next four hours? You are working for the person who employed you, so that you could give him profit .
- The working day has been divided: some amount of work you do to meet your own needs; some amount of work you do to meet the needs of the employer .
- And the wage you get is only for the work that you did for your own needs . You are not going to get a wage for the work that you did to meet the needs of the employer .

EXAMPLE

- The variant worked in the doubt session: Rs. 2,000 per day, eight hours of work . Marx would say the Rs. 2,000-worth of labour was already produced in the first five hours .
- In the extra three hours the capitalist extracts the revenue or profit . You have done the whole work in the first four or five hours; the extra hours are for the capitalist class, and you get no reward for them — your reward is fixed at Rs. 2,000 .

QUICK REVISION

- Working day = necessary labour time + surplus labour time .
- First four (or five) hours: the worker earns his own subsistence . The remaining hours: the worker produces for the employer, unpaid .
- The wage covers only the first portion .

6.2.17 *Value of Commodity = C + V + S*

- Marx believes the value of a commodity is equal to $C + V + S$.

- S = surplus value. V = variable capital. C = constant capital .
 - There are two types of commodity in play here: labour power is a commodity (what I have offered to the company in exchange for a wage), and a smartphone is a commodity . The worth of the phone and the worth of the labour power are both $C + V + S$.
- What was the source of the Rs. 5 lakh? It was that labourer only, who got Rs. 30,000 . If that labourer was not there, there would not have been Rs. 5 lakh or Rs. 3 lakh of income; there would not have been any surplus .
- Human labour is the source of capital .

The most important line here

KEY CONCEPT

Constant capital does not add any value to the commodity . Rather, it is the variable capital that adds all the value to the commodity . That is: machines do not add any value; labour power is the source of all values .

- Illustration: do you really think that the computer, the word processor, the paint program or the design software gave any value to my content? The content was all mine . I am the source of profit — not the software .
 - That software is available to everyone . How you use it is what makes you different and makes your content different from the rest . So if that content garnered Rs. 5 lakh, it is not because of the word processor or the design software — it is because of the labour, the variable capital, and that alone .

QUICK REVISION

- Value of commodity = $C + V + S$.
- C = constant capital = machines and tools, static, already invested .
- V = variable capital = labour power, the worker .
- S = surplus value = the appropriated difference between value created and wage paid .
- Constant capital adds no value; variable capital adds all the value . Human labour is the source of capital .

6.2.18 Capitalism as an Inverted World

- Exchange value of labour is the source of profit . The exchange value was very low — Rs. 30,000 — while the worth of the services lent to the company was Rs. 1 lakh . So the surplus is Rs. 70,000 .
- Who is going to have that Rs. 70,000 — you, or the person who employed you? The person who employed you keeps it in his pocket . But who created it? You did . You created Rs. 70,000 worth of product and did not get Rs. 70,000; the capitalist got it .
- Is capitalism not an inverted world? This is what Karl Marx says: capitalism is an inverted world . You do the work but do not get the amount; he does not do the work but gets all .

Homo Faber

- In primitive communism, in ancient society and in feudal society, what was recognised was Homo Faber — man as a working, creative, expressive being .
- It is only through work that you express your creativity and your potential . But today, in capitalism, the one who works does not get the money and the one who does not work gets all the money .
- Capitalism runs purely and purely on profit . Nothing else is the driving force of this engine — only profit, only surplus value .

Living labour and dead capital

KEY CONCEPT

Marx's line: living labour creates dead capital, but the dead capital dominates over the living capital .

- What is dead capital? The content . It is dead in the sense that it is not a living species . The source of the content was you, who created it .
- But this dead capital has come to dominate over the living capital, because the living capital was worth only Rs. 30,000 while the dead capital is worth Rs. 5 lakh .
- Your creation has become over and above and external to you in this world . Your creation has assumed an identity above you — you are worth Rs. 30,000, your creation is worth Rs. 5 lakh . This is the inverted world we live in .
 - You already knew these things before joining the course, but somehow you did not think like this and did not go into these details . What seemed to be common sense — how did it become common sense to us? That is what Marx is arguing .

QUICK REVISION

- Surplus is created by the worker and pocketed by the capitalist — capitalism is an inverted world .
- Homo Faber: man as a working, creative, expressive being — recognised in earlier modes, denied in capitalism .
- Capitalism's only driving force is profit / surplus value .
- "Living labour creates dead capital, but dead capital dominates over living capital" .
- The creation assumes a reality above and external to its creator .

6.2.19 Doubts Taken in Class

State the definition of surplus value clearly

- The value your work produces and what you get are two different things — the potential you have versus what you get . The difference between these is the surplus value, appropriated by the capitalist class .

What do the extra working hours have to do with it?

- Assume Rs. 2,000 per day for eight hours — approximately Rs. 50,000–Rs. 60,000 per month allowing for holidays . Rs. 2,000 is fixed income per day, but you must work eight hours .

- Marx says the Rs. 2,000-worth of labour was already produced in the first four or five hours . In the extra three hours the capitalist extracts the revenue or profit from you — that is what gives him the higher return, and you get no reward for it because your reward is fixed .
 - Coming next: the modes of exploitation — the concept of the length of the working day, absolute surplus value and relative surplus value .

Is Durkheim's division of labour a source of solidarity a law?

- No, it is not a law . Durkheim was not a positivist sociologist when he discussed the division of labour . It is just his belief; it is not something that can be empirically tested, and he never said this was a law he was giving .
- One thing he did state law-like: with industrialisation the older form of solidarity weakens . But the claim that organic solidarity will then integrate society is not a law [as stated in lecture] .
- The reason: when Durkheim discusses the division of labour thesis he is always comparing society with an organism, and in an organism everything happens naturally . Since it was a natural, evolving outcome, he did not decide to give a law .

If firms underpay us and the government also takes a portion, are we doubly exploited?

- The student's formulation was that we have become new slaves and the government owns our labour . [Recorded as raised in class; the detailed answer was carried into the state-and-capitalism discussion of the later classes.]

Is the value of wage in surplus value the same as variable capital?

- Variable capital is you . Constant capital is the machines from which the goods come — but who created those machines? Labour power only . You created those machines and you work on them .
- Why are you called “variable”? Because you are adding value to the commodities . The machine per se does not add any value . Which design of shoe is to be made — do machines decide that? You do . You control the machines, you repair them, you make the whole chart, you decide sales and marketing . You are the main source of value to the capitalist, not the machines .

In this era of heavy industrialisation, is it right to assume constant capital is negligible?

- No . Constant capital is constant only — in comparison with variable capital, which is the labour I am selling in exchange for income . Constant capital is something already invested in by the capitalist class .
- The machine, the assembly line, the transformer — these are static . They are not going to give value to the commodity; the value is given by you . In fact those machines were created in the first place by your labour, so you are the ultimate source of profit, not the machines .

One more numerical

- You worked for the company and made a product whose worth in the market is Rs. 2 lakh, but you were given Rs. 40,000 . Surplus value = Rs. 1.6 lakh, appropriated by the company, not by

you .

- Tomorrow you will get a bonus, or after one year you will get a raise, and you will be happy . Why are you happy? This is false consciousness — taken up in the next class .

QUICK REVISION

- Surplus value = value produced – value received; appropriated by the capitalist .
- The extra hours of the fixed working day are the source of the capitalist's return .
- Durkheim on division of labour: not a law — society compared with an organism, so change is natural rather than law-governed .
- You are variable capital because you add value; machines are constant capital and were themselves made by labour .
- Constant capital is never negligible, but it is never value-creating either .
- Being pleased by a bonus while the surplus stays appropriated = false consciousness .

6.3 Surplus Value, the Law of Motion of Capitalism and Class Struggle

6.3.1 *What the Test Was Actually For*

- On the answers glanced through: the attempts were good . It does not matter how many questions you have left — initially it will take time to attempt all the questions .
- Those who left four questions need to work on time management: the paper was not so lengthy that four questions should be left . Leaving four questions means something is wrong with your writing speed, or with your thinking process — you are taking a lot of time to think .
- Those who left one or two questions are completely fine . Over time, those leaving four will come down to one or two, and those leaving one or two will complete the paper . This will happen naturally; we do not need to worry about it .

Why the test used new questions

- Since previous year questions had already been gone through, the main purpose of the test was to check how you manage everything when you confront new questions .
- In the examination you will get new questions only . We should not expect them to repeat questions — at least for the last three years that is not happening in any optional .
- They are not going to see what you have memorised; what you have understood is what they are going to check .

QUICK REVISION

- Leaving four questions = a speed or thinking-process problem; leaving one or two is normal at this stage .
- Tests are set with new questions because the examination itself does not repeat questions .

- Understanding, not memorisation, is what is being examined .

6.3.2 *Everything Has a Price Tag — Use Value Turned into Exchange Value*

The whole of yesterday's micro-detail can be simplified into one movement . Take the same act twice, once at home and once in the market .

- What does it mean? It means only one thing: today everything has got a price tag . Your smile, your car, your house, your sense of humour, even your beauty, even your eyes . Even your body organs have value .

KEY CONCEPT

- Marx: all that is solid melts into air, and all that is holy is profaned . This is what capitalism — modern industrial capitalism — is .
- This is not the world people once had, when they were hunting and gathering and simply consuming their primary needs .
- Capitalism is that spirit which can turn all use values into exchange values — and this is how profit is generated .
- So, in simple words: in capitalism the use values are transformed into exchange values, and this generates profit .
- But that does not fully answer the question . The next question is: how does exchange value generate profit?

QUICK REVISION

- The same activity has use value at home and exchange value in the market .
- Everything today carries a price tag — smile, humour, car, house, beauty, even body organs .
- “All that is solid melts into air, and all that is holy is profaned” .
- Capitalism is the spirit that converts use values into exchange values; that conversion is the generation of profit .

6.3.3 *What Counts as Labour, and What Counts as a Commodity*

- When you made your friends laugh, was that not labour? What is the simple meaning of labour? Work .
- Making other people laugh is also work . Sometimes you do not charge for it — that does not mean you are not doing work; it just is not paid work .
- When the same person made his friends laugh we did not call it work; now he makes an audience laugh and it is regarded as work . This is weird — and that is the point .
- Marx: every commodity has both use value and exchange value .

Commodity does not mean physical object

- My communication skill is also a commodity . This is why companies ask for someone with good communication skill and good experience .

- Experience is also a commodity . Your educational background is also a commodity — only because of these things do you get money .
- You exchange your past experience, your educational background, your communication skill with the other person, and in exchange you get money . You have exchanged a commodity — and the name of that commodity is labour .
- Everything in the world is a commodity .

QUICK REVISION

- Labour simply means work — including unpaid work such as entertaining friends .
- Every commodity has use value and exchange value .
- A commodity need not be a physical object: communication skill, experience and educational background are all commodities .
- What you actually exchange for a wage is the commodity called labour .

6.3.4 How is Exchange Value Determined?

- If I am a comedian who has to make people laugh, how is my exchange value going to be determined? What is the criterion for paying me? A very big question .
 - Imagine a comedian whose video garners one billion views — that means his worth is one billion views . But he is paid only for one million views . This generates profit .
 - Noodles version: your skill can make a plate of noodles worth Rs. 1,000, and the price tag on your noodles is Rs. 900 or Rs. 1,000 . But how much are you getting? Rs. 100 per plate . Where has the Rs. 900 gone?

KEY CONCEPT

Marx's idea is very simple: the worker in the production process creates value more than what is given to him or her . And that created value which is more than what is given to him — is that not surplus? This is surplus value .

QUICK REVISION

- Exchange value is set below the value the worker actually creates .
- The comedian paid for one million of a billion views; the noodle-maker paid Rs. 100 on a Rs. 1,000 plate .
- The gap is surplus value: the worker creates more value than what is returned to him .

6.3.5 Value of Commodity = $C + V + S$ — Worked Through a Smartphone

- Take the commodity as a smartphone . In common sense its value is, say, Rs. 80,000 . How did Rs. 80,000 become the price tag? Because the commodity carries many things which, when added, make the cost Rs. 80,000 .
- Marx says those things are $C + V + S$.

Definitions dictated in class

- Constant capital (C) is the amount of money invested in raw material, machines or tools .
- Variable capital (V) is the amount of money invested in hiring the labourer — the amount of money invested on the wage of the labour, which we call labour power .
 - If my worth is Rs. 10 per month, that means the employer has invested Rs. 10 on me . So variable capital is Rs. 10 . My worth is Rs. 10 . I have sold my labour for Rs. 10 — that is why labour power is variable capital .
- Surplus (S) — and remember, where did this surplus come from? It did not come from thin air . The surplus comes from the labourers only . Is the smartphone itself creating surplus, or is it the labourer who creates it? It is created by V .

The chain of reasoning

1. My worth is Rs. 10 . But what I am creating is worth more than Rs. 10 . And what I am getting is only Rs. 10 .
2. Marx: the worker produces, in the work process, value worth $V + S$.
3. V is variable capital — the labour power, which is paid labour .
4. S is the surplus created by that labour power, worth more than the labour power itself . But S is not given to the worker — therefore S is unpaid labour .

CRITICAL POINT

This is what exploitation is: you do not give him the unpaid labour; you have hidden the unpaid labour from him . You give him only what is required to meet his needs, and put the rest in your pockets .

Rate of exploitation

- Marx: the rate of exploitation = surplus value $\div$ variable capital = S/V .
- The more the S — the more surplus value is generated — the higher the rate of exploitation .
- It also means: rate of exploitation = unpaid labour $\div$ paid labour .

QUICK REVISION

- Value of commodity = $C + V + S$.
- C = money invested in raw material, machines and tools; V = money invested in hiring the labourer (the wage / labour power); S = surplus, created by V alone .
- The worker produces $V + S$ but is paid only V — S is unpaid labour .
- Rate of exploitation = S/V = unpaid labour/paid labour .

6.3.6 Why Capitalism Gets the Detailed Treatment

- Notice that we did not go into such detail for feudalism, for ancient society or for primitive communism . Why? Because Marx himself never went into those details of those modes of production .
- Marx is the scholar of capitalism . He is always remembered as the scholar of capitalism — not

even of communism . Communism is a dream .

- Largely, whatever he has written is about capitalism — thus *Capital*, volumes 1, 2 and 3 (*Das Kapital*) . He is mainly talking about capital .

QUICK REVISION

- Marx did not elaborate the earlier modes; he is the scholar of capitalism .
- Communism in his work is a dream, not an analysis; *Capital*, volumes 1–3 is the body of the analysis .

6.3.7 The Two Modes of Exploitation

- We know the rate of exploitation is S/V . The more you exploit, the more profit you gain; the more surplus value generated, the more profit . Now: how does exploitation actually take place?
- There are two modes of exploitation: absolute surplus value and relative surplus value .

Absolute surplus value

- Take the length of the working day as 0 to 8 hours .
- Within that 0–8 span, the worker was getting only that amount required for him to meet his needs — equivalent to 3 hours (V) . The remaining 3 to 8, that is 5 hours, was surplus generated for the capitalist class .

EXAMPLE

- The services you offer the company are worth Rs. 1 lakh per day . What are you getting per day? Rs. 2,000 — the bare minimum that should be given to you to meet your everyday needs . The remaining Rs. 98,000 is retained .
- And that Rs. 2,000 is made in about three hours . What are you doing for the remaining five hours? You are working for the capitalist class, not for yourself .
- If I am the industrialist and want to extract maximum profit, the first option is to increase the length of the working day . In 8 hours the workers produced Rs. 1 crore; so double the hours to 16 and they can produce Rs. 2 crore . Make it 10 hours .

Why this route is blocked

- This is not an easy job — especially today, when you have labour laws, the Factory Act, a welfare state, and communist parties across states who will protest that making workers work 12 or 14 hours is inhuman and against human rights .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- During the lockdown, labour laws were suspended . Suspension of labour laws means the capitalist class was free to make workers work extended hours, and workers could not form unions or protest — they had to work silently .
- Minimum wage was also withdrawn; maternity benefit was also withdrawn . This happened

in Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh, and a case also went to the Supreme Court .

- That was a mode of exploitation: minimum wage not guaranteed, and increased working hours definitely there .

The second route to absolute surplus value

- Surveillance — tight monitoring of the workers . If they want a half-hour break, it should be strictly half an hour; managers are kept for exactly this, because every single minute counts .
- This is why companies are very strict and now have biometric mechanisms: come on time, leave on time and not before — because it is important for them to generate surplus value .
- Something we do not realise: we feel we are working for ourselves . Marx says no — you are working for yourself only about 20%; for the remaining 80% you are working for the company .

The lines to write

- Absolute surplus value is generated by increasing the length of the working day, and by tight monitoring or surveillance of the workers .
- However, the length of the working day cannot be increased beyond a point, due to labour laws and human rights .

Relative surplus value

- Since the first option is blocked, the last option left is relative surplus value — the second way to exploit .
- Recall the formula S/V . If you want the rate of exploitation in your favour, either increase S or decrease V . Extending the working day is what increases S directly; that cannot be done . But decreasing V can be done .
- So: 0 to 8 cannot be extended . Till 3 hours it was V , and the remaining 5 was surplus . Reduce the 3 to 2 — and the surplus rises from 5 to 6 . That is relative surplus value .

How relative surplus value is achieved in reality

- The task for the capitalist is to increase the productivity of labour . What he produced in 3 hours, if he can now produce in 2 hours, productivity has increased .
- And it does not stop: what you did in 2 hours you now do in 1; then in half an hour; then 15 minutes, 10, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1 — and then you are unemployed .
- The increase in productivity is supplemented with the introduction of machines . Most workers are now gradually replaced by machines, precisely because the length of the working day cannot be increased .
 - You will abuse the capitalist class — they make us work all day, they do not even leave us alone at home . But machines cannot abuse the capitalist class .
- Line to write: relative surplus value is achieved by increasing the productivity of the labour and the introduction of machines .

What machines then do

- Machines are highly productive; they will produce 24×7 without any complaint .
 - And you have now been appointed manager of the company . You are happy about the promotion — but what does it mean? You now manage: that the machines are working properly, that staff comes on time, the repairs of the machines, the installation costs . You are doing monitoring now .
- The fact is: machines have been introduced at the cost of workers .
- Although machines increase the amount of goods produced, since workers have been eliminated those goods will not be purchased . This leads to overproduction and under-consumption .
 - In economy there are cycles of boom and bust — sometimes overproduction and under-consumption, sometimes underproduction and over-consumption . Marx is explaining the reason behind that cycle — what is happening in reality at the ground level .
- However, this will sow the seeds of the destruction of capitalism .

DATA & FACTS

- From about 1850 to 2020 — more than 150 years — what we have seen is nothing but more and more mechanisation and rationalisation at workplaces .
- Old workers and unskilled workers are getting more and more unemployed .
- Marx's thesis: the increase in unemployment is inevitable — it cannot be avoided .
- Surplus value is generated at the cost of the employment of millions: capital is accumulated and appropriated by a few people, and the maximum number are unemployed .

QUICK REVISION

- Two modes of exploitation: absolute surplus value and relative surplus value .
- Absolute = lengthening the working day + surveillance; blocked by labour laws and human rights (except when those laws are suspended, as in the lockdown) .
- Relative = shrinking necessary labour time by raising productivity and introducing machines .
- S/V : absolute raises S directly; relative lowers V .
- Machines replace workers $\rightarrow$ overproduction and under-consumption $\rightarrow$ boom and bust; rising unemployment is inevitable .

6.3.8 The Industrial Reserve Army

- When machines are introduced and many people are replaced by them, the pool of these unemployed people is called the industrial reserve army (IRA) .
- Definition to write: the industrial reserve army consists of a pool of both the unemployed who want to work, and the underemployed .
 - If you are underemployed, you are a member of the reserve army . If you are unemployed but want to work, you are a member of the reserve army .
 - What is underemployment? Suppose you have a PhD and you are working in a menial job — wiping floors in some office . That is underemployment . And for some positions people

are over-employed .

What the pool does to bargaining power

- The capitalist class now has many people who can work at whatever price the capitalist decides — because they are unemployed . Readily available for exploitation .
- If you are the owner of a factory and a worker asks for a high wage, you can simply say: we have many people who will work for a hundred rupees; why should we give you more? So when there are many unemployed people, you lose bargaining power .
- The capitalist class is free to recruit any person from that pool — and this pool is the creation of the capitalist class itself .

EXAMPLE

- When the lockdown was imposed, workers said in interviews that they could do whatever it took to sustain their lives today, because they had nothing in their hands .
- This is what the reverse-migrant workers were saying while going back to their homes . They had become extremely vulnerable — and that is the extent of vulnerability those people had fallen victim to .
- These people are, in the language of Marx, the industrial reserve army .

QUICK REVISION

- Industrial reserve army = pool of the unemployed who want work + the underemployed .
- Underemployment: qualification far above the work performed .
- The pool destroys the bargaining power of those in work, and it is created by the capitalist class itself .

6.3.9 Dead Labour Dominates Living Labour

- As the cycle goes on — necessary labour time falling from 2 to 1.8 to 1.6 to 1.4 to 1 to 0.5 — you will lose your labour power . And when you go looking for a job, the capitalist can pull someone cheaper than you from the large pool of the underemployed . This is how capitalism is running .

The conclusion

- The worker produces values worth more than its own value at the workplace . The value of the commodity generated by you is worth more than your own self .
- And what you are producing is dead labour — it is simply an expression of your labour, so it is dead .
- Dead labour is worth more than living labour . Dead labour dominates over living labour . Your worth is Rs. 30,000 per month; what you are producing is worth Rs. 1 lakh per day .

EXAMPLE

- You are a painter . A company has hired you and gives you Rs. 30,000 per month for making

paintings, and those paintings are sold for Rs. 11 crore .

- Your work is bigger than you . And this will happen only in capitalism .
- Since the commodity is worth more than the labour power, the dead capital dominates over the living capital, and — the most important line — the commodity assumes a reality external to the creator .

QUICK REVISION

- The worker produces more value than he himself is worth .
- What is produced is dead labour; dead labour dominates over living labour .
- The commodity assumes a reality external to its creator — this happens only in capitalism .

6.3.10 *Commodity Fetishism*

- When you look at commodities like a premium coffee chain's coffee or a flagship phone, what is your first reaction?
- The fact is that actors fail to realise that the worth of the commodity — Rs. 400 per glass of coffee, Rs. 80,000 for the phone — is actually the result of labour .

The Feuerbach parallel

- This is the same thing Feuerbach had told people: we have created God, but we have elevated God to such a level that the creation has become external to the creator — and now we assume he is almighty, he is everything .
- And the same status we have now started granting to these objects . We fail to realise that these objects are the creation of their creators, and the objects assume a reality of their own .
- This is what is called the fetish of commodity . Line to write: this leads to fetishism of commodities .

What “fetishism” means

- Deep desire, revering, craving, lust — “I have a fetish for this, I have a fetish for that” . It is almost equivalent to lust .
- And fetishism is, by the way, the name of a religion . It is about craving for something mystical and magical; those objects seem to create an aura, and you start believing they have talismanic features — like pearls, or a highly precious stone that gives the impression that there is something magical inside it .
- Fetishism means to worship objects which seem highly magical to you . And the same worship we are doing of commodities .

The extension by the neo-Marxists

- We do this with actors and singers too . Adorno and Horkheimer call this the cultural industry; that is why they are neo-Marxists, and they were very much influenced by the writings of Marx .
- Reading Marx on commodity fetishism, they argued that we are not able to differentiate

between the singers and performers to whom we have given so much value — we start believing they have magical value, and they become superhero-like .

- They assume a creation just as God was to those people, and as the commodity is to the working class . The same thing happens when people see cultural personalities .

The line to write and the underlying argument

KEY CONCEPT

Commodity fetishism is the result of actors failing to realise that the commodity is the creation of labour — the creation of labour value only .

- Basically Marx is saying: the worth of the phone should be the worth of the amount given to the people who manufactured it . If the worth of the person who made it is Rs. 20,000, then the amount of the phone should also be Rs. 20,000 . What about the extra Rs. 60,000?
- Why do we give so much status to it? Because it differentiates people — it helps people differentiate themselves from the rest . It becomes a status symbol, because investing Rs. 1 lakh or Rs. 2 lakh in a phone is a status .
- But why did it assume that status? Because it cost Rs. 1 or Rs. 2 lakh — while the real cost is Rs. 20,000 . The moment you break into this illusion, this smoke screen, you will not have a fetish for this object .

QUICK REVISION

- Commodity fetishism = failing to see that the commodity is the creation of labour .
- The Feuerbach parallel: we create God, elevate the creation above the creator, then worship it .
- Fetishism is originally the name of a religion — worship of objects that appear magical or talismanic .
- Adorno and Horkheimer extend it to the cultural industry and to cultural personalities .
- The status symbol rests on the price, and the price rests on appropriated surplus — break the illusion and the fetish dissolves .

6.3.11 The Law of Motion of Capitalism

- Kepler gave the law of planetary motion; Marx has given the law of motion of capitalism . A very important law .
 - An aside noted in class: Durkheim and Marx are very much alike here — both are macro scholars, both give importance to structures rather than to individuals, and both are saying that something becomes external to the individual . And when anything is external to you, it always assumes a coercive power over you .

Capitalism rewards efficiency — and you cannot beat a machine

- Capitalism rewards efficiency: the more efficient you are, the more you are rewarded . But you cannot be more efficient than a machine — so the capitalist will always prefer machines over you .
- “Machine” here does not literally mean a machine . It means anything that is beyond human

labour — a supercomputer, artificial intelligence . You cannot be more efficient than these .

- After a point of time there will come a time when machines will start thinking like human beings . Today machines do not think like humans, and that is the only thing which differentiates a machine from us .
 - When machines start thinking like humans, that is singularity . What will happen to humans then? What will be the means of subsistence? Will there still be an economy where you sell your labour and get paid every month? What kind of mode of production will there be? Very futuristic — but some people say we will have singularity by 2050 .

Why capitalism digs its own grave

- Capitalists are their own grave diggers . Workers do not have to do anything — structurally it is happening .
1. To extract maximum profit from workers, the working day cannot be lengthened, because those laws exist .
 2. So either the capitalist cuts the wages of labour, or he replaces the labourers with machines .
 3. In both cases you have developed the means of production in order to replace the workers .
 4. The moment the means of production get developed, the surplus value decreases . Why? Because the source of surplus value is labour . Machines are not the source of surplus value .
 5. Imagine you have many machines and become highly efficient with a great volume of goods . But who will purchase these goods? The people who could have bought them have been replaced by machines and have no purchasing power .
 6. Unless people purchase the goods, you cannot make profit . If you cannot make profit, the surplus value is decreasing .

The lines to write

- The law of motion reveals the inherent contradictions within capitalism .
- With the development of means of production, the rate of surplus value will decrease — because the source of surplus value is V , not C . S was the result of V ; S was not the result of C .
- The law of motion describes the mechanism of the inherent contradiction .

QUICK REVISION

- Kepler: law of planetary motion . Marx: law of motion of capitalism .
- Capitalism rewards efficiency, and machines — including supercomputers and AI — are always more efficient; hence singularity as the extreme case .
- Replacing workers destroys purchasing power, hence profit, hence surplus value .
- The law of motion reveals — and describes the mechanism of — the inherent contradictions within capitalism .
- Marx and Durkheim converge: both macro, both structural, both on externality becoming coercive .

6.3.12 The Three Laws Within the Law of Motion

First — the law of capital accumulation

1. Each capitalist tries to expand by increasing output (surplus value) and reducing costs .
2. They might hire more workers to increase the output .
3. But the wages of these hired workers will eat up the company's profits .
4. Therefore, in order to keep the wages low, the capitalist introduces labour-saving machinery .
5. But this will create unemployment and a reserve army of labour . Trapped from both sides .
6. And these unemployed people will not have purchasing power to buy the goods produced from the machines .
7. This will result in overproduction and under-consumption — which for the capitalist is complete loss .
8. Therefore, in the long run, the rate of surplus value will fall, and cyclical recession or depression will creep in .

Second — the law of concentration of capital

- This is the direct outcome of the first law .
- What happens generally when companies are not making profits? They are eaten up by a bigger conglomerate or a bigger company — and here come mergers and acquisitions (M&A) .
 - Bigger companies start merging with the companies making losses . What happens with public sector banks when they make losses? The bigger bank keeps them with itself . When small finance banks are in losses, the bigger banks buy them . Divestment is the corresponding term in public sector undertakings .
- Line to write: the falling rate of profit will force concentration of capital, as some capitalists will try to buy out or merge with small businesses .
- This also shows that smaller companies will go out of business .

Downward mobility and proletarianisation

- When smaller companies go out of business, the people who worked in them also go out of jobs — not all of them will be integrated into the big companies, which have their own demands and expectations of workers .
- These unemployed people will witness downward mobility in their life . They are sinking in — they are going to join the ranks of the proletariat .
 - Some had achieved upward mobility — managers, who are not just proletariat . Some had opened their own shops: petty bourgeois — the small shopkeepers, the small dairy owners .
 - When the economy witnesses depression or recession, these small shops are either closed down or eaten up by the big corporates . This is what happened during the lockdown also — many shops closed down, and in the language of Marx all those people have sunk in, joining the ranks of the proletariat . Those once making lakhs are now making thousands, earning their subsistence, trying to recover from the slowdown . There are many millions of people like this in India right now .

KEY CONCEPT

Raymond Aron (R-A-Y-M-O-N-D A-R-O-N) calls this process proletarianisation .

Third — the law of increasing misery

1. One company aims to achieve higher efficiency and introduces machines; workers go out of jobs .
2. With increased machines, surplus value inevitably decreases .
3. Then under-consumption and overproduction happen; eventually recession and depression come .
4. This company is eaten up by a bigger company .
5. All those who became unemployed or underemployed join the ranks of the proletariat — the reserve army . That is proletarianisation .
6. The more people join the reserve army, the clearer the division of society into two — polarisation .
7. Society will increasingly become polarised between a shrinking capitalist class and a massive proletariat that suffers worsening misery .
8. Finally a point will come when this cannot continue, and revolution shall occur .

CRITICAL POINT

- In all three laws you will see the elements of the laws of dialectics .
- In the third law — increasing misery — the element of the first law is clear: increasing misery accumulates quantitatively until a point comes at which revolution occurs . Exactly like water being heated and heated until it turns to gas .

QUICK REVISION

- Law of capital accumulation: expand output, cut costs → hire → wages eat profit → labour-saving machinery → unemployment + reserve army → no purchasing power → overproduction and under-consumption → falling rate of surplus value → cyclical recession/depression .
- Law of concentration of capital: falling profit forces buy-outs and mergers; small firms die; their workers and the petty bourgeois sink into the proletariat — Raymond Aron's proletarianisation .
- Law of increasing misery: polarisation between a shrinking capitalist class and a massive, worsening proletariat, until revolution occurs .
- The first law of dialectics — quantity into quality — is visible in the third law .

6.3.13 Class Struggle — Class in Itself and Class for Itself

- Class struggle is the struggle between two classes: the bourgeoisie and the proletariat .
- Marx says class has two dimensions: objective and subjective .
 - Subjective is class in itself . The objective dimension of class is class for itself . [Note: in

the previous class the same pair was presented with the labels the other way round — see section 2.13 . Both formulations are recorded as delivered.]

The subjective dimension — class in itself

- Marx says a class consists of people having similar relation to the means of production . That is the subjective dimension of class .
- All of you are proletariat . We do not own the means of production . We only have our labour to sell to the corporate people .
 - It does not matter whether you are a worker in a large software firm or a worker at a street food stall in a busy market — all of you are similar; you are a worker, proletariat, at the end of the day .

The objective dimension — class for itself

- The objective dimension of class is when this class in itself realises that whether we are in the software firm or at the street stall, both of us are exploited — and our common enemy is the owning class .
 - When these people stop posting pictures showing off that they work at a prestigious firm, and realise that they and the street-stall worker are the same, with no difference between them — then they become class for itself .

KEY CONCEPT

Class for itself = a class which is aware or conscious of the exploitation; being conscious of it they share solidarity; out of this solidarity they have also identified their common enemy; and therefore they bring revolution against the common enemy .

- Till now we do not have class for itself . We have only class in itself . We have groups working in companies; we do not have groups across companies identifying all these owners as their common enemy . We have only dispersed people working in different companies .
- When we have the conscious set of people who recognise that whether they work in this company or that, all of them are exploited, and that their common enemy is one — the ruling class, whatever the individual owners' names may be — then class becomes class for itself .
- And this solidarity is the result of exploitation . This solidarity is not the result of interdependence — that is the difference from Durkheim . There is a difference even in solidarity .

QUICK REVISION

- Class struggle = bourgeoisie vs proletariat .
- Class in itself = people sharing a similar relation to the means of production, without awareness of it .
- Class for itself = conscious of exploitation + solidarity + common enemy identified + revolution against that enemy .
- We have only class in itself today — dispersed, company-bound, not cross-company .

- Marxian solidarity comes from shared exploitation, not from Durkheimian interdependence .

6.3.14 *False Consciousness and the Chains That Divide Workers*

- The revolutionary class is class for itself, because they have identified the common enemy and are aware they are exploited . They do not become happy on being promoted .
 - You will see people updating a status: “I have just got a promotion — from junior sales manager to executive sales manager.” In the language of Marx, that person is the victim of false consciousness .
- Unless that person attains true consciousness, he will never be a member of the revolutionary class .
- Line to write: Marx believed the members of class in itself are the victims of false consciousness .
- Meaning of false consciousness: false consciousness develops when the degree of exploitation is not realised by the worker .
 - And even if he realises the exploitation — if your friend in a big firm says “this is everywhere, you cannot escape exploitation” — then to Marx that person is still a member of class in itself, because he is speaking in a helpless fashion .
 - The teacher added the real-world qualification the students themselves would raise: these are bookish things, and in reality we have families, people we look up to, and our own next generation to provide for .

Why it has become so difficult — the chains

- In the *Communist Manifesto* Marx writes: “Workers of the world, unite. You have nothing to lose but chains.”
- Which chains? Rousseau, the Enlightenment scholar, once said: men are born free, but they are constrained by chains . Marx picked up that chain .

Chain 1 — the nation

- Nation is one chain . Chinese workers are not going to unite with Indian workers, because to them we are Indians and to us they are Chinese .
- Simply, nationalism will never let class consciousness develop — and that is why Marx will never like the nation . And remember, nation is in the superstructure; being part of the superstructure it will never let class consciousness get developed .

Chains 2 to 5 — race, caste, gender, sexuality

- Workers are also divided by race: Black worker, white worker .
- By caste: Dalit worker, upper-caste worker .
- By gender: male worker, female worker . And by sexuality .
- Gender, race, sexuality, nation — all these are superstructures which will never let the workers unite . These are the ideologies which are ruling over you and will never let class consciousness develop .

- Marx says that with these superstructural forms of consciousness, the capitalist class has always justified inequality and exploitation . These things have actually helped the capitalist class exploit the people — the capitalist class knows that hostile nations will never unite, so let us exploit .

QUICK REVISION

- False consciousness = the degree of exploitation is not realised; helpless acceptance of exploitation is also class in itself .
- Celebrating a promotion is, in Marx's language, false consciousness .
- “Workers of the world, unite. You have nothing to lose but chains” — Rousseau supplies the image of the chain .
- The chains: nation, race, caste, gender, sexuality — all superstructural, all preventing class consciousness .
- These forms of consciousness are what the capitalist class uses to justify inequality and exploitation .

6.3.15 *The Three Prerequisites — Homogenisation, Pauperisation, Depression*

- For a class in itself to become a class for itself, there are certain prerequisites — certain conditions which have to be met:
 1. Homogenisation
 2. Pauperisation — from “pauper”, meaning a poor person . (Not Karl Popper.)
 3. Depression

Homogenisation

- “Homo” means same; “-isation” means the process of creating a homogeneous reality . You, me, everyone — irrespective of our skills and education — will have to become similar, and we will become similar at a certain point of time .
- When technologies and machines are introduced in the name of efficiency, all of us will join one rank . You will be thrown out of your company and I will be thrown out of mine; we become a pool of homogeneous people who have been replaced by machines, and whose differences have been obliterated by the introduction of machines .
- It does not matter whether you are high-skilled, low-skilled, semi-skilled or unskilled . The highly skilled person will also be replaced by another machine which is also highly skilled .
 - At one point of time it was the low-skilled worker on low wages that capitalism required, and that is how capitalism actually came into existence . Today, with the ever-increasing urge for profit, they have hired many high-skilled workers — but those high-skilled workers do not feel secure in their jobs . “There is no job security; next day we may be fired.” And this is why people prepare for the civil services .
- So homogenisation means the obliteration of differences between high-skilled, low-skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled — all these differences will end with the introduction of labour-saving machines .

- And then solidarity will be achieved between the high-skilled, low-skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled . A process is going on — a bond is being made from class in itself towards class for itself .

Pauperisation

- Pauperisation means the process of increasing poverty .
- Obviously, when all these people are homogenised by the introduction of labour-saving machines, all these victims will become poor . Purchasing power will fall down . If they do not have purchasing power, how will they consume? That means they have become poor — and this is the process of becoming poor . It is a process .

Depression

- Depression here refers to the pressing down of the intermediate strata . The managers, executives and senior executives — that upper stratum gets depressed, pushed downward, and presses into the proletariat .
- When they join the ranks of the proletariat they realise that at the end of the day all of them are exploited only — none of them are getting what they are producing . This is what Marx says we have to realise .

COMPARISON

- Recession vs depression: an economy is called to be in recession when it goes through the cycle of lower consumption for at least two consecutive turns .
- When the cycle continues for about four, it is called depression . Depression is the extended version of recession, where finally consumption is not happening at all . First recession comes, then depression .
- When these three conditions are met, class in itself will become class for itself .

QUICK REVISION

- Three prerequisites: homogenisation, pauperisation, depression .
- Homogenisation = obliteration of skill differences by labour-saving machines, producing solidarity .
- Pauperisation = the process of increasing poverty; purchasing power collapses .
- Depression = the intermediate strata (managers, executives) pressed downward into the proletariat .
- Recession = two consecutive cycles of falling consumption; depression = the extended version, roughly four .

6.3.16 Why the Revolution Has Not Happened

- The biggest question: why has class in itself not yet become class for itself? Why has the revolution not yet occurred?

KEY CONCEPT

Line to write: the only reason why class in itself has not yet become class for itself is the prevalence of false consciousness perpetuated by the superstructure .

- Illustration from the lockdown: on social media people started writing that Chinese goods should be dumped and nobody would buy them . This is nothing but false consciousness — in the name of the nation you got divided .
- What is happening is that the bourgeoisie and proletariat of one country are revolting against the bourgeoisie and proletariat of another . What should be happening is that the proletariats of both countries should be criticising the bourgeoisie of both countries . But the opposite is happening — because the nation has divided us .
- In the name of the nation, the difference between bourgeoisie and proletariat disappears entirely . Nation is one ideology which has fooled you — not letting you realise that you are exploited .

QUICK REVISION

- The single reason revolution has not occurred: false consciousness perpetuated by the superstructure .
- Boycott campaigns organised along national lines are the textbook case — the class line is erased by the national line .

6.3.17 Alienation Introduced — Species Being and the Circuit of Commodity

- Alienation is a by-product of everything already covered .

Species being at its extreme potential

- In primitive communism the workers had full control over what they wanted to produce . Homo Faber was fully creative, fully expressive; species being — species essence — was at its extreme potential .
- Meaning: the worker was free to express himself the way he wanted to . He was free to make a fishing boat, free to make a bow and arrow, free to cut and etch stones, free to hunt anything (there was no wildlife protection Act either), free to make paintings on the cave walls and to carve figures on the caves .

The decline across modes of production

- The same logic operates in offices: if you want to be creative you are not given enough freedom or room to express it; you are simply asked to do whatever minimum is required from you, and there are different people for the rest .

The circuit of commodity

- Primitive communism: $C_1 - C_2$. I am the producer of tomato, you are the producer of garlic . I am free to produce tomato, you are free to produce garlic . I want garlic, you want tomato — I gave you tomato, you gave me garlic . Direct exchange . (In the earlier era: I gave you deer, you gave me lion.)

- Ancient and feudal, once commercial purposes appear: $C_1 - M - C_2$. I produced tomato, I sold tomato, I got money; with this money I can now purchase garlic . There is no direct relation any more — the relation is through money .
- Capitalism: $M_1 - C - M_2$. You produce tomato, you sell tomato, you get money — but with this money you are not going to the shop to get garlic . You are going to buy one more acre of land; on this land you will sow more tomatoes so that you have more money; so that you invest more in land; so that in future you buy more and more acres .
- It is money in a cycle . You are not consuming; you are only finding ways to earn more and more money .

KEY CONCEPT

Money, which at one point of time was just a means to the end of consumption, has now in itself become the end . Money has become the end today .

The fisherman illustration

- Subsistence (a coastal belt such as Odisha): you are a fisherman, you fish, you consume it . Finished .
- Commercial: you fish, you sell the fish, you get money, and with this money you meet some other needs .
- Capitalism: you fish, you sell the fish, you get money, and with this money you buy a bigger net to catch more fish, so that you get more money when you sell them, so that you get a still bigger net — and this goes on and on, until one day you become the leader of the fishermen's association .
- You are producing more than what is required — this is why Gandhi told us to limit our needs .
- Marx: labour creates worth more than its value, and this value is pocketed by a class . And when you buy a larger number of nets, ships and boats, you hire more people to manage them — and there begins capitalist exploitation .
- So the relation between humans has turned into a relation between things .

QUICK REVISION

- Species being was at its extreme potential in primitive communism; expression declines across slavery, feudalism and capitalism .
- Circuit of commodity: $C_1 - C_2$ (primitive) $\rightarrow C_1 - M - C_2$ (ancient and feudal) $\rightarrow M_1 - C - M_2$ (capitalism) .
- In capitalism money ceases to be a means and becomes the end itself .
- Fisherman: subsistence $\rightarrow$ commercial $\rightarrow$ capitalist accumulation of nets; production exceeds requirement .
- The relation between humans has turned into a relation between things .

6.3.18 Doubts Taken in Class

Is depression the same as the formation of the petty bourgeois and lumpen proletariat?

- When there is depression in the economy there is no consumption; with no consumption there is no profit; and when profit is not being gained, you and other people join the same ranks .
 - In the lockdown many people became unemployed — the data shows many people lost their jobs . In fact, during the lockdown the Indian economy witnessed informalisation . The modern idea of development is to move towards formalisation of the economy, but what we actually witnessed was informalisation: more and more people became underemployed and vulnerable, available as forced labour, readily available to do anything for any amount of money .

Lumpen proletariat

- Not so important, but note the term . The lumpen proletariat are even below the proletariat, and Marx is not very happy with them .
- Who are they? Those who have not studied, who are dependent on alcohol, who lie about with no idea of what is going on in the world — drug users, alcoholics, peddlers, beggars . Marx does not expect anything from these people .

The worker has dissatisfaction and disinterest at work — how does Marx cater to that?

- Marx will not cater to those people; he is telling us what is going to happen .
- Marx clearly says boredom is a very natural process in work . Why do you get bored? When you are doing the same thing every day — a monotonous, repetitive task .
- When you perform a monotonous and repetitive task you become, in the language of Karl Marx, alienated .
 - Imagine that worker who had full creativity and could do whatever he wanted . Now you will do only what the capitalist tells you to do, because you are dependent on him for your survival . And that is how the death of expression and the death of creativity creeps in, and you become like a cog in the machine .

Difference between unemployment and underemployment according to Marx

- By this logic all are underemployed, as surplus value will always be more than variable capital . Everybody is underemployed .
- To an economist, underemployment means something narrower: your degree is B.Tech but your work is that of a peon or a clerk . But underemployment in the Marxian sense is something everybody is facing .

If capitalists are already making losses and some are becoming petty bourgeois, why will workers revolt against them?

- There is long literature on this; taken up in the next class — along with who exactly are the workers who will bring the revolution .
- What we do know is that capitalism is not the end of history, and that capitalism has evolved — it is not the same as the one described by Karl Marx . We also have socialism; but do we have communism anywhere?
 - When Marx talks about communism he is talking about a communist society in a stateless society . What we have today is the communist state — we have states being ruled by

communist parties, and that is not what the idea of communism is to Marx . So when people criticise Chinese or Russian communism they believe they are criticising the Marxian idea of communism, but they are not — they are only criticising a nation, because communism in the language of Marx has not yet arrived .

The point at which Marxism could be proven wrong

- In the language of Marx: if I am earning a lot of money and I am happy and partying all night, I am living in false consciousness — not able to realise that I am still underpaid and exploited .
- Second case: if I am getting bored of my job, of the everyday routine task, then again Marx is right — because in that case I am alienated .
- So what is that one point at which Marxism can be proven wrong? If I am happy, Marx says false consciousness; if I am sad, Marx says alienation . You are right in both cases — so when will you be wrong?

CRITICAL POINT

This is what Karl Popper is saying: if you cannot be proven wrong ever, then Marxism cannot be science . It is pseudoscience .

Is ours an investment-oriented society?

- Yes — purely investment-oriented . When you become a millionaire, will you consume millions? No — you will invest in the stock market, in fixed deposits, recurring deposits, insurance policies .
- It is the chase for money that we are doing every day . Consumption is not the end today; money has become the end .

Why did Marx not discuss the work process in the administrative arena, since government employees are also proletariat?

- At that point of time there was no concept of the state providing work for the workforce . It was all the industrial capitalist class .
 - Remember Adam Smith on self-interested individuals, laissez-faire, the free market economy, the free hand — let the state not intervene .
- The state providing you employment is not a very old concept — it is a very new concept, which came basically after the World War . Reference given: the Beveridge Report / Beveridge Commission, established after the World War .

QUICK REVISION

- Depression → no consumption → no profit → ranks merge; the lockdown pushed the economy towards informalisation, not formalisation .
- Lumpen proletariat sit below the proletariat and Marx expects nothing of them .
- Monotonous, repetitive work produces alienation — the cog in the machine; boredom is natural to such work .
- In Marxian terms everyone is underemployed; the economist's definition is narrower .

- The Popper objection: happy = false consciousness, unhappy = alienation; unfalsifiable, therefore pseudoscience .
- Money, not consumption, is the end in an investment-oriented economy .
- The state as employer is a post-war concept — Beveridge; in Marx's time it was laissez-faire .

6.4 Alienation, Socialism and the First Criticisms

6.4.1 *The Essence of Marx, and What Alienation Means*

- The essence of the writings of Marx is that workers do not realise that they are exploited . We do not realise that we are exploited, and we are living in false consciousness .
- And as long as we are living in false consciousness, the new society will never get developed .
 - The analogies used: just as smokers do not realise that the cigarette is harming them; just as people wearing very high heels do not realise the harm; just as certain heads of state did not acknowledge that climate change was happening, or that the pandemic was real — similarly workers do not realise that exploitation is there .

The meaning of alienation

- Alienation simply means you are estranged — estrangement .
 - Suppose you have made something and you cannot buy it . You made the phone; you cannot buy it . You made the car; you cannot buy it . Is it not a very strange thing?

KEY CONCEPT

Alienation is the social breakdown of the natural interconnectedness between the worker and his produce or product, and between the worker and the production relations .

QUICK REVISION

- Essence of Marx: workers do not realise they are exploited; false consciousness blocks the new society .
- Alienation = estrangement — you make the thing and cannot possess it .
- Definition: social breakdown of the natural interconnectedness between worker and product, and between worker and production relations .

6.4.2 *Alienation is Not Exclusive to the Proletariat*

- Generally what we believe is that proletariats are the victims of alienation . Marx said even the bourgeoisie are alienated . Just remember this .
- Because the bourgeoisie are also individuals . The production process and the relations of production — everything is external to the actor, and not just to the proletarian actor but to the bourgeois actor as well .
 - The whole economy is over and above the biggest industrialist . The industrialist is not

over the economy; the economy as a system is over and above the biggest business houses . Therefore these are also alienated .

CRITICAL POINT

Marx believed alienation is not exclusive to proletariats, because the bourgeoisie are equally alienated . However, the alienation of proletariats is of an extreme type and of a different degree — quantitatively higher alienation, qualitatively different alienation .

Two illustrations of proletarian alienation

- The simple example: you are a worker in a noodles factory . You make the noodles, but you cannot buy the noodles — because you are not given enough income or salary to buy it . You are alienated from your own produce .
- The most basic example: all of you want to become civil service officers . But you know very well that you are highly talented and highly creative in your respective fields — maybe singing, maybe dancing, maybe acting, maybe the guitar .
 - But you are not trying to polish those skills . Rather you want to become an officer . In that sense you are alienated from your desires — because playing the guitar, singing, dancing or acting are not given so much status in society . So your wish to become an officer is not your wish .
 - You are alienated from your creative self, your inner self, your potential self — from the species being, the species essence .

Why the job itself was never a choice

- Recall: before you become a philosopher, before you start thinking and speaking on any given subject, you have to eat something first . The very first, primary need is survival .
- For survival you would inevitably enter into social relations of production . So the basic question — why do you want to do a job? To survive . Going for a job is therefore not your choice; it was inevitable .
- But why did you not go for the job that you like? You are going for the job that is given status in society, not for the thing you feel creative with . So you are alienated from your desires and from your creative potential .

QUICK REVISION

- Bourgeoisie are alienated too, because the economy as a system is external to them as well .
- But proletarian alienation is quantitatively higher and qualitatively different — of an extreme type .
- You make the product and cannot buy it; you have talent and abandon it for a higher-status occupation .
- Taking a job at all is inevitable (survival); which job you take is where alienation from desire shows .

6.4.3 *The Four Types of Alienation*

Alienation is of four types .

1. Alienation from species being
2. Alienation from the product
3. Alienation from the production process
4. Alienation from production relations (sociability)

1 & 2 — *Species being and the product*

- The first two have already been covered above . Alienation from the product: what you have made does not belong to you . It belongs to the person who asked you to make that thing .

3 — *Alienation from the production process*

- First of all, you did not make the whole product by yourself . In a car you made only the rubber of the tube that goes into the tyre at the very back — not even the whole tyre .
- Imagine there was a point of time when you could make the whole product all by yourself and you used to take pride in your craftsmanship .
- Craftsmanship does not exist today . It is all machine work that you see today .

EXAMPLE

- When you go to the Taj Mahal or the Red Fort, nobody today can make that Taj Mahal or that Red Fort at today's rates — even though machines have arrived .
- And look at our expression at these monuments: “how could those people make this kind of thing in that time, when we cannot make it today?” That question is wrong . They could make those things because they did not have machines .
- When machines start making things, things look uniform — a machine works to create standardisation . A machine can create “Taj Mahals” — the ten-rupee replicas sold in the shops outside — but it cannot create the Taj Mahal . The Taj Mahal can only be created by craftsmen .
- The whole production process has been broken down . Some workers work on the tyre; some on the window of the car; some on the nuts and screws that fix the wheel to the platform; and some others design the platform itself .
- And the people who make the tyre do not really know what final shape their produce is going to take .
 - Software engineer: they code and code and code all their lives — but they do not even know what they are actually coding for . They are operating on a minuscule part of a larger operation they are not even conscious of . They only know that they have to learn the big languages and write that code .
 - The same with people working on mathematical operations — solving a theorem without knowing what its application in the real world is . They simply solve the equations, because they know solving them will get marks .
- Those making the glass of the car do not even know what the final car is going to look like .

Every day they come to the assembly line and make these glasses in the same shape with the same dimensions .

- The creative potential of that man has been finished . He could make all the things by himself; now, in the name of specialisation, he has actually become alienated from the larger process .

4 — Alienation from production relations, or sociability

- Think of the people who work whole day and night . They are so involved in their work that they do not even know who their neighbours are .
- They do not get enough time to go out with their family; they do not get enough time to spend with their friends .
- And moreover, they do not even get time to chat with their fellow employees in the factory or office where they work . They cannot even have a casual conversation .
 - They register themselves with the biometric, go to the computer, keep working there, eat there, sit there, and then leave . This is the life .
- If you look at the life of those people from the top, it seems a repeated, monotonous, stereotyped pattern that they have become part of — a cog in the machine . The machine keeps going, and looked at from above, they keep going in exactly the same process . No change at all .

QUICK REVISION

- Four types: species being, product, production process, production relations (sociability) .
- Product: what you make belongs to whoever ordered it .
- Production process: the process is broken into fragments; the maker of a part cannot see the whole — the death of craftsmanship in the name of specialisation .
- Machines standardise: they can make Taj Mahals, not the Taj Mahal .
- Production relations: no neighbours, no family time, no friends, not even casual conversation at work — a cog in the machine .

6.4.4 How the Bourgeoisie are Alienated and in False Consciousness

- Marx says it is not only that the bourgeoisie are alienated — even the bourgeoisie are the victims of false consciousness . False consciousness is on both sides; alienation is on both sides . Generally people believe only the working class lives in false consciousness — no, everyone is in false consciousness .

The false consciousness of the bourgeoisie

- The bourgeoisie think that they are earning profit through constant capital — through machines .
 - Otherwise why would they introduce machines? The only reason for the introduction of machines is that they think machines can give them profit .
- But when machines are introduced, in the long run they realise that it is a loss — the rate of surplus value is declining . It takes them a very long time to realise it; and then Marx comes and explains it .

The alienation of the bourgeoisie

EXAMPLE

- Take the standard flavour of instant noodles — the classic yellow packet . We have been eating that same packet forever .
 - It is not that the manufacturer did not try to introduce different flavours . They tried . But the market did not accept them — the consumers did not accept those flavours, even with advertising campaigns behind them .
 - So even the manufacturers have become alienated from their own produce . They are not able to introduce any other flavour, though they think every day about how to move beyond that yellow packet .
- The market has assumed a reality of its own . They have created the product, but they are not in control of this product now — people want that particular version and nothing else .
 - That is why the bourgeoisie have also become alienated from the product . The same is visible in a car model that has run essentially unchanged for years, and in phone models numbered one after another .
 - But this is not a very great concern to Marx . His main concern was the alienation of proletariats .

KEY CONCEPT

What Marx actually wanted to tell us by discussing bourgeois alienation is that the market is over and above both these players . The market has assumed a reality which none of these players can control .

- An aside from class: people call every brand of instant noodles by the name of the leading brand — brand names becoming generic is itself a mark of this .

QUICK REVISION

- Even the bourgeoisie live in false consciousness — they believe machines (constant capital) generate their profit .
- In the long run they discover the rate of surplus value is falling instead .
- Bourgeois alienation: the producer can no longer control the product; the market dictates it .
- The real point: the market is over and above both classes and beyond the control of either .

6.4.5 Which Type of Alienation is Commodity Fetishism?

- Answer: alienation from the product .
- You have made a part of the phone — not the full phone . No person today makes a full product . Some make the screen; some make the battery, in an altogether different department; some make other components .

The global value chain

- Today we are in the era of the global value chain — the whole production process has become globalised . The company is American, but the components and the production process are in

China . The assembly line spans from America to China .

- And it is not just the raw-material components: marketing, operations and sales all go into it . It is not so simple today .
 - Think of the contribution, in percentage terms, of each person in the whole production process of one phone . Even the person who greets you when you enter the showroom is part of the larger production process — because the brand runs on an image, an image of being very customer-friendly, and the phones themselves are user-friendly . So the very smile of the seller is also part of the production process .

What happens at the point of purchase

- When you as a consumer go to the showroom and see the newly launched model, you start looking at it as something magical — as extraordinary compared with the rest .
- In the whole process of attributing magical quality to the commodity, you do not realise that it is simply a product of the labour process — the product of a labourer who did not get anything like the amount you are going to shell out from your pocket to buy it .
- So the very idea of the status symbol is not real . But this is something you would not realise; you would simply buy it . This is the fetish of the commodity .

The religious parallel and Freud

- Just as with God: you have created God, but you do not realise that it is your own creation — and then you ask that creation for favours, a minute after having made it .
- This idea comes straight from Feuerbach's writing on religion .
- Sigmund Freud — a very important scholar whose importance will be felt in later topics — says religion is all about wish fulfilment: you wish that someone were there, the grandfather, the grandest of all fathers, God . Similarly, you simply wish to have that phone .
 - You may already have a better phone, but you would still want it . There is no rationality in it .

CRITICAL POINT

- If we were rational — in the language of the economists who modelled human nature as *Homo economicus*, a conventional model not applicable today: highly utilitarian, rational, interest-maximising, selfish — then why is he not saving his money?
- Why is he spending ruthlessly on products that do not have any value per se? It is all about the fetish that people have about these commodities .

QUICK REVISION

- Commodity fetishism corresponds to alienation from the product .
- Nobody makes a whole product: the global value chain fragments it across countries and functions, including the salesperson's smile .
- At the point of purchase the commodity appears magical and the labour behind it disappears .
- Feuerbach on religion and Freud on wish fulfilment are the parallels; *Homo economicus*

cannot explain the behaviour .

6.4.6 The Contradiction Inside Marx — Orthodox and Hegelian Marxists

- Till capitalism everything is fine . Marx said inherent contradictions within capitalism will sow the seeds of its destruction, and then we will have socialism . In that sense, workers do not need to do anything — capitalism will collapse automatically, just as every previous mode of production collapsed .
- But there is one more statement in the *Communist Manifesto*: “Workers of the world, unite. You have nothing to lose but chains.”
- These two things are very contradictory . On the one hand he is pleading with the workers to realise that they are exploited, that they are in false consciousness, and to revolt . On the other hand he says capitalism is destined to collapse automatically due to inherent contradictions — the law of motion, capital accumulation, polarisation, homogenisation, pauperisation, depression, all inevitably forming two clear-cut classes .
 - Maybe people are not smart enough to see that these two are not opposites . But since Marx is dead, we cannot ask him which side he is on — so people became Marxists all by themselves . Some go with one philosophy, some with the other .

Why “Hegelian”?

- Marx was against Hegel — so what is a Hegelian Marxist? Hegel was all about consciousness — the world consciousness, which is evolving; and whatever changes we see in society are nothing but the evolution of consciousness, the evolution of ideas .
- Marx says we are living under false consciousness, so we need true consciousness — true consciousness being the realisation that these people are exploiting us .
- So when Marx said “workers of the world unite”, the interpreters of Marx saw Hegel and Marx coming together: Hegel was all about the evolution of consciousness, and Marx wants the workers to develop the very consciousness that has not yet let them realise that they are exploited .
 - Doubt raised: Hegel’s consciousness is about the world spirit — how will man develop it? Answer given: “it will come” — when philosophers talk about anything there is no concept or logic; it is random . That is exactly why philosophy has a problem getting the status of science .

QUICK REVISION

- Contradiction: automatic collapse (inevitability) vs the call to unite (agency) .
- Orthodox Marxists = revolution is inevitable .
- Hegelian Marxists = revolution is not inevitable; the working class must act .
- The Hegelian label comes from Hegel’s primacy of evolving consciousness, which Marx’s call for true consciousness echoes .

6.4.7 Liberalism and the Three Reactions to It

Liberalism

- Liberalism is basically Adam Smith's idea: the market should be liberated from any intervention of the state . Laissez-faire . Free market economy .
- The principle of liberalism: the more wealth is accumulated, the more development happens . The more money you make, the more developed you become .
- The problem: when you are making a lot of wealth, your concern is only to make wealth . And when your only concern is to accumulate wealth, you are not going to take care of the workers who are working for you — not their physical or mental health, not the working conditions they live in, not whether they can survive on the income you give them . They have no pension, no insurance, and you are not concerned about these things .
- The victims of liberalism were the working class .

DATA & FACTS

- 1750 — the industrial revolution era begins .
- 1750 to 1800 — the dominant period of liberalism .
- After 1800 — great movements begin, starting in Britain .

Reaction 1 — the Luddites (1800 to the 1810s)

- The Luddites are those people who are against technological development .
- Why would anyone be against technological development? Because technology was developing at the cost of their employment .
- These were the people who attacked factories and attacked the machines, because with the introduction of machines they were the ones expelled from the factories . So they formed a band and charged against the machines that had cost them their jobs .
- When they charged in full-fledged fashion against those machines, the industrialists called the state administration and the bureaucracy — the police and administrative officers .
 - And what would those officers do? Asked who is wrong, they conclude the workers are wrong . So you are serving the interest of the capitalist class — because you do not know the whole story, the whole narrative, or the philosophical idea that led to these developments . You just know one action — the surface act . You do not know the deep inner working of the law of motion of capitalism . So you arrest the workers; and the workers abuse you too, saying you are also involved with these people .
- The Luddite movement was a grassroot movement — it started out as a local movement, but eventually spread all over England .

Reaction 2 — Chartism

- Chartists were those who said we need to introduce the working class into the parliamentary system .
- Before Chartism, workers were not represented in parliament — it was all elites and the bourgeoisie . The industrialist class was also the parliamentarian class, so it was inevitable for

the police and the officers to serve them .

- Why were workers not represented? Because they were not owners of private property . In those times, if you wanted to become a member of parliament in the British house, you needed to have private property — that was one condition .
 - Today there is no such condition: you need to be a citizen and to meet the age requirement . But at that time the private-property condition automatically served the interest of the capitalist class, because they were the ones who had private property, while the working class was working merely for subsistence .
- Chartism was also a grassroot movement . A People’s Charter was implemented — dated in the lecture as 1834 [as stated in lecture] — through which the working class could now find themselves represented in the British house .

Reaction 3 — socialism

- Socialism was the third — and the important — reaction to liberalism .
- Note on usage: when the word liberalism is used here, it automatically implies capitalism . Liberalism and capitalism are synonyms in this discussion .
 - Why could Marx say that with the introduction of machines workers would be replaced? Because he could see it . Although he was born in 1818 and died in 1883, he had seen in the historical records the movements — such as the Luddites — of those who were the victims of technological advancement .

What socialism means

- Socialism is not a unified ideology — socialism is of multiple types .
- Liberalism served the self-interested individuals of Adam Smith’s language: pursue self-interest, no matter what; there is an invisible hand which will automatically serve all the people, because if you want to become a billionaire you will obviously give jobs to many people, so your self-interest serves society as a whole . But liberalism is all about self-interest at the end of the day — it is highly individualist .
- On the other hand, socialism is about collectivism — against individualism .
- Collectivism is all about collectively owning the resources — that is, public ownership .
 - Who is the owner of a public sector undertaking? You and I . Because in India the public is sovereign — whereas in Britain Parliament is sovereign . We are sovereign; we give money to run it; so we are the owners .
- But it is very utopian . How is the public going to own? How does it happen in reality? Is there any method?

The word “utopia”

- Thomas More wrote a book called *Utopia*, and coined the word, specifically to describe the ideal society — the ideal society we should have, where we do not have wealthy individuals exploiting workers .
- And all this is happening before Marx — Marx has not yet arrived; these discussions come earlier .

- Utopia is a dream world . This early strand is therefore called utopian socialism .

QUICK REVISION

- Liberalism = Adam Smith, laissez-faire, free market; principle: more accumulation → more development; victims: the working class .
- 1750 industrial revolution; 1750–1800 the dominant period of liberalism; after 1800, reactions begin in Britain .
- Luddites (1800–1810s): against technological development because it cost them employment; attacked machines and factories; a grassroot movement that spread across England .
- Chartism: demanded working-class representation in parliament, blocked by the private-property qualification; grassroot; the People's Charter [1834 as stated in lecture] .
- Socialism: the third reaction — collectivism and public ownership against liberal individualism .
- Thomas More coined “utopia” in his book describing the ideal society, before Marx .

6.4.8 The Utopian Socialists

Robert Owen (Owenism)

- Owen said the biggest problem is the condition of workers, and we can improve it if we give them good education . Education is the basic necessity: if people are educated they will take care of themselves .
- So our duty should be to give them good health and good education — the money they will earn on their own .
- He also focused on cooperatives .
 - What is a cooperative, and how is it different from a private limited company? In a cooperative, whatever revenue the company makes is distributed to everyone . The dairy sector has many such cooperatives .
- He also talked about trade unions — form trade unions . He was basically concerned about the working class only, and that is why he gave the ideas of cooperatives, trade unions, good health and good education .

The New Lanark experiment

- The problem: he did not have enough money or capital to give everyone health and education, or to run campaigns for the cooperative movement . So Owen said: I will show this to the world by doing one experiment in my countryside .
- The name of that place was New Lanark . He established a huge textile factory there . Today New Lanark is a World Heritage Centre .
 - Comparison offered in class: much like a company town where the school, the market and everything else belongs to one industrial house .
- He then demonstrated New Lanark to the capitalists in Britain, in London, and pleaded with them: you should also do something like this for the workers . If you do not take care of your workers, how will you earn profit? These are the people whose hard work is giving you profit .

- He was requesting them with folded hands — and that is precisely why the capitalists were not impressed .

Charles Fourier and Claude Henri de Saint-Simon

- After Robert Owen came Charles Fourier . Owen and Fourier were British citizens [as stated in lecture] . Fourier's idea was not very different from Owen's .
- And then came Claude Henri de Saint-Simon, the Frenchman — also a utopian socialist . Saint-Simon was more about cooperatives and centralised planning .

Why “utopian”

- Utopian in the sense that they believed the capitalist would help the workers, would establish cooperatives for them, would give them good health and good education . But that does not happen .

CRITICAL POINT

- Present-day link: corporate social responsibility (CSR) . If you look into CSR reports you will see how much is spent on welfare — and what is actually done with that money .
- The idea of CSR is actually the gift of the writings of these utopian socialists .

QUICK REVISION

- Robert Owen: good health, good education, cooperatives, trade unions; the New Lanark textile factory experiment, today a World Heritage Centre; pleaded with capitalists and was ignored .
- Charles Fourier: broadly the same idea .
- Saint-Simon (French): cooperatives and centralised planning .
- Utopian because it assumes capitalists will voluntarily help — CSR is the modern descendant of this idea .

6.4.9 Scientific Socialism

- After utopian socialism came scientific socialism — what we today call Marxism . Marxism is scientific socialism, not utopian socialism .
- Marx believes we do not have to plead with the capitalist class . Peaceful methods are not going to help anyone . In fact the more you request, the more it reveals the exploitation you have been the victim of .
- You should be authoritative — because it is only because of your labour that those people have gained profit . The very rooms in which they sit, the staff room, the ball room, everything, is made by your labour . So go with full authority and full confidence; do not be nervous at all .
- The proletariat have to bring a revolution against the bourgeoisie, because they have already suffered a great deal of exploitation .
 - Many people died simply by working in the factories — bad health, unsafe and insecure working conditions, no pension, no income, no insurance, and child labour on top of that .

- And it is not happening to one generation only . Generation by generation, the working class produces more working class . Since they are not educated they cannot educate their children; these uneducated people act as cheap labour to the capitalist, who is very happy because cheap labour does not have to be paid much . They will not even encourage them to study more — because with education they would start talking about rights .

The definition

KEY CONCEPT

Scientific socialism is the result of the inherent contradictions within capitalism . These inherent contradictions will automatically reveal two clearly polarised classes — bourgeoisie and proletariat . Either the proletariats will violently overthrow these people, or, if they do not, capitalism will collapse automatically . In both ways capitalism is doomed to collapse .

Why is it called “scientific”?

- Because it is a natural outcome . Inherent contradiction — just like any other mode of production destined to collapse . It is happening naturally: law of dialectics, law of motion .
- Therefore socialism is a natural outcome, and that is why it is scientific . It is not the outcome of the working class per se; the inherent contradictions will automatically polarise the world into two, and then one will overthrow the other .

The principles of scientific socialism

1. The means of production would be owned and managed by the working class .
2. The working class will produce and distribute the goods and services according to the work — according to the working labour . If you have done work for so many hours, whatever should have been given to you in the first place, and was instead pocketed by the capitalist, will now be given to you . There will be no surplus value appropriation by the capitalist .
3. Once the distribution process is over, the state shall wither away .
 - On point 3: capital has been accumulated for a very long time, so this accumulated surplus capital has to be distributed first . Imagine you are sitting on behalf of the workers, and each worker comes and says “I was working in this factory for ten years” . You calculate how much surplus value should have been received in those ten years against what was actually received, and the difference is paid out . Once that whole process is over, the state withers away .

The socialist state

- In scientific socialism the state is managed by the working class, and the objective of this socialist state is the distribution of goods and services .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

In fact India also had this objective: in 1950, when the Planning Commission was established, its objective was precisely to distribute goods and services .

- Socialism is nothing but the dictatorship of the proletariat — the working class manages the affairs of the economy . They decide what is to be produced, how much is to be produced, and

what shall be given to those people involved in the production process .

- Once everything has been given according to their labour time, the state shall wither away . Once the state has withered away — because we have achieved equality — we will have communism: stateless, classless, moneyless, profitless .

QUICK REVISION

- Scientific socialism = Marxism; no pleading, no peaceful petitioning — the proletariat must act with authority .
- It is “scientific” because socialism is the natural outcome of inherent contradictions, not of working-class will per se .
- Three principles: means of production owned and managed by the working class; distribution according to labour performed with no appropriation of surplus; the state withers away once distribution is complete .
- Socialism = dictatorship of the proletariat; the socialist state’s only objective is distribution (compare the 1950 Planning Commission) .
- Communism: stateless, classless, moneyless, profitless .

6.4.10 *Democratic Socialism*

- Socialism is not of one type . There is Owen, Fourier and Saint-Simon; there is Marx’s version; and there is another version — democratic socialism .
- Democratic socialism is not Marxist socialism or scientific socialism . Why?
- Democracy is a political concept; socialism is an economic concept . In democratic socialism, socialism is managed and run by democracy — the politics .
- And it is a democracy chosen by the people, the working class . The working class chooses workers . In Marxian terms, we are the proletariats giving votes to proletariats to rule over us — proletariats ruling the proletariats — and these proletariats are running the economy . And that is why it is a socialist economy .
 - The teacher noted that describing us all as proletariats is not highly accurate — that will become clear when the criticism is taught . But let us use the Marxist terminology .
- And since we are socialist, nobody can be poor . Everybody will be given education, insurance and pension — and that is why so many welfare schemes are doled out every year: employment guarantee schemes, health missions covering primary, secondary and tertiary care, and free education from the age of 6 to 14 [as stated in lecture] .
 - Scandinavian countries follow this model . But there is a huge difference between them and us: the population issue does not exist there — that is why they are always ranked first on happiness . The scale of the problem here is different; even getting out of a city can take two hours .
 - A doubt raised — is the process becoming a hoax? The answer given: you are privileged people living in 2020 and can easily call it a hoax; think about the times in which Marx was writing .

QUICK REVISION

- Democratic socialism $\neq$ Marxist socialism: the state is the end, not an instrument, and never withers away .
- Democracy is political, socialism is economic; the working class votes for the working class .
- Welfare schemes — employment guarantee, health missions, free schooling — are its expression .
- The Scandinavian countries are the model case; population scale is the difference noted .

6.4.11 Communism as Full Expression of the Self**KEY CONCEPT**

When Marx says we have attained communism, that means we have attained a civilisation where you can hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, graze cattle in the evening and criticise after dinner — without ever becoming either a fisherman, or a hunter, or a grazer, or a critic .

- In that sense you would express your full creativity .
- Today you are either a teacher or an engineer, either a doctor or a professor, either a civil servant or a teacher . You cannot be both .
 - Very basic question: can any person be both a doctor and a civil service officer? If you are a civil servant you can never practise medicine — never . The civil service code forbids pursuing anything for personal gain; charity is permitted, but nothing for personal gain — the office-of-profit logic .
- Marx believed that today we are constrained in occupations . We cannot express our potential .
- But tomorrow, when we have communism, we will be fishermen, hunters, gatherers, herders and critics — everything at one time, in one whole day, without ever being called or recognised as any one of them .

Why we cannot pursue two passions equally — the working day again

- There are many people who are not able to pursue both interests and passions equally, because they cannot give equal time to both . And this is what the concept of the working day is all about .
- If you are an officer you would have to work from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. The length of the working day will not let you do anything else . It is something external to you, and it restricts you from pursuing any other interest .
- And this length of the working day is a capitalist concept that we are following .

CRITICAL POINT

In fact the very idea of Sunday — of the weekend — is the result of working-class movements, labour movements and Ambedkarite movements . These people have given us Sundays . Otherwise every day was the same working day .

QUICK REVISION

- Communism = hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, herd in the evening, criticise after dinner — without becoming any one of these .
- Today occupations constrain us; you cannot be a doctor and an officer at once .
- The length of the working day is external, coercive and capitalist in origin .
- The weekend itself is a product of labour and Ambedkarite movements .

6.4.12 Doubts on Socialism and Communism***We develop efficient growth through competition, which is not in communism***

- How do you know it is not in communism? Nobody has seen communism . If nobody has seen it, how do you criticise it?
- “I am telling you what Marx is telling me to tell you. I am not praising Marx, nor am I criticising you. You cannot say Marx is wrong, because you have not seen that thing yet.”

Does Marx not talk about incentivising merit, talent and hard work?

- All of that is utopia . The question of “hard-working people” is taken up properly when stratification is taught .

Tribal societies have communism, but we see power relations there

- Yes — power relations are definitely there . Power you cannot avoid .

CRITICAL POINT

And this is what the critique of Marxism is also about: society may be classless, but society can never be powerless . And the moment you have power, class comes again . Society can be classless, but can never be statusless — and class and status are two different things .

- Many critics of Marx come from elite theory — Vilfredo Pareto; and the idea of lions and foxes from Machiavelli's *The Prince* .
- Elites are born to rule over us; society can never be equal; elites are destined to be born . Some will be lions and some will be foxes, and the ideal ruler will be the one who combines the best elements of both .
 - The teacher applied this typology to contemporary national leaders by way of illustration, while noting that such applications cannot be empirically tested and remain a matter of opinion .

QUICK REVISION

- You cannot criticise communism empirically — it has never existed .
- Merit and incentives are utopian in this frame; taken up under stratification .
- Key critique: a society can be classless but never powerless or statusless; class and status are different .
- Pareto's elite theory and Machiavelli's lions and foxes: the ideal ruler combines both; such

labels remain untestable opinion .

6.4.13 *Criticism of Alienation — Framing, and C. Wright Mills*

What “classical scholar” means

- Durkheim, Marx and Weber are classical scholars . Meaning: they can never be criticised .
 - That does not imply criticising them is immoral . It implies that even if you criticise them, you will find yourself supporting their ideas . At the end of the day you remain in the trap and cannot escape it .
- So a critic of Marx is a Marxist only . He may be a non-Marxist; he may be an anti-Marxist — but he will always use Marx’s own concepts (capitalism, socialism, communism) while criticising him . You are using Marxist concepts to criticise Marxism, and therefore you cannot escape this vicious cycle .

C. Wright Mills

- C. Wright Mills — you know him from sociological imagination . He is the first person in America to introduce Marxism in universities; Marxism was never taught in US universities until the 1930s .

DATA & FACTS

- Sociology is a very young discipline — in fact the youngest of all the disciplines, hardly 100 years long; a centenary was celebrated only recently .
- Philosophy is as old as human beings — the mother of all sciences, older even than mathematics . Political science is also a very old subject .
- Sociology is young because it came as a response to modernity — and modernity is itself a very young concept .

The argument

- Mills says: when Marx was analysing capitalism, the capitalism of those times was industrial manufacturing capitalism — what we today call the secondary sector .
- The tertiary or service sector did not exist in as developed a form as we have today . In those times it was a full-fledged manufacturing sector, and that is why the workers were blue-collar workers .
 - “Blue collar” is a symbolic term — it does not mean they literally wore blue shirts .
- Line to write: Marx’s analysis of capitalism, and of alienation, was limited to the manual working class — that is, blue-collar workers .
- C. Wright Mills has discussed alienation among non-manual workers — the workers of the service sector, the white-collar workers .

Prostituting the personality

- Mills says these white-collar workers are “beautiful idiots” . Why?

KEY CONCEPT

Because in the sales room, in the board room, in the ball room and in the conference room, these people are prostituting their personalities — selling the pieces of their personalities in pursuit of self-interest or personal gain .

- What does it mean? They will sell you their smile . They will sell you their glamour, their services, their expression — to seek personal gain, whether a promotion or the reward for giving good service .
 - Examples given: the cab driver who talks pleasantly about everything through the whole ride — the economy, politics, everyone — and at the end asks for a five-star rating . The delivery executive who asks for a rating at the door . A salesperson in a showroom who talks to you very sweetly; an air hostess who does the same . You would not see a software engineer or a mechanic talking to a customer like this — only the service-class workers .
- So in the language of C. Wright Mills these are the people who have become alienated from their own real selves — because their smile is an expression of the reward they seek from you, in the form of a higher rank, a promotion, or good feedback from the customer . They are serving the interest of larger companies by selling pieces of their personalities .
- This is known as white-collar alienation .

CRITICAL POINT

- But was it a critique of alienation? No — it is not a criticism of Marx .
- It is simply a refinement of Marxism in the modern era — the application of the same concept to today's time . Application, not criticism .

QUICK REVISION

- Classical scholars cannot really be criticised — critics end up using their concepts and remain inside their frame .
- C. Wright Mills: author of the sociological imagination; first to introduce Marxism in US universities (Marxism untaught there until the 1930s) .
- Marx analysed the blue-collar, manual, secondary-sector worker; Mills extends alienation to the white-collar service worker .
- White-collar workers prostitute their personalities in the sales room, board room, ball room and conference room — selling smile, glamour and expression for personal gain .
- This is white-collar alienation — an application and refinement of Marx, not a criticism .

6.4.14 André Gorz and Herbert Marcuse — Leisure Shaped by Capitalism

- During the era of Marx the working day was 12 to 16 hours .
 - In fact the labour laws of the time said only that you could not make a child work for more than 12 hours — so more than 12 hours was against child rights, and anything less was fine . Twelve hours was the minimum length of the working day .
- When you are working 12 to 16 hours you would not have time for leisure activities — no time

for your own entertainment .

- Today the working days have become shorter — 8 hours, 9 hours, at maximum 10 hours . Beyond that it becomes a court case, because we have labour laws (except where someone is operating in the informal economy — but these scholars are writing about Europe) .

The argument

- At the surface it seems we now have a great deal of time for leisure . But just as the working day was shaped by capitalism, leisure has also been shaped by capitalism .
- After work, what are you going to do? Watch a streaming platform . Play games on a console . Watch videos online . Listen to music . These leisure activities have also been shaped by capitalism .
- And when you are watching these things, you are again working for these people — because when you watch, they earn, and you do not get anything . So the vicious cycle is complete .
- How you are going to spend your time has also been shaped by capitalism . So even when you are out of work, out of the factory, you are still in the sphere of capitalism — you cannot escape it .
- Instead of finding leisure in talking to your friends, your parents or your family members, you find leisure in these commodities . And this is how you have become one-dimensional .
 - Ask anyone what their source of entertainment is, and the prompt reply is a streaming platform or a video site — and that is what their entertainment is .

Herbert Marcuse

- Herbert Marcuse says leisure is shaped by capitalism, and we have become passive robots chasing false needs . These are false needs .
- This is very much like commodity fetishism — because both of these scholars are neo-Marxists .

Cultural industries and cultural goods

- These streaming platforms and video sites are cultural industries, and what comes out of them are cultural goods .
- Neo-Marxists say the cultural industry produces cultural goods, and no cultural good is very different from another — all of them are the same, because it is a repetitive flavour .
- Capitalists have identified what kind of taste you have, so they repeat similar things: they introduce different characters, but with similar lyrics, similar scenes and a similar ending scene as well .
 - The teacher admitted candidly that even he cannot tell the difference between two of the major streaming platforms — a very basic question that still confuses him .
 - Two doubts deferred: whether this amounts to surveillance (taken up later), and whether alienation is the same as McDonaldisation (no — taken up later) .

6.4.15 Welfare Capitalism, Keynes, Beveridge and the Welfare State

The liberals' response to the responders

- The people responding to liberalism were Owen, Fourier, More, Saint-Simon and Marx . The liberals then responded to them:
 - “Your objectives are very nice . We really like your objectives . You want proper safe working conditions for the workers, you want to give them good education and good health . Ultimately it will benefit us only . We agree.”
- So what they proposed was: let us have welfare capitalism .
- Welfare capitalism means the capitalist giving you education, good health, schooling, good residence — good quarters, working-class quarters — everything provided by the capitalist .
 - Like the housing given by a large industrial house: a house within the complex, with water and electricity and everything else .
- The purpose: so that they do not revolt, and work silently . “We have given you everything, so now there is no need to bring a revolution — just work.”

Why it failed — the Great Depression

- But this welfare capitalist model was not sustainable . It failed — the biggest failure was in the 1930s, the period of the Great Depression .
 - At that point of time welfare capitalism was not purely welfare capitalism; it was largely capitalism with a little bit of welfare . And it collapsed in the 1930s .

What led to the Great Depression

1. After the World War, America had become highly prosperous — producing cars and much else .
2. The cultural industry got established: radio, FM, music, Hollywood, cinema, and popular music forms .
3. People had become consumers of these cultural goods and were ready to buy a car .
4. But after a point, when France and others also recovered and started making these goods, the world was flooded with goods while demand did not keep pace with the production .
5. Ultimately, with overproduction and under-consumption, the Great Depression came in .

Why the revolution still did not happen — John Maynard Keynes

- When the Great Depression came in 1930, people got highly excited — the time of Marxism has come . Depression is the last thing in the laws; after this revolutionary consciousness would develop and these people would overthrow the capitalists .
- But it did not happen . Why? Only because of one man: John Maynard Keynes .

KEY CONCEPT

Keynesian economics overthrew Marxist economics . Keynesian economics was developed to fight this demand-deficit economy .

- And it is because of Keynes that we today study monetary policy and fiscal policy, and the idea of stimulus — fiscal stimulus and monetary stimulus .
 - Cut the repo rate; cut taxes under fiscal policy; inject money into the economy; cut the CRR . All of these come from Keynesian economics .

- Keynesian economics simply tells us that when there is a demand deficit, we should work on increasing the demand — and demand can be increased if people are given that much amount of money, in whatever form it may be .
- These ideas were much liked by the man who became President of America after the Great Depression — Franklin Roosevelt . He transformed the American economy into a Keynesian economy and actually established Keynesian economics .
- And from there the drive of Marxism started weakening . Somehow it was believed that whenever the economic or business cycle goes through boom and bust, Keynesian economics would always fix the anomaly of demand deficit or supply deficit . So working-class consciousness would not develop, and the overthrow would never happen . These were the things that actually disrupted the idea of Marxism .

From welfare capitalism to the welfare state

- After Franklin Roosevelt came the idea of the welfare state . From welfare capitalism we moved towards the welfare state .
- By the 1960s the whole of Europe and the USA had absorbed this idea — the welfare state had become the new normal .
- But this welfare state also got over: the demise of the welfare state in the 1970s . Why it collapsed is taken up later .

Keynes and Beveridge

- Keynes in America and Beveridge in Britain — these are two people who were working towards a new system where economies remain stable and do not fluctuate the way they did during the World War or the Great Depression .
- To fight the Great Depression we had Keynes . To fight the deficits after the World War we had the Beveridge Report . These two people actually established the idea of the welfare state .
 - A doubt clarified in passing: a software engineer is white collar; a hardware engineer is blue collar .

QUICK REVISION

- Welfare capitalism = the capitalist supplies education, health, housing, so that workers do not revolt .
- It collapsed in the Great Depression of the 1930s — post-war American prosperity, cultural industry, then global overproduction against insufficient demand .
- Keynes prevented the expected revolution: demand-deficit economics, monetary and fiscal policy, stimulus; adopted by Franklin Roosevelt .
- Keynes (America) and Beveridge (Britain) established the welfare state; it became the new normal by the 1960s and died in the 1970s .

6.4.16 A Doubt on Fascism

- First, a logical point: you cannot ask how an orange is different from a car . One is a fruit and one is a vehicle; there can be no comparison between them .

- Fascism is a political ideology . Capitalism is an economic ideology . So comparing fascism and capitalism is comparing two very different things .

What fascism is

- Fascism is an ultra-nationalist ideology — in the sense that the whole of nationalism is subordinated to the interest of one leader; the nation as a concept serves one leader .
 - Under Nazism, German nationalism was not over and above the leader — the leader was over and above German nationalism . Therefore to be German became equal to being a supporter of that leader's version of Germany: the Nazi Germany that despised Jews, that wanted to establish its supremacy across Europe, to become prosperous across Europe and to expand beyond its confines .
- Fascism and Nazism are different . Fascism was in Italy, under the leadership of Mussolini — Italian nationalism subordinated to the interest of Mussolini, very much similar to Hitler's Nazism .

Gramsci and the Prison Notebooks

- Under fascism, whoever protested against Mussolini was jailed . One of those jailed was Antonio Gramsci, a neo-Marxist .
- Gramsci wrote *The Prison Notebooks*, in which he explained how these totalitarian, fascist regimes are run .
- Gramsci's reading was also very instrumental in the development of critical theory — Adorno and Horkheimer .

CRITICAL POINT

- A caution given on ideal types: these are concepts . The use of these ideal types is very wrong sometimes — it becomes a journalistic use when people casually label a leader a fascist . A full treatment was deferred to the politics section .
- Context: after the World War people expected the rise of socialism, but what came instead was the rise of totalitarian leaders and, in America, the cultural industry . Dictatorship, fascism and Nazism are the ideologies which prevented the establishment of the new utopian world of socialism — which is why people start equating fascism with capitalism .
 - Also clarified: neo-Marxism is not only about criticising — it is much more than that .

QUICK REVISION

- Fascism is a political ideology, capitalism an economic one — they are not comparable categories .
- Fascism = ultra-nationalism in which the nation is subordinated to one leader; Nazism (Germany) and fascism (Mussolini's Italy) are distinct .
- Gramsci, jailed under Mussolini, wrote *The Prison Notebooks* on how totalitarian regimes are run; this fed into critical theory .
- Ideal types are analytical concepts, not journalistic labels .

6.5 The Criticism of Marx

6.5.1 Opening Doubts

How exactly are the bourgeoisie alienated?

- If I am the owner of a company and I am not able to produce something out of my own wish — if whatever I produce comes out of subjugation to market forces — that is alienation .
- I have become subjugated to the demand-and-supply game; I have become subordinated to market supply-and-demand forces . I cannot do anything on my own .
 - Illustration from the teacher's own trade: I may know I can teach the subject in ten days, but nobody will accept a ten-day programme as credible, so I have to run a three-and-a-half to four-month programme . If I drop the fee very low it will look cheap; if I raise it very high nobody will pay . So the price and the length are both decided by the market, not by me . I am alienated .

Why is Marxism known as a romantic philosophy?

- Anything is romantic which seems rosy — when you romanticise the idea of being an ambassador, or of being a district collector, that is romanticising .
- Many people romanticise Marx, and others therefore call Marxism a romantic philosophy — in the sense that you can talk about it, but it is not going to happen . It will remain in the book, and that is why you can romance about it .

Apart from communism, is there any solution to alienation?

- Yes — Marx gave a solution for alienation also .
 1. Decrease the working hours . At that point of time the working day was 12 to 16 hours, so he suggested 8 to 10 — drop it .
 2. The end of capitalism — communism .
- But André Gorz and Herbert Marcuse say that even though working hours have decreased, the leisure we have gained is something we have become trapped in . It is also an illusion; it is not leisure; it is also false needs that we are chasing . Leisure is shaped by capitalism, and we have become alienated from leisure also . So the circle is complete .

Was Marx vindictive because of his own suffering, or did he really want equality?

- Look at the idea itself . Socialism will come . What is the purpose of socialism? To distribute the goods and resources, to minimise all inequality, to end all the oppression of the working class that was happening in capitalism .
- Once that is done, the work of the state is over . Who is going to distribute the goods and resources? The working class only — they will decide their own fate . The capitalists have had their turn .
- Once distribution is over, the state shall wither away, and then we have communist society .

QUICK REVISION

- Bourgeois alienation: the owner cannot produce out of his own wish either — the market dictates product, price and format .
- Marxism as “romantic philosophy”: attractive to talk about, not going to happen .
- Marx’s own solutions to alienation: shorter working hours, and communism . Gorz and Marcuse close that exit — leisure too is shaped by capitalism .
- The purpose of socialism is distribution and the ending of oppression; then the state’s work is over and it withers away .

6.5.2 Criticism of Alienation — Max Weber**CRITICAL POINT**

A general point about how criticism works among these scholars: you would not find them mentioning the name of the person explicitly in their books . You will not see Weber writing Karl Marx’s name while criticising him .

- Max Weber says alienation is something that you cannot escape . Our societies are going to be more and more rationalised — we are going towards a process called rationalisation .

What rationalisation means (in brief)

- Today we talk about numbers, rules and laws . Everything is quantifiable today . Everything is bound by rule today . Gone are the days of tradition, religious beliefs, customs and norms; everything today is either rule-bound or quantifiable .
- Now, when everything is rule-bound, number-bound and quantifiable, there is no space for human emotions . Rationality displaces emotion .

Bureaucrats as the highest manifestation of rationality

- Max Weber says that bureaucrats — the administrative and police service officers — are the highest manifestation of rationality .

EXAMPLE

- Imagine a poor person who lost everything in the lockdown and wants a licence to open a restaurant . He goes to the district collector and pleads: all my wealth is gone, I have nothing in my hands, my family will die hungry, please understand, I really need this licence .
- The collector says: wait for one or two minutes, I have an urgent meeting . The man waits — and the collector returns after an hour . Then the collector does not even look at him; he is on a call with another officer, quoting rule six .
- Finally: “many people have applied for a licence; you can apply for a licence.” There is no emotion .
- But the collector is also helpless . He is a mouthpiece, a spokesperson of the civil service code, and cannot do anything beyond that code . If the person is dying, the officer will say: write

an application stating that you are dying .

- Everything has a process, a rule, a procedure; everything has to be in written form; the paper travels a long chain of higher authorities; then the rule book is opened to see which rule fits the licence .

The line

KEY CONCEPT

Max Weber: bureaucrats are “specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart.”

- That means the very idea of being impersonal and rational has alienated those people from emotions, empathy and sympathy . All those values are gone; only rule, rationality, process and procedure remain .
- Remember: Weber is not talking about the alienation of the working class . He is talking about the alienation of humanity . All people are going to act like this; the larger trend is the rationalisation of societies, and bureaucrats are the manifestation of that rationality .
- The larger trend of rationalisation will eliminate everything magical, spiritual, emotional and humane in humanity .
- Impersonality is one of the features of bureaucracy — you cannot afford to get emotional with the client, you have to remain strictly rule-bound, you change your personality when you enter service . And this is nothing but alienation — alienation from human emotions, empathy and sympathy .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber: alienation cannot be escaped; societies move towards rationalisation .
- Rationalisation = everything quantifiable and rule-bound; no space for emotion .
- Bureaucrats are the highest manifestation of rationality — “specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart” .
- Weber generalises alienation from the working class to humanity as such .
- Impersonality, a defining feature of bureaucracy, is itself alienation from empathy and sympathy .

6.5.3 Robert Blauner — Alienation is Relative, Not Universal

- Blauner’s starting objection: all the Marxist scholars say we are alienated, alienation will definitely be there, we are helpless, nothing is going to happen . Blauner says: at least ask those people once .
 - Are they really alienated? Or are you going to sit on your chair and comment on them relentlessly? First tell them the definition of alienation, and then ask them: are you feeling this?

KEY CONCEPT

Robert Blauner’s statement: alienation is not a universal phenomenon . Rather, it is a relative

phenomenon .

- The reasoning: all industries are not the same . We have the textile industry, the print industry, the chemical industry, the automobile industry — all these industries are different from one another .
- How can you say that in all industries alienation is there? In some industries maybe alienation is not there; in some, some people may be alienated and some may not .
- What does this show? That Blauner is not a structuralist . He wants to ask the people themselves — as a bureaucrat, as a worker in any factory, are you really alienated? He wants to check it himself; he wants to conduct a survey .

The survey

- Blauner conducted a behavioural attitude survey in four industries: craft (print), chemical, textile and automobile .

The problem of measurement — operationalisation

- How do you measure alienation? There is no scale . Alienation is not a quantifiable thing .
- When you decide to measure something that does not seem measurable, social scientists use one word: they operationalise the concept .
- Operationalisation of the concept means you establish certain criteria of alienation . If those criteria are met, then the person is alienated . This is the way we measure alienation .

The four dimensions Blauner used

1. Powerlessness — “nobody listens to me; I simply obey other people . Although they have told me I am an executive manager, nobody listens to me.”
2. Meaninglessness — “I keep doing it only because the money comes at the end of the month . Otherwise I do not find any meaning in the work that I am doing.”
3. Self-isolation (self-estrangement) .
4. Normlessness — there is no system, no proper rule or governance in place . You believed you were the one to be promoted to the managerial level, but someone very close to the boss got the promotion instead .

The result

- After collecting the data from all four industries, he plotted degree of alienation against the different industries — print, textile, automobile, chemical — and formed an inverted U-curve .
- Conclusion: in the automobile sector alienation is extreme; in the print or craft sector alienation is least .
 - Doubt raised: if the names of the industries change, there will be no inverted U-shape — for instance if you put a toy industry or restaurants in place of print . Answer: obviously; but he analysed only these four industries .

QUICK REVISION

- Blauner: alienation is relative, not universal — it varies by industry, so ask the workers .
- Not a structuralist; he surveys behaviour and attitude in four industries: craft/print, chemical, textile, automobile .
- Alienation is unmeasurable directly, so it is operationalised through four dimensions: powerlessness, meaninglessness, self-isolation, normlessness .
- Result: an inverted U-curve — extreme alienation in automobile, least in print/craft .

6.5.4 Goldthorpe and Lockwood — Ask What Meaning They Attach**KEY CONCEPT**

Line to write: instead of categorising the working class as victims of alienation, the job of a social scientist should be to see what meaning they attach to their work .

- You cannot simply say all of them are alienated . Ask them: how exactly does this job matter to you? Is it only a source of income to you, or is it something more than that?
 - Think about people working in a large, respected industrial house — they feel proud of being an employee there, because the whole ecosystem of that house is very different from that of other companies . They feel they will do anything for the company, so there is no scope for them to feel alienated .
 - Think about people in a big software firm, sitting on bean bags, working on their laptops, enjoying it — they feel even better there than at home, and that is why they are considered highly productive also . Mutual needs are being exchanged .
- Of course it depends which particular section of worker you are talking about . But if it depends, that simply means alienation is not universal .
- So instead of simply calling them victims of alienation, we should ask them . This is what Goldthorpe and Lockwood are saying .

QUICK REVISION

- Goldthorpe and Lockwood: study the meaning workers attach to their work rather than assigning them the label of alienation .
- Every company has its own ecosystem; pride and mutual exchange can displace alienation .
- If alienation depends on the case, it is by definition not universal .

6.5.5 Simone de Beauvoir and Arlie Hochschild**Simone de Beauvoir**

- Simone de Beauvoir simply argues that it is the women who are alienated — it is not the working class .
- Alienated from what? From the species being — from their true potential .
- Women have a huge potential to transform the world .

DATA & FACTS

The figure cited in class: according to the World Economic Forum, the World Bank and similar organisations, if the workforce gets feminised — if women are brought into the workforce — the GDP of the nation will grow by 50% of what it is today in the next ten years [figure as stated in lecture] .

- And what are they doing? They are at home taking care of the father, the husband, the child . The true creativity and the potential that they have — they have been alienated from it .
 - Women can fly fighter jets . Now imagine a woman who has spent all her life cooking rice and dal — that means she has been alienated from her true potential, from the fact that she could do anything .
- And it is only because of patriarchy that women have become alienated . Patriarchy gained its power and privilege by subjugating women to its interests . How does man gain power? Only by suppressing women . And with the suppression of women comes her alienation .

Arlie Hochschild — emotional labour

- Arlie Hochschild has given one concept: emotional labour .
- Emotional labour is more laborious than physical labour . It is mentally tortuous .
 - To keep smiling every day is not an easy job . A physical task is still easy; but to communicate 24×7 — “hello sir” — and to talk in a sweet fashion, is very difficult . Think of the customer-care call where the customer speaks in one language and the agent must answer sweetly in another throughout .
- Hochschild says emotional labour is the source of alienation in the service sector — very much similar to C. Wright Mills’s white-collar alienation, but she is specifically talking about women .
 - Note running through all of these: none of them are actually critics . They are applications and extensions .

QUICK REVISION

- De Beauvoir: it is women who are alienated — from species being and true potential — and patriarchy is the cause .
- Feminisation of the workforce as the counterfactual (GDP figure as stated in lecture) .
- Hochschild: emotional labour — harder and more mentally tortuous than physical labour — is the source of service-sector alienation, especially for women .
- Parallel with Mills’s white-collar alienation, but gendered .

6.5.6 Critique of Class in Itself / Class for Itself — Vladimir Lenin**Recap of the problem**

- Class in itself: people having similar relation to the means of production . The teacher of sociology and the worker making street food at a large sweet-shop chain are the same — because both are not owners of the means of production; both are only selling their labour .
 - And yet we still look down on that worker — “how much would he earn in a day?” Marx

would abuse me for that: who are you to say anything to that person? You belong to that class only .

- When would I get this realisation? Only when exploitation attains a level at which the revelation of the inherent contradiction becomes inevitable and the polarisation becomes inevitable — until there are clearly only two kinds of people on earth: the owners, and those who are not owners and work for them .
- When exploitation takes us to that level, this exploited class will form a union and overthrow these people — class for itself . But it does not happen like this . The world is not so easy .

The Russian problem

- Vladimir Lenin wanted to mobilise the working class — the peasants — in Russia .
- In Russia there was no working class . The industrial revolution came later . The major class that was fighting was the peasant class — it was landlord and serf .
- Lenin believed that these peasants cannot bring any revolution by themselves . They are protesting and agitating, but everything is in a very individual fashion . They need to be organised together .
- Unless they are organised, unless they are mobilised, the revolution would not happen — their agitation and protest will be loosely taken, or will seem very individualistic .
 - Analogy: if you want to protest against a decision of a university, you alone cannot do anything unless it is a mass, mobilised protest, covered by the media and given a lot of footage over ten days . Until that happens, no change comes .

The All-Russia newspaper and the Vanguard Party

1. First, these peasants have to be imparted the consciousness that they are exploited .
2. For that, Lenin talked about an All-Russia newspaper . In that newspaper different editors would write, every day, about how the working class is exploited — and they would write in the language legible to those peasants .
3. The peasants read the newspaper every day and then discuss it with their friends .
4. Gradually a Vanguard Party — a political party — will be established: the party of the peasants, or the party of the workers .
5. This Vanguard Party will bring forward the revolution, working to bring consciousness among these people that they are exploited .
 - The comparison drawn in class: this is what the Communist Party of India was doing initially — going into the affected districts and telling people about the oppression of the state, about land distribution and land reform .
6. These are the people who impart consciousness among the people, because they believe that people are not going to become conscious all by themselves . An external party has to be there to mobilise them around a similar conscious feeling .

KEY CONCEPT

Lenin: the Vanguard Party will help in imparting consciousness among the oppressed . That means

for a class in itself to become a class for itself, you need not just homogenisation, depression and pauperisation — you also need one political party . It is not that easy .

Why this is not a critique either

- Lenin was also a Marxist — and that is why the ideology became Marxist–Leninist .
- The act is familiar, the discourse is familiar, the oppression is familiar, the concerns are familiar, the classes are almost the same — only the characters have changed .

QUICK REVISION

- Class in itself only becomes class for itself when exploitation and polarisation become undeniable — but Marx’s automatic route does not work .
- Russia had no working class; the fighting class was the peasantry, and it was unorganised .
- Lenin: All-Russia newspaper written in the peasants’ own language → discussion → Vanguard Party → revolution .
- A fourth prerequisite is added to Marx’s three: a political party .
- Marxism came out of the factory, Marxism–Leninism out of the land; Marx rejected the party, holding democracy to be a bourgeois ideology .

6.5.7 Nancy Hartsock — Women as Commodities

The circuit of commodity, recalled

- $C_1 - C_2$, then $C_1 - M - C_2$, then $M_1 - C - M_2$. Initially we exchange commodities; then money gets introduced and the commodity is sold for money, which helps in buying another commodity; and now money has become the end . The commodity is not the end . Investment, reinvestment .

The argument

- Nancy Hartsock, a feminist, wrote an article titled “Women and/as Commodities” .
- She says it is the women who are commodities . Just as a commodity has both use value and exchange value, women also have both use value and exchange value .

CRITICAL POINT

The very concept of family has come into existence only because of the exchange of women . If women were not exchanged, the family would not have been possible .

The manifestations she lists

- Bride price in some regions — that means it works like a commodity .
- Dowry — a manifestation of the fact that the woman is a commodity; that is why she is traded for money .
- Trafficking of women — one of the biggest international crimes; women trafficked across borders through networks .

- The trophy wife — an eighty-year-old man about to die marries a twenty-five-year-old . Why? He has gained status . That woman is a commodity to him, because by keeping that commodity in his house he symbolises status . The existence of the human is reduced to the level of a commodity .

KEY CONCEPT

A note on how sociologists speak . When sociologists speak like this, they are not criticising us . They simply reveal to us something that is hidden — something not visible to common-sensical observation . You knew all those things, but the way it is told was not known to you . This is the art of sociology: defamiliarisation . You become defamiliar with something that was familiar to you, and you start looking for the strange in seemingly familiar scenes .

The circuit applied to the gender wage gap

- Hartsock says $C_1 - M - C_2$ is a highly patriarchal notion, and it is applicable to the gender wage gap .
- For women, what actually happens is $C_1 - M(\text{minus}) - C_2$. A man and a woman are both working in the same organisation; for the same work the man gets more money and the woman gets a lower wage .
- The man's labour power exchanged for money lets him buy a house . Her labour power, sold for less, does not — so she will have to remain dependent on him .
- The whole gender wage gap is a constructed notion through which these patriarchal marriage structures are maintained, so that women are always dependent on the male .

QUICK REVISION

- Hartsock, “Women and/as Commodities”: women too have use value (unpaid caring services) and exchange value (marriage, money) .
- The family exists because women are exchanged .
- Manifestations: bride price, dowry, trafficking, the trophy wife — the human reduced to a commodity .
- Defamiliarisation is the art of sociology: making the familiar strange .
- $C_1 - M(\text{minus}) - C_2$: the gender wage gap is constructed to keep women dependent within patriarchal marriage .

6.5.8 Nancy Hartsock — Women as the Real Source of Surplus Value

First, why machines cannot be the source of surplus

- Some students were confused about why machines cannot give surplus, since so many things come out of them and money keeps flowing .
- Look at it practically . A computer lying idle on a table is dead labour . The moment you sit at the chair and operate it, pages come out of the printer, and those pages are sold for a thousand rupees .
- What is the source of surplus value? You — not the computer . The computer will not produce

a page by itself . And the valuation of what comes out depends on the work you did, not on the fact that it came from a computer .

- And by the way, who made the computer? Labour only . So the source of the fixed capital is also variable capital . Ultimately it is variable capital alone which is the source of all the surpluses .

The argument

KEY CONCEPT

Nancy Hartsock says the real source of surplus value is women .

1. Before you sit at the computer and expend the labour power that generates the surplus, you must have eaten something; someone must have taken a great deal of care of you — breakfast, lunch, care, love, affection .
 2. Hence the saying that behind every successful man there is a woman . That man is highly productive in the office only because he was taken care of very well back at home . Unless you are peaceful at home your mindset will not be right — how can you be a productive labourer in the office?
 3. So the real source of surplus value is that woman's labour power — this labour power has generated the other labour power (LP has generated LP') .
 4. It is the women who give workers to the society . If workers are productive, their productivity is the result of the reproduction process that all workers have gone through .
 5. So reproductive labour is not rewarded — only productive labour is rewarded . And “reproductive” does not mean only biological reproduction; it means care as well .
- And that is why we have the debate on wage for housework . For three or four months it became a dominant discourse and the newspapers were flooded with articles on whether it should be given; some argued that it definitely should be .

QUICK REVISION

- Machines cannot be the source of surplus: the idle computer is dead labour, and labour made the computer in the first place .
- Hartsock: the real source of surplus value is women's labour — the care and reproduction that makes the productive worker possible .
- Reproductive labour (biological and care work) is unrewarded; only productive labour is rewarded .
- Hence the wage-for-housework debate .

6.5.9 Critique of Scientific Socialism — Does Socialism Exist?

The sequence did not hold

- Marx said the history of society has been the history of class struggle: primitive era → ancient society → feudal society → capitalist society → socialism → finally communism .
- Now look at Russia, India and China . They had feudalism, and they jumped directly to

socialism — with no capitalism in between .

- The Chinese revolution and the Russian revolution were both agrarian revolutions — peasant-class revolutions, not working-class revolutions .
- What does it show? That history is not so unilinear or predictable . In empirical observation, the sequence Marx laid down was not followed in either of these societies .

Do we really have socialism today? — the case of China

- China is a socialist society with a capitalist economy and a communist party . All three at once .
- China calls itself a socialist society . Being a socialist society, your duty should be to be concerned about the welfare of the oppressed and marginalised sections — equality . As a socialist society China should be producing socially useful goods — good health, education, public goods .
 - But, as stated in class: inequality in China is even bigger than that of India; the rate of poverty is increasing; dropouts from school are increasing; people are not getting proper education; malnutrition and health issues are worse . Only during the pandemic did China gain — and that too relatively, because everybody else was almost in depression . [claims as stated in lecture]
- That means it is not socialist in that sense .

When are you actually categorised as socialist?

- It is not enough that you own the means of production — the strategic sectors: rail, power, nuclear, petrochemicals, atomic energy, defence .
- You should also distribute all the benefits . Just owning the means of production is not going to help; it does not give you the status of being socialist . The next duty is to distribute the resources — which is not being done .
- What is the revenue being spent on instead? Warfare, defence goods, and the expansion of territory — the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor, a “look west” / pivot-to-Eurasia policy (just as the United States once had a pivot to Asia), and One Belt One Road . They want to expand; they are not concerned about the poor people; they are only concerned about making wealth .
- Dumping goods all over the world at the cheapest prices: if you dump goods at the cheapest price, what wage will your worker get? A worker who should have got a hundred will get fifty — because the main idea is to establish hegemony worldwide through “made in” products . So you would not be giving enough wage to the workers . That is not what a socialist economy is about .

KEY CONCEPT

Lynette Ong: China is a capitalist country with a socialist facade . It is like Adam Smith wearing the suit of Karl Marx .

Power is also a resource

- The Communist Party has usurped power . Power is also a resource — and it is not distributed . No one outside the party can be in power, and even within it the chance is small .

- So power is not distributed, wealth is not distributed, and poverty and inequality are rising . In no way should it be called socialist that way .
- The only reason for calling China socialist would be that the state is the owner of the strategic sectors . But if China is socialist because of that, China is also non-socialist, because the wealth generated from those enterprises is not distributed across the population — how else would you explain rising poverty?
- So China is socialist and non-socialist both . It depends on what is important to you — only the ownership, or also what happens after the ownership .

DATA & FACTS

- China became a communist nation in 1949 .
- In 2004 China recognised private property in its constitution . If private property is also recognised, then what is socialist?

The alternatives are no different

- J. K. Galbraith: under capitalism, man exploits man; and under communism it is just the opposite — which, as the teacher noted, is not really opposite at all, because the opposite of “man exploits man” is still “man exploits man” .
- The fact is that the alternatives beyond capitalism are no different from capitalism . You call yourself socialist or communist, but your practices are highly capitalist .
- Therefore Francis Fukuyama, in his book *The End of History*, believed that capitalism is the end of history — because the alternatives beyond capitalism are no different from capitalism . (Randall Collins was named alongside in the same connection.)
- Everywhere you can see $M - C - M_2$. Money is generated and not distributed; money is generated and then appropriated . Earlier we had appropriation of money by the capitalist class; today we have appropriation of money by the state .
- And in those times you could escape one capitalist by joining some other company . Today you cannot escape the state — and therefore the state is the super bourgeois . You can move from one company to another, but you cannot leave the country .

QUICK REVISION

- Russia, India and China jumped from feudalism to socialism without capitalism, and through agrarian, not working-class, revolutions — history is not unilinear or predictable .
- Socialism requires distribution, not merely state ownership of strategic sectors .
- Lynette Ong: a capitalist country with a socialist facade — Adam Smith wearing the suit of Karl Marx .
- Power is an undistributed resource; private property recognised in 2004 .
- Galbraith’s epigram; Fukuyama’s *End of History*: the alternatives are no different from capitalism .
- Appropriation has moved from the capitalist to the state — the state as super bourgeois, because you cannot exit it .

6.5.10 Critique of the Mode of Production — Anthony Giddens

- According to Marx, history has been the history of class struggle, and class struggle is the motor of history; societies evolve only because of the struggle between classes, and cannot evolve if classes do not struggle .
- Anthony Giddens, in *A Contemporary Critique of Historical Materialism* (described in class as an article rather than a book per se), says there is no absolute universal formula that with class struggle history will evolve .
- And it is not the only struggle in the world . There are many other struggles which Marx has ignored .

EXAMPLE

- Look at the partition of India and Pakistan . Was it class struggle? Was it the result of bourgeoisie versus proletariat, or lords versus serfs? No . It was about religious communities, not about a Hindu bourgeoisie and a Muslim proletariat .
- The World Wars were not bourgeoisie versus proletariat — these were nation-states at war .
- The fact is that class struggle is only one of the struggles . There are many other forms of struggle Marx did not take into consideration .

Fault line conflict

- One of the other forms is fault line conflict — conflict on the lines of ethnicity and religion .
 - The Israel–Palestine conflict, Jews versus Arabs, is not a struggle of bourgeoisie versus proletariat .
- Ethnicity is a cultural identity . Son-of-the-soil movements are the clear case: in the north-east, people from elsewhere are considered outsiders . With limited resources, if the local people are not served first and outsiders come and take away jobs and resources, it automatically leads to conflict between locals and outsiders — whoever that outsider may be .
 - In that conflict the seven states unite . It is not the mobilisation of proletariats — it is the mobilisation of a region against outsiders . Two classes clearly emerge: insiders and outsiders, purely on ethnic lines .
- The concept of fault line conflict is given by Samuel Huntington in his book *Clash of Civilizations* .
- The India–China war, the India–Pakistan wars, Doklam, surgical strikes — these are not class struggles . They are ethnic struggles or nation-state struggles . Not even religious struggles: it is not Buddhism fighting Hinduism, or Confucianism and Taoism fighting Sikhism or Islam .
 - And ethnicity cuts across the nation: if I trace my blood ancestry to Lahore, then a connection with that side exists for me . On the lines of nation they are divided; on the lines of ethnicity they are united .

How the world we live in was actually produced

- The world history we are part of today is not the result of class struggle . We adopted a socialist pattern of society only because of the World War .

- After the World War the world was divided into two blocs — capitalist and communist — and Nehru had to choose one flavour, and chose the one that seemed better and closer .
- So what we have is Fabian socialism — which is nothing but democratic socialism . Both are one and the same; Fabian is a British term, there is no difference between them .
 - How democratic socialism differs from Marxian socialism you already know: democracy is there; the state will be there forever, not only until inequalities are removed; and we achieved socialism not through violent struggle by overthrowing the bourgeoisie .

QUICK REVISION

- Giddens, *A Contemporary Critique of Historical Materialism*: no universal formula that history evolves through class struggle .
- Class struggle is only one struggle among many; partition and the World Wars are not class conflicts .
- Fault line conflict — conflict along ethnic and religious lines — is Samuel Huntington's concept from *Clash of Civilizations* .
- Ethnicity is a cultural identity: son-of-the-soil movements produce insiders and outsiders, not bourgeoisie and proletariat .
- India's socialist pattern came from the post-war bloc choice, not from class struggle: Fabian = democratic socialism .

6.5.11 Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe

- Ernesto Laclau and Chantal Mouffe say that it is not important to predict what will happen in the future — as Marx predicts that socialism is inevitable and will come with the demise of capitalism .
- Instead of predicting the future and presenting yourself as a prophet, we should rather be interested in studying why some revolutions are happening only in some places .
 - Why are feminist revolutions happening in some places and not in others? Why did the civil rights movement happen in some places and not others? Why do environmental movements happen in some places and not others?
- This is what sociologists should study: why movements are localised and not universal . Marx says workers of the world unite — but why did workers unite only in a few pockets of the world and not the world over? What prevents them from uniting?

Their three points

1. For every revolution to happen, there has to be a discourse — and it has to be a democratic discourse

- Very important line: for every revolution to happen there has to be a discourse, and the discourse has to be a democratic discourse .
 - Before the 1700s, the relation between man and woman, and the subordination of women, was seen as normal . It was very normal for a woman to obey the man; there was no question about it at all . If in the 1700s you had talked about feminism, that would have been a problem .

- But now you can easily speak as a feminist on social media or anywhere you want — because we have the discourse available . The discourse of gender equality exists; there is a widely accepted notion that women and men are equal, and that equality of opportunity should be given irrespective of sex . And if a democratic discourse is not available, revolutions will not happen .
- And when the democratic discourse is there, there is no need to bring forward a violent revolution . People will write editorials; students will make notes of them and reproduce them; some will clear the civil services writing essays on them; and then an officer will bring that change in her district . It happens peacefully, through the democratic process .

2. *Revolutions are not limited to class struggle*

- We have movements related to environmental rights, human rights, women's rights, civil rights, and racial and ethnic movements . We have LGBT and sexual-identity movements .
- We have movements on the lines of every identity you can think of — sexual identity, women's identity, ecological and eco-feminist and environmental movements . So we have multiple kinds of movements and multiple kinds of struggles . It is not just class struggle and capitalism that everybody is concerned with — capitalism is just one thing .

3. *Do empirical study instead of prediction*

- Instead of making predictions about the future of history or the end of history, the job of a sociologist should be to conduct empirical study on why revolutions happened in a few pockets and why they did not happen in others .
 - For example: why did feminism develop in Europe and not in India? And how is feminism in India different from feminism in Europe? This is what sociologists should study — instead of making predictions .

QUICK REVISION

- Laclau and Mouffe: study why revolutions are localised rather than predicting an inevitable future .
- Condition for revolution: an available democratic discourse — feminism before the 1700s was unsayable; today it is ordinary .
- Where democratic discourse exists, change comes peacefully rather than through violent revolution .
- Revolutions are not limited to class: environmental, human rights, women's, civil rights, racial, ethnic, LGBT movements .
- The sociologist's job is empirical study of where movements do and do not occur .

6.5.12 *Jürgen Habermas — Legitimation Crisis*

- Jürgen Habermas is still alive; he is a second-generation neo-Marxist belonging to critical theory .
- He says: I am surprised that capitalism is still alive — despite the World Wars, the rise and fall of fascism and Nazism, the crash of Wall Street in 1929, the Great Depression of 1930, the

subprime crisis of 2008, the Occupy Wall Street movement, and the lockdown . Why does this wall not fall?

- The teacher's own aside: it is not a very great answer — but the biggest answers come only from the biggest questions .

His answer

KEY CONCEPT

The problem is that today the state will never let capitalism fall . What we have today, in the name of capitalism, is state-regulated late capitalism .

- Whenever the economy goes through a bust, the state will help and come to the rescue — the state will help the private player . This is what happened in the United States, where money was doled out even for people employed privately, and in India as well .

How the discontent gets redirected

- When the state is regulating late-capitalist societies and the economy goes through a depression period, people will not criticise the owners of these private companies . People will criticise the government .
 - If you lose your job after a lockdown, whom will you abuse — the owner of your company, or the government? The owner was sitting at home and may not even know that you were removed — and yet you abuse the government on social media .
- So the discontent generated at the private place will be channelled towards the public sphere .
- And when you start abusing the state, the state gets confused . What should we do? Should we be concerned about the welfare rights of these people, or about the declining profits of those people — because those people are running us, and these people are voting us? The state is trapped .
- And this is known as legitimisation crisis, in the language of Habermas .

QUICK REVISION

- Habermas: second-generation critical theory; puzzled that capitalism survived every crisis of the last century .
- Answer: state-regulated late capitalism — the state rescues capital at every bust .
- Consequence: discontent generated in the private sphere is channelled into the public sphere; people blame the state, not the employer .
- The state, caught between welfare rights and declining profits, faces a legitimisation crisis .

6.5.13 Erik Olin Wright — Contradictory Class Location

- Erik Olin Wright has given the concept of contradictory class location .
- He says today we are living in finance capitalism, run by insurance conglomerates, stock markets, banks and mega banks — these are the agencies which are running capitalism . Money comes from these banks and insurance companies, and we are the shareholders of the big corporations .

The contradiction

- You are a proletarian in the company . The moment you go back home, you are a shareholder of that company — and as a shareholder you are an owner, holding a certain percentage of ownership .
- So you are owner and worker both . Are you bourgeoisie or proletariat? You cannot tell . At today's rate these are invalid concepts .
- The manager — if there was ever such a category between bourgeois and proletariat — is bourgeoisie in comparison to the proletariat, but proletariat in comparison to the bourgeoisie .
 - The manager acts like a bourgeois towards the worker: he gives commands and instructions, cuts his salary, writes a bad review . And the same manager acts like a worker in front of the bourgeoisie .
- The petty bourgeoisie — the shop owners, owners of small means of production — are bourgeoisie when they employ workers in their own shop, and the same is true of everyone acting as a proletarian in another company .
- So you would not be able to point at anyone and say “this is bourgeoisie” . There is no clear-cut line of distinction today in the era of finance capitalism .

QUICK REVISION

- Erik Olin Wright: contradictory class location, under finance capitalism run by banks, insurers and stock markets .
- The same person is worker by day and shareholder-owner at home .
- The manager is bourgeois downwards and proletarian upwards; the petty bourgeois is both at once .
- The bourgeois/proletariat line no longer holds cleanly .

6.5.14 Laclau and Mouffe Again — The Complexity of Identities

- Today we have a highly complex, diverse, fluid, globalised world . There are no clear-cut categories available, and therefore everybody has different concerns — as a member of a different nation, a different class, a different religion .
- And since all of them have different concerns, the struggles would also be different . Therefore it is not only economic class .
- There is not just an economic class: we have an environmental class, a sexual class, a religious class, an ethnic class — different classes . Not classes in the terms of Marx, but classes all the same — groups of people .
- When you have different concerns, how would you mobilise? How would you become a class for itself? And when this class is also divided across identity — upper caste, Black, white — it is not very easy for them to get united under one umbrella for a single cause .

QUICK REVISION

- A fluid, globalised world offers no clear-cut categories; concerns differ by nation, class and

religion .

- Environmental, sexual, religious and ethnic “classes” exist alongside the economic one .
- Cross-cutting identities make mobilisation under one umbrella extremely difficult — hence no class for itself .

6.5.15 *Pierre Bourdieu — Four Forms of Capital*

- Pierre Bourdieu says there are four forms of capital: economic capital, social capital, cultural capital and symbolic capital .
- When Marx talks about capital — volumes 1, 2, 3 — he is talking only about one form of capital: economic capital . And he believes that only because of this economic capital will we have struggle .
- But Bourdieu says we have multiple forms of capital in the world — and when we have multiple forms of capital, you cannot say that we will have only economic class struggle .
- This is known as convertibility of capital — you have converted your contacts into wealth .

EXAMPLE

- If you are the son or daughter of a senior civil service officer, there are very high chances that you will clear the civil services . Not because of any eligibility criterion — but because you have cultural capital .
- You have been trained; you have been seeing those things since childhood; the programmes watched at home, the clubs visited, the way of speaking and writing are all different . These are accumulated advantages gained purely by virtue of being born into that family — and they can be exchanged for social capital and then for economic capital .
- On symbolic capital: a very elite, sophisticated professor speaking elegantly — whatever she says seems right and everyone notes it down . There are many millionaires and billionaires, but only a few of them have symbolic capital; it is highly exceptional .
- Caution: these are forms of capital, not forms of capitalism . There is no such thing as “symbolic capitalism” .
- Bourdieu’s argument: humans have multiple forms of capital, and each form of capital can be exchanged for any other form . Ultimately anybody can become an owner of the means of production that way . Economic class is not the single group or identity in the world — class is not only economic .

QUICK REVISION

- Four forms of capital: economic, social, cultural, symbolic .
- Social = contacts; cultural = education, accent, demeanour, taste; symbolic = aura and power, the outcome of all the others .
- Convertibility of capital: each form converts into another, ending in economic capital .
- The officer’s child clears the exam through inherited cultural capital, not eligibility .

- Because class is not only economic, class struggle cannot be only economic .

6.5.16 *Why Capitalism Sustained Itself — Gramsci and Digital Capitalism*

If the question is asked — why did the revolution never occur, and why has capitalism sustained itself — these are the scholars you can write about .

- Laclau and Mouffe — localised movements, multiple identities, no single class subject .
- Jürgen Habermas — state-regulated late capitalism and the legitimation crisis .
- Adorno and Horkheimer of critical theory — the cultural industry producing cultural goods which have nullified our consciousness . We have become consumerists; we consume these goods, we like these goods, these are false needs, and we do not realise it . We chase them and are now in a vicious trap . When you are in the habit of watching these things or buying these commodities, you would never think about bringing a revolution — in fact, if someone discusses revolution with you, you may even start considering him an idiot .

Antonio Gramsci and cultural hegemony

- Antonio Gramsci's writing had a very great influence on the development of critical theory . Adorno and Horkheimer are part of critical theory, and Habermas is the extension of that, although his own account of why the revolution did not come is quite different .
- Gramsci asks: what is the meaning of success today? For all of us, the meaning of success is to have wealth, to speak good English, to have a good community, to have great social capital and good contacts .
- And how did you come to know that this is what success is? Because this is what you have been studying, watching, listening to and reading — every single time .
- That means education, media, the state and laws — all these institutions and their dominant ideas — have made those dominant ideas of material success into common sense to you .
 - You see the biggest industrialists photographed with heads of government, and administrative officers photographed with them, so you start thinking that to be successful you must become either an industrialist or an officer . The state advertises this: these are the people who are celebrated; education is what you do to get in there; English is what you learn to be a global, cosmopolitan citizen — and it is also, today, the meaning of success .

KEY CONCEPT

Gramsci: when the ideas or the ideologies of the dominant sections of society become common sense to the members, they have become victims of cultural hegemony .

- Line to write: cultural hegemony is when the dominant notions and ideas — of leisure, of entertainment, of success, of good education, of status — become common sense to the members of society .
- Example: ask someone their hobby and they say they play marbles — a two-rupee game . And you laugh at that person, and tell him to study, or to become like us and watch the video sites and streaming platforms instead . Basically you are telling him to accept the dominant notion of entertainment, to become like us — the victims of cultural hegemony — and never to dare

to think beyond it .

- When cultural hegemony is established, there is no scope for revolution . Everybody would be involved in speaking good English, making a lot of wealth, having good status and lounging away their time with the great ones . There would be no time and no discourse of revolution . Nobody would find that they are exploited, because they have been brainwashed through media, education and the state as institutions .

Ursula Huws — i-capitalism / digital capitalism

- Capitalism has matured a lot — we have multiple forms of capitalism now . One of them is i-capitalism, that is, digital capitalism, given by the scholar Ursula Huws .
- When we are sitting on the internet updating our status, or watching anything, what is happening is that we are working for those companies . We are giving them our data; we are telling them what our likes are .
 - You tell the video platform the kind of videos you like; therefore from the next day it starts giving recommendations of that same type . So you become more and more of a consumer, and you are very happy with the platform .
- You think that you are having a time pass, that you are having leisure, that you are having fun . But Ursula Huws is saying that is also work that you are doing — and you are not able to realise it . You are in false consciousness . You do not think that it is work .
- Remember: proletariat give labour power, and labour power gives surplus . Today social media users give their so-called intellectual and leisure time, and that generates surplus . So at the end of the day surplus is accumulated in both ways — either by working, or by having leisure and intellectual time .

CRITICAL POINT

- These may be proletariat, but these are cyber-tariats — who do not even realise that they are working . They think they are having fun .
- This is false consciousness at its peak . Earlier people at least knew that they were working; today they do not even know that they are working .

QUICK REVISION

- Why capitalism survived: Laclau and Mouffe, Habermas, Adorno and Horkheimer's cultural industry, Gramsci, Huws .
- Gramsci: cultural hegemony = the dominant sections' ideas of success, leisure and status becoming common sense, transmitted by education, media, state and law .
- With hegemony established, there is neither time nor discourse for revolution .
- Ursula Huws: i-capitalism / digital capitalism — leisure online is unpaid work, generating surplus through data .
- The cyber-tariat does not even know it is working — false consciousness at its peak .

6.5.17 *Final Doubts*

Wage for housework

- A separate debate — it would take about 45 minutes to conclude, and is covered under work and economy . The prior question is: what do we call work? How do we measure and categorise something as work?
 - One economist argues that even filling in application forms for examinations is work — because when you do the same thing in an office you get paid for it . When you register as an applicant you are telling the state that you want to sit this exam and want to be a member of the bureaucracy, and you are giving your time and your labour . Some people give ten years to the exam — very precious years, in fact more precious than the years they will later spend working .

What does “dominant discourse” mean?

- Discourse means the way you speak . The dominant discourse today is equality — and therefore LGBT persons can speak out, voice their concerns and protest against the state for not letting them have the tag of marriage .
- Marriage as an institution has been hijacked, usurped and appropriated by heterosexuals — as if marriage is the private property of heterosexuals and homosexuals cannot have it .
 - You will see Marxist ideologies and discourse everywhere . The way that scholar speaks is very much similar to what Marx would have said about the economic classes and about the oppression of the proletariats .

False consciousness — one line

- False consciousness simply means that we do not realise that we are exploited .

How can we convert symbolic capital into economic capital?

- These are forms of capital, not forms of capitalism — there is no “symbolic capitalism” .
- Symbolic capital is an outcome of all the capitals . Once you have accumulated cultural capital and economic capital, then you gain symbolic capital . There are many millionaires and billionaires, but only a few billionaires have symbolic capital which the others do not . It cannot be shown objectively — but symbolic capital is possessed by very few people; it is highly exceptional .

Why does the Chinese party keep the communist tag and not the socialist tag?

- China and Russia are both run by communist parties, but they call their states socialist states .
- They are not going to call their state a communist state, because “communist state” is an oxymoron . The two words cannot be put together — there cannot be a dark day or a bright night . It should be communist society .
- Since they know it is not a communist society, they use the term socialist state . The communist party rules, and capitalism is the form of economy they have been following for a long time — it is not new to their economy .

Why can we not compare Marxian socialism with the socialism of Russia and China?

- In Marxian socialism the state is a temporary body: the state will distribute everything, and once everything is done it will wither away .
- In Russia and China the state has become the end . There is no alternative beyond the state socialism they follow .
- Hence the term state socialism — state and socialism always staying together . The state will never wither away .

Did Marx know he was a sociologist?

- Marx did not know that he was a sociologist, because at that point of time there was no department of sociology .
- And he was never writing like a philosopher, an economist, a political scientist or a sociologist — because he is everything . He is like a Renaissance man . Look him up and you will see all the labels: political philosopher, political scientist, lawyer, economist, sociologist .
 - The same is true of Ambedkar — you cannot say he was a sociologist, or a historian; he was all of it .

Restating Lenin's position

- Nobody can criticise Marx — that has to be understood first . Lenin is simply saying one thing: you cannot mobilise the classes against the oppressor — whoever that oppressor may be, a landlord in feudal society or the bourgeoisie in capitalism — unless you have a political party .
 1. The political party will impart consciousness among those people who are exploited .
 2. The political party will tell the people how they are exploited .
 3. The political party will publish journals, newspapers and editorials to educate them on how they are exploited .
 4. And when they are finally convinced that they are exploited, these convinced people will be mobilised against the oppressors . That is what Lenin did — he formed the Vanguard Party .
- Marx never said to form a political party . Marx said class in itself will automatically become class for itself with homogenisation, monopolisation and depression [as stated in lecture; earlier delivered as pauperisation] . Was there any fourth condition of a political party? No .
- Lenin says all of that will not be enough — ultimately you will have to build a political party to impart consciousness among these people . That is why the philosophy is called Marxist–Leninist: “Leninist” means the agenda of the political party has now been added, which Marx never proposed .
- In fact Marx did not believe in democratic instruments like a political party . He believed democracy is a bourgeois ideology — false consciousness, telling us equality, equality, so that revolution never comes .

QUICK REVISION

- Wage for housework turns on the prior question of what counts as work at all .
- Dominant discourse = equality; hence the claim that marriage has been appropriated as the

private property of heterosexuals .

- False consciousness = not realising that we are exploited .
- Symbolic capital is the outcome of all other capitals and is possessed by very few .
- “Communist state” is an oxymoron; hence socialist state + communist party + capitalist economy .
- Marxian socialism: the state is temporary . Russia and China: state socialism, where the state is the end .
- Marx was a Renaissance man, not a sociologist by self-description .
- Lenin adds the political party as the vehicle of consciousness; Marx rejected the party, holding democracy to be a bourgeois ideology .

6.6 Answer-Writing Toolkit

Every item below was stated by the teacher across the five classes as guidance for writing answers . Nothing here has been added from outside the lectures .

6.6.1 *The Standard of Understanding an Answer Must Reflect*

- Can you explain the concept in simple language in two minutes to someone with no background — a parent, or a rickshaw puller? If yes, your understanding is at the required level .
- Explain the essence and the meaning of the term — not the features .
- Once understanding is secure, revision is only for keywords and facts, and takes very little time .
- Whatever you struggle to articulate, scribble down — that becomes your own mind map, and you refer to it before handouts or class .

6.6.2 *Examples are Compulsory*

- Whenever you study anything theoretical, always look out for examples .
- Unless you have examples in your head to justify what you have written in theory, the answer will not reflect the level of understanding expected from a candidate .
- The examiner can only know you have understanding when you write examples . Without them you are not showing your true potential .

6.6.3 *Managing Time in the Paper*

- Time is lost in the thinking process — typically 20–30 minutes across the paper, in fragments .
- The cause is either lack of revision or, more often, lack of understanding of what you are revising .
- Leaving one or two questions is acceptable at the start; leaving four points to a problem with writing speed or with the thinking process .
- Questions will always be new — the examination does not repeat questions . Memorisation is

not what is being tested .

6.6.4 *Handling the Previous-Year Question Flagged in Class*

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

- PYQ: “Is non-positivist methodology scientific?” — deferred to Unit 4 in class, but unanswerable unless you know what “scientific” means .
- If you know non-positivism but assume positivism = science, you will wrongly conclude that non-positivism is not science .
- The question is very basic — and basic questions are the toughest .

The method demonstrated on “higher unemployment is the source of higher crime rate”

1. Identify the type of statement: objective, cause–effect, testable → a positivist proposition . A phenomenologist would never make it: for phenomenology there are multiple causes behind multiple effects and objectivity is an illusion .
2. Note that Marxism would also reject it, because to Marx the owning, ruling class is the criminal class — so defining crime as working-class crime is not Marxist .
3. Establish that scientific = testable = falsifiable, not “true” .
4. Think about possibilities beyond the given statement . You do not have to quote data or reports . If $A \rightarrow B$ is falsifiable, what else could lead to B — C, D, E?

6.6.5 *Lines the Teacher Dictated to be Written Down Verbatim*

- The theory of historical materialism reflects how societies develop class characters, and how the relations of production between these classes are justified by the forms of consciousness — that is, the superstructure .
- All modes of production developed as a result of inherent contradictions in the previous modes of production, which were the result of the contradiction between relations of production and means of production .
- Class is a group of people having similar relations to the means of production .
- The value of commodity = $C + V + S$. Rate of exploitation = S/V = unpaid labour/paid labour .
- Constant capital does not add any value to the commodity; it is the variable capital that adds all the value .
- Absolute surplus value is generated by increasing the length of the working day, and by tight monitoring or surveillance . However, the length of the working day cannot be increased beyond a point, due to labour laws and human rights .
- Relative surplus value is achieved by increasing the productivity of the labour and the introduction of machines .
- The industrial reserve army consists of a pool of both the unemployed who want to work, and the underemployed .
- Commodity fetishism is the result of actors failing to realise that the commodity is the creation of labour .

- The law of motion reveals the inherent contradictions within capitalism, and describes the mechanism of the inherent contradiction .
- The members of class in itself are the victims of false consciousness . False consciousness develops when the degree of exploitation is not realised by the worker .
- The only reason why class in itself has not yet become class for itself is the prevalence of false consciousness perpetuated by the superstructure .
- Alienation is the social breakdown of the natural interconnectedness between the worker and his produce, and between the worker and the production relations .
- Marx's analysis of capitalism and of alienation was limited to the manual working class — blue-collar workers . C. Wright Mills discussed alienation among non-manual, white-collar workers .
- Instead of categorising the working class as victims of alienation, the job of a social scientist should be to see what meaning they attach to their work (Goldthorpe and Lockwood) .
- Cultural hegemony is when the dominant notions and ideas — of leisure, entertainment, success, education and status — become common sense to the members of society (Gramsci) .

6.6.6 Terminology Cautions

- Use infrastructure, not “economic base”, when pairing with superstructure — “economic base” is general language, right but technically not sound .
- Do not confuse means of production with mode of production . Write MOP in capitals for Mode of Production and means of production in small letters .
- Forces of production = means of production — the difference is only one of translation; use them interchangeably .
- Do not say “pure capitalism” — the term is pure communism .
- Never list the Asiatic mode of production with the four main modes — thin literature, and Marx never wrote extensively on it .
- Bourgeoisie is a noun; bourgeois is the adjective .
- Four forms of capital, not forms of capitalism — there is no “symbolic capitalism” (Bourdieu) .
- “Communist state” is an oxymoron — the correct pairing is communist society, or socialist state ruled by a communist party .
- Pauper, not Popper — pauperisation comes from pauper, meaning poor .

6.6.7 Strategy Notes

- The syllabus sits at BA honours level — between BA and MA . Some recent questions come from MA-level areas .
- Do not chase books for the one MA-level question out of twenty; you may lose the larger picture of the nineteen you are supposed to do . There is choice in the paper .
- No scholar should be your favourite . You cannot afford to be in love with one scholar .
- There are hundreds of critics of every thinker; limits have to be set on how many scholars you carry .
- Note-making method is your own choice — device or notebook . Devices allow editing and

additions later; there is no single recommended method .

6.6.8 *Ready-Made Answer Frames from These Classes*

- “Why has the revolution not occurred / why has capitalism sustained itself?” → false consciousness perpetuated by the superstructure; Laclau and Mouffe on localised movements and multiple identities; Habermas on state-regulated late capitalism and the legitimisation crisis; Adorno and Horkheimer on the cultural industry; Gramsci on cultural hegemony; Ursula Huws on digital capitalism and the cyber-tariat .
- “Is Marxism a science?” → the Popper problem stated in class: happy = false consciousness, unhappy = alienation; if it cannot be proven wrong, it is not science .
- “Criticism of alienation” → Weber (rationalisation and impersonality); Blauner (relative, operationalised in four dimensions, inverted U-curve); Goldthorpe and Lockwood (meanings attached to work); C. Wright Mills (white-collar); Gorz and Marcuse (leisure); de Beauvoir and Hochschild (women, emotional labour) . Note that most of these are applications, not criticisms .
- “Criticism of class in itself / class for itself” → Lenin (Vanguard Party as a fourth prerequisite); Erik Olin Wright (contradictory class location); Bourdieu (four forms of capital); Laclau and Mouffe (fragmented identities) .
- “Criticism of the mode of production and scientific socialism” → Giddens (no universal formula, other struggles); Huntington (fault line conflict); the empirical jump from feudalism to socialism in Russia and China; Lynette Ong on China; Galbraith; Fukuyama .
- History vs sociology question → Marxism was a response to the Industrial Revolution; sociology is rootless without history, but history is fruitless without sociology . Origins of patriarchy, private property and class inequality are all historical sociology .

Statement	Scientific?	Why
“Yesterday Santa Claus came to my room and gave me this gift.”	No	It cannot be tested. Here nonsense and untestability happen to coincide. Saying “many people report Santa gifting them things” is only verification, not a test in Popper’s sense — you cannot think of a condition that would falsify it.
“There is one planet between the Sun and Venus.”	Yes	Not because you already know Mercury is there. It is scientific because it has the power to be proven wrong: go and look; if no planet is seen, the statement had the capacity to be falsified. If a planet is seen, it was tested right — but the condition of being provable wrong existed in the first place.

Society	Classes
Primitive society	Classless
Ancient society	Master and slaves
Feudal society	Lords and serfs
Capitalist society	Bourgeoisie and proletariat

	Use value	Exchange value
What it is	The services rendered for yourself or for your own needs, not for anyone else	The same services sold to someone else for money
What it reflects	Fulfilment of human need per se	Commercial gain obtained by selling the commodity
Name of the labour	Labour	Labour power

Term	Definition	What it consists of
C — Constant capital	The capital required to produce the commodity. “Constant” means it is not changing, not dynamic — it is static.	Machines and tools — the machine out of which shoes or phones are produced
V — Variable capital	The labour power. Not machines and tools, but you — the labourer who gave his or her labour power to the company in exchange for money.	The worker’s labour power
S — Surplus value	The higher chunk that the capitalist class appropriated — the difference between the value of wage and the value of capital.	Rs. 4.7 lakh in the running example; Rs. 9.7 lakh in the larger one

The same thing...	... as use value	... as exchange value
Your smile	Greeting guests at home — “hello uncle, hello auntie, how are you?” The need being satisfied is respect for elders and guests.	Smiling in a shopping mall greeting customers — “hello sir, how may I help you?” The customer is impressed by the service and buys; your smile has generated revenue for the company.
Noodles you cook	Making them for your brother or sister at home.	Making them for paying customers.
Your sense of humour	Recalling old stories and cracking jokes so your friends laugh.	Making an audience laugh.
Your car	You decide where to go and where to stop over.	You rent it out to a ride-hailing platform.
Your house	You sit in your room, study, talk to friends.	You rent it out to students or list it on a home-sharing platform.

	Absolute surplus value	Relative surplus value
Method	Increase the length of the working day; plus tight monitoring and surveillance of workers	Reduce the necessary labour time by increasing the productivity of labour and introducing machines
Effect on the 8-hour day	Stretch 8 hours to 10, 12, 16	Keep 8 hours; push V down from 3 hours to 2, so S rises from 5 to 6
Constraint	Blocked by labour laws, the Factory Act, the welfare state, unions and human rights	Not blocked — but it is what eventually destroys capitalism

Mode of production	What happens to expression
Primitive communism	Full control over what to produce; species being at its extreme potential; free to create, hunt, paint, carve
Ancient / slave society	The moment you become a slave you are not free; you do what the master tells you. You are not even free to have a child; what you do and for how many hours is decided by the master. The first society in which a human being became the private property of another human being — and private property cannot be expressive or creative
Feudal society	Serfs were not free to produce what they wanted; they produced what they were asked to produce — indigo, because the colonial planters wanted indigo. How much they got for the produce was also decided by the lords. No power over what or how much is produced
Capitalist society	The proletariat is the worst — worse than serfs, worse than slaves — because the relation between humans has turned into a relation between things

Strand	Which statement they follow	Position on revolution
Orthodox Marxists	Inherent contradictions will inevitably collapse capitalism	Revolution is inevitable
Hegelian Marxists	“Workers of the world, unite — you have nothing to lose but chains”	Revolution is not inevitable — the working class will have to overthrow the capitalists; they will have to do something

	Marxist / scientific socialism	Democratic socialism
Role of the state	The state is simply an instrument that will achieve equality	The state is not the instrument — the state is the end
Fate of the state	Once equality is achieved the state withers away	The state is there to stay forever
What is equally important	Only the economic transformation	Both democracy and socialism are equally important

	Two hundred years back	Today
Exercise	After half an hour of jogging you used to feel fresh	After half an hour of jogging you check how many calories you have burnt
Greeting	You would greet people — “hello, how are you?”	You would rate them — 3 out of 10, 4 out of 10
Education	Qualitative — theological and religious education	Quantifiable — what percentage did you get in class 11 and 12; a numbered curriculum from class 1 to 12

	Marxism	Marxism–Leninism
Born from	The factories	The agrarian land
Class concerned	The industrial working class of the Industrial Revolution	The peasants of an agrarian society
Consciousness	Will develop by itself — it is inevitable; no external agency needed	Must be imparted by an external political party — nothing happens unless we act upon it
Political party	Marx never believed in establishing one; he held democracy to be a bourgeois ideology	The Vanguard Party is the essential addition

	Use value of women	Exchange value of women
What it is	Services that are useful but not traded for money — the caring services: caring for the child, looking after the elderly, waiting for the husband, cooking food for the family	The woman acquires exchange value on the occasion of marriage — she is exchanged for two things: money and marriage
Charge	She is not charging anything for these services	The exchange market: bride price, dowry, trafficking, the trophy wife

Form of capital	What it is	How it converts
Economic	Ownership of the means of production; wealth	The endpoint the other three are converted into
Social	Your contacts — you know politicians and bureaucrats, you sit with them in a club every weekend	With contacts it is not a difficult task to become a millionaire — social capital can be exchanged for economic capital
Cultural	Your education, qualification, the way you speak, language, accent, the way you carry yourself, the clothes you put on	A certain demeanour and good qualification make it easier to establish contacts — cultural capital converts into social, then into economic
Symbolic	Power — aura, charisma. Some people you cannot speak in front of when you first confront them	An outcome of all the capitals: once you have accumulated the others, you gain symbolic capital

Marx, Durkheim and Max Weber: PYQ Approach and Weberian Methodology

7.1 Marx and Durkheim: Previous Year Questions and Answer-Writing Approach

This lecture sequence is devoted to previous year questions of both Karl Marx and Émile Durkheim, preceded by an examination of contemporary variants of Marxism . The debate on whether Marxism remains relevant today is extensive: numerous arguments demonstrate why Marxism might be considered obsolete, while equally robust arguments affirm its enduring analytical power . In a competitive examination setting, however, where an answer is strictly capped at approximately 250 words (or 150 words for a 10-mark question), candidates cannot enter into the full scope of this philosophical dispute and must master structured, dimension-dense presentation .

7.1.1 *Surveillance Capitalism — Shoshana Zuboff*

Building upon the analysis of high capitalism (as formulated by Ursula Huws), contemporary sociology incorporates the framework of **surveillance capitalism**, formulated by Shoshana Zuboff . These conceptual variants extend beyond Marxian theory alone; they provide critical analytical value across subsequent units, including work, economic life, and social stratification .

KEY CONCEPT

- Marx posited that expanding human needs and desires drive continuous technological advancement; this technological development creates new social classes and fundamentally transforms the relations of production .
- As technological advancement occurs, society bifurcates into those who own or monopolise that technology and those who become dependent upon it — generating structural exploitation .
- Shoshana Zuboff builds directly upon this foundational proposition, arguing that modern digital technology has evolved into an undemocratic apparatus that poses a direct threat to democratic institutions and human freedom .
- Technology systematically strips individuals of free will, hampers human creativity, and subverts individual autonomy .
- Digital systems condition and direct what individuals think; consequently, genuine democracy — which rests upon autonomy, free will, equality, and uncoerced freedom of speech and expression — is fundamentally undermined .

Digital space and social media platforms are engineered and monopolised by big tech corporations . Platforms prompt users with queries such as “what’s on your mind”, capturing subjective states, while e-commerce algorithms anticipate personal desires . Personal computing hardware and mobile devices create structural dependency, rendering modern life unthinkable outside their infrastructure .

EXAMPLE

- Digital footprints — desires, ideas, cultural preferences, music streams, consumer choices, partner selection and matrimonial preferences, and search queries — are comprehensively recorded, aggregated, processed, behavioural-modelled, and monetised .
- **Big Data as Big Business:** User data is extracted as raw behavioural material and converted into predictive commodities for corporate profit .
- Geolocation monitoring generates immediate consumer prompts (e.g., feedback queries upon exiting a shopping mall); individual privacy is subject to perpetual surveillance .

Because human cognition, consumption, geolocation, and physical habits are continuously monitored, individual privacy is eliminated, compromising constitutional democratic rights . Capitalism has assumed a surveillance orientation: it no longer merely supplies physical commodities in the marketplace, but actively fabricates and directs the internal desires of consumers .

QUICK REVISION

- **Surveillance Capitalism** (Shoshana Zuboff): Extends Marx’s thesis on technology → emergent class divisions → exploitation .
- **Core Premise:** Technology has become an undemocratic instrument threatening free will, human autonomy, and constitutional democracy .
- **Mechanism:** Ubiquitous behavioural tracking transforms human experience into Big Data, packaged and commercialised by corporate tech monopolies .
- **Shift:** Capitalism transitions from merely manufacturing commodities to manufacturing subjective human desire .
- **Parallel Formulation:** High capitalism (Ursula Huws) .

7.1.2 Directives, Dimensions and the Universal Answer Structure

Examination directives — such as “critically assess”, “elucidate”, “describe”, “elaborate”, “critically analyse”, “do you agree”, and “critically examine” — require a unified structural approach . A competitive examination demands the coverage of **maximum analytical dimensions in minimum time** . Regardless of the directive, the substantive core of a high-scoring answer remains stable; a multi-dimensional body satisfies the academic requirements of all directives .

CRITICAL POINT

- Content is dictated by thematic dimensions rather than the directive term alone .
- Marks are lost when candidates fail to deconstruct indirect, non-linear (“ghuma kar”) question framings .

- Final evaluation depends strictly on conceptual clarity, dimensional breadth, and precise comprehension of the core proposition .

The Universal Seven-Step Body

1. **Definition:** Establish the foundational conceptual definition immediately; never bypass the formal definition .
2. **Presentation:** Incorporate a clear conceptual diagram or flow chart to structure information efficiently .
3. **Typology or Classification:** Provide formal categorical breakdowns where applicable .
4. **Empirical Illustrations:** Integrate relevant real-world and sociological examples .
5. **Counter-Perspective / Critique:** Systematically articulate theoretical criticisms and alternate perspectives .
6. **Applied Administration / Policy Context (Optional):** Connect organically to governance, administrative realities, Indian public policy, or statutory schemes without artificial force-fitting .
7. **Balanced Conclusion:** Synthesise the arguments through contemporary sociological relevance or a balanced theoretical summation .

CRITICAL POINT

- Flow charts and schematics are presentation tools, not ends in themselves; forced diagrams consume critical exam time without adding value .
- Schematics must be pre-planned and memorised prior to the examination rather than invented spontaneously in the examination hall .
- The commodification of “diagram templates” in exam preparation exemplifies **commodity fetishism**: human expression is alienated from the individual and fetishised as an external, marketable commodity .

Structural Flexibility and Word Limits Point format and continuous paragraph format possess equal academic validity . Candidates may combine tabular classifications with analytical prose, or structure points followed by explanatory paragraphs .

DATA & FACTS

- **20-Mark Requirement:** Target approximately 250 words (ranging practically between 220 and 280 words) .
- **Page Allocation:** Answer booklets provide 3 to 4 pages strictly to accommodate variations in individual handwriting size, not as a target volume to be filled .
- Quality is determined by dimensional density and conceptual precision, not spatial exhaustion .

EXAMPLE

High-ranking candidates (such as an allocated IPS officer and an All India Rank 19 candidate) consistently cleared the examination writing succinct, dimension-focused answers of approximately 2.5 pages within 4-page answer spaces, prioritizing conceptual completeness over descriptive padding .

QUICK REVISION

- **Core Strategy:** Maximum analytical dimensions within minimum time .
- **Universal Seven Steps:** Definition → Presentation/Diagram → Typology → Examples → Counter/Critique → Administrative/Policy Linkage → Balanced Conclusion .
- **Format:** Paragraphs and bullet points are equally valid .
- **Spatial Discipline:** 250 words for 20 marks; avoid artificial page-filling .

7.1.3 PYQ: Critically Assess the Marxian Theory of Alienation**PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**

Question: Critically assess the Marxian theory of alienation. (10 Marks / 20 Marks — 250 Words)

Step-by-Step Answer Structure

1. **Definition:** Alienation (*Entfremdung*) is the social and structural breakdown of the natural interconnectedness between the producer and their produce, the production process, fellow workers, and their human species-being .
2. **Historical Trajectory (Diagram):**

Primitive Communism → Ancient Society → Feudal Society → Capitalist Society

Primitive communism embodies the optimum realization of species-being (creative self-expression) . As historical modes of production advance, species-being is progressively compromised, reaching peak alienation under capitalism .
3. **Scope of Alienation:** Alienation encompasses both the proletariat and the bourgeoisie, though Marx concentrated primarily on the working class .
4. **Four Dimensions of Alienation:**
 - Alienation from the *product* of labour .
 - Alienation from the *process/act* of production .
 - Alienation from *fellow workers / social relations* .
 - Alienation from *species-being (human creative potential)* .
5. **Integration of Commodity Fetishism:** Highlight alienation from the product as the foundation for the fetishism of commodities, where dead labour dominates living labour .
6. **Marxian Solutions:** Reduction in the length of the working day, followed by the revolutionary dismantling of private property through communism .
7. **Counter-Critique (“However”):**

- Under contemporary capitalism, leisure itself is commodified and manufactured, leading to alienation from leisure (André Gorz, Herbert Marcuse) .
- In the post-industrial service economy, white-collar workers suffer distinct psychological alienation .

8. Additional Theoretical Dimensions:

- **Emotional Labour:** Arlie Hochschild demonstrates that alienation in service economies extends to the commercialisation of human emotions .
- **Feminist Critique:** Simone de Beauvoir highlights institutional alienation of women from their existential human potential .
- **Industrial Variation:** Robert Blauner argues alienation is not uniform but varies across technology levels (craft, machine, assembly-line, automated continuous-process) .
- **Bureaucratic Alienation:** Max Weber highlights alienation within bureaucratic hierarchies .

9. Applied Policy Conclusion: Link to welfare initiatives and institutional mechanisms aimed at overcoming structural alienation .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

- **Startup India:** Policy framework providing initial capital and liquidity, enabling workers to transition into self-directed enterprise .
- **Stand Up India:** Targeted credit delivery to unlock the entrepreneurial potential of women, Scheduled Castes, and Scheduled Tribes .
- **Targeted Skill and Livelihood Schemes:** Programmes such as USTTAD, Nai Manzil, and Seekho Aur Kamao aimed at empowering socio-economic minorities .

QUICK REVISION

- **Definition:** Breakdown of natural interconnectedness between producer, produce, process, and species-being .
- **Historical Arc:** Peak alienation under industrial capitalism vs. optimum species-being in primitive communism .
- **Four Dimensions:** Product, Process, Fellow Workers, Species-Being .
- **Solutions:** Reduction of working day; abolition of private property via communism .
- **Critiques & Extensions:** Alienated leisure (Gorz, Marcuse); Emotional labour (Hochschild); Industrial variation (Blauner); Bureaucratic alienation (Weber); State entrepreneurship schemes (Startup India) .

7.1.4 PYQ: What is the Marxist Concept of Fetishism of Commodities?

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question: What is the Marxist concept of fetishism of commodities?

Primary Analytical Approach

1. **Definition of Fetishism:** In anthropological and religious studies, fetishism refers to belief systems wherein inanimate, mystical objects are perceived to possess independent, magical powers over human actors .
2. **Commodity Fetishism in Marx:** In capitalist production, human labour-power crystallises into commodities . The social relations between individual producers assume the fantastic form of a material relation between inanimate things . Commodities appear as self-governing entities endowed with intrinsic value, while producers remain unaware that market value represents congealed, dead labour .
3. **Empirical Example:** High-technology consumer goods (e.g., premium smartphones) possess market valuations and social prestige completely detached from the physical labour costs of production .
4. **Extension to Cultural Goods (Frankfurt School):** Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer argue that the “culture industry” commodifies cultural artefacts (pop music, mass media, standardised web series), manufacturing false needs and alienating consumers through standardised entertainment .
5. **Theoretical Elevation to Reification (György Lukács):**

KEY CONCEPT

- György Lukács formulated the concept of **reification** by synthesising Feuerbach’s analysis of religion, Marx’s commodity fetishism, and Weberian rationalization .
- **Feuerbach:** God is a human creation externalised and endowed with supreme authority over human creators .
- **Marx:** Commodities are human products that assume objective market power over their makers .
- **Lukács:** Reification extends commodity fetishism across the entire social order: human-created social structures — such as the family, the nation-state, religious orthodoxies, and patriarchy — are perceived as immutable, natural, objective entities that exercise total domination over human consciousness .

Critical Evaluation and Feminist Counter-Perspective Marxist and Neo-Marxist structural frameworks risk reducing human actors to passive structural puppets devoid of transformative agency .

- **Nancy Hartsock (Feminist Standpoint Critique):** Analyzes the commodification of women under patriarchal capitalism (dowry systems, bride prices, transnational trafficking, sex-work networks) .
- **Wages for Housework Movement:** Articulates that uncompensated reproductive domestic labour is the foundational source of systemic surplus value extraction in capitalism .

Secondary Analytical Approach (Labour Theory of Value) Capitalism transforms qualitative use-value into quantified exchange-value .

DATA & FACTS

$$\text{Total Value of Commodity} = C + V + S \quad (7.1)$$

Where:

- C = Constant Capital (machinery, raw materials, dead labour) .
- V = Variable Capital (labour-power, wages paid) .
- S = Surplus Value (unpaid labour extracted by the capitalist) .

V (human labour) creates both C and S . The extraction of S relative to V defines the rate of exploitation ($\frac{S}{V}$), driving the illusion that capital generates wealth independently of living labour .

QUICK REVISION

- **Fetishism:** Attribution of autonomous, magical power to human creations .
- **Commodity Fetishism:** Social relations between human producers appear as objective relations between things; living labour dominated by dead capital .
- **Culture Industry:** Adorno & Horkheimer extend fetishism to commodified mass culture and media .
- **Reification:** Lukács extends commodity fetishism to social institutions (nation, family, state, patriarchy) .
- **Feminist Standpoint:** Nancy Hartsock (commodification of women, wages for domestic labour) .
- **Mathematical Formulation:** Value = $C + V + S$; surplus value extraction is the root of fetishisation .

7.1.5 PYQ: Alienation from Human Potential and Marx's Solution**PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**

Question: According to Marx, how are human beings alienated from their human potential, and what does he suggest to change this?

Key Analytical Terms

- **Alienated:** Structural estrangement from self and production .
- **Human Potential:** Species-being (*Gattungswesen*), *homo faber* (man as creative producer) .
- **Change:** Concrete historical mechanisms of emancipation .

Substantive Argument

1. **Conception of Human Potential:** Humans are distinguished from animals by conscious, purposeful labour (*homo faber*) . Work is the primary historical act of material survival, wherein humans objectify their creative potential by transforming natural resources .
2. **Historical Denial of Potential:** Under advancing modes of production, the division of labour and private property separate the worker from the creative process . Under capitalism, labour

is degraded from an active expression of creative being into a coercive, repetitive means of physical survival .

3. Mechanisms of Change:

- *Immediate*: Reduction in the length of the working day to liberate human time .
- *Structural*: Revolutionary overthrow of capitalism and the establishment of communism, abolishing the private division of labour .

4. Contemporary Limitations: Commodified leisure under modern capitalism compromises genuine emancipation outside work (Gorz, Marcuse) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Human Potential**: Species-being, *homo faber*; labour as conscious, creative self-realisation .
- **Alienation Mechanism**: Capitalism degrades work into repetitive, coercive wage-slavery .
- **Remedies**: Reduction of working day + revolutionary abolition of private property (communism) .

7.1.6 PYQ: Evaluate Marx's Idea on Mode of Production

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question: Evaluate Marx's idea on mode of production.

CRITICAL POINT

When encountering complex theoretical questions under examination pressure, immediately establish the structural definition . Writing the formal definition clarifies the analytical path of the answer .

Definition and Structural Model A **Mode of Production** (MoP) is the specific historical organisation of economic production through which a society secures its material subsistence . It comprises the dialectical unity of the **Forces of Production** (means of production and labour-power) and the **Relations of Production** (property ownership, class relations, and distribution) .

EXAMPLE

The Historical Engine Metaphor:

- Mode of production acts as a historical engine driven by two internal mechanisms: the *forces of production* (technology, tools) and the *relations of production* (class structure) .
- Expanding material needs require technological advancement . As forces of production evolve, existing relations of production become structural obstacles (fettters) .
- The resulting dialectical contradiction sparks social revolution, transforming the entire mode of production .

Critical Evaluation

- **Teleological Determinism**: Marx's assertion that capitalism must inevitably collapse into socialism reflects prophetic teleology rather than rigorous empirical science .

- **Post-Marxist Critique (Ernesto Laclau & Chantal Mouffe):** History does not follow deterministic economic laws; analysis must focus on why socialist revolutions occurred in agrarian societies (Russia, China) rather than advanced industrial economies .

KEY CONCEPT

Sociology functions to formulate foundational questions rather than deliver dogmatic prophecies . As Slavoj Žižek emphasizes, transformative social change begins with asking the right structural questions .

Feminist Critiques

- **Nancy Holmstrom:** Historical materialism exhibits patriarchal bias . Historical evolution is framed around male hunting, technological innovation, and public production, obscuring women's domestic labour and reinforcing gender hierarchies .
- **Shulamith Firestone:** Dialectical history is fundamentally rooted in the struggle between biological sexes over reproduction and domestic control, rather than class struggle alone .

DATA & FACTS

- Despite high aggregate economic activity, India's **Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR)** remains among the lowest globally, reflecting patriarchal allocations of unpaid domestic labour and ideological barriers to female autonomy .

Methodological Critique: Karl Popper and Pseudoscience In *The Poverty of Historicism*, Karl Popper classifies Marxism as a **pseudoscience** .

KEY CONCEPT

- Genuine scientific theories must satisfy the criterion of **falsifiability** — specifying empirical conditions under which they can be refuted .
- Marxism relies entirely on verificationism and deploys unfalsifiable immunising concepts :
 - If workers mobilise: proves Marxist class consciousness .
 - If workers fail to mobilise: attributed to “false consciousness” .
 - If workers recognise exploitation but remain inactive: attributed to “alienation” .
- Because no empirical observation can refute the theory, Marxism fails the scientific demarcation test .

CRITICAL POINT

Concluding Assessment: While methodologically vulnerable to deterministic critique, Marxian political economy provided the analytical foundation for labour legislation, occupational pensions, workplace rights, and the institutional development of the modern welfare state .

QUICK REVISION

- **Mode of Production:** Forces of Production (means + labour) + Relations of Production

(property/class relations) .

- **Engine Metaphor:** Expanding needs → technological shift → class conflict → structural transition .
- **Critiques:** Teleology/Prophecy (Laclau & Mouffe); Patriarchal erasure (Holmstrom, Firestone); Low FLFPR realities .
- **Popperian Critique:** Unfalsifiable pseudoscience; false consciousness functions as an immunising hypothesis .
- **Legacy:** Institutional foundation of the welfare state and labour rights .

7.1.7 PYQ: Similarities and Differences between Alienation and Anomie

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question: Identify similarities and differences between Marx's theory of alienation and Durkheim's theory of anomie. (20 Marks)

Foundational Definitions

- **Anomie (Émile Durkheim):** A state of normlessness resulting from the breakdown of collective moral values and regulatory ethical standards that integrate society .
- **Alienation (Karl Marx):** The structural estrangement of human beings from their produce, labour process, fellow workers, and species-being under capitalist property relations .

Core Theoretical Similarities

1. **Responses to Modernity:** Both concepts represent sociological diagnoses of modern industrial transformation by thinkers shaped by rapid modernisation .
2. **Pathologies of Modern Society:** Both diagnose specific dysfunctions of industrial capitalism — treating human isolation and atomisation as systemic outcomes .
3. **Pathology in Division of Labour:** Durkheim's *anomic division of labour* (repetitive, uncoordinated tasks generating meaninglessness) parallels Marx's alienation from the labour process and species-being .
4. **Rise of Isolated Individuals:** Both identify the structural atomisation of the individual in modern society .

Structural Differences

EXAMPLE

- **Durkheim's Pipeline Metaphor:** Anomie is like a clogged water pipe; clearing normative blockages restores functional equilibrium .
- **Forced Division of Labour:** Allocating occupations on ascriptive caste or gender lines (e.g., manual scavenging) rather than merit reflects structural pathology .

QUICK REVISION

- **Anomie:** Normlessness, moral deregulation, functionalist reform (*change in structure*) .

Analytical Dimension	Anomie (Émile Durkheim)	Alienation (Karl Marx)
Nature of Problem	Pathological, temporary aberration of rapid modern transition .	Inherent, structural pathology endemic to the capitalist mode of production .
Remedial Path	Institutional social reforms, occupational corporations, moral education; <i>change within structure</i> .	Revolutionary overthrow of private property; communism; <i>change of the structure</i> .
Division of Labour	Abnormal forms (anomic, forced); normal division creates organic solidarity .	Fundamentally exploitative, coercive, and estranging under class society .
Societal Spread	Universal mass phenomenon affecting all strata during normlessness .	Primarily a class phenomenon concentrated in the exploited proletariat .
Underlying Causation	Breakdown of moral regulation and collective consciousness .	Asymmetrical property ownership and extraction of surplus value .
Role of State & Law	Organs of moral regulation capable of healing social pathologies .	Superstructural instruments of bourgeois class domination .

- **Alienation:** Structural estrangement, class exploitation, revolutionary overhaul (*change of structure*) .
- **Similarities:** Diagnoses of modernity, industrial pathologies, division of labour dysfunction .
- **Differences:** Temporary vs. structural; moral vs. economic; reformist vs. revolutionary; state as moral healer vs. state as capitalist tool .

7.1.8 PYQ: Capitalism and Personal Relationships between Men and Women

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question: According to Marx, capitalism transforms even the personal relationship between men and women. Critically examine with illustrations from the contemporary Indian context.

CRITICAL POINT

Marx wrote limited material directly on gender dynamics; the foundational text on this subject is Friedrich Engels's *The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* .

KEY CONCEPT

Christine Delphy's Materialist Feminist Framework:

- The domestic **household** operates as a distinct mode of production .
- Means of production: Domestic chores, childcare, and unpaid emotional labour .
- Relations of production: Asymmetrical, patriarchal relations between men and women .
- **Structural Duality:** Working-class men who are proletarians in the capitalist workplace

function as the bourgeoisie within the domestic household, exploiting women's unpaid labour .

Transformation under Industrial Capitalism

- **Public vs. Private Split:** Industrialisation separated the household from public production, instituting a rigid sexual division of labour . Male wage work was categorised as productive labour, while female domestic work was designated as non-productive care work .
- **Institutional Dependence:** The systemic gender wage gap reinforces female economic dependency and sustains patriarchal, male-headed households .
- **Commodification of Men:** In the contemporary Indian context, dowry inflation operates as a market-driven commodification of grooms, escalating directly with capitalist wealth accumulation .

QUICK REVISION

- **Theoretical Foundation:** Friedrich Engels (*Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State*) .
- **Christine Delphy:** Domestic household as mode of production; industrial proletariat becomes domestic bourgeois .
- **Mechanisms:** Public/private spatial split, devaluation of reproductive labour, gender wage gap, escalating dowry markets .

7.1.9 Remaining Marx and Durkheim PYQs for Self-Practice

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Additional Practice Questions:

1. Sometimes workers feel no attachment to their work; explain the Marxian theoretical framework for this condition (Theory of Alienation) .
2. Differentiate between slave and feudal societies in the Marxian typology of historical modes of production .
3. Examine Marx's transition from "class-in-itself" (*Klasse an sich*) to "class-for-itself" (*Klasse für sich*) .
4. Critically analyse Durkheim's *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* and the role of religion; examine religious revivalism in modern society .
5. Explain Durkheim's sociological methodology in *Suicide*; evaluate its applicability to high suicide rates in contemporary India .
6. Write short analytical notes on: (a) The Sacred and the Profane, (b) Totemism as elementary religion, (c) Social Facts treated as things .

Methodological Challenges in Observing Social Facts

- **Empirical Invisibility:** Social institutions (family, state, religion) are non-material social facts that cannot be directly perceived through the senses .

- **Eliminating Personal Biases:**
 - *Crime*: Researchers must analyze crime functionally rather than morally .
 - *Religion*: Requires total detachment from personal religious beliefs or secular biases .
 - *Nation-State*: Nationalism evokes intense ideological bias; as Rabindranath Tagore noted, uncritical nationalism can operate as a destructive collective epidemic .
- **Causality and Invisibility**: Establishing objective cause-and-effect relations for non-observable social facts requires rigorous indirect methods .

CRITICAL POINT

Durkheim resolved these challenges in *Suicide* by applying the **indirect experimental method** via comparative statistical analysis and the method of **concomitant variation** .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question: How accurately did Tönnies, Durkheim, Weber, and Marx predict the character of modern society?

- **Ferdinand Tönnies**: Transition from *Gemeinschaft* (close community) to *Gesellschaft* (impersonal association), resulting in declining intimacy and rising individualism .
- **Émile Durkheim**: Shift from mechanical to organic solidarity; temporary modern anomie resolving into functional interdependence .
- **Karl Marx**: Polarisation of classes leading to revolutionary collapse of capitalism, followed by socialism and stateless communism .

CRITICAL POINT

Common Methodological Critique: Classical thinkers relied largely on inductive reasoning based on European modernization, formulating grand universal trajectories that risk being unfalsifiable .

Durkheimian Sociology of Religion Religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to **sacred things** (set apart and forbidden) that unite adherents into a single moral community (Church) .

1. **Social Integration**: Generating *collective effervescence*, elevating individuals above the profane .
2. **Social Control**: Establishing collective constraints against disruptive behaviour .
3. **Cognitive Categories**: Supplying foundational concepts of time, space, causality, and morality .

CRITICAL POINT

Dysfunctions in Complex Societies: While Durkheim emphasized integration within homogeneous clans, in modern heterogeneous, multi-religious societies, competing religious identities often generate inter-group communal conflict .

Sociology of Suicide: Positivist Method and Critiques

- Durkheim used comparative rates (e.g., lower Catholic suicide rates vs. higher Protestant rates

due to differences in social integration and moral regulation) .

- **J. Maxwell Atkinson (Phenomenological Critique):** Official suicide statistics are not objective social facts, but social constructions produced by coroners' subjective interpretations of ambiguous deaths .

Comparative Division of Labour

- **Adam Smith:** Economic perspective — division of labour increases aggregate productivity, market wealth, and commerce .
- **Karl Marx:** Critical perspective — generates class polarisation, deskilling, and multidimensional alienation .
- **Émile Durkheim:** Sociological perspective — generates organic solidarity and functional interdependence in modern societies .

QUICK REVISION

- **Social Facts Challenges:** Invisibility, value-biases (crime, religion, nationalism — Tagore's critique) .
- **Tönnies:** *Gemeinschaft* → *Gesellschaft* .
- **Religion:** Integration, Collective Effervescence, Social Control, Cognitive categories; limited by communal conflict in plural societies .
- **Suicide Method:** Concomitant variation; challenged by Atkinson's ethnomethodological critique .
- **Division of Labour:** Smith (Productivity) vs. Marx (Alienation) vs. Durkheim (Organic Solidarity) .

7.1.10 Neo-Marxism: Superstructure, Critical Theory and the Frankfurt School

Base, Superstructure and the Myth of Meritocracy In orthodox Marxism, the economic base unilaterally conditions the superstructure . Neo-Marxism revises this model, emphasizing the autonomy and power of superstructural institutions in sustaining capitalism .

EXAMPLE

- **Educational Legitimation:** Education propagates the ideology of meritocracy — asserting success depends entirely on individual effort . Failure is internalised as personal inadequacy rather than structural class exclusion .
- **Class Privilege in Elite Education:** Elite educational institutions impose high economic barriers (e.g., tuition costs), reproducing class reproduction under the guise of open competition .
- **The Myth of Meritocracy:** Conceptualised by Louis Althusser as an ideological mechanism of the state .

Orthodox Marxism vs. Neo-Marxism While Marx focused overwhelmingly on the economic base, Neo-Marxists argue that the failure of proletarian revolution in the West was caused by the ruling class's ideological control over the superstructure .

Neo-Marxist Scholar(s)	Superstructural Domain Analysed
Louis Althusser	Ideological State Apparatuses (ISA) and the State .
Antonio Gramsci	Cultural Hegemony via civil society (Religion, Media, Education) .
Adorno, Horkheimer, Marcuse, Habermas	The Culture Industry, manufactured false needs, mass media .
Paul Willis; Paulo Freire	Critical pedagogy and ideological reproduction within schooling .

KEY CONCEPT

Frankfurt School and Critical Theory:

- Formulated by scholars including Max Horkheimer, Theodor Adorno, and Herbert Marcuse, drawing on Antonio Gramsci and György Lukács .
- **Core Question:** Why did the predicted socialist revolution fail to occur despite the Great Depression, imperialist wars, and systemic capitalist crises?
- **Resolution:** Capitalism sustains stability through the **Culture Industry** and the rise of **Totalitarian Hegemony** .

Mechanisms of Cultural Hegemony

- **Culture Industry (Adorno & Horkheimer):** Mass culture, pop music, radio, and cinema pacify the working class, instilling false consciousness and transforming citizens into passive consumers . Commodified culture projects the illusion of upward mobility, diffusing revolutionary class consciousness .
- **Totalitarian Nationalism and Capitalist Expansion:** Authoritarian regimes direct working-class frustrations away from structural poverty toward jingoistic nationalism and targeted minorities . This hyper-nationalism facilitates corporate deregulation, privatisation, and state retreat from social welfare .

QUICK REVISION

- **Base-Superstructure Shift:** Neo-Marxists focus on superstructural autonomy to explain the absence of revolution .
- **Myth of Meritocracy:** Louis Althusser; education legitimises structural class inequality .
- **Frankfurt School:** Critical Theory explaining capitalist stability via cultural hegemony and mass media (Adorno, Horkheimer, Marcuse) .
- **Culture Industry:** Standardised cultural products create manufactured desires and pacify critical consciousness .

7.2 Max Weber: Intellectual Background and Overview of His Concepts

7.2.1 Handouts, Doubts and the Rule for Conflicting Versions

CRITICAL POINT

- Standard academic textbooks are designed for university curricula rather than the targeted requirements of the UPSC sociology syllabus . Study should focus on precise conceptual mastery .
- **Class in-itself vs. Class for-itself:** Class-in-itself (*Klasse an sich*) represents the objective economic category; Class-for-itself (*Klasse für sich*) represents the subjective attainment of conscious class solidarity .
- **Rule for Conflicting Versions:** In rare instances of contradiction between lecture audio and written materials, the verified analytical handout stands as the authoritative reference .

7.2.2 French Sociology, German Sociology and the Split

Max Weber stands as a foundational figure in classical European sociology, marking the intellectual bridge between European sociology and American sociological thought .

The Conservative Unity of French Sociology French sociology (Auguste Comte, Saint-Simon, Louis de Bonald, Joseph de Maistre, and Émile Durkheim) was unified around a conservative commitment to **traditional social order** . Troubled by post-revolutionary instability, they sought new institutional mechanisms to restore normative integration, establishing the foundations of **structural functionalism** .

The Radicalism of Karl Marx Marx rejected the premise that social institutions function for systemic stability, arguing instead that institutions operate to secure the dominance of the ruling class . Emancipation requires the revolutionary dismantling of private property to establish a classless society .

The German Methodological Split German sociology was divided between two competing traditions: revolutionary materialism (Marxism) and interpretive social action (Weberianism) .

Feature	French Sociology	German Sociology
Intellectual Character	Highly unified; shared conservative orientation .	Deeply split between Marxist and Weberian traditions .
Foundational Focus	Preservation of social order and institutional cohesion .	Structural transformation (Marx) vs. Subjective meaning (Weber) .
Core Epistemology	Positivism; treating society as an objective organism .	Historical materialism (Marx) vs. Interpretive non-positivism (Weber) .
Theoretical Orientation	Structural Functionalism .	Radical Conflict vs. Interpretive Sociology .

QUICK REVISION

- **French Sociology:** Comte, Durkheim; unified, conservative, positivist, structural functionalism .

- **Marxian Stance:** Institutions serve the ruling class; revolutionary transformation required .
- **German Sociology:** Split between Marxism (macro-materialist conflict) and Weberianism (interpretive action and domination) .

7.2.3 *The Life History of Max Weber*

- **Origins:** Born in Erfurt, Germany, into an affluent middle-class family; one of eight children .
- **Family Dynamics:** His father was a prominent civil servant and politician; his mother, Hélène Fallenstein, was a devout Calvinist Protestant .
- **Academic Training:** Studied law, economics, and history at the University of Heidelberg, completing two doctoral dissertations . Married Marianne Weber, an influential sociologist and feminist scholar .

EXAMPLE

The 1897 Breakdown: In the summer of 1897, following a severe dispute in which Weber confronted his authoritarian father on behalf of his mother, his father died suddenly . Weber suffered acute guilt and a debilitating psychological breakdown .

DATA & FACTS

- **Incapacity (1897–1902):** Weber remained unable to teach, research, or write for five years .
- **Productive Period:** Fully resumed scholarly production in 1902, publishing his masterworks over the final 18 years of his life .
- **Death:** Died of pneumonia in 1920 at age 56 .

QUICK REVISION

- Born in Erfurt; lawyer father and devout Calvinist mother .
- University of Heidelberg; dual doctorates in law and history; married Marianne Weber .
- Psychological breakdown (1897–1902) followed by late scholarly production; died in 1920 .

7.2.4 *Major Works and the Political Context*

The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism (1904–1905) Dedicated intellectually to the worldview embodied by his mother, this study examined how religious ideas (specifically Calvinist inner-worldly asceticism and the doctrine of predestination) contributed to the rise of modern rational capitalism in Western Europe .

Economic Ethics of World Religions (1913–1919) A comparative sociological analysis spanning Hinduism, Buddhism, Ancient Judaism, Confucianism, and Islam, examining why rational capitalism failed to emerge endogenously in non-Western civilisations .

CRITICAL POINT

Weber and the First World War:

- A lifelong German nationalist, Weber initially supported the First World War before turning critical of imperial mismanagement .
- Marxist philosopher György Lukács argued that Weber's wartime writings reflected a search for charismatic political leadership to restore German unity .

DATA & FACTS

- Served as a German delegate at the 1919 Versailles Peace Conference .
- Advised on drafting the Weimar Constitution, contributing to the formulation of **Article 48** (emergency presidential powers), which was later exploited during the collapse of the republic in 1933 .

Economy and Society (1920) Weber's magnum opus, left unfinished upon his death and published posthumously . It formulated his definitive theories of social action, ideal types, bureaucracy, and structures of domination .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Mode of Domination over Mode of Production:** Weber reinterprets human history not as a sequence of modes of production, but as transformations in the **modes of domination** and authority .
- **Historical Trajectory:** Society shifts from traditional and charismatic authority toward legal-rational authority and systemic **rationalization** .

QUICK REVISION

- *Protestant Ethic* (1905): Religious ideas as engines of modern capitalism .
- *World Religions* (1913–1919): Comparative analysis of non-emergence of capitalism .
- Political involvement: Versailles delegation, Weimar Constitution drafting (Article 48) .
- *Economy and Society*: History defined by transformations in modes of domination and rationalization .

7.2.5 Social Action as a Critique of Economic Action

Weber's theory of social action serves as a direct methodological alternative to Marxian economic determinism .

KEY CONCEPT

- **Critique of Marxian Inductivism:** Weber argued that asserting the inevitability of proletarian revolution treats individuals as passive structural puppets .
- **Neglect of Subjective Meaning:** Marxian theory ignores the subjective meanings, cultural motivations, and religious values that human actors attach to their work .

Work as Worship: The Absence of Proletarian Revolt Workers often do not revolt because labour carries profound normative and spiritual meaning . Work is experienced as a domain of personal dignity, vocational duty, and religious calling (*Beruf*) .

EXAMPLE

- Benjamin Franklin's maxim "work is worship" reflects an inner-worldly Protestant ethic wherein economic labour is understood as a moral obligation to God .
- In the Indian context, **Vishwakarma Puja** involves the ritual worship of tools, machinery, and production equipment; factories halt commercial operations for devotional worship .
- Everyday cultural practices — breaking coconuts on new automobiles, tying protective threads to machinery, displaying sacred symbols in workplaces — show that human labour is mediated by religious values rather than purely monetary calculation .

Reducing human action entirely to material interests reflects **economic reductionism** . Economic relations constitute only one dimension of a broader social matrix shaped by ideas, values, and religious convictions .

QUICK REVISION

- **Critique of Economic Reductionism:** Human action is guided by subjective values, not purely material interest .
- **Meaning in Labour:** Work conceptualised as moral duty, identity, or sacred devotion (Franklin, Vishwakarma Puja) rather than simply alienated wage labour .

7.2.6 Against Positivism and Against Subjectivism

Weber rejected both positivist nomothetic determinism and extreme subjectivist idiographic description, establishing interpretive sociology as a rigorous middle path .

Dimension	Positivism (Nomothetic)	Subjectivism (Idiographic)
Analytical Focus	Formulating universal laws of the social world .	Documenting unique, unrepeatable historical events .
Conception of History	History is governed by invariant natural laws .	History is a descriptive narrative of singular occurrences .
Key Representatives	Auguste Comte, Herbert Spencer, Karl Marx .	Classical German historicists and descriptive historians .
Methodological Flaw	Erases human subjectivity, agency, and contingency .	Misses broader patterns, causal connections, and structural parallels .
Weberian Verdict	Flawed; reduces society to abstract, rigid formulas .	Flawed; produces disconnected, non-comparative narratives .

CRITICAL POINT

Theoretical concepts like "mechanical solidarity" or "normal division of labour" do not exist as concrete, tangible entities in empirical reality . Positivists construct rigid laws that fail to capture lived experience, while idiographic historians document narrow events without uncovering structural patterns .

EXAMPLE

Comparative Historical Patterns (Theda Skocpol): While descriptive historians treat the French, Russian, and Chinese Revolutions as disconnected events, comparative historical sociology identifies shared structural conditions: state administrative incapacitation combined with agrarian revolt under external military and economic crises .

Weber introduced the **Ideal Type** methodology to resolve this dilemma, enabling comparative analysis without falling into deterministic law-making .

QUICK REVISION

- **Nomothetic (Positivism):** Universal law-seeking; deterministic; ignores individual meaning .
- **Idiographic (Subjectivism):** Narrow historical description; misses comparative structural patterns .
- **Weber's Resolution:** Interpretive sociology powered by the methodological tool of the **Ideal Type** .

7.2.7 Authority and Power: The First Overview

Weber drew a fundamental analytical distinction between **Power** (*Macht*) and **Domination/Authority** (*Herrschaft*) .

EXAMPLE

- An ordinary citizen demanding obedience from a police officer is ignored .
- A superior police officer issuing a lawful command is immediately obeyed because the command carries institutional authority .
- An armed criminal compelling compliance at gunpoint exercises raw power or illegitimate coercion, not legitimate authority .
- A father directing a child to return home on time is obeyed based on traditional familial authority .

Type of Authority	Basis of Legitimacy	Primary Illustration
Traditional Authority	Sanctity of age-old customs, heredity, and sacred traditions .	Patriarchal family head; hereditary monarchies .
Charismatic Authority	Devotion to the perceived extraordinary, heroic, or sacred qualities of a leader .	Transformative religious prophets or dynamic political leaders .
Legal-Rational Authority	Legality of enacted formal rules, procedural codes, and constitutional norms .	Modern civil service; constitutional state bureaucracy .

The Three Ideal Types of Authority**Power vs. Authority**

- **Power (*Macht*):** The probability that one actor within a social relationship will carry out their own will even against the resistance of others .
- **Authority (*Herrschaft*):** The probability that a specific command will be voluntarily obeyed by a given group of actors because it is perceived as legitimate .
- Power is not inherently greater than authority; they represent analytically distinct modes of social control .

CRITICAL POINT

Coexistence of Authority Types in Concrete Reality: Real-world institutions combine multiple authority forms . A senior civil servant operates formally under legal-rational authority, but may also command compliance through personal charisma and traditional norms of deference to official authority .

QUICK REVISION

- **Power (*Macht*):** Imposing will despite resistance; coercion .
- **Authority (*Herrschaft*):** Legitimate command securing voluntary compliance .
- **Three Types:** Traditional (Custom), Charismatic (Personal aura), Legal-Rational (Enacted rules) .
- **Concrete Reality:** Empirical authority structures blend all three ideal types .

7.2.8 Methodology: *Verstehen*, Empathy and Social Action

Weberian methodology rests on three interconnected pillars: the **Ideal Type**, **Verstehen**, and **Adequate Causality** .

Verstehen (Interpretive Understanding) *Verstehen* denotes the interpretive comprehension of the subjective meaning (*Sinn*) that actors attach to their social conduct .

Dimension	Empathy (<i>Verstehen</i>)	Sympathy
Core Meaning	Reconstructing the subjective orientation by placing oneself in the actor's position .	Feeling passive sorrow or emotional pity for another person .
Epistemological Value	Foundational methodological requirement for sociological explanation .	Inadequate for scientific sociological research .

CRITICAL POINT

Earlier thinkers treated human beings as passive entities governed by external structural laws :

- Auguste Comte: Social order restored automatically via organic equilibrium .
- Émile Durkheim: Crime, punishment, and solidarity analyzed purely as objective social facts without individual subjectivity .
- Sigmund Freud: Individual personality reduced to deterministic subconscious structures (id,

ego, superego) .

EXAMPLE

The statement “The Industrial Revolution began in England” records an objective historical event . However, explaining *why* it emerged specifically in England requires interpreting the subjective religious values, institutional motivations, and economic orientations of historical actors via *Verstehen* .

Definition of Social Action

KEY CONCEPT

Social Action (*Soziales Handeln*) is any human conduct that is subjectively meaningful, purposive, and oriented in its course to the past, present, or expected behaviour of other actors within a historical context .

EXAMPLE

- An individual opening an umbrella during rainfall is an isolated physical reaction, not a social action .
- Two cyclists accidentally colliding is a non-social physical occurrence; however, a deliberate collision or subsequent physical altercation oriented toward the other person is a social action .
- **Clifford Geertz’s Balinese Cockfight:** An external observer might see merely animal cruelty; interpretive analysis reveals the cockfight as a symbolic status contest over community power and prestige .

KEY CONCEPT

Iron Will and Value Neutrality: Developing *Verstehen* requires “iron will” — the methodological discipline to bracket one’s personal values, biases, and ethnocentric judgements to understand the actor’s subjective motivations on their own terms .

QUICK REVISION

- **Verstehen:** Interpretive, empathetic reconstruction of subjective meaning .
- **Social Action:** Conduct endowed with subjective meaning and oriented toward other actors .
- **Disciplinary Turn:** Shifts sociology from macro-structural laws (Durkheim) to micro-subjective action (Weber) .
- **Methodological Requirement:** Iron will to maintain value neutrality .

7.3 Kant, Objectivity in Social Research and the Ideal Type

7.3.1 Immanuel Kant: Empiricism and Rationalism

KEY CONCEPT

Epistemological Lineage: Just as G.W.F. Hegel's dialectics provided the philosophical foundation for Karl Marx, Immanuel Kant's critical epistemology forms the philosophical foundation for Max Weber .

Kant resolved the philosophical divide between **Empiricism** and **Rationalism** by positing two distinct domains of human knowledge :

Dimension	Empirical World (Phenomena)	Rational / Noumenal World
Nature of Reality	Directly observable through sensory perception .	Non-observable directly; requiring interpretive conceptualisation .
Mode of Access	Direct observation (touch, vision, measurement) .	Cognitive interpretation and mental construction .
Physical Analogy	A physical glass of water .	Subatomic particles and atmospheric forces .
Social Application	An observable physical altercation .	The subjective motives, grievances, and meanings behind the conflict .

QUICK REVISION

- Kant's epistemology: Knowledge is structured by mental categories .
- Two domains: Directly observable empirical phenomena vs. interpreted noumena/meanings .
- Weber's takeaway: Social reality cannot be understood through raw sensory empiricism alone; it requires interpretive conceptualisation .

7.3.2 The Image Exercise: Accentuation of Features

When individuals recognise stylized portraits, cognition operates through the **one-sided accentuation of selected characteristics** rather than photographic replication .

Historical Figure	Accentuated Stylized Attributes
Karl Marx	Prominent beard, moustache, distinct facial structure, Victorian overcoat .
Jawaharlal Nehru	Red rose pinned to the achkan/jacket, distinct cap, aristocratic posture .
B.R. Ambedkar	Formal blue western suit, necktie, specific hairline, spectacles .
Mahatma Gandhi	Shaven head, round wire spectacles, khadi dhoti, walking staff .

CRITICAL POINT

- Sociological concepts operate through this same cognitive process .
- What Marx presented as "capitalism" is not an absolute physical entity, but a theoretical

construct accentuating specific exploitative dynamics .

- Durkheim’s “mechanical solidarity” and “organic solidarity” do not exist as tangible empirical objects; they are analytical models constructed to interpret complex historical developments .

EXAMPLE

- In *Democracy in America*, Alexis de Tocqueville does not present an unmediated photograph of democracy, but an interpreted model of American institutional life .
- Yuval Noah Harari (*Sapiens*) observes that nation-states, corporations, and consumer markets are shared mental constructs that coordinate collective human action .

QUICK REVISION

- Concepts are mental models constructed by accentuating specific empirical elements .
- Abstract entities (capitalism, solidarity, democracy, poverty) are conceptual models rather than directly observable physical objects .

7.3.3 Objectivity in Social Research

In his seminal essay *Objectivity in Social Research* (1904), Weber outlined the methodological limits of objectivity in the social sciences :

1. **Absence of Pure Objectivity:** Absolute, unmediated objectivity does not exist in the cultural sciences; all knowledge of social reality is mediated by conceptual frameworks .
2. **One-Sided Accentuation:** Theoretical perspectives represent selective, one-sided accentuations of infinite social reality .
3. **Need for Explicit Definitions:** Researchers must rigorously define the conceptual boundaries of the terms they deploy rather than assuming universal meanings .
4. **Value Relevance (*Wertbeziehung*):** The initial selection of a research problem is inevitably value-laden, guided by cultural relevance and researcher interest .
5. **Interpretive Data Collection:** Data collection and sociological coding are themselves interpretive processes .
6. **Value Neutrality (*Wertfreiheit*):** While problem selection is value-relevant, the actual execution of research, data analysis, and presentation must remain strictly value-neutral .
7. **Ideal Type as Methodological Tool:** The ideal type provides the objective measuring rod necessary to navigate subjective empirical reality .

CRITICAL POINT

The Comparative Fallacy: Asking “Is China a democracy?” or “Is India secular?” assumes these concepts possess single, fixed empirical definitions . In reality:

- French secularism (*laïcité*) demands strict mutual exclusion between church and state .
- Indian secularism embodies *sarva dharma sambhava* (principled distance and equal respect for all religions) .

- Concepts function as analytical models rather than universal physical realities .

QUICK REVISION

- Pure objectivity is unattainable; social reality is infinite and selectively interpreted .
- **Value Relevance (*Wertbeziehung*)**: Values guide topic selection .
- **Value Neutrality (*Wertfreiheit*)**: Research execution must remain unbiased .
- Concepts (democracy, secularism) are analytical models that vary across historical contexts .

7.3.4 *Ideal Type: Definition and Features*

CRITICAL POINT

The term “ideal” does not denote an ethical, normative, or moral goal . An ideal type of a criminal syndicate, bureaucracy, or terrorist network is an analytical construct, not an ideal to be pursued .

KEY CONCEPT

Ideal Type Defined: An **Ideal Type** is a conceptual construct formed by the one-sided accentuation of one or more points of view and by the synthesis of a great many diffuse, discrete, more or less present and occasionally absent concrete individual phenomena into a unified analytical construct . It serves as a **measuring rod** to assess similarities, differences, and causal connections in empirical reality .

Illustration: Models vs. Empirical Realities

- **Capitalism:** An ideal type of pure capitalism (zero state intervention, pure free market, total private ownership) exists nowhere in pure form; empirical economies (e.g., the United States invoking the Defense Production Act during crises) show varying combinations of market forces and state intervention .
- **Democracy:** An ideal model specifying universal participation, perfect information, and absolute rights serves as a comparative benchmark to measure empirical democratic institutions .
- **Family:** The heteronormative nuclear family functions as one specific analytical model, against which diverse empirical family forms (joint, same-sex, single-parent, cohabiting) can be sociologically analyzed .

Typology of Terrorism (*Analytical Accentuation*) The term “terrorism” is deployed as an ideal-typical category across diverse socio-historical contexts :

Core Methodological Features of the Ideal Type

1. It is **not** an average type, nor a statistical aggregate, nor an unmediated depiction of reality .
2. It provides an unambiguous conceptual baseline to guide empirical research .
3. It functions as an analytical **measuring rod** to calculate divergences between empirical cases and the theoretical model .

Historical / Political Movement	Distinct Context and Stated Objective
ISIS / Daesh	Middle East; violent establishment of a transnational caliphate .
ETA (Basque Homeland & Liberty)	Spain; ethno-nationalist separatism .
Red Brigades	Italy; left-wing militant revolutionary struggle .
NSCN (Khaplang Faction)	North-East India; regional ethno-political autonomy .
Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA)	Colonial India; anti-imperialist armed liberation (Bhagat Singh) .

Ideal Type Category	Theoretical Definition	Sociological Example
Historical Particular Ideal Type	Phenomena rooted in specific, unique historical epochs that occurred only once .	Modern Western rational capitalism; the ancient city-state .
Historical Universal Ideal Type	Abstract concepts present across diverse historical eras and civilisations .	Feudalism; Bureaucracy; Charismatic authority .

Classification of Ideal Types

QUICK REVISION

- **Ideal Type:** Methodological measuring rod; pure mental construct via one-sided accentuation .
- **Non-Normative:** “Ideal” denotes logical purity, not moral desirability .
- **Two Broad Classes:** Historical Particular (Western capitalism) vs. Historical Universal (Bureaucracy, Feudalism) .

7.3.5 Types of Social Action

Weber classified social action into four distinct ideal-typical orientations :

Application: Selecting Sociology as an Optional Subject

- **Affective:** A personal passion for social philosophy and intellectual inquiry .
- **Traditional:** Selecting the subject because family members previously chose it .
- **Value-Rational:** A normative commitment to social justice and understanding inequality .
- **Goal-Rational:** Calculating syllabus overlap, scoring trends, and preparation time .

CRITICAL POINT

In concrete social reality, human conduct is rarely purely unmixed; empirical actions represent complex blends of all four orientations . Ideal types provide the analytical categories necessary to isolate and evaluate these overlapping motivations .

Type of Social Action	Foundational Basis	Concrete Illustration
Affective Action	Determined by immediate emotional states and feelings .	Studying sociology out of love for the discipline; celebrating a loved one's birthday .
Traditional Action	Determined by ingrained custom, habit, and unreflective tradition .	Festive gift exchange at Diwali; habitual ritual worship .
Value-Rational Action (Wertrational)	Conscious belief in the unconditional intrinsic value of a conduct, regardless of its outcome .	Jain dietary and economic ethics; engaging in principled philanthropy commanded by religious scripture .
Goal-Rational Action (Zweckrational)	Instrumentally oriented to calculating means, ends, and secondary consequences .	Selecting an optional subject strictly based on syllabus size and scoring efficiency .

QUICK REVISION

- **Four Ideal Types of Social Action:**
 1. **Affective:** Emotionally driven .
 2. **Traditional:** Custom and habit driven .
 3. **Value-Rational (Wertrational):** Intrinsic moral/ethical duty .
 4. **Goal-Rational (Zweckrational):** Instrumental means-ends calculation .
- Empirical actions represent blended configurations of these four types .

7.4 Verstehen, Value Neutrality and the Process of Rationalization

7.4.1 Ideal Type Crystallized: Capitalism and Secularism

Different sociological paradigms construct distinct ideal-typical models of the same empirical phenomenon :

Thinker / Paradigm	Ideal-Typical Conception of Capitalism
Émile Durkheim	Specialised organic division of labour creating modern moral solidarity .
Karl Marx	System of class exploitation, surplus value extraction, and structural alienation .
Adam Smith	Free market economy driven by self-interest and productive efficiency .

KEY CONCEPT

Capitalism as an all-encompassing, single physical entity does not exist; there are only specific theoretical models constructed to analyze economic systems .

QUICK REVISION

- Competing paradigms construct distinct ideal types of capitalism (Smith: efficiency; Marx: exploitation; Durkheim: solidarity) .
- Ideal types serve as comparative baselines to evaluate empirical variations (e.g., French strict separation vs. Indian principled distance) .

7.4.2 Why Social Action? The Critique of Homo Economicus**KEY CONCEPT**

- Through the **Ideal Type**, Weber challenged deterministic historians .
- Through the **Theory of Social Action**, Weber challenged neoclassical economists .

The Neoclassical Fallacy of Homo Economicus Neoclassical economics (Jeremy Bentham, John Stuart Mill) posits *homo economicus* — an actor who invariably acts as a purely rational, utilitarian utility-maximiser .

EXAMPLE**The Dining Choice Paradox:**

- An individual selects an expensive luxury restaurant over an adjacent budget diner .
- **Economist's Model:** Classifies the decision as irrational expenditure .
- **Sociological Interpretation:** The decision may be:
 - *Value-Rational*: Seeking a peaceful, dignified setting for a meaningful discussion .
 - *Affectual*: Expressing care and esteem for a partner .
 - *Traditional*: Conforming to established familial or social dining habits .

Economists cannot label actions as “irrational” simply because they diverge from narrow material utility-maximisation . Human action is shaped by diverse, culturally meaningful motivations that sociologists must interpret through *Verstehen* .

QUICK REVISION

- **Homo Economicus:** Neoclassical model of the purely utilitarian, cost-minimising actor .
- **Weberian Critique:** Human conduct is driven by diverse value-rational, affective, and traditional orientations .
- **Sociological Task:** Interpret the subjective meaning behind action rather than dismissing it as irrational .

7.4.3 Verstehen, Hermeneutics and Value Neutrality

Hermeneutic Roots Weber adapted *Verstehen* from **Hermeneutics** — the methodology of interpreting historical texts and deciphering an author's unstated intentions . Weber extended this approach to human social interaction, arguing that history is the product of meaningful social actions .

Rescuing the Individual from Structural Determinism In structural theories (Marxian historical materialism, Durkheimian functionalism), the individual disappears behind macro-structures . Weber recovered human agency and subjective meaning, establishing interpretive sociology .

KEY CONCEPT

The Protocol of Value Neutrality (*Wertfreiheit*):

- **Value Relevance:** A researcher's personal values inevitably guide the selection of a research subject (e.g., a sociologist researching their own community) .
- **Value Neutrality:** Once research begins, personal biases, political preferences, and moral judgements must be systematically bracketed .
- Sociologists must explicitly define their conceptual models (such as patriarchy, democracy, or capitalism) to maintain analytical transparency .

QUICK REVISION

- **Hermeneutics:** Textual interpretation extended to human social action .
- **Agency over Structure:** Recovers the individual from macro-structural determinism .
- **Methodological Realism:** Value relevance in problem choice; strict value neutrality in execution .

7.4.4 Rationality and Rationalization

Rationality forms the core analytical theme uniting Weber's sociology of religion, economy, bureaucracy, and domination .

KEY CONCEPT

Rationality Defined: Any human conduct that is conscious, deliberate, and systematically calculated to achieve goals through appropriate means is **rational** . Non-rational conduct occurs when actions are overwhelmed by unreflective instinct, extreme obsession, or emotional excess .

Sociological Conceptions of Modernity

- **Émile Durkheim:** Modernity is the transition from mechanical to organic solidarity driven by the division of labour .
- **Karl Marx:** Modernity is the era of industrial capitalism and heightened class struggle .
- **Max Weber:** Modernity is the historic, worldwide process of **Rationalization** .

KEY CONCEPT

Rationalization Defined: **Rationalization** is the historical process whereby traditional, affective, and religious orientations are systematically replaced by calculable, efficient, rule-bound, and predictable procedures .

EXAMPLE

The Evolution of Transportation: The historical shift from mythical locomotion (magic carpets)

→ the mechanical wheel → the bicycle → the railway → the automobile → aviation → automated electric transport illustrates progressive rationalization: increasing efficiency, calculability, and predictability through technological innovation .

Dimension	Theoretical Meaning	Concrete Illustration
Efficiency	The optimal means to achieve a given end in the minimum time and effort .	Algorithmic navigation and automated transport routing .
Calculability	Prioritising quantifiable numerical metrics over qualitative values .	Precise estimation of travel duration, costs, and performance data .
Predictability	Standardization ensuring uniform, predictable outcomes across time and space .	Standardized service interfaces and fixed operational protocols .
Non-Human Technology	Replacing fallible human discretion with automated, rule-bound technology .	Fully automated digital ticketing, routing, and payment systems .

The Four Core Dimensions of Rationalization

Bureaucracy as the Epitome of Rationalization Modern bureaucracy represents the purest organizational expression of rationalization: impersonal, specialized, strictly rule-bound, meritocratic, and operating with machine-like efficiency .

Disenchantment of the World (Entzauberung)

KEY CONCEPT

Rationalization inexorably produces the **Disenchantment of the World**: the eradication of magical, mystical, and sacred elements from public life, replaced by technical calculation and scientific intellectualisation .

CRITICAL POINT

The Iron Cage of Rationality (Stahlhartes Gehiise): Rationalization culminates in a rigid, dehumanising “iron cage” . As formal, instrumental rationality eclipses human values and substantive ethics, individuals become trapped within automated systems of bureaucratic and technological control .

QUICK REVISION

- **Modernity:** Defined by Weber as the overarching process of **Rationalization** .
- **Four Dimensions:** Efficiency, Calculability, Predictability, Non-Human Technology .
- **Bureaucracy:** The quintessential institutional vehicle of formal rationalization .
- **Outcomes:** Disenchantment of the world (*Entzauberung*) and the Iron Cage of Rationality (*Stahlhartes Gehiise*) .

7.4.5 *McDonaldization — George Ritzer*

George Ritzer extended Weber’s rationalization theory in his framework of **McDonaldization**: the process by which the operating principles of the fast-food restaurant come to dominate sectors of contemporary society (education, media, healthcare, and family life) .

The Four Principles of McDonaldization

- 1. **Efficiency**: Fast, automated service interfaces (kiosks, app ordering) minimizing transaction time .
- 2. **Calculability**: Quantifiable metrics (portion sizes, low prices, speed) taking precedence over culinary quality or nutritional value .
- 3. **Predictability**: Standardized menus, branding, and service experiences across all locations .
- 4. **Control via Non-Human Technology**: Automated cooking, automated timers, and algorithmic assembly lines controlling human labour .

Sector	Manifestation of Rationalization	Sociological Consequence
Higher Education (McUniversity)	Standardized multiple-choice testing, mechanized grading, automated portals .	Education reduced to quantitative CGPAs; critical pedagogical inquiry marginalized .
Mass Media & News	60-second news digests, soundbites, sensational headlines driven by TRP metrics .	Commodified infotainment replacing substantive public discourse .
Religion	Cyber-darshan, televised rituals, commercialised guru ratings .	Sacred religious traditions transformed into commodified consumer goods .
Intimacy & Family	Algorithmic dating applications (swiping profiles like consumer items) .	Interpersonal relationships mediated by efficiency, convenience, and calculability .

Institutional Applications of McDonaldization

QUICK REVISION

- **McDonaldization (George Ritzer)**: Application of Weberian rationalization to contemporary institutions .
- **Four Dimensions**: Efficiency, Calculability, Predictability, Non-Human Control .
- **Domains**: Higher education (McUniversity), news, cyber-religion, and commodified digital dating .

7.5 Types of Rationality, Causality and the Theory of Authority

7.5.1 Class Schedule and Prelims Strategy

DATA & FACTS

UPSC Preliminary Examination Strategy Metrics:

- **Qualifying Target:** Approximately 52% (around 104 marks out of 200) .
- **Attempt Volume:** Candidates should target at least 88 questions, avoiding the trap of under-attempting .
- **Knowledge Distribution:** On average, a well-prepared candidate knows approximately 25 questions with certainty .
- **Calculated Elimination:** The remaining ≈ 63 attempted questions require structured elimination and calculated reasoning (frequently choosing between two narrowed options) .

CRITICAL POINT

Preparation requires **goal-rational action (Zweckrational)**: systematically analyzing previous year question trends to allocate study time efficiently, rather than following traditional or unreflective advice .

7.5.2 Why Weber Studies Rationalization

Weber sought to explain why modern rational capitalism, formal law, bureaucratic administration, and institutional secularisation emerged first in Western Europe . While rationality exists in all civilisations, Western modernity generated a historically unique form of **formal rationality** .

7.5.3 The Four Ideal Types of Rationality

Rationality Type	Theoretical Definition	Concrete Illustration
Practical Rationality	Pragmatic, everyday calculation of self-interest in immediate situations .	An individual finding money on the road and taking pragmatic steps to keep it .
Theoretical Rationality	Intellectual abstract conceptualisation to master reality cognitively .	Scholars formulating concepts like “alienation”, “patriarchy”, or “anomie” .
Substantive Rationality	System of action guided by substantive ethical, moral, or religious value systems .	Living within the cultural norms of a community; pre-marital celibacy based on religious principles .
Formal Rationality	Calculable means-ends action based on universally applied formal rules and laws .	Handing lost money to the police to avoid legal disqualification in public examinations .

KEY CONCEPT

Rationalization as a Historical Trajectory: Rationalization represents the historical transition wherein substantive, theoretical, and practical rationalities are progressively displaced by **Formal Rationality** . Simultaneously, traditional and affective actions give way to **Goal-Rational Action** .

(*Zweckrational*) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Four Rationalities:** Practical (pragmatic), Theoretical (intellectual), Substantive (value-led), Formal (rule/calculation-led) .
- **Western Uniqueness:** Modernity is characterised by the ascendancy of **formal rationality** .
- **Direction of Change:** Shift from substantive/traditional values toward formal calculability and *Zweckrational* conduct .

7.5.4 Causality: From Mono-causality to Adequate Causality

Thinker / Tradition	Is Sociology a Science?	Epistemological Grounding
Émile Durkheim	Yes .	Positivist study of objective, external social facts and invariant laws .
Karl Marx	Yes .	Scientific discovery of historical dialectics and the economic laws of capitalism .
Max Weber	Yes .	Interpretive science of social action analyzing cause and consequence through <i>Verstehen</i> .

KEY CONCEPT

Sociology as an Interpretive Science: Sociology is a science that attempts the interpretive understanding of social action in order thereby to arrive at a causal explanation of its course and effects . While social reality lacks absolute physical objectivity, rigorous objective study remains possible through **value neutrality** and **ideal types** .

Rejection of Mono-Causality Classical thinkers deployed deterministic, single-cause models :

- Marx: Economic base → determines superstructural consciousness .
- Durkheim: Demographic/dynamic density → causes division of labour and organic solidarity .

CRITICAL POINT

Weber rejected mono-causal determinism . What appears as direct causation in social science is a correlation between ideal-typical concepts . Because social concepts are analytical approximations rather than absolute entities, sociological explanations must be multi-causal and probabilistic .

KEY CONCEPT

Adequate Causality (*Adäquate Verursachung*):

- Natural Science Model: “If *X*, then necessarily *Y*” (Deterministic) .

- Weberian Social Science Model: “If X , then there is a high probability of Y under specific historical conditions” (Probabilistic) .
- The emergence of Western capitalism cannot be reduced to a single economic cause; it resulted from the probabilistic confluence of multiple factors (rational law, free labour, modern accounting, and the Protestant ethic) .

QUICK REVISION

- **Interpretive Science:** Causal explanation of social action based on probabilistic understanding .
- **Rejection of Mono-Causality:** Replaces economic or demographic determinism with multi-causal analysis .
- **Adequate Causality:** Probabilistic explanation of historical developments through ideal types .

7.5.5 Power, Legitimacy and Authority

Intellectual Context of Economy and Society Drafted in the final years of his life and left unfinished at his death in 1920, *Economy and Society* represents Weber’s mature sociology of domination . Following his death, Marianne Weber preserved, organized, and published his manuscripts .

DATA & FACTS

Marianne Weber was a prominent feminist scholar whose works were reviewed by Émile Durkheim, illustrating the intellectual intersections of early classical sociology .

KEY CONCEPT

History as the Struggle for Power: Weber diverged fundamentally from Marx by arguing that human history is driven by the struggle for **power and domination**, rather than class struggle alone . Even in a hypothetical communist society with abolished private property, inequalities of power and administrative domination would inevitably persist .

Definitions: Power, Legitimacy, and Domination

- **Power (*Macht*):** The probability that one actor within a social relationship will be in a position to carry out their will despite resistance, regardless of the basis on which this probability rests .
- **Authority / Domination (*Herrschaft*):** The probability that a command with a given specific content will be obeyed by a given group of persons .

CRITICAL POINT

Talcott Parsons’s English translation of *Herrschaft* as “authority” obscures Weber’s emphasis on structural **domination** . Authority exists only when power is accepted as legitimate by those subject to it .

EXAMPLE

- A citizen paying an administrative fine to a uniformed police officer acknowledges the legitimate authority of the legal role .
- If the same officer issues arbitrary personal commands outside statutory rules, compliance ceases because the order exceeds legitimate authority .
- Authority depends on the compliance of subordinates; when citizens withdraw recognition of legitimacy, political authority dissolves .

QUICK REVISION

- **History as Struggle for Power:** Power relations persist beyond economic class divisions .
- **Power (*Macht*):** Imposing will despite resistance .
- **Domination/Authority (*Herrschaft*):** Power legitimated by voluntary compliance .

7.5.6 The Three Ideal Types of Authority

Type of Authority	Source of Legitimacy	Historical / Modern Examples
Traditional Authority	Sanctity of immemorial traditions and the legitimate status of those exercising authority under them .	Hereditary monarchs; patriarchal household heads; feudal lords; pre-colonial dynasties .
Charismatic Authority	Devotion to the exceptional sanctity, heroism, or exemplary character of an individual leader .	Religious founders (Prophet Muhammad, Jesus Christ, Guru Nanak, Gautama Buddha); political figures (Mahatma Gandhi, Adolf Hitler, Barack Obama) .
Legal-Rational Authority	Legality of enacted rules and the right of those elevated to authority under such rules to issue commands .	Modern constitutional rulers; civil servants (IAS/IPS officers); public administrative bureaucracies .

Analytical Features of the Authority Types

- **Traditional Authority:** Operates through personal loyalty, customary obligations, and inherited status . Administration is carried out by personal retainers, favourites, or kinsmen .
- **Charismatic Authority:** Operates as a revolutionary force transcending established rules and traditions . The leader is perceived as a visionary or saviour in times of acute crisis . Charismatic authority is inherently unstable; to endure, it must undergo **routinization of charisma** into traditional or legal-rational institutions .
- **Legal-Rational Authority:** Operates through impersonal, codified statutes and procedural rules . Obedience is owed not to the individual official, but to the impersonal legal order that establishes the office .

QUICK REVISION

- **Traditional:** Grounded in custom, personal loyalty, and hereditary succession .
- **Charismatic:** Grounded in perceived extraordinary qualities; revolutionary but unstable; undergoes routinization .
- **Legal-Rational:** Grounded in impersonal, enacted rules, official jurisdiction, and constitutional procedures .

7.5.7 The Confluence: Social Action, Rationality and Authority

The core elements of Weberian sociology — Social Action, Rationality, Ideal Types, *Verstehen*, and Causality — integrate within the theory of authority :

Social Action of the Population	Corresponding Rationality	Legitimated Structure of Authority
Traditional Action	Practical Rationality	Traditional Authority
Affective & Value-Rational Action	Substantive Rationality	Charismatic Authority
Goal-Rational Action (<i>Zweckrational</i>)	Formal Rationality	Legal-Rational Authority

Integration of the System

1. **Traditional Authority:** Sustained when populations engage in traditional social action, accepting hereditary status as self-evident .
2. **Charismatic Authority:** Sustained when populations act through affective devotion and value-rational commitment, projecting extraordinary qualities onto a leader .
3. **Legal-Rational Authority:** Sustained when citizens act through goal-rational calculation, demanding formal rules, statutory jurisdiction, and institutional accountability .

CRITICAL POINT

The Epistemological Departure of Interpretive Sociology: Classical functionalism treated macro-structures as external forces that unilaterally govern individuals . Weber demonstrated the reverse: **macro-structures of authority are sustained by the subjective social actions and shared meanings of individual actors** . To explain the state, bureaucracy, or economic systems, sociologists must interpret the subjective meanings guiding human action .

EXAMPLE

Multi-Causal Voting Behaviour in Contemporary Elections: An individual's voting decision blends multiple orientations:

- *Charismatic:* Emotional appeal and personal attraction to a leader's rhetoric .
- *Traditional:* Historical family or community alignment with a political movement .
- *Goal-Rational:* Material calculation of policy outcomes, infrastructure delivery, or governance

performance .

Explaining electoral behaviour requires multi-causal, probabilistic models (**adequate causality**) rather than deterministic reductions .

QUICK REVISION

- **The Weberian Confluence:**
 - Traditional Action + Practical Rationality → **Traditional Authority** .
 - Affective/Value-Rational Action + Substantive Rationality → **Charismatic Authority** .
 - Goal-Rational Action + Formal Rationality → **Legal-Rational Authority** .
- **Epistemological Shift:** Macro-structures are established, maintained, and transformed through micro-level social actions .
- **Methodology:** Reality is analyzed through adequate causality and multi-causal probabilities .

7.6 Answer-Writing Toolkit

7.6.1 The Standard Body of a Sociology Answer

1. **Definition:** Define the core sociological concept immediately using precise theoretical terms .
2. **Presentation / Diagram:** Incorporate a clear conceptual schematic, flowchart, or matrix .
3. **Typology:** Detail the formal classifications or ideal-typical categories .
4. **Empirical Grounding:** Provide relevant, contemporary real-world and Indian sociological examples .
5. **Critical Counter-Perspective:** Systematically incorporate criticisms from competing paradigms (Marxist, Functionalist, Feminist, Phenomenological) .
6. **Applied Policy / Administration (Organic Linkage):** Reference constitutional provisions, statutory frameworks, or administrative schemes where relevant .
7. **Balanced Synthesis:** Conclude with contemporary relevance or a synthesis connecting micro and macro dimensions .

7.6.2 Essential Keywords and Conceptual Anchors

- **Marxian Alienation:** Species-being (*Gattungswesen*), *homo faber*, objectification, constant capital (*C*), variable capital (*V*), surplus value (*S*), commodity fetishism, reification (Lukács), culture industry (Adorno & Horkheimer), alienated leisure (Gorz, Marcuse), emotional labour (Hochschild), industrial automation (Blauner) .
- **Mode of Production:** Forces of production, relations of production, structural fetters, dialectical transformation, historical historicism, falsifiability (Karl Popper), gendered labour (Holmstrom, Firestone), female labour force participation (FLFPR) .
- **Weberian Methodology & Concepts:** *Verstehen*, subjective meaning (*Sinn*), ideal type, value relevance (*Wertbeziehung*), value neutrality (*Wertfreiheit*), adequate causality (*adäquate Verur-*

sachung), rationalization, disenchantment of the world (*Entzauberung*), iron cage (*stahlhartes Gehiise*), McDonaldization (Ritzer), power (*Macht*), domination/authority (*Herrschaft*), routinization of charisma .

7.6.3 Core Diagrams and Comparative Models

- **Alienation Trajectory:** Linear diagram showing declining species-being from Primitive Communism → Ancient → Feudal → Peak Alienation in Capitalism .
- **Mode of Production Engine:** Two-wire dialectical model connecting Forces of Production with Relations of Production .
- **Alienation vs. Anomie Matrix:** Structural comparison (moral deregulation vs. class exploitation; reform in structure vs. revolution of structure) .
- **Weberian Triadic Confluence:** Structural matrix linking the four Social Actions → the four Rationalities → the three Authority Structures via Adequate Causality .

7.6.4 Examination Strategy and Time Management

- **Word Discipline:** Target approximately 250 words for 20-mark questions; prioritize analytical depth and dimensional variety over descriptive length .
- **Structural Uniformity:** Paragraph formats and point formats are equally effective; organize responses around clear conceptual definitions .
- **Overcoming Writer's Block:** When encountering ambiguous or indirect questions, begin by defining the core sociological concept .
- **Preliminary Exam Management:** Review previous five-year question patterns, target at least 88 question attempts, and use systematic elimination techniques .

QUICK REVISION

- Master the seven-step answer structure .
- Deploy precise sociological vocabulary across all questions .
- Use clear conceptual diagrams and multi-dimensional matrices .
- Maintain spatial and word discipline (250 words per 20-mark answer) .

Max Weber and Talcott Parsons

8.1 Max Weber: Disenchantment, Authority and Bureaucracy

8.1.1 *Disenchantment (Revision of a Student Doubt)*

A student asked for disenchantment to be explained once again . The meaning is very simple: disenchantment means that you are no longer enchanted .

KEY CONCEPT

To be no longer enchanted means that you no longer believe in the magical, spiritual, traditional world . Put plainly: you no longer believe in the concept of God; you no longer believe in the concept of souls and spirits; you no longer believe in the concept of caste; you no longer believe in the concept of the joint family . All those traditional elements and values are over . You have become completely rational .

The Candlelight Dinner Analogy Suppose you go on a date with a girl . It is a candlelight dinner in the open, near the beach in Goa . The girl says, “Wow, what a beautiful night, such a starry night, so many stars, they are twinkling, that is so romantic” . And then the boy says: this is due to refraction of light .

The next morning it is rainy and a beautiful rainbow appears . She asks for a photograph with the rainbow, and the boy says there is nothing special about it—it is total internal reflection of light .

When you start giving explanations in a fully rational manner to everything around you, you lose the magic, you lose the charm, you lose the beauty of the world . That is what we call a disenchanted man, woman or person .

The Bureaucrat Speaks the Same Way This is exactly how a bureaucrat speaks . You go to a bureaucrat in a full emotional state, and he speaks in a fully rational, law-bound manner “according to CRPC code 345” . It is the same reaction the girl receives when she is told it is total internal reflection of light .

CRITICAL POINT

There is no difference between the disenchanted person and that bureaucrat . Both are dehumanized, both are completely rational . This is what the world is going to become . This is what Max Weber said .

QUICK REVISION

- Disenchantment = no longer enchanted = no longer believing in the magical, spiritual, traditional world (God, soul, caste, joint family) .
- Analogy: stars explained as refraction; rainbow explained as total internal reflection—the charm dies .
- The disenchanted person and the rule-quoting bureaucrat are the same type: dehumanized, completely rational .

8.1.2 Authority and the Basis of Legitimacy

In each form of authority, you have given legitimacy . You have given legitimacy to those authorities to rule over you . The form of legitimacy is very simple .

Why Do You Obey the Prime Minister? Today you have given legitimacy to the Prime Minister to rule over you . If asked what the basis of that legitimacy is, you will say the Constitution . But let us be very honest—it is not only the Constitution . It was also the charisma of that leader—the Modi wave . This is a fact . And let us be more honest: it was also tradition . Tradition has somehow played a very big role .

KEY CONCEPT

Reality is highly complex and cannot be captured through concepts . That is why we form only models . Weberians would never say that this is what absolute reality is . They would say it is a model—largely a trend, not the absolute reality .

The American Example: Trump versus Hillary Clinton Consider the election in the USA in which Trump fought against Hillary Clinton . People voted for Trump . What could have been the reason?

1. **Charisma**—the way he used to speak . He connected with the masses because he used to sound very ordinary, and so he spoke in a very simple fashion . This was the first thing that attracted people .
2. **Restoring the great American pride**—he believed past leaders of America were responsible for the current state of the economy, that the economy was in doldrums, that America had been wasting funds on defence in Iran, Iraq and Afghanistan, and that this had to stop . In this he also sounded very rational .
3. **Legal-rational element**—he belonged to the Republican Party . A political party is a legal-rational authority; it is not a religious organisation .
4. **Gender**—the fourth factor was that he was male, and this cannot be ignored . Hillary Clinton could have become the first woman president; for so long no woman president has been elected . Somehow the role of patriarchy plays a role in elections .

KEY CONCEPT

Patriarchal bargain: in order to exercise power, Hillary Clinton bargained with patriarchy—she exchanged power by carrying a patriarchal tone and attitude into the election and into her speeches .

But largely, the Prime Minister rules us on the basis of the Constitution . Largely, this has been the trend . We can no longer say that India today is governed by Brahmins, which at one point of time was the case .

EXAMPLE

We used to have Brahmanical authority . Brahmins used to decide everything; even the kings used to get appointed by Brahmins . There was no democracy—people did not elect people; it was Brahmins who elected people to the throne .

That too was legitimate authority . Legitimacy is now given to legal-rational authority on the basis of rules and regulations .

Why We Obey Charismatic Figures When it comes to heroic, charismatic, supernatural-quality-possessing leaders—Gandhi, Hitler, Mother Teresa, Jesus Christ, Prophet Muhammad, Lord Buddha, Guru Nanak—we are not obeying them or giving them legitimacy to command us on the basis of the Constitution . We are simply enthralled by the heroic and supernatural qualities those people possess .

- They induce hope in a hopeless situation .
- They somehow give us salvation and pacify our concerns .
- They make us believe that this crisis period will be over very soon—“trust me, yes we can” .
- People fall in love with those heroic qualities and start looking at that person as someone directly sent by God to the earth .

KEY CONCEPT

What is legitimacy? Legitimacy is justification—what actually justified their rule . The reasons for justification have been different throughout history, but justification is justification; only the reasons differ .

The Legitimacy of Traditional Rulers The reason for traditional authority to rule upon us has largely been legitimacy on the basis of ancient traditions or texts .

- Why should there be the rule of the Queen in England? Today the Queen is simply a ceremonial, nominal head—not the executive head—but at one point of time she was the executive head . What gave legitimacy was ancient tradition and text: the monarch was sent directly to earth by God from heaven . Religious texts used to give legitimacy .
- In ancient India, Kanishka of the Kushan empire was called *Devaputra*—son of God . That is the kind of title we used to give .
- The first invaders of India—Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushans—were all traditional authorities . None of them ruled upon us on the basis of a constitution, nor purely on the basis of heroic qualities . Largely it was the ancient text or tradition that legitimised them .
- In the Greek texts one finds a connection established between the Greek and Indian civilisations—that is why we always say Indo-Greek . The claim was that our culture, our language, our civilisations have been quite similar, and this justified their rule .

EXAMPLE

The British in India: they first made us believe that we are uncivilised and not capable enough to govern ourselves . It was not that they directly conquered or annexed India . They first took permission from Jahangir to establish a port . Why did the British obey Jahangir? Because Jahangir was a traditional authority, standing in the lineage of the Mughal emperors . That is why they did not challenge him—they obeyed him and took permission .

QUICK REVISION

- Legitimacy = justification for rule; the reasons differ across history, the need for justification does not .
- The PM's legitimacy mixes constitution + charisma + tradition—reality is complex, so Weber offers only models and trends .
- Trump's victory read through four factors: charisma, restoring national pride, party (legal-rational), and gender/patriarchy; Hillary Clinton's "patriarchal bargain" .
- Charismatic figures are obeyed because they induce hope in hopeless situations; traditional rulers are obeyed on the strength of ancient texts and traditions (Devaputra, monarchy by divine sanction, Indo-Greek claims, Jahangir and the British) .

8.1.3 Ideal Types of Traditional Authority

Max Weber has done a very rigorous analysis of each and every thing in the world . The ideal types of traditional authority are the following keywords, which are going to help you be different from other candidates :

1. Gerontocracy
2. Primary patriarchalism
3. Patrimonialism, also called prebendalism
4. Sultanism—the extreme version of patrimonialism

CRITICAL POINT

A student asked whether traditional and charismatic authority may be illegitimate for someone . Yes, definitely . Even the rule of the present Prime Minister is considered illegitimate by many people—they believe EVM machines have been hacked, that the Supreme Court and High Court and other institutions have been demolished, that police and army officials were involved, and that the media has become subjugated to the whims and fancies of the leader . But that does not change the fact that he is the Prime Minister .

Gerontocracy—Rule of the Elderly Gerontocracy simply means rule of the elderly . The root word *geron* describes elderly people; *-cracy* means rule, while *-logy* means study . Gerontology as a discipline talks about care, health and death; gerontocracy is a form of authority .

- Example: Sparta . Or any village community—the village panchayat, where the elderly, anyone considered above 60, are ruling .
- Plato once said that anyone below 50 should not be the ruler of the nation state—anyone

below 50 should not be eligible to be the ruler .

- That means the factor to become ruler is age . The legitimacy you give to that person to rule upon you is age . The elderly could rule because we had given them legitimacy and we gave it because they were elderly .
- This happens in tribal societies, in village societies, in Sparta, in the Greek and Roman empires and even in modern civilisations .
- Have we not had the rule of the elderly only since independence? Only the elderly are ruling . We are seeing the reality, but we must also see the concept in the same way . This is just a model .

CRITICAL POINT

Students of public administration, in the name of bureaucracy, know only IAS and IPS . Their understanding of bureaucracy is un-Weberian—they read only the surface, even when reading Weber's own model . The way they read Max Weber and the way we read Max Weber are very different .

Primary Patriarchalism Primary patriarchalism basically operates at the level of the household or family . It is the rule of the father at home; the father is the head of the household .

- Even in joint families we have rule of the elderly—gerontocracy—and most of those elderly would be men .
- The concepts mix, because reality itself is like that . We only take the help of models to get closer to reality, and then we find that in this model too, that reality is fitting in . Reality is highly vast and complex .

Patrimonialism—The Most Important Concept Among the traditional authorities, patrimonialism is considered the most important one . Think of it simply: the rule of the father at home has been extended . Now the home has been replaced by the country, and the father is the ruler . When patriarchy is extended to a larger state, that becomes patrimonialism .

KEY CONCEPT

Patrimonialism is the extended version of primary patriarchalism . The only difference: primary patriarchalism as a concept operates in the household or family; patrimonialism is beyond the family .

In patrimonial authority the ruler says: all you people are like my family—the old man, the old woman, the fasting one, the poor, the rich, all of you are my family, and I take responsibility of this family, called India . This is exactly how leaders speak . What is Max Weber studying? Social action—every time . And along with that he is moving to bigger and bigger levels, to large-scale social structures as well .

Features of Patrimonialism

1. The administration and military are loyalists—loyal to the leader, not to the nation . When military and administration are loyal to the leader rather than the nation, that is patrimonialism . And that leader may well have had charisma; of course, that is why he could become leader .

Reality is not so segregated or layered; we are only using concepts .

2. The administrators are appointed on the basis of contacts—kin relations or any personal affiliation . Which means not on the basis of merit . There is no merit, only contact .
3. The administration and military are the personal instrument of the master .
4. There is no clear-cut division between public and private ends . The so-called salary of administrators or military officers is not given from the treasury . Today the salary of an IAS, IPS or army officer is given from a fund of India; but in those times there was no such contingency fund or consolidated fund . The treasury existed, but it was used only for the expenses of the leader—no other person could take a salary from it .

DATA & FACTS

What then was the source of salary? Bribe, corruption and loot . It was not a fixed income . The official had full authority to take a bribe because he was an official; he could coerce the people to give bribes precisely because he was an official . Remember, this is a model—a model having certain features—not reality .

Ideal Type as Mental Construct Remember this very important thing: this is an ideal type . An ideal type is a mental construct . Mental construct means that in reality you would not find the actual type . These are only highly accentuated or exaggerated features of patrimonialism . What Marx presented to us in the name of capitalism was not capitalism; it was only exaggerated features of capitalism that made us believe we were studying capitalism .

Patrimonial Bureaucracy: Examples The Mughal Empire of India was a patrimonial bureaucracy . Remember this word .

- Bureaucracy is not exclusive to modern society . Even in traditional societies we had bureaucrats—the treasurers you have read about, the *dhamma mahamatras* who spread the culture and religion in Ashoka's time, the treasurers of the Gupta empire .
- The Mauryan empire is largely believed to be an empire having a great degree of bureaucracy: proper administration for the navy, the treasury, the administration of horses and elephants, with committees; and the *Arthashastra* clearly outlined the working of that bureaucratic machinery—it was all about the economic and political administration of the Mauryas .
- Even ancient Egypt, the Chinese empire and the Babylonian regime are patrimonial bureaucracies .

COMPARISON

Empire versus nation: during the Mughal regime there was no conception of India, no conception of nation as such—it was an empire, not a nation . In an empire you are indebted to the leader of the empire . In a nation it is not the rule of the leader, it is the rule of law; the leader is not over and above the law . In the Mughal empire the leaders were over and above all the laws; the administration and military were personal instruments, like slaves to those leaders .

Sultanism The extreme form of patrimonialism is sultanism . We do not have to go into these details, but you should have these keywords—because when you read editorials talking about the falling state of democracy, or that democracy in India is not the same that we had, you should

have a sense of what they are actually talking about: what they think the ideal type of democracy is, against which they have measured this lower degree and concluded that it is a failed or flawed democracy .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The scholar Christophe Jaffrelot calls the current Prime Minister's rule that of sultanism—that it is a sultan ruling India, not a democratic leader . This is how the controversy develops and why people start calling him fascist . Why sultan? Because when media, Supreme Court, High Court, CBI, CVC, NITI Aayog and the press—when every instrument of administration appears to have become the mouthpiece of the leader, it gives the impression that it is a sultan ruling us and not a democratic leader . Sultanism means that the administration has become the personal instrument of the master .

QUICK REVISION

- Four ideal types of traditional authority: gerontocracy, primary patriarchalism, patrimonialism (prebendalism), sultanism .
- Gerontocracy = rule of the elderly (Sparta, village panchayat, Plato's bar of 50); the legitimising factor is age .
- Primary patriarchalism = rule of the father within the household; patrimonialism = the same extended to the state .
- Four features of patrimonialism: loyalty to leader not nation; appointment by contacts not merit; administration as personal instrument of the master; no separation of public and private ends, with salary coming from bribe, corruption and loot .
- Ideal type is a mental construct of accentuated features; Mughal, ancient Egyptian, Chinese and Babylonian regimes are cited as patrimonial bureaucracies, and Jaffrelot's "sultanism" is the extreme case applied to contemporary India .

8.1.4 Charismatic Authority

Charisma is something that has wings . If you see charisma in a leader, there are very high chances that you may see the same charisma in his son or daughter—the charisma has flown to the other leader . For example, Rajiv Gandhi and Indira Gandhi—you see a similar charisma in them . You may not see the same in Rahul Gandhi today, but that does not make him someone who is not from the Nehru family; he still is from the Nehru family .

Charismatic authority simply is authority that gains legitimacy on the basis of the heroic, extraordinary qualities that the leader possesses .

KEY CONCEPT

Charismatic authority comes in the times of crisis . Whenever society is going through a period of crisis, you will see charismatic authority developing . You start seeing charisma in that person only because you know the context—it is the crisis in society that has made you look out for someone who could bring back the same power or the same pride . Such crises are not frequent; they happen once in hundreds of years . That is why such leaders are born once in hundreds of

years, and why in hundreds of years you remember only two or three leaders .

Illustrations from the Lecture

- **Hitler**—this is what Max Weber believed when Germany lost World War II: he was looking for someone who could bring the same pride to Germany once again . And afterwards Hitler came in 1933, and people considered him a charismatic personality . *[as stated in lecture]*
- **Gandhi**—it was the crisis situation India was going through . We were oppressed under the British empire and we wanted freedom, liberation .
- **Lord Buddha**—the lower castes were oppressed and were looking for someone who could free them from the oppressive caste structure . It was mainly the Vaishyas, who belong to the third category in the status group, who wanted to improve their status, because their status had been kept very low by the Brahmins . Lord Buddha came in and told them there is no such thing as caste or Vaishya; he challenged the Brahmins .

Features of Charismatic Authority

1. Charismatic authority is a historic and transitory phenomenon . When society is in a transition phase, the leader comes to help society move through that transition into a smoother, better world: Gandhi comes to help India become free; Lord Buddha comes to help the lower castes become free of oppressive caste structures; Hitler comes to liberate Germany from whatever he presents as the barrier to a great Germany .
2. They develop during the times of crisis .
3. They legitimize their authority on the basis of ancient traditions . Hitler would legitimize himself by taking recourse to the great Aryan rule—the white supremacy, Aryanhood, and the claim that this Aryanhood is in threat . Gandhi would talk about ancient Hindu texts to show that Hindus have always lived in an egalitarian system—he would talk about the Rig Veda and the Bhagavad Gita, to ensure that we live in a peaceful, harmonious fashion .
4. The charismatic leader may be a hero or he may even be a tyrant .

Routinization of Charisma Now where is the problem? The person came during the times of crisis and his rule was transitory . What happens when he dies?

KEY CONCEPT

Write this under the heading **Routinization of Charisma** . On the death of the charismatic leader, the charisma gets routinized—that is, transferred—either to the next generation, or it takes the form of a traditional authority or a legal-rational authority .

- **Example 1—Prophet Muhammad:** When Prophet Muhammad died, some people believed his son possessed the charisma; some believed the half-brother, Abu Bakr, possessed it . Some believed one man was the legitimate heir to Prophet Muhammad, others said no . The Shia-Sunni divide came from there . *[as stated in lecture]* Shia and Sunni became sects, with their own boards and institutions—Shia board, Sunni board—and different administrative organisations catering to the interests of Shias or Sunnis . Not just that: we have nation states which are Shia and Sunni today . Saudi Arabia as a Sunni state; Lebanon, Jordan, Iraq, Iran

and Syria as Shia states, with Syria being Alawite Shiite . *[as stated in lecture]* The charisma also assumed the form of a text—the Holy Quran—which is traditional authority: ancient tradition and text . The boards and organisations are legal-rational authorities .

- **Example 2—Lord Buddha:** Lord Buddha died, and Buddhism got developed after that as a religion . When Buddha was alive there was no religion called Buddhism; only after his death did Buddhism come in . It also came as text—the three Pitakas in Buddhism .
- **Example 3—Guru Nanak:** On the death of Guru Nanak, Sikhism developed as a religion . The same charisma that Guru Nanak possessed also got passed on to the other nine gurus . After all the gurus, the last guru was the Guru Granth Sahib—traditional authority, ancient text and tradition . This text possessed the charisma of all the gurus . We also have Gurdwaras, Gurdwara Prabandhak Committees, the Akali Party—political parties, that is legal-rational authority—Punjab as a state, and the Khalistan movement . All of this is charisma continuing to travel .

QUICK REVISION

- Charismatic authority = legitimacy resting on heroic, extraordinary qualities; charisma “has wings” and can pass to descendants (Indira and Rajiv Gandhi) .
- It is a historic and transitory phenomenon, arises in times of crisis, legitimises itself through ancient traditions, and its bearer may be a hero or a tyrant .
- Crises come once in hundreds of years—hence only two or three such leaders are remembered (Gandhi, Buddha, Hitler as the lecture’s cases) .
- Routinization of charisma: on the leader’s death charisma transfers to the next generation or converts into traditional authority (Quran, Guru Granth Sahib, three Pitakas) or legal-rational authority (boards, committees, parties, states) .

8.1.5 Legal-Rational Authority

Legal-rational authority is authority that is legitimized on the basis of rules and regulations . But the question is: what are rules and regulations? We had rules and regulations even during the Mughal empire .

CRITICAL POINT

People may say: but we did not have a constitution . So what—that is just one form . It is not that unless you have a constitution you do not have rules . In Britain there is no written constitution; they are running by an unwritten one . So you cannot say they do not have formal rules and regulations .

Therefore: legal-rational authority is legitimized on the basis of formal codes, rules and regulations . Weber did not define what a formal code is because all of these are ideal types only . Remember one most important thing: according to Max Weber, legal-rational authority represents the modern bureaucracy .

What Modern Bureaucracies Have

- A formal code of conduct and written rules of appointment .

- Appointment not on the basis of contacts but on the basis of merit .
- As an administrator you are not loyal to the minister—you are loyal to the Constitution . You are not even loyal to the President; even if the President tells you something, you may say no, because your loyalty is to the Constitution . You are not a loyalist to anyone .
- Modern bureaucracy is highly rational, not emotional; fully bound by laws and legal regulations . It performs *zweckrational* social action and is driven by formal rationality .

Did we have this form of bureaucracy in the Mughal empire or the Mauryan empire? No—and why not will become clear when bureaucracy is taught as the next topic .

KEY CONCEPT

In conclusion: Max Weber believed that legal-rational authority is the marker of modernity . All those traditional societies which were run by traditional bureaucracies could not develop the modern form of economy, the modern form of judiciary, or the modern form of capitalism .

CRITICAL POINT

Remember: capitalism existed then and exists now; bureaucracy existed then and exists now . The forms of capitalism and bureaucracy have changed . Rules may be written or unwritten; officials may not be appointed by competitive examination or on merit—they may be appointed on the basis of the spoils system—but still they are bureaucrats, they are officials . There may not be a clear-cut separation between private and public ends, but bureaucracy is still there .

QUICK REVISION

- Legal-rational authority is legitimised by formal codes, rules and regulations—a constitution is only one form of these (Britain runs on an unwritten one) .
- It represents modern bureaucracy: formal code of conduct, written rules of appointment, merit-based recruitment, loyalty only to the Constitution, rule-bound and unemotional conduct .
- It is driven by formal rationality and performs *zweckrational* social action .
- Conclusion dictated in class: legal-rational authority is the marker of modernity; traditional societies run by traditional bureaucracies could not develop modern economy, judiciary or capitalism .

8.1.6 Bureaucracy: Definition and Scope

Here comes the difference between political science, public administration and sociology . The way you are going to read bureaucracy is very different from the way a student of public administration or political science reads it . Max Weber is ours—he was a sociologist . He was never a political scientist and never a public administration academic .

KEY CONCEPT

Bureaucracy is an organizational model, rationally designed to achieve the task in an efficient manner . Write it exactly like this . Basically it is a machine—a machine used to bring efficiency in

the organization . This is what Max Weber calls machine-like efficiency . Bureaucracy is a model . It is not reality .

Bureaucracy Is Not Limited to Government Bureaucracy is not limited to the government . Since it is an organizational model, you see bureaucracy everywhere :

- In schools, colleges and universities
- In hospitals
- In political parties, in the theatre, in hotels and clubs
- In shopping malls
- In political administration
- And even in religious organisations

CRITICAL POINT

When public administration teaches Max Weber, it limits him only to political administration—but Max Weber himself never limited bureaucracy to political administration .

Why an Ideal Type Is Needed Since we know we have bureaucracy in every sphere of society, the question is how to study such a vast reality . A single man cannot study such a vast reality; therefore a model has to be constructed, and that model is the ideal type .

KEY CONCEPT

Next line: since bureaucracy is a vast reality, a model—that is, an ideal type—is constructed to highlight the most accentuated features or typical characteristics of bureaucracy . Accentuated features means typical characteristics . What we are going to study in the name of bureaucracy is a model having certain features; it is not the absolute reality .

QUICK REVISION

- Bureaucracy is an organizational model rationally designed to achieve tasks efficiently—a machine delivering machine-like efficiency .
- It is a model, not reality, and it is not confined to government: schools, universities, hospitals, parties, hotels, malls, theatres and religious organisations all display it .
- Weber was a sociologist, so the sociological reading of bureaucracy is wider than the public-administration reading .
- Because the reality is vast, an ideal type is constructed to highlight the most accentuated or typical characteristics .

8.1.7 Features of the Ideal Type of Bureaucracy

1. **Division of Labour:** When you become an IAS or IPS officer you will be allocated a district . In that district you will have many other officers as well—some governing law, some revenue collection, some postal services, some trade or military defence . That means bureaucracy is a model running on division of labour, and division of labour ensures efficiency . Write down:

division of labour is implemented to ensure efficient performance of the tasks . The same is true in any organisation—a technical team, a content team, a video team, a graphics team . Division of labour is there, and that is what bureaucracy is all about .

2. **Merit-Based Recruitment:** When you become an IAS, that is based on merit, not on contacts . If we have a technical team, that is purely on merit, because we want good performance . We cannot afford people who come solely by contacts; we need efficient workers . Merit is something that has to be judged . How do we judge someone's merit? We look for experience . A person may even be asked to write a test on a specific thing .
3. **Written Rules:** Rules are codified . Nothing will be done orally . For example, if an employee takes a taxi home and comes the next day for reimbursement, he would be asked to produce and submit everything in return . Nothing is done orally . Even in political administration specifically, you will do everything in written form—there will be letters signed by district collectors that are passed down . Even in universities everything is based on written documents; everything is written and codified .
4. **Strict Separation of Private and Official Income:** Whatever things are available at your disposal as an administrator, you cannot use those things for your personal gain . When you become an IAS officer you will have a computer on your table—you cannot take that computer to your home . It stays there . You will have a pen, stationery, a printer, a very nice table—these are official . You may even write this as strict separation of private and official ends rather than income .
5. **Officials Cannot Improvise:** You cannot change the rules . Rules are already laid out; you just have to act on them . Suppose as an officer you create a special exception for someone very close to you—a close relative comes to you for help and you change the rules specially to help that person out . That cannot be done . You cannot afford to be emotional or creative, or create a special grant or exception for someone .
6. **Impersonal Relations:** Impersonality is also one feature of bureaucracy, and it is very similar to the rule that officials cannot improvise . When you talk to your client, that has to be a purely impersonal relation . This is what modern society is all about: there is no place for emotion . It is not *Gemeinschaft*, it is *Gesellschaft* . It is not simple, mechanical solidarity having similar consciousness; it is specialised division of labour and organic solidarity . A *blasé* attitude—not unconcerned exactly, but basically not emotional . Whether it is your mother, your father, your son, your daughter, your friend, or someone you do not know—all are equal to you . That is impersonal relation .
7. **Hierarchy—Chain of Command:** Whether you are a teacher in a school, a professor in a university, a political administrator under government machinery, or a staff member at a shopping mall, all of us have to obey the orders given by our superiors . A teacher obeys the principal; a professor obeys the vice chancellor; an assistant collector obeys the collector; the collector obeys the chief secretary . There is a long chain of command that you cannot escape . If you do not obey, that has to be justified only on the basis of rules . You cannot simply say “I will not obey you”; you must cite a justified rule—“I cannot do this, officer, because this is beyond the ambit within which I can work” . So if an MLA comes to you and asks for a favour, you are free not to obey him . Even with higher officials, you are free not to obey them if that refusal is based on rules . But if the order is within the rules, you will have to obey—you have

no choice .

KEY CONCEPT

Write down one more line . Max Weber says that the endeavour—the attempt of all modern world societies is to approach or get closer to the ideal type of bureaucracy . It is the modern bureaucracy, not bureaucracy as such . We had bureaucracy even in the Mughal empire, but that was not merit-based, not purely impersonal, and had no strict separation between private and public ends .

QUICK REVISION

- Seven features of the ideal type: division of labour, merit-based recruitment, written (codified) rules, strict separation of private and official ends, no improvisation by officials, impersonal relations, and hierarchy/chain of command .
- Division of labour is implemented to ensure efficient performance of tasks; merit is judged through experience or testing .
- Impersonality places bureaucracy in *Gesellschaft* and organic solidarity, not *Gemeinschaft*—mother, friend and stranger are treated alike .
- Disobedience is legitimate only when justified by a rule—which is why an MLA's or even a senior's illegitimate order can be refused .
- Weber: the endeavour of all modern societies is to approach the ideal type of modern bureaucracy; nobody has reached it .

8.1.8 Bureaucracy in Reality: The Distance from the Model

Since we know that what we have read is not bureaucracy but a model of bureaucracy, the reality is different—and this model can be used to understand the differences between reality and the model .

Feature of the Model	What the Lecture Points Out in Reality
Strict separation of private and public ends	In every bureaucracy of the world there is corruption; public power is used to serve private ends . Officers take bribes because permission comes only from them; earnings happen under the table .
Merit-based recruitment and hierarchy	The chain of command is not sacred; it has been violated many times . People become senior or supersede others on the basis of contacts or personal affinal relations developed with the senior-most person in the chain .
Impersonality and equal treatment	In IAS, IPS and many bureaucracies you would not see lower-caste people promoted to the upper rungs; largely upper-caste men, or at any rate men, are promoted to the upper level .
Universal access to the top	Lower castes and women gain entry but do not reach the top level . If one or two do, it becomes an exception—and an exception is not a general rule .

EXAMPLE

You will see corruption even in the Supreme Court and in universities . Only recently, the head of a department of political science was chosen when someone else—the senior-most according to the seniority principle—should have been there . Mughal bureaucracy was still bureaucracy, although not on this model: it was patrimonial bureaucracy . Things at their disposal—horses, elephants, cavalry—could be used for personal gain . Today, if you get a horse as an IAS officer from the Government of India, you cannot go for a ride on it .

QUICK REVISION

- The ideal type is a measuring rod: the gap between model and reality is itself the finding .
- Corruption everywhere shows the absence of strict separation of private and public ends .
- Hierarchy exists but does not run in a streamlined fashion—contacts and personal relations break the seniority principle .
- Caste and gender ceilings mean the promise of impersonal, merit-based promotion is not realised; the exceptions do not make a rule .

8.1.9 *The Iron Cage and the Irrationality of Rationality*

KEY CONCEPT

Write down: Max Weber believed that the bureaucratization of society is inevitable . The more we get developed or advanced, the more we get bureaucratized . And therefore it is an iron cage which cannot be escaped by humanity—this is an iron cage of rationality . Underline, highlight, italicise: it is developed as a result of a large number of people performing instrumental social action and exhibiting formal rationality .

Therefore the modern world is a highly disenchanted world—a world having no space for values, customs, traditions, emotions and affection, but a space reserved only and only for efficiency, stability, calculability, rationality and predictability . That is formal rationality .

CRITICAL POINT

And therefore it is not rationality that is going to drive the world; rather it is the irrationality of rationality that is going to occupy the world .

The Trajectory of Rationalization This is what the trajectory of societies has been historically . From the dark ages till the modern ages, it is nothing but rationalization that has been going on .

- First we questioned religion . Authority was no longer based on religion; now it was based on constitutionalism . It was no longer tradition, customs, religion—rather it was a man coming to power purely on the basis of the Constitution .
- We questioned all the traditions . Patriarchy was questioned—Mary Wollstonecraft questioned patriarchy in the French Revolution . So the world would no longer be run only by men; women can also rule .
- The world would no longer be run by a religion, a gender or a caste . In India we have been ruled by caste for so long—by Brahmins . Today anybody can become the Prime Minister, Chief Minister or a bureaucrat irrespective of his caste .
- That means traditions, customs, values and emotions have been sidelined . What is rewarded is merit and efficiency—rationality, calibre, the ability to perform the task in the least time allotted . It does not matter whether you are Brahmin or Dalit, man or woman .
- Rationality, efficiency, calculability and predictability are the principles on which the world now runs . Rationalization has been going on, and this implies disenchantment—you are no longer enchanted with patriarchal rule, no longer enchanted with Brahmins who were believed to possess magical spirits .

What the Rational Individual Has Become This is rationality: a fully planned day, routine, scheduled, completely disconnected from emotions—not talking to parents, not talking to friends, not going out with friends, no fun time, no entertainment . All the values gone; completely rational, goal-oriented, instrumental man or woman is what we are turning into . And this is what Max Weber cautioned us against .

Examples of the Irrationality of Rationality

EXAMPLE

- **MCQ-based selection:** today people become professors, toppers or bureaucrats on the basis of MCQs, because efficiency is what we strive for—maximum result in minimum time . But are you creating creative individuals, or rote learners? People become rote learners, because there is no written examination; you cannot check them on analysis, only on which option is right, which can easily be rote learned . Go through previous year questions, rote learn in two or three days, tick the same thing, and once you are out you forget everything . We are creating rote learners, not learned individuals .
- **TRP in newsrooms:** TRP is rewarded, and what are we creating in its name? Fake news and yellow journalism . When TRP is rewarded, fake news spreads, because fake news gets maximum viewership .
- **The bureaucrat who cannot serve:** you become a bureaucrat to serve the public, but you cannot serve the public because you are bound by the Constitution and by rules . The rules have come in between you and the public . You cannot improvise, cannot go beyond the rules, cannot help anyone within a minute . The person before you may be dying, but the rules ask you to first get a report written . The rules are more important .
- **McDonald's:** you eat there because it is cheaper and saves time . The consequence is obesity, non-nutritious food, environmental degradation and generation of plastic; the world gets more and more toxic .
- **Cars and transport:** produced in the name of efficiency, leading to environmental degradation—and every car is produced by manual labour in the mines, which is the most dangerous work for anyone's health, where health standards are not followed . You only see the finished product, not what is happening backstage . This is commodity fetishism—you do not realise the labour that has gone into it; you only fetishize commodities .
- **GDP and the environment:** we calculate a nation's development in terms of GDP, but this GDP comes at the cost of gross national happiness and of the environment—which is why another programme, the SDGs, became necessary . Potable water is decreasing, groundwater has receded, global warming has melted ice sheets, pollution is carried by jet streams into the darker regions, and even Antarctica is going to be over very soon .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Alvin Toffler, author of *Future Shock*, is described in the lecture as a very great sociologist whose predictions of the 1960s are actually happening today . Sociology is a very young discipline—barely a hundred years old—but the claim made in class is that after two hundred years sociology will replace every social science, because sociology is not philosophy .

QUICK REVISION

- Bureaucratization is inevitable: the more advanced the society, the more bureaucratized—an inescapable iron cage of rationality .
- The cage is built by large numbers of people performing instrumental social action and exhibiting formal rationality .

- The modern world is therefore disenchanted: no space for values, customs, tradition, emotion or affection—only efficiency, stability, calculability, rationality and predictability .
- The result is not rationality but the irrationality of rationality: MCQs producing rote learners, TRP producing fake news, rule-bound officers unable to help a dying person, McDonald's producing obesity and plastic, GDP produced at the cost of happiness and environment .
- Commodity fetishism names the failure to see the labour behind the finished product .

8.1.10 Weber's Ambivalence and the Bridge to Protestant Ethics

CRITICAL POINT

Max Weber—and specifically Max Weber—did not give any opinion on bureaucracy . He was ambivalent; ambivalent means he was confused . He did not really know what to call this bureaucracy: is it efficient and should we be happy about it, or is it leading to irrationality and we should not be happy about it? What should be done? Can any individual do anything about it? You would say you can change the system . But can you? You become systematized when you enter the system .

That is why very few IAS, IPS or other officers become famous in their fields only because they have gone beyond the rules . They did not limit themselves to the bureaucratic regime that asked them to obey the seniority chain of command; they actually went beyond it, and that is why they became the highlight of the newsrooms . When you do not obey, you become the highlight—and that is an exception .

Where Does All of This Come From? Max Weber is telling us through his book: whatever changes you have read so far in history—formal rationality, *zweckrational* social action, legal-rational authority—where are these things coming from? What is the source of a man, an emotional man, thinking rationally? What is the source of a man not being concerned about any person but only about his goal, his plan, his schedule?

KEY CONCEPT

The source of all these things is Protestant theology, which we also call the Reformation . There were two historic events in world history: one was the Renaissance, and the second was the Reformation—the Protestant Reformation . Everything got changed with this only . And remember, this book is one of the biggest critiques of Marx .

The next question is how Marx, Weber and Protestantism—four seemingly different realities—are connected to each other, and how they connect to the way we act rationally right now .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber gave no verdict on bureaucracy—he was ambivalent about whether it is efficiency to be welcomed or irrationality to be feared .
- Individual escape is doubtful: you become systematized on entering the system, and the officers who become famous are the exceptions who went beyond the rules .

- The source of formal rationality, *zweckrational* action and legal-rational authority is Protestant theology, i.e. the Reformation .
- The Renaissance and the Reformation are the two historic events; the *Protestant Ethic* is one of the biggest critiques of Marx .

8.1.11 Doubts Answered in Class

Is the irrationality of rationality simply the loss of the human element because of rules? Yes . The irrationality of rationality implies losing the human element . Disenchantment is nothing but the irrationality of rationality; it leads to it .

Did Weber, in the end, become a positivist? He did not become a positivist . Remember this . He never gave any law . Why can you not give a law as Weber? Because Marx and Durkheim are interested in looking at the world as an objective reality—that there are laws in this world which are running the world .

How Marx Was Presented in This Contrast Marx explains through the laws of dialectics . He learned from Hegel that the world moves, but for Marx it is not the idea, it is the material condition . In assuming laws of dialectics he has assumed the world to be objective and monocausal—a cause-effect relation . Contradictions developed in ancient society, then in feudalism among lords and masters, and the bourgeoisie developed within it . As technology developed, classes developed . Marx sees a single cause-effect relation and no other reason behind the formation of class, the formation of the mode of production, or the evolution of society .

For Marx everything is governed by the economy; the economy is the sole engine . Religion, law and the state are all helping the economy and justifying the condition of the poor and oppressed—telling them they will get heaven in the next life . Today, according to this reading, the state favours corporations and lords rather than human rights, because those people have power . Society is the organ, the economy is the engine .

How Weber Reads Action Differently Weber asks whether an action is merely instrumental and economic, or affectual and emotional; each action must be understood as a pattern that was historically evolving . There was a time when people did not talk in terms of money . Whatever we produced, we divided with one another; we sat under the sky, singing and dancing . Our action was not instrumental—it was affectual social action and traditional social action . Even festivals were not “festivals” as such—they were the mode of living .

QUICK REVISION

- Irrationality of rationality = loss of the human element under rules; disenchantment and it are the same movement .
- Weber never became a positivist and never gave a law, because for him there is no single objective law of the social world .
- Marx by contrast is monocausal and dialectical: material conditions, contradictions, technology and class, with religion, law and state serving the economy .
- Weber insists on reading each action historically and notes that pre-modern action was

affectual and traditional, not instrumental .

8.2 The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism

8.2.1 Irrationality of Rationality: The Student's Own Case

What is the main concern that all of us have today? We are being driven by rational forces—forces that are not in our hands . Take your own example .

- Why are you studying sociology? You are not studying sociology for sociology . That is not affectual social action; it is instrumental social action . So this is rationality .
- But this rationality is irrational, because you are studying sociology for UPSC . In that sense you do not know sociology .
- You study to make keywords and to make notes; you study to answer the questions . All through the lecture you are concerned with the keywords you are going to write in that answer .
- The moment the lecture is over the question comes: “Sir, how to answer this question? How to get 6 marks out of 10? How will I get 12 out of 20, how will I get 300?” Even after a lecture on how rationalization has trapped us in the iron cage of rationality, the immediate question is about scoring .

CRITICAL POINT

That means you are simply manifesting instrumental social action . Is this in your hand? Can you change it? This is not in your hand . You have already become part of the system . You cannot change it . This is the irrationality of rationality: you lose the charm of everything you listen to or see, because you become highly instrumental .

QUICK REVISION

- Studying sociology for UPSC rather than for sociology is instrumental (*zweckrational*) social action .
- The action is rational in means but irrational in outcome—the charm and substance of what is learned is lost .
- The individual cannot escape it because he has already become part of the system .

8.2.2 The One-Crore Thought Experiment: Formal versus Practical Rationality

Before understanding Max Weber's *Protestant Ethic*, a few things must be very clear . All the things you have read so far are rivers; this is the ocean into which all the rivers are going to merge . Now you will understand social action better, rationality better, and why we read authority at all . Everything is in this book .

Suppose I give you one crore rupees and ask you to do just one thing with it, and to give me an honest reply—brutally honest, because this is not a personality test of UPSC where you have to

fake .

CRITICAL POINT

An aside made in class: UPSC does conduct a personality test, but the very act of testing personality would not let the real personality come out . This is the inherent contradiction within the system .

Basically all of you said you would invest . Which kind of rationality is being exhibited there?

Choice with One Crore	Kind of Rationality	Explanation Given in Class
Investing the money	Formal rationality	You weigh everything, calculate everything, and try to maximise utility out of what is in your hand .
Buying a Mercedes C-Class—fifty lakh in the car and the rest in its petrol	Practical rationality	Like picking up a two-thousand rupee note and spending it . No calculation of maximum utility, simply spending it .

Your investment in property is a manifestation of instrumental social action, because you are investing for the family, for the future—you have all those people in your head, and one day you have to look after them as well . You would invest in property or in the stock market, thinking that the more you get, the more beneficial it would be for your future or your family . That is perfectly *zweckrational* social action .

KEY CONCEPT

But what is the origin of these things? If three hundred years back I had given you one crore rupees, would you have invested it in the stock market or in property? No . This is the main theme of the *Protestant Ethic* . In one line: the fact that you would invest one crore rupees today means, Max Weber says, that you should be thankful to the Protestants . This attitude of investing money comes only from Protestantism .

QUICK REVISION

- Formal rationality = calculating and maximising utility (investing the crore); practical rationality = spending it as it comes (the Mercedes) .
- Investment for family and future is *zweckrational* (instrumental) social action .
- The disposition to invest is historically recent—Weber traces it to Protestantism .
- The *Protestant Ethic* is the “ocean”: social action, rationality, ideal type and authority all flow into it .

8.2.3 A Detour: How to Read History for the Examination

To those who do not have even a little idea about the word Protestant: if you know Buddhism, Buddhism today is a religion, but it never developed as a religion—it actually was a protest .

Buddhism developed as a protest against Hinduism . Students who have not read ancient history should, if nothing else, definitely read Buddhism .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

When you read ancient history, do not perform affectual social action; do not get emotional about ancient history . You have to be highly rational . You cannot afford to read the whole of ancient history from R.S. Sharma . The right method is: go through previous year questions, check the weightage of questions area-wise, and in a meticulous, planned fashion read the points from the book that gives maximum result in minimum time . Throughout this you are performing *zweckrational* selection only .

Ancient History—What to Read

1. Harappa—Harappan civilisation, that is the Indus Valley Civilisation; both are one and the same .
2. Buddhism
3. Jainism
4. The Mauryan Empire
5. The Guptas
6. Scientific achievements during ancient India—trigonometry and the rest; this is the last chapter of R.S. Sharma .
7. Philosophies of ancient India—Nyaya, Mimamsa, Vaisheshika; the Darshanas, the six Shad Darshanas . This is the second-last chapter .

You do not have to read the Greeks, Shakas, Parthians and Kushans; you may even skip the Satavahana dynasty and such topics . If you do only this much, it will take you only three days—maximum . Whoever is preparing should start ancient history right now, because ancient history is generally considered boring and whatever you think is boring should be read first, since otherwise you will not read it later at all .

Medieval and Modern History

- **Medieval:** no Sultanate . Only the Mughals, plus Chola and Pallava (according to some books these are part of ancient history, according to others early medieval), and Bhakti and Sufi . Only these four for medieval .
- **Modern:** you do not have to read early modern history—the period from the 1750s to 1857 before the revolt . Just read the major events in modern history along with the major acts . That is it .

Always keep previous year questions beside you while reading these things . You cannot remember everything, and therefore you should not even try to become a scholar in modern history . Last year in modern history many questions came which are not present anywhere—not in NCERT, not in Spectrum, not in any general book read by competitive aspirants . What is in your hand you can do; what is not in your hand becomes part of the competition .

Art and Culture Art and culture: NCERT only . From it, Buddhist art is definitely important, along with paintings, Indo-Islamic architecture, folk dances and classical dances .

QUICK REVISION

- Read history instrumentally: previous year questions first, weightage next, then the minimum book that gives maximum result .
- Ancient: Harappa/IVC, Buddhism, Jainism, Mauryas, Guptas, scientific achievements, philosophies (Shad Darshanas)—skip Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushans, Satavahanas .
- Medieval: Mughals, Cholas, Pallavas, Bhakti and Sufi only . Modern: major events plus major acts, skipping the pre-1857 early modern period .
- Art and culture: NCERT only—Buddhist art, paintings, Indo-Islamic architecture, folk and classical dances .

8.2.4 *Buddhism as Protest: The Analogy for Protestantism*

Lord Buddha challenged Hinduism . In Hinduism we had a varna structure: Brahmins at the top, then Kshatriya, then Vaishya, and Shudra at the bottom . This was graded inequality, and Lord Buddha challenged this inequality .

- Lord Buddha himself was a Kshatriya; he belonged to a family of princes . Mahavir Jain was also a Kshatriya . Both of them were Hindus .
- Buddha challenged Hinduism because of corruption, because of inequality, because of the monopoly of Brahmins, and for many other reasons .
- From there on people started reposing their faith in Buddha . They saw him as someone very charismatic, someone who could challenge the Brahmins, someone who could give a new way of life and tell them how to lead their lives, what should be done and what should not be done, how to spend their precious life on earth .
- A new way of life was told to the masses by Buddha, and from here on Buddha started gaining that halo behind his head . People actually made Buddha what Buddha was .

Reformation in Hinduism

EXAMPLE

Reform in Hinduism began as a response to the challenge posed by Buddha . Hinduism had to reform itself because Brahmins realised that most of their followers were becoming Buddhists, and they wanted to retain them . One of the reforms was that the use of animals in agricultural activities would stop, and the eating of beef would stop . Within Hinduism, to eat beef was earlier a natural thing, considered at par with the values of Hinduism . Only after the challenge posed by Buddha did beef eating, animal eating, the sacrifice of animals and the use of animals in agriculture get suspended .

Reformation within Buddhism Within Buddhism too there were disputes after the death of Buddha . People began arguing about which beliefs should continue to exist and which should not . Because of two opposing groups, Buddhism split into multiple factions—initially into two, and then a third developed: Mahayana and Hinayana . This was nothing but reformation in Buddhism . Lord Buddha told the people that the Brahminical monks tell you not to do these things but they

themselves are indulging in them: they ask you to maintain celibacy but do not; they ask you not to eat non-vegetarian food but they eat it; they ask you not to amass wealth but they have amassed enormous wealth—all the corrupt things through the back doors . People got enlightened, which is why that period is called the Indian enlightenment period—*nirvana* .

KEY CONCEPT

A similar fate befell Christianity in the early sixteenth century . It was the rule of the Catholic Church, just as we had the rule of Hinduism until Buddha came . We had the rule of Catholicism until the “Buddha of Germany” came—that is, Martin Luther . Martin Luther acted just like Buddha . Just as Buddhism is an offshoot of Hinduism, Protestantism is an offshoot of Catholicism . To understand Protestantism you have to understand Catholicism .

DATA & FACTS

Some facts given in class about Protestants:

- The founder-owners of McDonald’s—Richard McDonald and Ray Kroc—were Protestants . McDonald’s was the first fast food chain in the world; the fast food culture started with it, and KFC, Domino’s, Pizza Hut, Burger King and the rest came by copying that concept . This is why George Ritzer studied McDonald’s and why McDonaldization became such an important topic .
- Warren Buffett—although he says he is agnostic and does not believe in God—is a Presbyterian, and Presbyterianism is a sect within Protestantism, so he is largely a Protestant .
- Bill Gates was born in a Protestant church; Benjamin Franklin was a Protestant .
- There is something special about Protestants that no other people possess .

QUICK REVISION

- Buddhism began as a protest against Hindu graded inequality (Brahmin-Kshatriya-Vaishya-Shudra); Buddha and Mahavir were both Kshatriyas and both Hindus .
- Buddha’s challenge forced reformation within Hinduism (end of beef eating and animal use in agriculture) and Buddhism itself split into Mahayana and Hinayana .
- The structural parallel: Catholicism: Protestantism :: Hinduism: Buddhism; Martin Luther is the “Buddha of Germany” .
- Modern illustrations of Protestant distinctiveness: McDonald’s founders, Warren Buffett (Presbyterian), Bill Gates, Benjamin Franklin .

8.2.5 The Doctrines of Catholicism

In the early sixteenth century, in Germany and in Europe, the Catholic Church was ruling, and the Catholic Church had these doctrines :

1. You can attain salvation by purchasing indulgences and by good work .
2. You have to pass through holy rituals like confirmation and baptism .
3. You must work until your immediate needs are met; once your immediate needs are fulfilled you do not have to work any more .

4. Profit is sin .

What Was an Indulgence?

EXAMPLE

At that point of time the Church used to print a letter of indulgence . Suppose you have committed a sin and you want to atone—to rid yourself of the sin and secure your place in heaven, since your entry into heaven is now debarred . The Church used to say: whoever has committed a sin, do not worry, we will give you a letter signed by God—but you will have to give us some money for it, and then all your sins will be washed away . People used to come and stand in very long queues waiting for the priest .

Good work meant: if you follow the advice of the Church and live according to the Catholic doctrine, you are doing good work . If you are listening to the Church and following the command of the priest, you are doing good work; otherwise you are not . Confirmation was a holy ritual of which everybody had to be a participant member . A priest with a long cap on his head would hold a stick, put his hand on your forehead, you would bow, and you would go away with the letter of indulgence saying that your seat in heaven is secured . Baptism involves the holy water in which you have to immerse yourself .

On the third doctrine: if I have worked enough to meet my immediate needs, I should stop working . Because if I am working even after meeting my immediate needs, that means I am working out of greed . To escape greed, work only until your needs are fulfilled; whatever you do after that is sin . On the fourth doctrine: if you are working to earn profit, you are going to commit a sin . And if by chance you have committed a sin, come back to us—we will give you a letter of indulgence .

QUICK REVISION

- Four Catholic doctrines: salvation through indulgences and good work; compulsory holy rituals (confirmation, baptism); work only until immediate needs are met; profit is sin .
- The letter of indulgence was a purchased, signed guarantee of heaven; good work meant obedience to the Church .
- Working beyond immediate needs was condemned as greed—which is precisely what blocked the accumulation of capital .

8.2.6 Martin Luther and the Protestant Reformation

One fine day Martin Luther came, and he challenged the Catholic Church . The way he challenged was also very unique: he wrote 95 theses .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The date given in class for Luther's act at Wittenberg, Germany was stated as October 31, 1570, while the schism that followed was dated to the event of 1517 . *[as stated in lecture]* Martin Luther wrote, in 95 sheets, what the problems with the Catholic doctrine were: how the Catholic people were looting the common masses, how the Catholic Church people were corrupt, and in what fashion they were amassing wealth and looting people in the name of God . These 95 sheets were nailed on the door of the main church . You do not have to remember these details for the

answer; this is background you should know .

Luther refused to recant: he said he would not take back his words, because whatever he had done was out of pure conscience . The word *conscience* was heard by those people for the first time—they knew only God, heaven and salvation . Man, in that world, was not a conscious being; man was simply sent on earth by God .

What Luther Proposed

1. You can attain salvation not by purchasing letters of indulgence, but only if you have faith in God . That means there is no need for letters of indulgence, baptism or confirmation .
2. These priests are intermediaries between us and God—and why should we believe them? If God has made all of us, then all of us are the children of God . Why should these people possess some special quality, as if they are the guardians of God? How can they become the custodians? We have to have a direct relation with God .
3. Go back to the teachings of the Bible, and do not make your own interpretations .

COMPARISON

Something of this sort happened in the Bhakti movement in India . Bhakti and Sufi movements were all about our direct connection with God, not relying on priests or an intermediary class between us and God .

The Bible in German The basic reason people used to depend on the priest was that the Bible was written in Latin, and Latin was the language of the elites—just as Sanskrit was the language of elites here . Since it was an elite language, common people could not read it themselves, and this established a dependency relation between the people and the priest .

Martin Luther is the first person to translate the Bible into German . When he translated it, common people could read the German Bible—the New Testament—all by themselves . In Germany the culture was that if you purchased a book, you had to read it out openly to the people around you—not carry it home in an envelope and read it peacefully as we do today . So the moment some people purchased the German version of the Bible, they started reading it out, and people listened—and they got to know that nothing of the sort was written in the Bible in the name of which the Catholic priestly class had been looting them through letters of indulgence, baptism and confirmation . They realised they had been fooled, and they were highly thankful to Martin Luther for enlightening them .

From Protest to Protestantism People started following Martin Luther like anything; to them he was a charismatic personality, and they obeyed whatever he told them . Luther's life was now at risk, because he had committed an act of heresy and was going to be excommunicated . But the Church knew that this man now had so many followers that it was very reluctant to kill him right away .

Suddenly a new wave erupted in Germany: for the first time a man was being followed by many people—a man who was not the interpreter of the text of God, an ordinary man . The followers of Martin Luther are today called Evangelicals; they are also called Lutherans, and what formed was Lutheranism—just as Buddhism developed after Buddha .

This was a reform within Christianity . The Christian church had to reform itself, and the result of all this was the Reformation of Christianity . The Reformation was the result of protest, and the people who protested and followed Martin Luther—because of whom Christianity had to reform itself—came to be called Protestants; hence Protestantism .

KEY CONCEPT

This event led to the breakdown of the church . At one point of time there was only one church, one empire, one set of followers; after this event the church was divided into two—the Catholic Church and the Protestant Church . That is, the event led to a schism—a breakdown or split—just as there was a schism within Buddhism (Hinayana and Mahayana) and within Islam (Shia and Sunni) .

QUICK REVISION

- Luther nailed 95 theses on the church door at Wittenberg, listing the corruption of the Catholic Church, and refused to recant, invoking conscience .
- His three proposals: salvation by faith alone; rejection of priests as intermediaries and direct relation with God; return to the teachings of the Bible .
- Translating the Bible into German broke the dependency created by Latin, and Germany's custom of public reading spread the discovery quickly .
- His followers became Lutherans/Evangelicals; the protest produced the Reformation, Protestantism, and the schism of the church into Catholic and Protestant .

8.2.7 The Doctrines of Protestantism

People became Protestants but they still wanted to attain salvation . The belief in heaven is not gone; only the method of going to heaven has changed . It is no longer holy rituals, purchasing indulgences or good work . The people who had to form the new doctrines were, besides Martin Luther, above all John Calvin, who was highly inspired by the writings of Martin Luther, Plato and Aristotle, and who formed his own doctrine which later became part of the Protestant ethic .

1. Predestination

KEY CONCEPT

John Calvin said something very landmark that changed the discourse of history: who is going to go to heaven has already been decided . So what you do on earth does not matter . The **elect** are those already chosen to go to heaven; those who are doomed to hell are also already chosen, and they are the **damned** . This is the doctrine of predestination .

Consider the parallel drawn in class: if I told you that who is going to become an IAS has already been chosen—that out of this batch twenty are destined—but I do not tell you the names, what will happen? It will create anxiety . That anxiety among the Protestants is called **salvation anxiety** .

2. Calling Calling means that when you do any work, your act of doing work is a call . When you are working you are actually obeying God, and it is in the work that your spiritualism is reflected . Your act of doing work is a reflection of obedience to the Divine—what in Hinduism we call

Dharma: to fulfil your duty and your obligations . When you are working you are fulfilling your obligations and duty not just towards your family but also towards the Holy, because this is why you have been sent to Earth . Very important line: work was to them a spiritual experience .

3. Asceticism—Ascetic Materialism Ascetics are those people who make money but do not spend it on themselves . But being ascetic meant a lot more than this to Calvin . Calvin said whatever earning you have made out of your work should not be spent on consumption; it should be spent on something that is more productive and something that will help other people as well .

So this was not just asceticism—it was **ascetic materialism**: do not spend on yourself, but invest whatever you have made in something productive or something that is going to help other people as well . Ascetic means someone who does not spend for consumption or to display his wealth—the opposite of conspicuous consumption . You may earn in billions but lead a very simple life . Examples given in class: the Brahma Kumaris, who are billionaires yet lead a very simple life; and Ramdev, described as completely ascetic .

4. Denial of Worldly Pleasures Denial of worldly pleasures simply means that when you work, you must be completely focused on work and not on other pleasures . Renounce pleasure; focus on work . Why focus on work? Because it is only through work that you are going to go to heaven—work is a spiritual experience .

KEY CONCEPT

Hidden in these four doctrines is what you do every day in your life—and why the British came to India, and how world history got changed . Everything is related to Martin Luther and John Calvin .

	Question	Catholicism	Protestantism
Profit Reconsidered	Is profit sin?	Profit is sin .	Profit is not sin—you go only by working, and work is a spiritual experience .
	What then is money?	Wealth beyond immediate needs is greed .	Money is the grace of God; the more you have, the more divine for the work you have done .
	What is the sign of salvation?	Rituals, indulgences and good work .	Material success—maximum wealth generation is a reflection of maximum divine grace, and hence a sign of being among the elect .

The parallel offered: in Hinduism we have Lakshmi Mata, the goddess of wealth—so when we work we are working to have Lakshmi, not for our profit .

So the Protestant doctrine was all about focusing on work and generating profit, with material

success as the sign that you are going to go to heaven . Given salvation anxiety, who will go to heaven? Only those who generate maximum wealth, because maximum wealth generation reflects maximum divine grace . So if I want to know whether I am destined for heaven, I must work and work until I make that much money .

QUICK REVISION

- Four Protestant doctrines: predestination (elect and damned), calling (work as obedience to the Divine, a spiritual experience), ascetic materialism (invest productively rather than consume), and denial of worldly pleasures .
- Predestination produces salvation anxiety; John Calvin, inspired by Luther, Plato and Aristotle, is its author .
- Profit ceases to be sin and becomes the grace of the divine; material success becomes the visible sign of election .
- The believer therefore works unceasingly to accumulate—not out of greed but to read his own salvation .

8.2.8 Weber's Question and the Ideal Type of Capitalism

Max Weber was dealing with one basic question: how did capitalism develop—and not just why, but why did capitalism develop in only two pockets of the world, England and the Netherlands?

DATA & FACTS

If you look into the statistics, in Europe most of the people who are prosperous and the countries which have high GDP are those countries which have Protestants . Till date, the countries with high GDP are those which are Protestant, and the people who are billionaires are Protestants . There must be something special about Protestants that no other people possess .

To answer this, Weber first had to explain the meaning of capitalism—because capitalism too is just a model . He knew he was dealing with a model that is not absolute reality . Did we not have capitalism before these countries? Weber says we had capitalism even before England and the Netherlands, even before the Protestant Reformation, even before the industrial revolution . But there is something special about this capitalism which no other form had .

So Weber formed an ideal type of capitalism . According to him, capitalism is characterised by nothing but amassing wealth: the more wealth you accumulate, the more capitalist you are . Wealth accumulation is the accentuated feature, the essence of capitalism . But wealth has been accumulated by many people in many fashions through the pages of history—so they too must be called capitalists . There is no reason not to .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber's research question: why did capitalism develop, and why only in England and the Netherlands?
- Supporting observation: high-GDP European countries and billionaires are disproportionately Protestant .

- Capitalism is a model; the ideal type of capitalism has wealth accumulation as its accentuated feature .
- Since wealth was accumulated in many historical forms, those forms too count as capitalism—hence the need for four ideal types .

8.2.9 The Four Ideal Types of Capitalism

Since wealth accumulation took place in different forms through history, Max Weber formed four ideal types of capitalism :

1. Booty capitalism
2. Traditional capitalism (merchant capitalism)
3. Pariah capitalism
4. Legal-rational capitalism

EXAMPLE

A note on the word *pariah*: it is spelt p-a-r-i-a-h . The origin of the word is from a tribe in India—the Pariah tribe—from where Max Weber took the word .

Booty Capitalism Booty capitalism is the one where wealth is accumulated by plunder—wealth accumulation by stealing . Who were these people? All the invaders—those who invaded India or any country—and pirates, such as those of Somalia . All of these are booty capitalists . The Aryans who came to invade India, and the Dasyus who made the indigenous people slaves and looted them, were also booty capitalists . They looted a tribe, hoarded that tribe's wealth, got satisfied, and after some days invaded another tribe . This is how the expansion of empires was happening .

Traditional (Merchant) Capitalism Traditional capitalism happened among those who used to collect something very expensive or luxurious—for example the silk route . This is what we also call merchant capitalism . Today's capitalism is all about mass production: you mass produce, things become cheaper, demand rises, and this demand impels another level of supply—mass production and mass consumption go hand in hand . But in merchant capitalism there was no mass production . There was production for a class by a class: merchants catered to kings and nobility, and that was the silk route . The nobilities produced things which were very expensive and could not be afforded by the common masses . That was also capitalism: wealth was accumulated by a select few who could afford it, or generated by those who could produce those expensive things . It was capitalism limited to the nobility or the elites .

Pariah Capitalism Pariah capitalism was the result of money lending . You lend your money to someone, and in that case too you accumulate more wealth . This is what banks do today—a bank such as ICICI earns by lending . There is a hidden layer here, because reality is not of a pure type; we have layers . Think about the Jews . Jews were hated by Europeans because money lending was the means through which they accumulated wealth . If you see many Jewish billionaires and millionaires today, the real source of their wealth was lending activities . Lending money to generate wealth was considered a sin in Catholic doctrine, and that is why Jews were hated initially—but this was also a form of making money .

Legal-Rational Capitalism The wealth accumulation we had after the industrial revolution was a revolutionary form, very different from any other form in history . It was not a class producing for a class; not wealth generated by a few by lending money; not wealth generated by looting people . It was mass generation of wealth, contributing to the rise of the wealth of nations; mass production catering to mass consumption; economies of scale . This is legal-rational capitalism—a very revolutionary form not present earlier in history .

KEY CONCEPT

Write down one line: according to Weber, the only feature that distinguishes the other forms of capitalism from present-day legal-rational capitalism is the **unrelenting pursuit of profit** . One crore becomes two crore, two crore becomes three crore; produce cars, advertise, reinvest—the unrelenting pursuit of wealth . This was not there in the earlier forms .

Form of Capitalism	Source of Wealth	Illustrations from the Lecture
Booty capitalism	Plunder and loot	All invaders; pirates of Somalia; Aryans and the enslavement of indigenous people by the Dasyus .
Traditional / merchant capitalism	Luxury production for a class by a class	The silk route; merchants catering to kings and the nobility; no mass production .
Pariah capitalism	Money lending at interest	Jews in Europe; modern banks such as ICICI; lending was a sin in Catholic doctrine .
Legal-rational capitalism	Mass production for mass consumption, economies of scale, reinvestment	Post-industrial-revolution capitalism; defined by the unrelenting pursuit of profit .

QUICK REVISION

- Four ideal types: booty (plunder), traditional/merchant (luxury goods, silk route), pariah (money lending), legal-rational (mass production and reinvestment) .
- “Pariah” is borrowed from the name of an Indian tribe .
- The single distinguishing feature of modern legal-rational capitalism is the unrelenting pursuit of profit through reinvestment .
- All four are ideal types—models, not the reality itself .

8.2.10 Protestants and the Industrial Revolution: Weber's Sources

DATA & FACTS

In the industrial revolution, 70 to 80 per cent of the employees, staff, factory owners, managers and workers were Protestant. The countries where the industrial revolution happened—largely England and the Netherlands—were at that point of time Protestant countries.

KEY CONCEPT

Write down: without understanding the social action of Protestants, one may not understand the rise of rational capitalism.

The next question in Weber's mind was: how can I understand Protestants—their social actions and the meanings they attach to work? Everything narrated so far as history was also read by Max Weber.

Benjamin Franklin Other than Luther and Calvin, Weber had also read one more man in America: Benjamin Franklin. Max Weber paid only one visit to America, in 1904—the same year in which he published his book, the *Protestant Ethic*. [as stated in lecture]

Franklin had written many books on how to become wealthy—as today one reads books like *Rich Dad Poor Dad*. He had published three books: *Advice to a Young Tradesman*, *The Way to Wealth*, and his *Autobiography*. Max Weber read these three books. So Weber read John Calvin, read Martin Luther, read these three books, and also read the Industrial Revolution—and found a connection in all of them.

KEY CONCEPT

Next line: Weber read books written by Benjamin Franklin to understand the meanings and motives attached by Protestants to their work. In Franklin's books Weber read the phrases we take for granted today: *money begets money*, *time is money*, *work is worship*—which later came to be regarded as world-revolutionary thoughts to be published in every corner of the school.

Weber's Mother Max Weber's mother was also a Protestant, and he dedicated the book to his mother. His mother was a social philanthropist. She used to earn a lot of money but never used to invest it on herself—she led an ascetic lifestyle, exactly on the lines of Protestantism. She used to invest in some things, and she also used to donate. The comparison drawn: just as today we have the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation—donating is the sign of the billionaire.

QUICK REVISION

- 70–80% of those involved in the industrial revolution were Protestants; England and the Netherlands were Protestant countries.
- Dictated line: without understanding the social action of Protestants one cannot understand the rise of rational capitalism.
- Weber's sources: Luther, Calvin, the Industrial Revolution, and Benjamin Franklin's three books (*Advice to a Young Tradesman*, *The Way to Wealth*, the *Autobiography*); one visit to America in 1904, the year of publication.

- Franklin's phrases—money begets money, time is money, work is worship—supplied the meanings Protestants attached to work; Weber's own mother, an ascetic Protestant philanthropist, is the book's dedicatee .

8.2.11 *The Ideal Type of Protestant Ethics*

Finally Weber developed an ideal type of Protestant ethics . He knew that what he was going to understand about Protestants would be his understanding only—not what Protestantism is in itself—but it was his attempt to understand the meanings and motives Protestants attach to work .

1. **Frugality**—be frugal, save your money, because money begets money . This is what he had learned from Benjamin Franklin .
2. **Industriousness**—be industrious, do hard work, and never complain in the work; because work is a spiritual experience, and if you complain about the work you are complaining against the wish of God . You have to work unrelentingly .
3. **Work is worship**
4. **Time is money**
5. **Calling**—it is in the work only that you gain spiritual experience .
6. **Predestination**
7. **Ascetic materialism**
8. **This-worldly orientation**—orientation to this world, not to the other world . Focus on your work; do not think about going to heaven . To go to heaven is a result of doing work, so focus on work first . You cannot go to heaven merely by standing on the road with faith in God and taking His name .

KEY CONCEPT

Weber clearly says: I am not saying this is what Protestantism is . I am saying this is a model of Protestantism .

QUICK REVISION

- Eight elements of the ideal type of Protestant ethics: frugality, industriousness, work is worship, time is money, calling, predestination, ascetic materialism, this-worldly orientation .
- Frugality and time-discipline come from Franklin; calling and predestination from Calvin .
- Complaining about work is complaining against the wish of God—hence uncomplaining, unrelenting labour .
- Weber presents this explicitly as a model of Protestantism, not Protestantism itself .

8.2.12 *Elective Affinity and Adequate Causality*

Weber now had two models floating before him—the ideal type of Protestant ethics on one hand and the ideal type of rational capitalism on the other . Looking at them together, he saw all the elements in the Protestant ethic which ultimately and unintentionally led to the rise of rational capitalism .

It was only in Protestantism that the spirit of capitalism was born . The spirit lay in the work ethic of the Protestants, which is also called the **Puritan work ethic** . What does the capitalist want? Capitalists always reward productivity; they reward hard work, discipline and punctuality; they reward frugality and justness . All these elements are the spirit of capitalism, and they were present in the Protestant .

KEY CONCEPT

Those people, unconsciously, through their social action of working harder and harder to secure their seat in heaven, ended up creating the industrial revolution and giving jobs and employment to so many people . They were working only to secure a place in heaven or to get the grace of God . They never knew what capitalism or the industrial revolution would become . That is why Max Weber said that rational capitalism was an accident in history . It was never planned . They were never working to set up factories . They never wanted to exploit anyone . It was never their intention to exploit people the way Marx looks at it, never to loot people, never to appropriate wealth or surplus value, never to make people work longer hours . Therefore: capitalism was the unintended consequence of the Protestant Reformation . Martin Luther never knew this would happen; John Calvin never knew .

Is This a Monocausal Claim? Is Weber saying Protestantism is the only cause behind the rise of capitalism? Is he drawing a monocausal relationship between the two ideal types? No . He never said anything like this . Because reality is very vast, what we can do is develop models; and when you draw a relationship between models you cannot be determinist about the causal relationship . He says capitalism was an accident in history, an unintended consequence of the acts of people who were working only to secure their place in heaven . So he cannot make a monocausal explanation . But one thing he can definitely see is that there is a relation between them .

KEY CONCEPT

Adequate causality: if x happens, there is a probability that y has happened because of x . This is not the determinism of natural scientists (“if x then y ”) . Adequate causality also implies multi-causality—one factor may be adequate among others .

Elective affinity: Weber sees Protestant ethics and rational capitalism as partners which cannot be separated . The affinity we have between hydrogen and oxygen, which is why we have water—a similar kind of affinity exists between Protestant ethics and rational capitalism . It is a subtle relationship: it is not that one leads to the other, both are interdependent and conjoined, like conjoint twins—two sides of the same coin, a hand-in-hand relation in which you cannot see a causal relation .

The Other Factors Weber says asceticism is the necessary condition—the other conditions in the ideal types are only sufficient . You cannot be a capitalist if you are not ascetic; you cannot be a capitalist if you are spending on yourself, because you have to reinvest your money . Besides asceticism, other factors responsible were :

1. Asceticism—the necessary condition
2. Formal laws—without laws there cannot be regulation in industry

3. Appropriation of the physical means of production—which Marx believed was the only condition
4. Market and trade

CRITICAL POINT

But trade, market and laws have existed in all parts of the world . Why then only in England and the Netherlands? Because there is something special about the meanings, which are hidden and have to be interpreted by a sociologist . Max Weber is an interpretative sociologist .

Turning Marx Upside Down

Dimension	Karl Marx	Max Weber
Base of society	The economy is the base .	Religion is the base .
Position of religion	Religion sits in the superstructure and justifies the economy .	Religion led to the development of the economy .
Form of causation	Monocausal and determinist .	Adequate causality, multi-causality, elective affinity—a dotted line and solid arrow .

Basically what Weber said is that the economy comes out of religion . This was a critique of Marx: Marx believed religion justified the economy; Weber turned Marx upside down and believed it is religion which is the base that led to the development of the economy .

QUICK REVISION

- The spirit of capitalism—the Puritan work ethic—was born in Protestantism, and capitalists reward exactly its virtues: productivity, hard work, punctuality, frugality .
- Rational capitalism was an accident of history: the unintended consequence of the Protestant Reformation, with no intention to exploit .
- Weber is not monocausal; he claims adequate causality (probabilistic, multi-causal) and elective affinity (conjoint twins, hydrogen and oxygen), not determination .
- Asceticism is the necessary condition; formal laws, appropriation of the physical means of production, and market/trade are the other, merely sufficient, conditions .
- Weber turns Marx upside down: for Marx economy is base and religion superstructure; for Weber religion is the base .

8.2.13 Why Not India? The Ideal Type of Hinduism

The next question is why the model of legal-rational capitalism never developed in any other pocket—why it never developed in India . To answer this, the social action of Hindus has to be understood, and the social action of Muslims has to be understood in order to understand why

Islam never led to the rise of capitalism . What is so special about Protestantism only, that the spirit of capitalism was absent in every other religion?

CRITICAL POINT

We study Hinduism rather than Islam or Judaism . Why? India is not only about Hindus—we have Muslims, Jews, Buddhists and Jains . The reason given: Indian Society/Indian Sociology, Paper 2, is also about Hindus; we have to study the caste system, which is not a system of Islam or Buddhism—these have actually challenged the caste system, yet we unfortunately study caste . That is why scholars such as Dipankar Gupta and Yogendra Singh call Indian Sociology Hindu Sociology, not just Indian Sociology .

KEY CONCEPT

To Max Weber, Hinduism is Indian Catholicism—the same Catholicism against which Protestants developed . That is why Buddha was taught: Buddha developed against Hinduism just as Luther developed against Catholicism . There is a relation between the Brahminism that we had and the Catholicism that they had; both share almost similar doctrines . So Weber developed an ideal type of Hinduism as well, saying: I am just an individual, I cannot know Hinduism in totality, but I would highlight certain accentuated features . This is his method: ideal type, adequate causality, elective affinity, verstehen .

Elements of the Ideal Type of Hinduism

1. **Karma-dharma theory**—you are born a Brahmin as the fruit of past karmas; you have become a Shudra because of past deeds and sins committed in a previous life . Karma means your deeds; dharma means your duty .
2. **Transmigration of soul**—the soul is a transitory phenomenon . The body is made up of essential elements—earth, fire, air—but it is the soul that decides your fate, and the soul has to be kept pure . Nothing is kept in the body or in worldly pleasures .
3. **Belief in rebirth**—since there is belief in the soul, there is belief in rebirth .
4. **No aspiration**—Hindus do not develop aspirations, because we are destined to perform this duty according to varna and dharma . Hence there is no concept of social mobility .

The Dharma of Each Varna

Varna	Dharma as Stated in the Lecture
Brahmin	To assist the kings, to give them advice, to educate and to preach religion .
Kshatriya	To safeguard the interest of the people and to secure the peace of any kind .
Vaishya	To indulge in merchant activities and to generate wealth .
Shudra	To serve the upper three varnas .

A Shudra cannot do what a Vaishya is doing; a Brahmin cannot do what a Kshatriya is doing; a Kshatriya cannot do what a Brahmin is doing. The division of labour has been done through the varna system in India. Ambedkar calls it not just division of labour but division of labourers, because the labourers themselves have been divided according to their varnas. Your specialisation comes out of your varna, not out of your merit or talent.

Consequences The child of a Dalit is born a Dalit and performs what is considered the occupation of a Dalit—it reproduces. The child of a Brahmin gets education at universities; the child of a Kshatriya performs a similar kind of occupation to his father. Aspirations are not high; they may be a bit different but stay in the same range. If you do not have aspiration and ambition, you are not going to work beyond your varna. And you also have belief in the afterlife—so what would you do with money?

EXAMPLE

One ancient Indian philosopher, Charvak, propagated a materialist philosophy: earn money, even if you have to steal, and live your life with full luxury—whether it comes by theft, by loot or by plunder. That is Charvak's materialism.

CRITICAL POINT

With such beliefs, can we ever develop the spirit of capitalism? We wait for Sunday; Monday feels like a curse—there are even songs about it. So we do not have labour commitment—we are not committed to labour. But Protestants are not like this: the more they work, the more they feel they are getting closer to their destination, that is heaven. They enjoy and feel pleasure in the work; we curse work and are concerned only about the paycheck. We are more oriented to the party, not to the work. This is why Weber believed Hinduism is Indian Catholicism.

QUICK REVISION

- Weber studies Hinduism because Indian sociology itself is largely built on caste (Dipankar Gupta and Yogendra Singh call it Hindu Sociology).
- Hinduism = Indian Catholicism; Weber constructs an ideal type of it too.
- Four elements: karma-dharma theory, transmigration of the soul, belief in rebirth, absence of aspiration and hence of social mobility.
- Varna dharma fixes occupation—Ambedkar calls it division of labourers, not division of labour; specialisation follows varna, not merit.
- Result: no labour commitment; work is cursed rather than experienced as spiritual, so the spirit of capitalism could not arise.

8.2.14 Answer-Writing Guidance and Doubts from This Class

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

What you have to do is understand the ideal type of Protestantism—known as the Protestant work ethic—and the ideal type of rational capitalism, and then draw a relation between these two. In the answer you simply explain these ideal types and draw the relation. You do not have to explain

all the history—Martin Luther, John Calvin, Benjamin Franklin . That history is only for your understanding, and it will help you in other units . The history-versus-sociology distinction here is itself usable: the narrative of Luther and the Church is history; the interpretation of meanings is sociology .

The Printing Press: A Point Added at the End

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

Before Martin Luther there were many people who had challenged the Catholic Church . Why then is Martin Luther singled out? Because Martin Luther took advantage of the printing press . The printing press was a very recent technology . By translating the Bible into German, Luther had two lakh copies published—and to publish two lakh copies in the 1530s was a big thing . They were colourful copies, not black and white, and people purchased them . The printing press as a technology actually led to awareness about the Bible; without it people would not have known what the Catholic Church does and what actually lies in the Bible . Therefore technology is an agent of social change, and religion in itself is an agent of social change—it was only because of Protestantism that capitalism took shape, so Protestantism had an adequate causal relation with the rise of the industrial revolution .

Were Protestants Only in England and the Netherlands? Largely, yes . Just as Hinduism is largely in India—we say largely . In the social world there is nothing like “only” . Some Protestants exist elsewhere too; we have to look at what is largely the case .

Is Weber a Pseudoscientist, Since All His Theories Are Irrefutable? You cannot call Weber a pseudoscientist, because Weber never said “this is why capitalism developed” . He never established a determinist relationship; he is not a monocausal scholar . And if he is not a determinist, how can you call him a scientist or a pseudoscientist in that sense? But you can definitely still call him a scientist: his research was very rigorous, aimed at understanding social action in an objective fashion, forming ideal types of reality and studying reality through models—which is what scientists do—while maintaining objectivity and not letting his values come in . He clearly says sociology is a science of social action in so far as it is concerned with its causes and consequences .

You may call Marx a pseudoscientist, because he was a determinist—although when people criticised Marx as an economic determinist, Engels came forward and defended the thesis, explaining why he is not .

According to Weber, Was Capitalism Not Exploitative? The question of exploitation does not arise at all . Weber is looking at capitalism in a very different fashion . When you say capitalism is exploitative, you are looking at capitalism through the Marxian perspective—not in an objective fashion . Remove those goggles, put on Weber’s goggles, and you see a different reality . Put on Durkheim’s glasses and you see a very different idea of capitalism; put on Adam Smith’s glasses and capitalism appears different again . There is no absolute reality in the social world—these are all perspectives .

QUICK REVISION

- For the answer: explain the ideal type of Protestant work ethic and the ideal type of rational capitalism, then draw the relation; leave the history out .
- Luther is singled out because he used the printing press—two lakh colourful German Bibles in the 1530s; technology and religion are both agents of social change .
- Protestantism was “largely”, not “only”, in England and the Netherlands—nothing in the social world is “only” .
- Weber is a scientist but not a determinist, so the charge of pseudoscience does not apply; Marx, being determinist, is more exposed to it, and Engels defended him .
- Exploitation is a Marxian category; for Weber capitalism is wealth accumulation, and there is no absolute reality in the social world—only perspectives .

8.3 Critique of Max Weber and the Comparison of Marx, Weber and Durkheim

8.3.1 *Placing the Protestant Ethic at the Centre of Weber's Work*

In Weber we have read social action, ideal type, authority, bureaucracy, and finally the *Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* . In the *Protestant Ethic* we can see all of them—bureaucracy, authority, ideal type, verstehen and social action . These were the rivers which were destined finally to meet the ocean .

KEY CONCEPT

Write it in the past tense: work was a religious or spiritual experience to Protestants . If work is a spiritual experience to you as a Protestant, and you are working continuously, relentlessly, incessantly in a non-stop fashion because you think you are engaged in a spiritual experience, you are bound to create a system called capitalism . When you are working you are not working to earn money—it is like going to a temple . This kind of belief is very unique and not found just anywhere in the world . They were working out of passion, not to earn money, but to secure their seat in heaven .

QUICK REVISION

- The *Protestant Ethic* is the point at which social action, ideal type, authority and bureaucracy all converge .
- Work was a religious/spiritual experience to Protestants—worship, not wage-earning .
- Continuous work driven by that belief is what produces the system called capitalism .

8.3.2 *Catholicism, Protestantism and Capitalism: The Three-Box Comparison*

Draw three boxes: Catholicism, Protestantism and Capitalism . What is written in the first box will not match the third; what is written in the second will match the third fully . That is where you see the congruence, correspondence and affinity between the two models .

Question	Catholicism	Protestantism
How is salvation attained?	By rituals and by purchasing indulgences .	By predestination—the elect have already been chosen; no indulgence, no baptism, no ritual is needed . Complete rejection of the Catholic path .
How long should one work?	Work until your immediate needs are met .	Calling—keep working . Can you stop worshipping once you feel satisfied? Worship is something you engage in forever and never feel satisfied with . Work is a spiritual experience .
What is sin?	Profit is sin .	Idleness is sin . Sitting idle is the sin; earning is not .
What should be done with wealth?	Distribute your wealth to the poor .	Ascetic materialism—asceticism yes, but manifested by investing money in something productive . Distributing a crore among the poor is not productive; they will come back tomorrow when it is finished .

Why the Protestant Was the Productive Worker If you are every time engaged in worship, always thinking that a sin has been committed, will you ever concentrate on work? Are you a productive worker to the capitalist? No .

The Protestants believed they had already been chosen, but did not know who among them were the chosen ones—hence salvation anxiety . They therefore felt that the more wealth they generated, the more their seat was secured . In wealth they saw the grace of God and the opportunity to go to heaven . So wealth was not generated out of greed; it was generated out of their wish to secure their seat in heaven . Since the wealth comes from work, they were productive to the capitalist class which needs hard-working workers .

Calling and predestination were values that gave the capitalist class productive workers . Because idleness is sin, if the boss said work one more hour, they would happily do it and would not complain . In the work they saw God . So: maximum hours given to work; and whatever was earned was largely invested in productive things—that is reinvestment and productivity, and that is precisely the spirit of capitalism .

KEY CONCEPT

The spirit of capitalism = hard work, efficient people, maximum hours of work, not sitting idle, reinvesting, being productive . Weber clearly saw that so many things match: it seems as if each was made for the other . And Hinduism has no such relation with capitalism at all—Hinduism is nothing but Indian Catholicism, so capitalism will never come from it, according to Weber . We do not have the labour commitment these people have; it is their belief that makes them different from the rest of the world—people like Bill Gates, Warren Buffett, McDonald's .

QUICK REVISION

- The Catholic box contradicts the capitalist box; the Protestant box matches it point for point .
- Salvation by predestination replaces rituals; calling replaces working-till-needs-are-met; idleness replaces profit as sin; ascetic materialism replaces charity to the poor .
- Salvation anxiety converts the search for a sign of election into unlimited productive labour and reinvestment .
- The spirit of capitalism: hard work, efficiency, maximum hours, no idleness, reinvestment, productivity .

8.3.3 Why Not the Jews, Muslims and Sikhs?

A student asked: Jews were also famous as hard-working people, so why did capitalism not rise there?

- **Jews**—the problem is that they invested heavily in lending . Most of the wealth they accumulated came out of money-lending practices . When you lend, your practice is to lend money, wait for it to garner interest and then collect it back—so you are sitting idle most of the time, and you are not able to think beyond that one given task of generating wealth . That is what pariah capitalism was, and Weber gives the example of the Jews for it .
- **Islam**—in Islam you will see many things which are haram, forbidden, and those forbidden things do not let the same spirit of capitalism develop, according to Weber . Islam, he says, practises hedonism; luxury is cursed, and the participation of women in the work sphere is cursed . This is not offered as the reality—this is Max Weber's ideal type of Islam .
- **Sikhism**—if you look into the practices of Sikhs, most of the wealth they generate is donated in langar or in charity . During the lockdown it was Sikh people who helped homeless people . But when you donate most of your wealth in charity, you are not an ascetic materialist; this is not what a Protestant would do .

A Protestant would instead invest the same amount in corona bonds—Covid bonds, as happened in Europe—rather than sending money to a relief fund . We Indians will do the latter because we are emotional; Protestants will never do these kinds of things .

QUICK REVISION

- Jews: money lending = pariah capitalism; lending involves sitting idle and cannot generate the work-ethic spirit .

- Islam: forbidden categories and what Weber's ideal type calls hedonism—cursing luxury and women's work participation block the spirit .
- Sikhism: wealth given in langar and charity is not ascetic materialism, because charity is not productive investment .
- The contrast is bonds versus relief funds—productive reinvestment versus emotional donation .

8.3.4 From Calling to Compulsion: Secularization

If work to a Protestant is a spiritual experience, what kind of social action is being performed? You will see traditional, affectual and value-rational social action—but you will not see *zweckrational* action . You are not doing work because you have to make so much wealth and have investment plans, a bungalow, a car, a foreign trip, or ambitions to become CEO . These calculations do not go into it . It is purely a spiritual experience, and when you are manifesting spiritualism there is no calculation of means and ends . You are simply spiritual without being utilitarian . Where work is a spiritual experience, there is no space for utilitarianism .

KEY CONCEPT

Puritans means the members of the Protestants—Puritans and Protestants are synonyms . Weber says, write it down: **“Puritans used to work in calling. But today they are forced to do so.”** Everything is hidden in this line .

What the Line Means The Protestants were simply expressing their spiritual feeling . They saw work as a spiritual experience and kept on working because to them work was nothing but worship . Ultimately the values required for the generation of rational capitalism were visible in the Protestants, and that is why rational capitalism developed in England and the Netherlands—because of their productive expenditure and investment practices, their hard work, and their treatment of idleness as sin .

But what happened after that? The money that was a sign for you that you are going to go to heaven had now become an end in itself . The same money which was a token, a grace of God, had become an end . Now you were working not to manifest spirituality, not working in calling, but to generate wealth—even if that generation of wealth comes at the cost of the exploitation of others . Gradually man became greedy, because he saw that people were giving him so much respect and status . So he wanted more and more wealth, and wealth generation became completely a manifestation of *zweckrational* social action . From there on there were no more values, no tradition, no affectual social action with God—everything was with the money .

COMPARISON

Here Max Weber is shaking hands with Karl Marx . If you remember, Marx said that initially we had C_1-C_2 , then C_1-M-C_2 , and finally in capitalism we have M_1-C-M_2 —money becoming the end . The two are very close to each other when Weber makes this statement .

KEY CONCEPT

Write down one line: Max Weber believed the money which was a sign of holy grace had now become an end in itself . And therefore it was no longer value-rational social action; rather it was completely *zweckrational* social action . It was no longer substantive rationality; rather it was completely formal rationality .

EXAMPLE

In simple language: you are a person who worships God every day before opening your shop . On the opening day you conducted the rituals, fed the priest, did everything . Every day you worshipped God, and you treated customers as manifestations of God . But ultimately, when you started generating wealth, it stopped mattering if a customer went away unhappy . Everything is forgotten; the idol gathers dust and it makes no difference . Money had now become an end in itself .

KEY CONCEPT

This is what Max Weber called the advent of **secularization** . Secularization is a process—hence the “-ization”—characterised by a decline in religious beliefs or values . If money-making has become an end in itself, then religious beliefs are declining . That is why Weber says Puritans used to work in calling, and today they are forced to do so: the concept of calling is finished .

QUICK REVISION

- Work as spiritual experience is value-rational, affectual and traditional—never *zweckrational*, because there is no means-ends calculation .
- Puritans = Protestants; Weber’s line: “Puritans used to work in calling; today they are forced to do so” .
- Money that was a sign of holy grace became an end in itself; value-rational action became *zweckrational*, substantive rationality became formal rationality .
- Weber here converges with Marx’s $C-M-C$ to $M-C-M$ formula .
- The outcome is secularization: a process characterised by the decline of religious beliefs and values .

8.3.5 Micro to Macro: Weber as a Substantive Sociologist

Is Weber studying social action or structures? Is he a micro scholar, or is he also talking about macro structures?

We started our journey with the social action of individuals—a small man and the attempt to understand his meanings through *verstehen* . Gradually, Weber says that a large number of social actions of people resulted in the formation of social structures . If millions are working with almost the same belief, it leads to the rise of capitalism—and these millions were in England and Holland, that is the Netherlands . So individuals worked to create capitalism, and now that same capitalism is forcing those individuals to generate wealth . It was their action which led to the rise of capitalism; now capitalism is forcing them . Capitalism as a structure is no longer in their hands

CRITICAL POINT

When you read only that second statement in isolation, Weber sounds just like a structuralist—like Durkheim on social facts: external to and coercive of actors . Capitalism becomes external to and coercive of actors; these are social facts which have now assumed a reality and are constraining individuals . You would not be able to think beyond generating wealth; wealth-making has become the end and spirituality has become a token symbol . The same applies to bureaucracy: when you become a bureaucrat you will be bureaucratized . Rules and regulations will constrain you; you will not be able to help an individual beyond the given rules, and you will feel the constraining power of these structures .

KEY CONCEPT

Weber used to tell us that the subject matter of sociology is the study of social action . But then it became clear that it is the study of social action, its causes and its consequences . What are the consequences of social action? Large-scale social structures . Capitalism is the result of a large number of people manifesting initially value-rational and finally *zweckrational* social action; it has assumed a reality of its own type and now exerts control over individuals .

Bureaucracy in the Same Line The social action of a large number of people led to the rise of bureaucracy . In bureaucracy—impersonality, hierarchy, division of labour, merit-based recruitment—everything becomes impersonal, rule-bound, legal, rational and calculable, all to ensure efficiency . In the end it is efficiency that has become an end in itself . And this efficiency was actually coming from the Protestants, who were deemed the most efficient people because they worked hard without complaint and treated idleness as sin . They would do whatever was necessary to be seen as efficient, because they wanted to secure their seat in heaven—salvation anxiety made everyone want to be as efficient as possible .

KEY CONCEPT

Weber concluded that rational bureaucracy—the modern form, as against the patrimonial bureaucracy of ancient times—and rational capitalism are the result of the social action of Protestants . The bureaucratic structure we adopted came from Europe; the Indian civil service came from Europe; and in Europe it came from the Protestants . Therefore capitalism is just one part of the larger process of rationalization . It is not so important to study capitalism as it is to study the process of rationalization . To study capitalism as a mode of production, and to regard the world as nothing but the evolution of modes of production, would be a very myopic study . Capitalism is the rationalized form of the economy; bureaucracy is the rationalized form of law; modern education is the rationalized form of education . The larger process to be studied is rationalization .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber begins with micro social action and moves to macro structures—this is why his sociology is called comprehensive .

- Large numbers of similar social actions create structures (capitalism, bureaucracy); the structures then become external to and coercive of the actors, sounding Durkheimian .
- Subject matter of sociology therefore = social action, its causes AND its consequences (large-scale structures) .
- Efficiency becomes an end in itself, and its source is the Protestant work ethic .
- Capitalism is only one part of the larger process of rationalization—which is the real object of study; bureaucracy is rationalized law, modern education rationalized education .

8.3.6 Critique of the Protestant Ethic Thesis

What follows are not really critiques; they are largely misinterpretations of Weber, because Weber himself never claimed what they deny .

1. R. H. Tawney R. H. Tawney is an economic historian . He says he can never be certain that Protestantism led to the rise of capitalism . He believes the spirit of capitalism was absorbed by the Protestants—it is not that the work ethic of the Protestants gave rise to the spirit of capitalism; rather, the spirit of capitalism made them work efficiently .

Where then does the spirit of capitalism come from? Tawney says its origin is not Protestant ethics but the Reformation, the Renaissance and the Scientific Revolution—largely the scientific revolution . In the Reformation he highlights not the Protestants but the concept of rationality: when Martin Luther challenged the Catholic Church, that shows a rational being—someone who can challenge the church rather than simply obey it because it has been done for so long . He was not performing traditional social action; he performed formal rationality, fully conscious: why should you people act as intermediaries between men and God? So Tawney says it is the spirit of rationality that gives rise to the spirit of capitalism, and that rationality comes from the Reformation, along with the scientific revolution and the Renaissance .

He may sound like a critic, but he is not—because Max Weber never said Protestant ethics is the reason behind the rise of capitalism . He only drew adequate causal relations: there is a probability that Protestant ethics may have led to it . He is not being determinist, so the question of criticism hardly arises .

2. Kurt Samuelson Kurt Samuelson says we cannot really say it was Protestant ethics that led to the rise of capitalism, or that there is even a probable relation between the spirit of capitalism and Protestants—because he can see the spirit of capitalism even in countries which did not have Protestants .

- **Belgium:** the chocolates which are so famous today have been famous for a very long time . Belgium is largely a Catholic country; there are not that many Protestants there . Yet Belgium, despite being a Catholic country, had the spirit of capitalism .
- **Switzerland:** here there were Protestants, but capitalism developed only in very late stages—at least a hundred years later . He is not saying capitalism did not develop; he is saying it took them a hundred more years to develop that spirit . So you cannot really say there is adequate causality .
- **Netherlands:** to Samuelson, capitalism in the Netherlands had developed even before the

Protestants . To him the Netherlands was a Catholic country, not a Protestant one—so it is Catholics who had the adequate relation with capitalism .

But this depends on what kind of ideal type each has drawn: the ideal type of Catholicism drawn by Max Weber and the one drawn by Kurt Samuelson are very different . And here the role of values comes in—Max Weber was himself a Protestant, his mother being a Calvinist, and Calvinism is a variant of Protestantism .

Samuelson also says the biggest critique of Max Weber should be that he was not objective: when everything is a probability, can his thesis be considered scientific? Where there is no objectivity, is there any scope for falsifiability?

3. Reinhard Bendix Bendix makes a very interesting observation about Japan . Japan lost the Second World War, but that loss evoked such a great spirit of nationalism and patriotism in the Japanese people that they continuously worked hard, relentlessly, unyieldingly and incessantly—and this actually led to the rise of Japanese capitalism . That is why Japanese electronics is the most unique in the world . And who were the Japanese? They were Buddhists . This shows that Buddhism can be practised in the private sphere: at home you are a Buddhist, but the moment you go out into the industry you become a hard-working individual, a Japanese nationalist who will do anything for productivity or the wealth of the nation . So capitalism existed without Protestantism . According to Bendix, to say that Protestantism led to capitalism, or even had an adequate relation with it, is not so right .

EXAMPLE

On Japanese capitalism (to be taken up in the chapter on Work and Economy): Japan practises job rotation—a worker may become a manager, a manager may become a clerk, a manager may for a few days become CEO . Everybody becomes everything . Unlike traditional capitalist enterprises where you are permanently a manager or permanently a clerk, there is no such strict compartmentalization in Japan and therefore no scope for alienation . Japan also has a maximum aged population and lacks the demographic dividend that India celebrates . When the elderly do not feel integrated with the young, the suicide rate rises .

4. Milton Singer Milton Singer conducted a study in Madras, India, and found a process called **compartmentalization** . Compartmentalization means the private sphere is different from the public sphere: at home you are completely religious, but the moment you go to the factory you are no longer religious and are concerned only about wealth . That does not mean your religiosity is over—you become religious again when you get back home .

In South India there are more temples than in the whole world—after every hundred metres you will see a temple . This shows that religiosity can exist despite capitalism . Weber says capitalism has come and religiosity is finished, money has become an end in itself . But Milton Singer says they are concerned with money at the office and become religious again when they come home . In simple terms, they lead life in two compartments: in private life they are religious, in public life they are businessmen . This is not the opposite of what Weber says; it is simply different from it .

Critic	Core Claim	Evidence Cited
R. H. Tawney	The spirit of capitalism was absorbed by Protestants, not produced by them .	Origin lies in Reformation, Renaissance and above all the Scientific Revolution; Luther's challenge itself displays rationality .
Kurt Samuelson	No adequate causality between Protestantism and capitalism .	Catholic Belgium had the spirit; Protestant Switzerland developed capitalism a hundred years late; the Netherlands had capitalism before Protestants and was Catholic .
Reinhard Bendix	Nationalism, not Protestantism, can produce capitalism .	Buddhist Japan's post-war nationalism produced Japanese capitalism .
Milton Singer	Religiosity and capitalism coexist through compartmentalization .	Study of Madras, India—religious at home, profit-oriented at the factory; the density of temples in South India .

CRITICAL POINT

A student asked whether the Protestant is similar to the Buddhist who rose against “Indian Catholicism” . Both came in reaction to a larger religion—Catholicism and Hinduism respectively—but their values are entirely different . For Buddhism, the material is the source of suffering . For the Protestant, material wealth is not suffering at all—it is a sign that he is going to go to heaven . For one it is the source of suffering, for the other the source of heaven .

QUICK REVISION

- Four critics: Tawney (spirit absorbed, origin in rationality from Reformation/Renaissance/Scientific Revolution), Samuelson (Belgium, Switzerland, Netherlands; objectivity and falsifiability), Bendix (Buddhist Japan's nationalism), Singer (compartmentalization in Madras) .
- None of these is strictly a critique, because Weber never asserted a determinist or monocausal link .
- Samuelson's deeper point: differing ideal types of Catholicism, and Weber's own Calvinist background, raise the question of value-freedom .
- Buddhism and Protestantism are structurally parallel as protests but opposite in values—material as source of suffering versus material as sign of salvation .

8.3.7 Critique of Bureaucracy

Again, these are not really critiques, because whatever the critics say has already been said by Max Weber himself .

1. Robert Merton—Dysfunctions of Bureaucracy

1. **Rules become an end in themselves:** Bureaucracy—in government offices and in the private sector alike—exists to ensure efficiency and to help the client . But when the rules made for efficiency become their own end, it leads to the displacement of the goal for which bureaucracy was made . Bureaucracy was made to serve people; you made rules, but now you are more concerned about the rules, and the rules act as obstruction . This is what we call **red tapeism**—from the red tape used on file holders since colonial times .
2. **There is no scope for improvisation:** Once the rules are made, it takes at least an era for reforms in those rules . If you suggest any change to UPSC, it will take fifty or sixty years; committees will be made, members will die, new members will be appointed, and the report will be delayed .
3. **Impersonality in procedures may lead to friction between public officials and the public:** Clients expect a certain empathy from bureaucrats, but bureaucrats are engaged in being highly formal, rational and in what Max Weber calls **cold calculations**—calculations which lack empathy or feeling for human beings . All the feelings are for the rules . The closer you are to the rules, the further you are from people; and this is what you will be trained for .

CRITICAL POINT

Is this really a critique? Weber has already said all of it, which is why Marx, Weber and Durkheim are classical scholars—nobody can criticise them, because they have said everything . Weber was ambivalent: one opinion was that these features have helped bureaucracy become efficient; the second was that the very same features which made bureaucracy efficient will make it inefficient . When Marx says we will have a better world in the name of socialism with the dictatorship of the workers, Weber says: the more you advance, the more society gets rationalized and bureaucratized, and the more it is the rule of rules . Humans would not be ruling; rules would rule . He called this not the dictatorship of the workers but the **dictatorship of the officials** .

2. Michel Crozier

1. **Bureaucracy refuses to learn from its own mistakes:** It is rule-bound and does not change . The rules, hierarchy and chain of command delay projects: the plan was to make a highway within five years, and the outcome was a highway that took fifty years with the expenditure rising from one million dollars to one billion .
2. **Everybody's responsibility is no one's responsibility:** You go to an office to get your work done, and the person there says he does not know—as satirised in the popular television show *Office Office* .
3. **Bureaucracy is engaged in dealing with its own problems and therefore does not get time for public welfare:** ACR reviews remain pending, disputes between officers occupy the system, corruption and appointment issues—the appointment of the wrong person, the overriding of the seniority principle—are its own internal problems .

GOVERNMENT & POLICY

The counter offered in class: today we have Digital India, and by being digital we are trying to be more efficient and to cut out all the intermediaries between people and officials . Middlemen are removed, expenditure is reduced, and we have schemes that transfer the beneficiary amount directly into the beneficiary’s account, so the welfare money that used to drain away on the route is saved .

3. Alvin Gouldner Alvin Gouldner is the same person who gave the idea of reflexive sociology . He conducted a field study in America among gypsum plant mine workers . He found that those people were doing their work with full sincerity, discipline and punctuality until one day a manager was appointed to oversee them . The moment a manager was appointed to monitor them, their efficiency got reduced . So you cannot say that bureaucracy ensures efficiency; rather, bureaucracy can also decrease efficiency .

The parallel drawn: why do some people not study at home and instead come to Delhi? Because they are not comfortable studying at home—they believe the lesser the monitoring, the better . If you appoint managers to monitor someone, they will not be efficient .

4. Jerry Pournelle—The Iron Law of Bureaucracy Go to any organization and you will meet two kinds of people: those who are working for the organization with full dedication, and those who are working in the name of the organization . The second kind boast about the work they do and present themselves as the ones with maximum contacts in the organization; every time they say what they have done for the organization . Unfortunately these people become visible, and the efficient, hard-working, dedicated people become invisible . And bureaucracy rewards visibility . That is why you see these people climbing the ladder like anything . So bureaucracy does not reward efficiency—bureaucracy rewards visibility, not efficiency . That is the iron law of bureaucracy .

Mechanical and Organic Models of Bureaucracy

Dimension	Mechanical Model	O
Character	Rigid, hierarchical, command-based—the pure Weberian model .	Pa ta
Decision-making	Top-down approach: they give you an order, you follow it .	Pa op de ti
Example given	Delhi University .	A or
Outcome	Fails to deliver—degrees still pending years after the batch has passed out .	Br

QUICK REVISION

- Merton: rules become ends in themselves (goal displacement, red tapeism), no scope for improvisation, impersonality causing friction and cold calculations .
- Crozier: bureaucracy refuses to learn from its mistakes; everybody's responsibility is nobody's responsibility; it is busy with its own problems instead of public welfare .
- Gouldner: the gypsum plant study—appointing a monitoring manager reduced worker efficiency, so bureaucracy can decrease efficiency .
- Pournelle's iron law: bureaucracy rewards visibility, not efficiency .
- Weber pre-empts all of it through his ambivalence—the features that make bureaucracy efficient are the ones that make it inefficient—and his prediction of the dictatorship of the officials .

8.3.8 Critique of Verstehen

Weber says the method is empathetic understanding—to understand social action in its historical context . Any action that is meaningful, oriented to other actors and performed in a certain historical context is social action . The question is: how are you going to interpret it?

Weber was a Protestant, and that is why he could interpret that to Protestants work is a religious experience . A tribal person could not interpret a Protestant's work like this . For a tribal person, spiritual experience is something else—the worship of natural forces: fire, air, earth, the forest . This they call animism and naturism; to them that is not religion in our sense . Imagine planting a person from the Andaman and Nicobar Islands beside you as you work in a factory . Would he be able to interpret what you are doing? First, he would not even know that this is “work”, because he is not from an industrial society and has lived in a tribal society forever . Second, that it might be a way of worship is a far more distant thought .

1. Crisis of Representation Who is going to understand the social action, and how is he going to maintain value neutrality? How can he be objective in the way you expect him to be? These are very subjective things . To put yourself into the shoes of another person, to think about what he is doing while taking into consideration the history of that person, is not an easy task . It is as difficult to do as it is easy to say .

2. Intersubjectivity The word was coined by Alfred Schutz, who is highly impressed with Max Weber but also criticises him . Schutz says he is highly thankful to Max Weber, because it is only because of Weber that we started studying individual actors and the meaning of the action . Weber is therefore indispensable for the rise of phenomenology .

Phenomenology: there is nothing objective in the social world; these are webs of meanings . What is a pen to you may be a stick or an earbud to someone else . A chair is not just a chair—turned over, its legs look like a defence shield, and a tribal who has never seen one may use it for defence rather than for sitting . Capitalism is different to Marx, different to Weber, different to Adam Smith, different to Durkheim . The colour red may imply different meanings to different people . A thumbs-up implies different things in different cultures—in Russia it carries a very different and vulgar meaning; in India something else; in America and Japan something else again .

So there is no objective meaning . Since there is intersubjectivity, reality is highly subjective from

one individual to another . And if your understanding of social action differs from someone else's, how would you ever understand social action? If nothing is objective, can we ever formulate laws? We can never formulate laws . At the same time Schutz was very happy that someone tried to study individuals, because scholars before Max Weber were studying only structure . From here comes phenomenology, and Schutz becomes interested in studying these different intersubjective meanings .

CRITICAL POINT

Post-modernism is an extension of phenomenology . Post-modernists say nothing is objective in this world; theories are highly fluid and not so applicable; Marxism has failed; science does not exist as an objective enterprise but is completely subjective, falsifying its own claims and coming up with another claim . There is no objective truth even in science . Science claims and projects itself as a grand narrative—but there is no grand narrative: no Marxism, no science, no functionalism .

QUICK REVISION

- Verstehen = empathetic understanding of social action in its historical context; Weber's own Protestant background made his interpretation possible .
- Crisis of representation: who interprets, and how is value neutrality and objectivity maintained when standing in another's shoes?
- Intersubjectivity (Alfred Schutz): meanings differ from person to person and culture to culture (pen, chair, thumbs-up, capitalism itself), so laws cannot be formulated .
- Schutz nevertheless credits Weber as indispensable to phenomenology, of which post-modernism is a further extension .

8.3.9 Comparison I: Paradigm, Tradition and Methodology

First, let us locate the three scholars . Paradigms are sets of beliefs . In natural science we have a dominant paradigm—today what Einstein said is the dominant paradigm, so gravitation must be explained through Einsteinian physics; Newtonian physics is outdated . Tomorrow it may be replaced by a new paradigm .

CRITICAL POINT

But in social science there is no dominant paradigm . No one is superior . You cannot say Marx is superior to Weber, or Weber to Durkheim, or Durkheim to Merton, or Merton to Talcott Parsons or Jürgen Habermas or Horkheimer . All of them have looked at the phenomenon through a perspective . When Marx talks about capitalism it is a perspective he is showing, not objective reality—if capitalism really were so exploitative, it would have been over by now .

Dimension	Durkheim	Marx	Weber
Paradigm	Structural functionalism, which itself falls under positivism .	Conflict paradigm—Marxism .	Interactionism, also known as interpretativism .
Why	Looks at how institutions help maintain society; does not look at conflict .	Does not see institutions working for society but for a class; sees only two opposing groups—bourgeoisie and proletariat, masters and slaves, lords and serfs, one class oppressing another with the help of institutions .	The subject matter of sociology to him is the study of social action; he studies the action of individuals, their meanings and motives, not conflict (though conflict returns in social stratification) .
Subject matter	Social fact .	Class conflict / class struggle .	Social action .

KEY CONCEPT

What is positivism? Whether water is in India or in America, water is H₂O only—it is the same everywhere, so you can theorise how water is formed . That is a general law . But water in India may be chemically similar to water in America, while an Indian is not similar to an American . If men are not similar, how can you theorise? Positivists nevertheless believed individuals are similar—every individual is just like matter . Like apples falling in reaction to the law of gravitation, individuals marry in response to the need of society . That is positivism .

Sociological Tradition

- **Durkheim**—macro tradition . He talks about structures constraining individuals, coercive of individuals: family as social fact, religion as social fact .
- **Marx**—macro . Larger structures again regulating individuals; society following laws .
- **Weber**—micro to macro . He started with micro social action, then studied structures, and then said the macro regulates the micro . The same macro which is the making of the micro now regulates individuals . This is known as **substantive sociology**—the integration of micro and macro . That means Weber is highly comprehensive: he is not talking only macro or only micro, but looking at both .

Methodology

Scholar	Methodology	What It Involves
Durkheim	Positivist methodology	The social world operates just like the natural world; social facts are treated as things; there is cause-effect in the social world; non-material social facts lead to social facts; generalizations can be developed—for example rapid industrialization leading to an increased suicide rate . Visible above all in the study of <i>Suicide</i> , where he is purely positivist, follows the scientific method, looks into cause and effect, makes laws, and uses concomitant variation . In the <i>Division of Labour</i> he is not positivist but a philosopher writing a dissertation, and it was later read through the functionalist perspective—division of labour creating organic solidarity and integration, a moral force binding people again after individualism weakened social cohesion .
Marx	Dialectical methodology	Not simply cause and effect . A thesis is rejected by an antithesis; the antithesis is rejected by another; then comes synthesis, which becomes a thesis and is rejected again “Due to inherent contradictions within capitalism, socialism would rise” seems like cause and effect on the surface—but the inherent contradictions themselves are dialectics . He does also believe in causal relations and that the world is governed by laws .
Weber	Historical method	Note: not “historical sociology”—historical method . Hermeneutics, the study of historical texts and the intention of the author, was extended to the study of social action, which must be understood in its historical context . That is why <i>Protestant Ethic</i> required full world history—Weber had to read history to understand how Protestants came about . It is only in history that Weber could reveal the reasoning behind the meaning they attribute to work . The historical method also implies <i>verstehen</i> causality (but multi-causal and adequate, not monocausal), and ideal type .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Careful distinction for the examination: the name of Marx's theory is historical materialism, but the method used to explain it is dialectics . When you see a question on historical method, write only Max Weber—not Karl Marx .

QUICK REVISION

- No dominant paradigm exists in social science, unlike Einstein replacing Newton in physics; all three offer perspectives .
- Paradigms: Durkheim structural-functionalist (within positivism), Marx conflict, Weber interactionist/interpretativist .
- Traditions: Durkheim macro, Marx macro, Weber micro-to-macro = substantive sociology, hence comprehensive .
- Methodologies: Durkheim positivist (*Suicide*, concomitant variation), Marx dialectical (historical materialism is the theory, dialectics the method), Weber historical method (hermeneutics, *verstehen*, adequate causality, ideal type) .
- For a question on historical method, the answer is Weber alone .

8.3.10 Comparison II: Modernity, Division of Labour and Religion

All three are the result of, and a response to, the period of great transformation—industrialization, the French Revolution, the Reformation, the Renaissance and the Enlightenment .

Subject Matter of Modernity

Scholar	What Modernity Means to Him	Principal Concerns
Durkheim	Industrialization—he responds to the force of industrialization, which has weakened cohesion and made people individualist, aspiring and ambitious . He was a conservative who believed traditional institutions had broken down; his question was what would bring solidarity again, and the answer was the division of labour—a qualitatively different, weakened, organic solidarity .	Weakened social cohesion; individualism; anomie; division of labour .
Marx	Capitalism—not industrialization per se; capitalism is the focus of his work .	Not cohesion but exploitation of working class; appropriation of surplus value; alienation of proletariat .
Weber	Rationalization—not industrialization or capitalism per se, but the larger process of which capitalism is only a part .	Disenchantment; the loss of space for emotion; spiritual alienation .

CRITICAL POINT

Marx is very pessimistic about institutions, because to him they work for the interest of the capitalist class . Bureaucracy is machinery planted to secure the interest of the capitalist class; so is the state; so is religion; so is law . Education is based on class privilege—whoever has more money gets better education, and the poor are told they could not clear the system because they lacked merit . But he could not clear it because he did not have the class position: whoever has class will have merit . You need money to go to Oxford .

Division of Labour

Durkheim	Marx	Weber
Division of labour brings solidarity—organic solidarity, interdependence and integration .	Division of labour is an instrument of exploitation . It justifies why you should get a low wage; and in the name of specialization it alienates you from your creativity, so you cannot explore your potential beyond one domain . Marxist scholars such as Braverman call this de-skilling —labour is not skilled but de-skilled .	Division of labour is there to ensure efficiency in the organization—one of the features of bureaucracy . He is not talking about exploitation or solidarity; he looks at it through an instrumental perspective . But given his ambivalence, he also holds that the same division of labour may restrict efficiency because concern with rules, hierarchy and process prevents you from helping the client—which is the irrationality of rationality .

EXAMPLE

The illustration of de-skilling given from personal experience: on first visiting Delhi University and asking teachers the meaning of certain theoretical concepts, the reply was to ask a different professor, “because they teach theory—my department is family and kinship, I am a specialist in that” . Your potential is not polished; rather you are reduced to one domain in the name of specialization . A PhD, in this Marxist reading, is not a good thing, because it means you now know nothing else .

Religion	Scholar	View of Religion
	Durkheim	Looks at the functions of religion: it is a force of social control constraining individuals; it brings solidarity; it has cognitive functions; it produces collective effervescence, a charge external to and coercive of individuals which unites them—as when people cry on seeing their favourite musicians .
	Marx	The function of religion is to opiate the masses—to nullify their consciousness and to let the capitalist class exploit them forever, in the name of sending them to heaven . It prevents revolutionary consciousness from developing; religion is therefore status-quoist, securing the interest of the capitalist class .
	Weber	He is not asking about the function of religion . He studies the social action of religious people—Hindus, Protestants, Muslims, Buddhists—and concludes that some religions have the power to bring in another force called capitalism . That way religion is a source of social change . But it depends which religion: Protestantism can bring social change; other religions cannot, and Hinduism maintains the status quo . Religion as a system can therefore be a source of both social change and status quoism .

CRITICAL POINT

The consequence drawn in class: Europe advanced and India could not, remaining underdeveloped with the same system maintained . Caste still rules; editorials are still written on caste; notes are still made on caste; Indian Society Paper 2 is still read as caste . We know people by their last names; in America they know people by their first names .

QUICK REVISION

- Modernity = industrialization for Durkheim, capitalism for Marx, rationalization for Weber .
- Concerns: anomie and abnormal division of labour (Durkheim); exploitation, appropriation of surplus value, alienation (Marx); disenchantment and societal alienation (Weber) .
- Division of labour: solidarity (Durkheim), instrument of exploitation and de-skilling—Braverman (Marx), efficiency but also its restriction (Weber) .
- Religion: functional and solidarity-producing (Durkheim), opiate and status-quoist (Marx), a possible source of social change but only for some religions (Weber) .

8.3.11 Comparison III: The Solutions They Proposed

Scholar	Solution
Durkheim	Reforms: normal division of labour and social reforms—professional associations, a moral state, a code of conduct, moral education and professional ethics . Only then will the normal division of labour come in and society evolve as it was supposed to .
Marx	Revolution and communism . Nothing else .
Weber	The hope lies neither with the masses nor with the bureaucrats, because he would see no difference between them—both are manifestations of formal rationality . Whenever a crisis comes, the one who will help bring social change is the charismatic authority: one charismatic man will come one day and bring in a new society .

KEY CONCEPT

Max Weber is also called the **bourgeois Marx** . Both Marx and Weber disliked capitalism—Weber clearly stated in his books that he was not happy with the present state—but the reasons are very different . Marx is unhappy because he sees the exploitation of the working class by the bourgeois class . Weber’s analysis is not so reductionist: he is unhappy because in capitalism there is no space for emotion . We have become highly disenchanted, concerned only about wealth and status, no longer concerned with helping people . The rules bring impersonality and separate us from individuals—and this he calls **societal alienation** . It is not just alienation; it is societal . You are alienated not because you are doing something that is one per cent of your potential, but because you are not doing something as a human—you are doing something to make a task machine-like efficient .

EXAMPLE

The school example: the teacher is not friendly with or concerned about students . The students to the school teacher are not Prashant, Swapnil, Rupan, Shubhangi, Vijay, Prakash or Raghavan—they are roll number one, roll number two, roll number three . The teacher has become completely alienated from who the students are . The student to the teacher is nothing but a means to get promotion: the better the result of the class, the better the chance of promotion . Bureaucracy is going on there too .

When a teacher fails a student or gives the lowest marks, she is not going to be emotional about it . She will simply present the mark sheet: see your mark sheet, E grade, this is your performance . Then there will be a parent-teacher meeting, in which the student sits in the corner as an object of discussion between two conscious, rule-bound, formal, mature beings—one teacher and one parent—both concerned about the efficiency of this “product” . You have become one individual reduced to what is in the grade sheet . This is what Weber was concerned with: the human is no

longer seen as human, but as an instrument of efficiency and calculability, someone who should be predictable and successful, someone who works like a machine .

CRITICAL POINT

Max Weber did not like Bismarck; it was the times of Bismarck when he was writing these things . He never had any hope from the masses—the hope that Marx had, that the masses will bring revolution and an egalitarian society will develop . Weber does not share it, although he too is critical of capitalism . He felt that the more we advance towards socialism or communism, the more we get rationalized and the more bureaucracy gets concentrated . Russia and China are the biggest examples: in the name of socialism, it is the bureaucracy which is ruling there . Therefore it is not the dictatorship of the proletariat but the dictatorship of the officials that will reign over civilisations in the future—and the hope lies in a creative, honest, charismatic political leader, not in a bureaucrat .

QUICK REVISION

- Solutions: reforms and moral institutions (Durkheim), revolution and communism (Marx), a creative and charismatic political leader (Weber) .
- Weber is called the bourgeois Marx: also anti-capitalist, but because capitalism leaves no space for emotion, not because of class exploitation .
- Societal alienation = being alienated from acting as a human, not merely from one's creative potential .
- Weber places no hope in masses or bureaucrats; advance towards socialism only deepens bureaucratization—Russia and China—producing the dictatorship of the officials .

8.3.12 Doubts Answered at the End of Class

How do we differentiate paradigm from methodology? Paradigm means a set of beliefs . Methodology means a set of methods used by a scientist—natural or social—to carry out research . The methods Weber had to use to understand rationalization were ideal type, verstehen and adequate causality .

Is Weber in between Durkheim and Marx when it comes to ideology? Weber never gave a functional theory . He is not talking about the function of anything to the system; he was against organicism and against positivism—that was the very first lecture on Max Weber . He is not looking at laws, so he is not a functionalist . And generally he is not a conflict scholar either; how conflict enters later will be seen in stratification . For now, what matters: he is neither functionalist nor conflict—he is interpretative or interactionist, an interactionist because he is studying interaction, the social action of individuals .

Subject matter of sociology according to Marx, in one word? Class conflict . The history of our society has been the history of class struggle; class struggle is the subject matter of sociology .

QUICK REVISION

- Paradigm = set of beliefs; methodology = set of methods (for Weber: ideal type, verstehen, adequate causality) .
- Weber is neither functionalist nor conflict theorist—he is interpretative/interactionist, and was against organicism and positivism .
- For Marx, the subject matter of sociology in one word is class conflict .

8.4 Answer Writing, American Sociology and Talcott Parsons

8.4.1 Answer Practice: Weber's Concepts for Analysing Legitimate Domination

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question (2015, 10 marks, 150 words): Which concept did Weber use to analyse the forms of legitimate domination? Time allowed in class: 7 minutes .

Let us understand the demand of the question . The examiner asks which concept or concepts; he might have forgotten to write the “s” . Concept does not mean you have to write only one concept .

Step 1—Look at the Keywords, Not the Sentence We are not supposed to read the question; we are supposed to look at the keywords . The keywords here are **legitimate domination**, which is itself a concept, and **forms**, which is very clear . So the idea should be to start with the definition of domination .

Step 2—Define Domination

KEY CONCEPT

When it comes to domination and authority, both are one and the same . Authority was the word used by Talcott Parsons when he translated the work of Max Weber from German into English . The meaning of domination—and remember, it is not power; power is different—is the probability of commands being obeyed, the probability of obeisance to commands .

Step 3—Explain How Domination Becomes Legitimate What gave legitimacy to the other person to exercise power over you, and what gave legitimacy for his commands to be obeyed by you? Domination gets legitimacy in three ways :

1. **Traditional domination**—you obey someone's command because he is your father or she is your mother; legitimacy based on tradition, customs, norms and values, or on ancient texts . In the Ramayana the ideal is displayed and everything moves around it—from there we learned that the lady should be like Sita, the father like Dashrath, the man like Ram . So: legitimate domination based on tradition or ancient texts .
2. **Charismatic authority**—sometimes the other person is very charismatic and has induced hope in a hopeless situation . You get fed up studying so many books—ancient history, modern history, medieval history, world history—nothing is registering; then you watch a

motivational lecture by someone on YouTube and hope returns . You start following that teacher and subscribing to his channel . Why are you obeying him? Because you saw charisma in him—heroic qualities, extraordinary features, oratory skills . Legitimacy given on the basis of extraordinary qualities .

3. **Legal-rational authority**—you are stopped on the road by a traffic policeman . Had some other person asked you to stop, you would not have stopped; but a uniformed man asked . You did not stop because you found charisma in him, nor because our ancient texts say we should obey policemen . You obeyed only because it is the command of rules and regulations—constitutionalism; as a citizen of India we have to obey the administration .

Step 4—Answer the Actual Question: Which Concepts?

1. **Social action**—whether you obey the policeman, listen to the motivational guru, or obey your father, everything you are doing is your social action .
2. **Ideal type**—the forms of authority are not pure types . A traffic policeman may also be a charismatic personality; in the real world you cannot cleanly differentiate . There are many IPS and IAS officers, but some are very charismatic . The larger trend is that you obey people based on rules—but traditional, charismatic and legal-rational authority are ideal types, not pure types .
3. **Domination / authority** itself .
4. **Adequate causality**—why did I stop my vehicle and pay two thousand rupees? A normal person draws a monocausal relation: he stopped you, therefore you stopped, and you had to pay . But in reality multiple reasons might exist—for instance, that person was driving with his father sitting beside him, and therefore he had to stop . It is not only that the policeman waved his hand . In reality you do not have monocausality; it is multi-causality, and at most, as sociologists, we can draw an adequate causal relation: if he stopped, there is a probability that he stopped largely because of this .

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

These are the minimum four concepts that you should have talked about . A student asked whether we can also write that Weber rejected something—no . When we see the question, the art of answer writing is basically to write what is asked . We cannot talk about the history of the concepts, the evolution or the origin of sociology here . Criticism is not required in this question—it is a 10-mark question . But you can mention that interpretative sociology was a vision of Max Weber, and that this vision helped sociology depart from the macro perspective to the micro . How will you be different if you write only what is required? That IS how you are different . Most people do not even address the question; without addressing it they ask how to be different . First address the question . What matters is structure: start with the definition of domination; then legitimacy and the forms of legitimate domination; then the examples; and finally the concepts Weber used . All of you study similar things from similar notes and lectures, and still your marks will differ .

QUICK REVISION

- Domination = probability of commands being obeyed; not power . Authority is Parsons' translation of Weber's German term .
- Three bases of legitimacy: tradition/ancient texts, extraordinary charismatic qualities, and formal rules (constitutionalism) .
- Four concepts to name in the answer: social action, ideal type, domination/authority, adequate causality .
- For 10 marks: no history, no origins, no criticism—define, classify, illustrate, then name the concepts . Structure is what separates scripts .

8.4.2 Reading the Newspaper Sociologically I: The Cult of the Topper

Now read a newspaper without any pressure and figure out what the author is trying to say and, as a student of sociology, how you are going to look at it . Notice the difference between how a common-sensical person reads an article and how a student of sociology reads it . Both pieces discussed here are from the *Indian Express*, and the author, revealed at the end, is Abhijit Pathak, a sociologist from JNU .

The Argument of the Article, in Summary The writer begins from the observation that our society worships success and adores toppers, and argues that precisely for this reason it needs to recognise there is no necessary link between a person's intellectual ability or academic excellence and their performance in a board examination . One can score full marks in English without any curiosity for poetry, short stories or novels; the topper in physics need not have any scientific temper or urge to understand the laws of nature . The experience of wonder, the joy of learning and unlearning, and the spirit of inquiry count for nothing, because the prevailing system believes in the fetish of quantification .

The craze for marks converts the learner into a smart consumer—the only skill required is the ability to consume knowledge capsules and facts, through mock tests, endless drilling and an obsession with ranking . Schools sell toppers as perfect products to raise their own market value, and the young learner is reduced to repeating what has been fed in . In such a world there is no poetic wonder, no criticality of social science, no inquiring spirit of science—one is only an exam warrior .

As fact-centric objective short questions become the new normal and memorisation becomes the key to success, it becomes very difficult not to score at least 80 per cent, while those who score 95 per cent still experience acute distress . The writer names this the **pathology of success producing the stigma of failure** .

Students also find almost no guidance while choosing subjects and entering college, for two reasons :

1. **Academic disciplines are hierarchized through the pragmatism of market rationality:** Just as in class ten you “chose” non-medical, so students, pressured by anxiety-ridden parents and driven by peer culture, prefer prestigious subjects—physics, economics, commerce, English literature, psychology—even when they have no intrinsic inclination toward them .

2. **Colleges and universities are themselves hierarchized in an age of ranking:** Institutions like St Stephen's or Lady Shri Ram College are consumed as fancy brands . Students prefer the prestigious college over the subject they like: Sanskrit or education does not matter, Miranda House or Hindu College matters at any cost .

This mass psychology of consumption complicates the politics of the cut-off and destroys human possibilities: someone who could have contributed immensely to the study of Hindi literature ends up doing economics; someone carrying the burden of a famous college's economics course might have found real satisfaction in history at a less reputed institution . The craving for status triumphs over personal liking, and education suffers .

The system, the writer says, works like a soulless machine, more interested in eliminating people than in finding or arousing anyone's real aptitude—if you do not have 99 per cent, you cannot study sociology at Lady Shri Ram College .

The final paragraph asks us to imagine the mental agony these youngsters pass through as social Darwinism is normalised and hyper-competitiveness becomes the philosophy of the age . Schools become highly oppressive institutions: heavily loaded school bags, weekly tests, never-ending home assignments, constant performance anxiety, parental pressure and the urge to be a topper . The world they inhabit, in the writer's words, has no rainbow, no sunset, no music . Even though thinkers like Rabindranath Tagore and Jiddu Krishnamurti felt the pain of this neurosis, the system remains as it is and the society being created is bound to be toxic and violent .

KEY CONCEPT

What is social Darwinism here? We take an entrance examination; whoever is intelligent gets selected and the rest are left behind—survival of the fittest, normalised inside universities . The sociological reading: this entire article is a description of the **irrationality of rationality** . Formal rationality—the fetish of quantification, marks, cut-offs, rankings, brand value—produces outcomes that defeat the very purpose of education .

QUICK REVISION

- The article: no necessary correlation between academic excellence and board marks; the system rests on a fetish of quantification .
- The learner becomes a consumer of knowledge capsules; schools sell toppers as products; disciplines and colleges are hierarchized by market rationality and brand consciousness .
- Social Darwinism is normalised and hyper-competitiveness becomes the philosophy of the age; Tagore and Krishnamurti had already felt this neurosis .
- Sociologically, the whole piece illustrates formal rationality producing the irrationality of rationality .

8.4.3 *Reading the Newspaper Sociologically II: The Age of Instant Enlightenment*

The second article, by the same author, is titled “The age of instant enlightenment” . Its argument, summarised: We live in an age of instantaneity and quick consumption . We had fast food; today we have fast education and fast motivation .

Everything—a McDonald's burger, a cup of Starbucks coffee, a message on Twitter, even political satire on YouTube—is produced and consumed as fast as one can imagine . There seems to be no end to the rapidly changing flow of commodities, symbolic goods, and Facebook and Instagram images and messages . We are only running, eternally hungry for something exciting and new .

This age of instantaneous consumption transforms even religiosity and spirituality into a product: from a quick look at a book by Osho while waiting at the airport, to a three-day retreat in a fancy ashram to learn a breathing exercise, the aspiring and mobile class turns even the alternative into a consumable product .

Not surprisingly, YouTube is full of innumerable packages of instant enlightenment—Zen Buddhism as the easiest spiritual path on earth, two minutes to heal your upset mind, one daily practice that will bring divine grace . We click on them precisely because the path is advertised as easy .

There are moments when this class too feels a need for peace, tranquillity and self-realization; but it is not easy to be free from attachment to the comforts and privileges it is used to, nor from the mood of instantaneity . Herein lies the sociology of the arrival of all sorts of life coaches, motivational speakers and new-age spiritual messiahs .

They come forward with packages of instant redemption—a feel-good movement for a couple of days before one goes back to the old routine of working like a robotic performer, earning, saving, consuming and buying all sorts of insurance . Come back from the office, have a cup of coffee, open the laptop, spend five minutes with a talk by a well-known spiritual speaker on two steps to think right, or a fifteen-minute morning meditation—and everything is calculated .

KEY CONCEPT

Through these two very different pieces the author is describing the **iron cage of rationality** that we cannot escape . A caution stated in class: this does not mean the author is a follower of Weber . In Indian sociology no person is a follower of any one paradigm .

QUICK REVISION

- Instantaneity and quick consumption turn even spirituality into a consumable product—airport Osho, weekend ashram, YouTube enlightenment .
- The mobile, privileged class seeks peace but cannot leave either its comforts or its mood of instantaneity .
- Hence the sociology of life coaches, motivational speakers and new-age messiahs offering instant redemption in calculated fifteen-minute packages .
- Both articles describe the same thing: the inescapable iron cage of rationality .

8.4.4 *The Origins of American Sociology*

We now leave European sociology . In American sociology our syllabus has three scholars—Talcott Parsons, Robert Merton and George Mead—and each of the three belongs to a very different tradition, just as Marx, Weber and Durkheim did .

COMPARISON

- European sociology had its foundation in historical events: the Renaissance, Reformation, Enlightenment, French Revolution and Industrial Revolution . These produced changes which were analysed, described and critiqued by Marx, Weber and Durkheim .
- American sociology has no such historical event or story of its own . The history behind American sociology is European sociology . American sociologists borrowed a great deal from Europe—functionalism, Marxism, feminism, everything was borrowed . But they also did some things European sociology did not do at that point of time .

The Reasons for Its Origin

1. **European theoretical tradition**—this reason is external to America .
2. **Immigration**—America is basically a land of immigrants; people made America, through slavery and through groups such as the Quakers . Even today, most of the people working in Facebook and Microsoft are Asians, not Americans; the industries are theirs but many of the workers are from non-American states .
3. **Urbanization**—the issues that arose with settling those migrants .

COMPARISON

Recall Durkheim: migration from rural areas to urban pockets led to a rise in material density and population volume . The increased population could not be adjusted in limited land, so a specialised division of labour was allotted—and instead of competition or conflict among people, you now have cooperation . That is how specialisation came into existence .

In America, immigration came from multiple pockets—from Europe, and from Africa through slavery; after the abolitionist movement most of these people migrated within America . With immigration came the problems of urbanization: how to settle these migrants . And with migration, anomie also built up in American society—crime rates increased, along with poverty and homelessness . These are precisely the things Durkheim calls anomie, and Durkheim knew they were the result of migration, which he studied while looking into the impact of industrialization .

The Golden Triangle**DATA & FACTS**

Urbanization, immigration and industrialization were happening at a very rapid pace in the **golden triangle**: Chicago, Washington DC and Boston . Rapid change means anomie—sudden change .

With rapid change, society was moving from simplicity to complexity, from pathology to diversity, from absolutism to relativism . The scholars who discuss simple-to-complex are Durkheim and, in fact first, Tönnies . Diversity here means many people coming from different backgrounds—black slaves, Europeans, Quakers .

The Immigration Timeline Shown in Class

Period	Who Came
1600s	Puritans; Jamestown; Quakers; sla
1700 onwards, around 1750	Scots-Irish .
1800	Irish, following the potato famine—
1850	Germans, Danish, Icelandic, Norwe
Later nineteenth century	Many people from Eastern Europe
1890s	The peak of immigration into Ame
1900s	When anti-Jewish sentiment was at Jews went to America—the figure cent . Members of the Frankfurt Sc during the war .

CRITICAL POINT

A consequence noted in class: you would not see Israel defying America; there is a bonhomie, a relation of harmony, between America and Israel which has sustained for so long, because America is influenced by a Jewish lobby . Although these people fled to America, they were such intellectuals that they contributed immensely in scientific advancement, defence equipment and agriculture .

QUICK REVISION

- American sociology arises from three sources: the European theoretical tradition, immigration, and urbanization .
- Its “history” is European sociology itself—theories were borrowed wholesale—unlike Europe, whose sociology grew out of Renaissance, Reformation, Enlightenment and the two revolutions .
- Immigration produced urbanization and anomie—crime, poverty, homelessness—concentrated in the golden triangle of Chicago, Washington DC and Boston .
- The immigration timeline runs from Puritans and Quakers in the 1600s to the 1890s peak and the Jewish and Frankfurt School exodus of the 1900s .

8.4.5 The Chicago School and Its Founders**DATA & FACTS**

The first university department of sociology was at the University of Chicago, founded in 1892 on the appointment of Albion Small as Head Professor of Sociology . Himself a researcher on the

histories of institutions and schools of thought, he played a central role in creating sociology as an academic discipline . He founded the *American Journal of Sociology* and edited it for thirty years . Emile Durkheim was on the editorial board of that journal—described in class as its chief editor . *[as stated in lecture]* At the same time Albion Small helped found and manage the American Sociological Association, the source of the maximum literature in sociology . Small was also deeply involved with social reform—a tradition that has continued throughout the department's history .

The Founders and Their Debate The founders of American sociology—of the Chicago School, the first school of sociology in America—were Albion Small, Lester Ward and William Sumner . All three had read European sociology . The school was established in the 1890s .

CRITICAL POINT

Ward and Sumner were engaged in a debate about what the approach should be: how should we solve the issues of poverty and homelessness produced by immigration, urbanization and industrialization? One position was: do not do anything—rather let us study it theoretically and understand why these things happened, uncover the laws behind the changes and then discover when order will come . This is speaking like Auguste Comte, and this position was that of social Darwinism and evolutionism . In the lecture this position was attributed to Ward, who was described as completely against intervention . *[as stated in lecture]* The other position was: no, we have to bring reforms; we have to intervene . In the lecture this was attributed to Sumner . *[as stated in lecture]* From here come two different schools in American sociology: one interested in reforms, the second against reforms .

The analogy given: the Congress in India also had two groups, moderates and extremists, and initially the moderates dominated . Similarly, in the founding of American sociology, the group that dominated was the social reformists . Those who said “we will only theorize” did not dominate—Europe had already done that; something different was needed . So social reformism and the Chicago School are one and the same, because the Chicago School proposed and was dominated by social reformism .

The Four Challenges

1. Poverty
2. Homelessness
3. Crime rate
4. Racism

Most of the migrants by the end of the 1900s were black, coming from Africa; today we label them African-Americans . In contemporary politics they are regarded as African-Americans, not simply as Americans . In India we do not say Sikh Indians or Muslim Indians; we do not label people as Kashmiri Indians or North-East Indians as a separate category—we simply say Kashmiri, North-Eastern, South Indian, Delhi or Mumbai . But in America the labels are African-American, Hispanic-American (again, Latinos), Asian-American . Most Indian-Americans live in the suburbs of America—that is, at the periphery, not at the core . And there are ghettos as well .

QUICK REVISION

- The department at the University of Chicago was founded in 1892 under Albion Small, who founded and edited the *American Journal of Sociology* for thirty years and helped found the American Sociological Association .
- Founders: Albion Small, Lester Ward, William Sumner; their debate was between non-intervention/social Darwinism and social reform/intervention .
- The reformists dominated, so Chicago School = social reformism .
- The four challenges before American society: poverty, homelessness, crime rate and racism—with hyphenated labels and suburban/ghetto settlement patterns as the racial backdrop .

8.4.6 The Reformers: Jane Addams and Du Bois

Jane Addams—Poverty and Homelessness Jane Addams is described as the first ever sociologist to get the Nobel Prize . She established the **Hull House**—like the charity organisations working to ameliorate the conditions of poor people . Through it she helped marginalized sections by giving them education, talking about their rights, giving them free food and a healthy lifestyle: the minimum desires that should be met . She was a reformist—acting in the world, not theorizing about the world .

From here on came social activism, which is not sociology and is a very different thing . You may be a social activist without being a sociologist, and you may be a sociologist without being a social activist . And there is a third category, social work—anybody can be a social worker . These three categories are very different from one another .

W. E. B. Du Bois—Racism Du Bois was himself an African-American, and he thought about the reasons behind racism in America . He gave the concept of the **colour line**—whites and blacks . This colour line is a creation of Europe . It was in Europe that the age of discovery began; while exploring different continents they came across people who did not look like them and called them blacks or browns . The labels we use today—brown, black—are actually from the European perspective; we are using European labels .

Du Bois says the white-black colour line is not just a colour line: it is oppressive, and it is imbued with the historical exploitation of blacks by whites . The races may be different, of course, but there is also inequality in this difference . Even when an African becomes an American by citizenship, he is still not purely an independent man with reasoning who can exercise fundamental rights just like any other white American . He is still an African-American—which means that man has dual consciousness .

KEY CONCEPT

Dual consciousness: I am African as well and American as well . In the private sphere I am African at home; the moment I go outside, I have to act like an American . Imagine sitting with white Americans as a student at Harvard or Cambridge, thinking of equal opportunity, expecting to graduate just like them—and then after class, in the canteen, finding that whites have different tables and blacks have different tables . If a black student tries to eat with the whites, the whites

get up and move elsewhere . So Du Bois could see a clear-cut inequality in democracy . America is considered the oldest democracy—and yes, it is the oldest democracy—but to Du Bois it was not really a democracy .

Chicago as a Laboratory Chicago at that point of time was not just a city; Chicago was a laboratory, because so many issues were cropping up—homelessness, poverty, crime rate, racism . To these reformers it was a laboratory where they could freely work: go out into the world instead of theorizing from an armchair, have discussion and interaction with people, and get to know their everyday experience .

And here Max Weber returns . When these reformers went out into the public sphere and tried to interact with the victims of immigration—Africans, the poor, the homeless, and women as well—they got to know their concerns . This is why we call it an application of verstehen at the end of American sociology . They started with reformism; they had challenges before them; and gradually, in order to understand those challenges better, they moved towards verstehen—discussion with women, with criminals, with blacks, with homeless people, chatting with them . They were not like Durkheim, Marx and Weber .

QUICK REVISION

- Jane Addams: Hull House, education, rights, food and a healthy lifestyle for the marginalized; the first sociologist to receive the Nobel Prize; a reformist acting in the world .
- Social activism, social work and sociology are three distinct categories .
- Du Bois: the colour line as a European creation, oppressive and historically loaded; dual consciousness; inequality inside the oldest democracy .
- Chicago became a laboratory, and everyday interaction with the oppressed amounted to an application of verstehen .

8.4.7 *How American Sociology Differs from European Sociology*

1. American sociology, unlike European sociology, was more pragmatic (pragmatism) and less theoretical .
2. Unlike European sociology, which had historical antecedents in its emergence, American sociology developed as a reaction to issues related to immigration and the exploitation of the immigrants—homelessness, racism, poverty, discrimination and the resultant consequence, that was increasing crime rate .
3. American sociology developed as an elixir to heal the wounds in the soil of Chicago (the golden triangle) .
4. Unlike European sociology, which was largely structural and macro, American sociology was mainly micro and engaged in everyday interaction with the oppressed .

For example, Jane Addams going to the homes of poor people, sitting with them, understanding their concerns; going to the homes of homeless or single women whose husbands had left them with their children .

The contemporary parallel drawn: the flood of immigrants from the Middle East to Germany and

France . Most European states closed their doors, and those who were absorbed were taken in as people required to perform menial and dirty tasks . Imagine American scholars dealing with such people through everyday interaction, trying to understand their concerns deeply rather than theorizing about them—*verstehen* .

QUICK REVISION

- Four dictated distinctions: pragmatic rather than theoretical; a reaction to immigration and its exploitation rather than to historical antecedents; an elixir for the wounds of Chicago; micro and interactional rather than structural and macro .
- The method that emerges out of reformist fieldwork is *verstehen* .

8.4.8 From Chicago to Harvard: Sorokin and Parsons

The Chicago School developed in 1890 and dominated American sociology until 1930; Chicago School was synonymous with American sociology in this period . In 1930 it lost its relevance, because Pitirim Sorokin, a Russian-American, came to America and established a department at Harvard University—the Harvard School of sociology .

Sorokin was himself a victim of the Russian revolution, whose timeline runs from 1917 through the following decades; it was a series of revolutions . From 1922 to 1930 he was neither Russian nor American—he was stateless, because the state was still to be formed after the revolution . He was a supporter of socialism, a crude supporter of the Marxian idea of socialism, and had joined the Socialist Revolutionary Party in Russia . In 1930 he fled to America and became an American citizen .

In America he was writing on why the revolution failed, and why the idea of Marxism did not turn out as it was supposed to—why it turned out brutal and violent . Marx never said revolution would entail horrors or murders; to Marx revolution simply entails a change in the mode of production that is inevitable . If it is inevitable, why are so many murders taking place? Is murder also part of the inevitability principle?

KEY CONCEPT

Sorokin is also known for the **cyclical theory** (to be taken up in later chapters) . Instead of moving linearly—ancient to feudal to capitalist to socialist to communist—he said that in reality it is a cycle: where you start, you come back there again . Even Marx's movement from primitive communism to pure communism can be read as a cycle, though it seems linear—as always, interpretation varies with the academician . For Marx the transition entails inherent contradictions within the mode of production and the domination of one group over another . According to Sorokin there are no two groups opposed to each other in that way .

Parsons versus Sorokin at Harvard One day Talcott Parsons came to study at Harvard and became a student of Sorokin—and their views turned out to be very opposite . A student not agreeing with the teacher: from there on two different schools within Harvard got established, with some agreeing with Parsons and some with Sorokin, just as in Germany there were supporters and non-supporters of Hegel . Then came Robert Merton, who as a student had the choice to do his PhD under either Sorokin or Talcott Parsons, Parsons having by then gained professorship .

From 1930 to 1960—thirty years—Parsons dominated over Sorokin, and structural functionalism dominated . Why? Parsons was a great admirer of Durkheim and Max Weber; Sorokin was a great admirer of Marxism . America was a democracy—indeed a capitalist democracy—and a democracy will never support violent revolutions . Sorokin, following his cyclical theory, believed capitalist democracy was about to decline . So at the end of the day Harvard University promoted Talcott Parsons and demoted Sorokin, because Parsons spoke like an American democratic person who would never talk about radical or revolutionary ideas . That paradigm dominated for about twenty years and declined in 1960 .

How Parsons Met Weber When Max Weber died of pneumonia in 1920, his wife Marianne Weber conducted conferences, speeches and discussions on Max Weber's thought, over which she used to preside . Talcott Parsons, visiting Germany, entered such a discussion hall in 1925 and listened to Marianne Weber . On the thoughts of Max Weber he got enlightened; that was his first encounter with Weber's thought .

KEY CONCEPT

Talcott Parsons = Weber + Durkheim. Weber gave the theory of social action, which is micro-sociology . Durkheim gave the theory of social fact, which is macro-sociology . Parsons had before him two people with two opposite ideas—and he supported both . Instead of choosing micro or macro, he decided to come up with an integrated approach, integrating both . And this is not an easy task: he is integrating not just micro with macro, but positivism—a theory about laws of the social world—with a web of meanings in which there is no theory . One says there is objective reality, the second says there is no objective reality . Weber's social action theory was itself indispensable for the construction of phenomenology and ethnomethodology, which are micro tools .

QUICK REVISION

- Chicago School dominated 1890–1930; Sorokin's arrival and the founding of the Harvard department in 1930 ended that dominance .
- Sorokin: stateless victim of the Russian revolution, socialist, author of the cyclical theory against linear evolution .
- Parsons, his student, disagreed; Harvard, in a capitalist democracy, promoted Parsons and structural functionalism dominated 1930–1960 .
- Parsons met Weber's thought through Marianne Weber's discussions in 1925; Parsons = Weber + Durkheim, and his project is the integration of micro and macro, of meanings and of positivism .

8.4.9 Talcott Parsons: The Structure of Social Action

In the pursuit of integration, the first theory Talcott Parsons gave is the *Structure of Social Action* . The integration is visible in the name itself: positivism is about structures, and social action is not about structure but about the meanings of individuals—and he says structure of social action .

The Unit Act

KEY CONCEPT

Just as we have units in chemistry—atoms, molecules—and units in physics, there must be units in the social world too. The unit of the body is the cell or tissue; tissues build up into organs, organs into the human body. Similarly there must be a unit of society: the unit of society is action—the actor and the action. He called it the **unit act**. Many unit acts form society, and then society dominates the unit acts. Notice how much like Weber this is: social action comes, then structure, then structure dominates the social action of individuals.

The Marriage Example There is a man who wants to date a girl, because he wants to get married. The goal is marriage—and goals are always momentary, never permanent. Today your goal is to become an IAS; tomorrow it will be to become chief secretary; then a politician; then a motivational guru. Goals keep changing.

What would Weber say? If I am looking at photographs of girls my parents have shown me, my looking at those photographs is a social action. It could be *zweckrational* or affectual—you would not be able to figure out which, and there is no monocausal explanation. But a researcher can empathetically understand the meanings behind it. And yet, be honest: if I am going through pictures of girls on my mobile phone, is there any certainty about what someone in my shoes would conclude? He might say I am on a dating app; it could equally be timepass. Both are very different things.

So Parsons says: it is not an easy task. We should understand social action—but how? And while understanding social action, you first need to understand why that person has such goals and why he adopts particular means.

Five Choices, and How Four Were Eliminated

Choice	What Happened, and Why
Parents' choice	Went with it and married—and the man was a cheat with other women. The marriage ended in divorce . Next time the actor says he will look for himself.
Matrimonial.com	Rejected . The site presents people who are not in any case the profiles there are not of the daughters—the very source of trouble for me” .
School or college	Rejected . That girl had already been married with courage to go back, and in any case she was not of the same caste.
Dating app	Rejected on two grounds: normally dating apps are for losers, all the time in meeting people face to face”; and the cost of ten thousand rupees to maximize the chances of finding your pocket .
Friend's suggestion	Finally chosen . Your friend suggested a girl of good taste, preference, family background, and of your caste, class, religion, family, and the requirement that the person be a Hindu.

QUICK REVISION

- *The Structure of Social Action* integrates structure (positivism) with social action (meaning) in its very title .
- The unit of society is the unit act—actor plus action; many unit acts make society, and society then dominates them .
- Goals are momentary, not permanent; Weber can interpret a social action but cannot fix its meaning with certainty .
- Parsons therefore asks how goals are formed and how means are selected—illustrated by the elimination of four of five marriage options .

8.4.10 Normative and Situational Constraints

Before arriving at the decision and cancelling all the other choices, many things were going on in the actor's head . Those things, in the language of Talcott Parsons, are **normative constraints** acting from above on the actor's orientation and **situational constraints**, acting from below .

KEY CONCEPT

Situational constraints have three criteria: **income** or money; **geography**, that is your location; and the **capability** of the individual . Normative constraints are the **norms and values** which decide what you consider available to you at all . The dating app was refused both because the norms tell you that you are not the kind of person who is available on dating apps, and because you could not pay the fee .

KEY CONCEPT

Write down: Max Weber, in his theory of social action, discussed how an actor acts in a situation and what meanings he attributes to the situation . However, Weber did not take into account the constraints faced by the actor in a situation—constraints which not only influence the availability of the means before the actor, but also influence the goals the actor decides for himself .

Even the Goal Is Not Yours Why are you thinking of getting married? Because marriage is an institution and a norm—so even in this so-called individual decision, norms are entering . Your goal to become an IAS is not culturally undefined . If you were American or European, would you have given a thought to becoming an IAS? Perhaps something else entirely . The goals you set are influenced by the norms and culture of society .

The IAS Example: Five Means and the Constraints on Them

Means Available	How the Constraints
Coaching	A student from Delhi because Delhi is a city where people doubt about their own girl child the parents often do not send a boy, but an investment and expenditure in a “crime city” added a further
Self-study standard books and YouTube videos	You are not for you; you and you also books you can Haralambos condensed version So even self-study constraints .
Library	You see friends anxiety building what will be meet the own internet, books air-conditioned and above you thousand is library is also end up in a atmosphere
Toppers’ notes	Ultimately un- .
Corruption and contacts	It does not work that it works against you allow .

CRITICAL POINT

Were these three decisions—library, toppers' notes, no corruption—independent of external factors? No. Budget, family, gender, even religion and region shaped them. On region: although UPSC is open to everyone, largely it is North Indians and South Indians who come to Delhi to prepare. You do not see many people from the North East, or from Andaman, or Jammu and Kashmir, or parts of Gujarat and Punjab preparing for civil services. No statistics were claimed for this—it was offered as a general observation. There are many pockets where people do not share the ambition to become IAS; they have their own ambitions to go to Australia, Canada or the Middle East—from Gujarat and Kerala to the Middle East, for instance. So even your goal of becoming an IAS is highly situational: where you were born, what kind of family you grew up in, what kind of education you got.

QUICK REVISION

- Two constraints: normative (norms and values, from above) and situational (income, geography, capability, from below).
- Dictated critique: Weber discussed how an actor acts and what meanings he attributes, but did not take into account the constraints that shape both the available means and the goals themselves.
- Even the goal—marriage, or becoming an IAS—is culturally supplied, not individually invented.
- Illustrated across coaching, self-study, library, toppers' notes and corruption, with gender, budget, region and family operating throughout.

8.4.11 The Three Influences on Parsons

Write down: Talcott Parsons was highly influenced by three schools of thought—utilitarianism, idealism and positivism.

Utilitarianism Utilitarian scholars believe that individuals are rational actors: they have multiple choices before them and will make their choice rationally. Parsons agrees that actors make rational choices—but says rational choices are not made in ignorance of the external constraints. Those constraints actually go into the making of that so-called final rational choice.

The Dinner Example The goal is to have dinner—in fact, to have pizza. The choices: go to a restaurant; order on Swiggy or Zomato; go to a dhaba; order from Domino's; or make it at home. There is very little money left in the pocket, and the auto or Uber fare to the place that is far from home adds to it—situational constraints. Why did you not go to the dhaba? Because it feels “low class” to you—that is a norm entering, along with your class position, your status and your family upbringing. Even if a lavishly named dhaba charged a thousand rupees you would go there, but not to the ordinary one. So normative and situational constraints finally made you eat at home.

COMPARISON

What would Weber see? A person eating a sandwich at home. Would Weber have the means to know that this is a pizza to me—a pizza made by my own hard work? To me it is pizza; to

someone else it is simply bread and sauce . Reality is subjective . What does Parsons ask? Tell me first why you are eating pizza, why in this manner, why at home—and also tell me the constraints which made you perform this action . That is the larger idea of Parsons over Weber .

The Gutter Cleaner and the Limits of Historical Context If I am working as a gutter cleaner, there is a historical context which has to be understood to know why I am performing this menial task . A researcher would find that lower castes have been engaged in such menial tasks for historical reasons, and that this has continued among some communities till date . So my action of cleaning a gutter is not just my own individual action—there have been historical constraints, situational constraints, an inability to afford education, and many other things .

But when you talk about historical context, that is a very large picture, and it may not capture the individual situational essence . This is what Parsons is saying to Max Weber .

COMPARISON

The analogy used: utilitarians study very short, minute-by-minute actions—like YouTube shorts . Max Weber is not studying shorts; Max Weber is studying the full movie, asking why this actor plays only this much of a role in the whole film . But Talcott Parsons says nothing can be traced simply by looking at history: situational and normative constraints have also to be looked into to understand the essence of reality .

QUICK REVISION

- Parsons draws on utilitarianism, idealism and positivism .
- The “rational” choice is itself produced by external constraints—the dinner and dhaba example .
- Weber gives the meaning of the act; Parsons demands the meaning plus the constraints behind it .
- History gives the large picture (gutter cleaner, caste) but misses the situational essence .

8.5 Objectivity in Weber, and Parsons on Pattern Variables and the Social System

8.5.1 Answer Practice: Weber’s Method of Maintaining Objectivity

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION

Question (2016): Examine Max Weber’s method of maintaining objectivity in social research . Reference given in class: Vishal, 14th edition, page 13, question 4 . The question is of 20 marks, but let us assume it is a 10-mark, 150-word question . Writing 10 marks is more challenging than writing 20 .

The process is the same: first get uncomfortable by looking at the question, then get comfortable by figuring out something that gives you comfort .

Step 1—Identify the Keyword “Examine” is not a very important keyword . As always, we have to write both sides . It does not matter whether the direction is “elucidate”—even then the other side must be written . The single keyword here is **objectivity** .

Step 2—Where Does Objectivity Come From? The notion of objectivity comes from the natural sciences . Positivists are the people who look for objectivity in the social world; they believe the social world is as objective as the natural world, and therefore that the scientific method can be applied in the study of the social world .

Max Weber believed the social world is not objective, at least not on the lines of the natural sciences . But although he believed there is no objectivity in the social world, he supported the idea of considering the meanings and motivations of individuals objectively . In the social world there is no objectivity; but we can study it objectively .

EXAMPLE

The cockfight illustration . Two people are engaged in a cockfight . I am a European watching them . Just by looking at the crowd, I may call it a source of entertainment—a show, some theatre . But when I start looking at the cockfight by putting myself in the shoes of those people, and after going through the history of the whole community, I realise it is not just a cockfight . It is a symbol of power struggle—a struggle for power and for status between two people . The meaning comes out very differently, and this is objective . So although the social world is highly subjective, the researcher can study that subjective world objectively if the researcher does not allow his values to enter the interpretation of social action .

Step 3—The Lines to Write

1. Objectivity has been a notion derived from the natural sciences that claims the research to be value free .
2. Positivists believed value-free analysis can be done with the application of the scientific method in the social world, which would help to discover laws of society . Example: Durkheim arrived at the law that with industrialization the suicide rate rises .
3. Max Weber, on the other hand, believed that the social world consists of meaningful social actions which are motivated and subjective . Therefore objectivity can be attained only if the researcher studies the web of meanings in a value-neutral fashion .
4. How can we study something value-neutrally? Through the concept of the **ideal type**, which helps the researcher study the social world objectively and helps maintain value neutrality .

Step 4—The Ideal Type as the Device of Value Neutrality

Scholar	Treatment of Capitalism
Adam Smith	A neoliberal economy gives rise to the wealth of nations .
Karl Marx	Capitalism is highly exploitative and alienates individuals .
Max Weber	Capitalism is the accumulation of wealth—accentuated feature of modern society .

In history there have been different methods of accumulating wealth . In tribal society it was booty capitalism—accumulating wealth by capturing or defeating other people . This is objective: it simply depicts what happened in history, with no judgment . Contrast Marx: “the history of all society has been the history of class struggle” . Weber simply portrays that wealth was accumulated; he does not talk about exploitation, expropriation, appropriation, surplus value or alienation . This is why it is a very unique method of objectivity in social science . And remember, ideal type also has types: historical, universal and historical-particular .

Step 5—Adequate Causality and the Claim to Science These ideal types helped Weber not only to maintain objectivity but also to draw adequate causal relations—to establish cause and effect in the social world . Cause and effect is also a feature of natural science, so there is science here . Hence: sociology is a science—but a science of social action with interpretative understanding of the meanings and motives, along with the causes and the consequences .

Step 6—The Critics**CRITICAL POINT**

Introduce scholars—advisable in a 20-mark answer, ignorable in a 10-mark one . Gunnar Myrdal and Alvin Gouldner clearly say objectivity is an illusion . David Marsland may also be introduced . Gouldner’s concept of **domain assumptions**: if I am a feminist, I study domestic violence, gender inequality and sexual harassment at the workplace . My personal life, my values and my reading of feminism influenced me to study these things—those are my domain assumptions . Similarly, as a Marxist scholar I would study class inequality, poverty, homelessness, misery, alienation, monotonous work, the platform economy, cyber and digital capitalism, migration, reverse migration and forced labour . Being a Marxist, you deal with those topics—so how can you say you are highly objective?

Max Weber’s answer: as far as the selection of the topic is concerned, your values are very much welcome; after the topic is chosen, no . The critics reply that even after the selection of the topic values will still be there .

KEY CONCEPT

So Weber's idea of objectivity is itself very "ideal": the ideal type gives us a direction, a target, a goal that everyone should try to attain . It is not something you can really live up to, but something you can always look up to while doing research .

QUICK REVISION

- Keyword: objectivity . Objectivity is a natural-science notion of value-free research; positivists import it wholesale, Weber does not .
- For Weber the social world is subjective but can be studied objectively—the cockfight read as a struggle for power and status .
- The device is the ideal type, which secures value neutrality: capitalism as accumulation of wealth, with no judgment, unlike Adam Smith or Marx .
- Ideal types also permit adequate causal relations, so sociology is a science of social action with interpretative understanding of causes and consequences .
- Critics: Myrdal, Gouldner (objectivity is an illusion; domain assumptions) and Marsland; Weber allows values only at the stage of choosing the topic .

8.5.2 Weber's Objectivity versus Positivist Objectivity

Element	Weber	Positivists
Type	Ideal type—not the actual type, nor the average type; it is an approximation of reality, not reality .	Actual type—what they study is taken to be the thing itself .
Understanding	Verstehen—empathetic understanding; Weberians understand us .	They do not understand people, they explain people .
Values	Value neutrality .	Value freedom, with strict separation between researcher and researched; prediction of reality .
Causation	Adequate causality—probability, multi-causality .	Monocausal: A led to B .
Assumption about people	A web of meanings; reality is highly subjective .	Just as they have the atom, we have people who are like atoms; behaviour is static, people in similar situations behave similarly everywhere, and therefore laws of the social world can be formulated .

KEY CONCEPT

Capitalism does not exist; it is a model . Democracy is a model, not a reality . Justice is a model—equal opportunity to everyone, free and fair elections as political justice, plus economic and social justice . In reality you do not have a hundred per cent of economic or social justice; you get one feature here and another there . Every scholar uses concepts and holds models in mind to explain reality . If nothing is certain, how can you come up with a law? That is Weber's position in one line .

QUICK REVISION

- Weber: ideal type, verstehen, value neutrality, adequate causality, web of meanings .
- Positivists: actual type, explanation, value freedom and researcher/researched separation, monocausality, prediction, and laws .
- Ideal type is neither the actual nor the average type—only an approximation .
- Democracy, justice and capitalism are all models rather than realities, which is why no law can be formulated .

8.5.3 Parsons on Orientation, and His Five Questions

Recall the diagram: an actor, arrows for the possible means, situational constraints below and normative constraints above. Parsons is studying the orientation of the actor—a word that comes from Weber's writings, since social action is meaningful action oriented to other actors.

COMPARISON

Weber: the actor is oriented to other actors. Parsons: the actor is oriented to other actors, of course—but this orientation is not so neat and clean. There are constraints, normative and situational, which Weber did not take into consideration. Weber tried to understand the social action of large numbers of people to figure out why large-scale social structures came into existence—his structures are the formation of individuals. That way structures are not objective reality, since they are our making, and all of us may attach different meanings to the same structure. To the concept of work a Protestant attributes one meaning and a Hindu another; so the very notion of capitalism is not objective—it is a reflection of the values of Protestants.

The Five Questions in Parsons' Mind

1. How does the actor finalize the means?
2. How are the goals or ultimate ends determined?
3. Why is the actor, despite having a different set of goals and means, able to interact with someone who does not share those goals and means?
4. How do the normative and situational constraints coerce the individual into certain means and certain goals?
5. **How come we have social order in society, with so many people having different sets of goals and different sets of means?**

EXAMPLE

Parsons is defamiliarizing what is very familiar. Two people talking is nothing extraordinary—someone asks the way to the temple, the other answers. But is this the kind of interaction Parsons is interested in? Yes: he is unearthing everything we take for granted. UPSC has approximately 1000 seats and about 3 lakh students appear. Finally 1000 make it and 2,99,000 are out. Why did they simply accept that they are not fit? Why did they not revolt or protest? What is it in society that stops them? Or: suppose you marry someone completely opposite to you. After a year both of you know that this is not the person each thought the other to be. Why then is there still no divorce? Why is the marriage still there? Social order is still maintained despite tension, anxiety and strain.

QUICK REVISION

- Parsons studies orientation, adding normative and situational constraints to Weber's orientation to other actors.
- His five questions: how means are finalized; how goals are determined; why actors with different goals still interact; how constraints coerce; and above all how social order is possible.

- The method is defamiliarization—treating the ordinary (an exam result accepted without protest, a marriage that does not end) as a problem requiring explanation .

8.5.4 *Pattern Variables*

Whatever choice you make can be studied easily through a pattern, because the choices individuals make constitute patterns . Large numbers of people go through similar means to achieve similar goals . There is complexity, but there is a pattern—and Parsons calls this pattern the **pattern variable** .

KEY CONCEPT

Definition: a pattern variable is a model used by the researcher to understand how the actor resolves the dilemma that he confronts in an action situation . Multiple choice means dilemma . Parents' choice or your own; UPSC or higher education or a foreign university; pizza or burger; hot coffee or cold coffee—every actor in any action situation confronts a dilemma, and finally makes one choice . Since it is a model, it is very much influenced by Weber's notion of the ideal type .

After analysing all the modes of social action, orientation, and normative and situational constraints, Parsons found there are two modes—two choices the actor has: to go with tradition, or to go with his own choice, that is individualism . Corruption is a manifestation of individualism; to write the UPSC examination is considered a traditional social action, or it may be considered value-rational—whatever it may be, it is not individualism .

Pattern Variable A (Traditional, Expressive)	Pattern Variable B (Modern, Instrumental)	What It Means
Ascription	Achievement	Ascribed status—you are Punjabi, a specific caste, of a specific religion; achieved status—you are an MBA, an MA, a doctor. In traditional society, you choose a partner by caste, religion, that is ascription; if by education, background and achievement, that is achievement orientation. In reality, it is both looked at, which is why it is only partially ascribed.
Affectivity	Affective neutrality	At home your mother is emotional and you may get annoyed with her. In the office, a person would not express that annoyance. In the office you cannot be emotional. If you have an issue you write it in an email, and the boss replies by email. Family = affectivity; work organization = affective neutrality.
Particularism	Universalism	At home my mother and family get special treatment. In school no student gets special treatment—all students are equal. In the office, we are roll numbers one, two, three, etc. In the public sphere, universal standards, and universal rules are the feature of modern society. Democracy is about—equal opportunity for everyone.
Diffuseness	Specificity	Your role at home is highly diffuse. You talk to our mother and father on all matters. In the office, we have some specific business; we talk to the boss generally. In the office people talk to the boss; they have work, and productive work happens through conferences and meetings. You cannot talk to the police the way you talk to your father; with a doctor the conversation is specific about treatment and medicine. You talk to the police about a specific law or accident.
Collective orientation	Self-orientation	In traditional society you always consider collectivity into consideration—you are a member of your nation, your religion, your community. In modern society you are highly self-oriented. Examples: first generation IES officers.

The Five Pattern Variables

DATA & FACTS

On intercaste marriage: till last year, 93 per cent of marriages in India were intra-caste—within the same caste even after 75 years of independence . Hardly 5 or 6 per cent are intercaste . Intra-caste marriage is not individualism; it is traditional action . Going out of your caste means making your own choice—individualism . A definitional problem also arises: if a Mishra marries a Pandey, is that intercaste or intra-caste? Generally we think both are traditionally Brahmins, so it is intra-caste endogamy—but the castes are in fact different, so it could be counted as intercaste . It depends on the assumptions the researcher works with .

QUICK REVISION

- A pattern variable is a model for understanding how an actor resolves the dilemma of an action situation—dilemma meaning multiple choice .
- Two modes of choice: tradition (A) and individualism (B) .
- The five pairs: ascription/achievement, affectivity/affective neutrality, particularism/universalism, diffuseness/specificity, collective orientation/self-orientation .
- A describes traditional society, B modern society; India's 93% intra-caste marriage rate is the class's test case, complicated by how "intercaste" is defined .

8.5.5 Significance of Pattern Variables and the Classification of Societies

1. Pattern variable as a model can help us to understand the social action of the individual inclusively, holistically and comprehensively .
2. Pattern variable A and pattern variable B are two different modes of orientation—in brackets, expressive and instrumental . A is highly expressive; B is instrumental .
3. Pattern variable B helps in understanding the larger social system: if the social action of individuals falls under pattern variable A, the social system is traditional; if under B, it is modern .

Recall that Max Weber talked about instrumental social action—means and ends rationally calculated, everything done by yourself, all the means at your disposal, your own decision . In every one of the five pairs, the right-hand side is all about you as an individual; when you have so much of "you", you have instrumental orientation, and when you have so much of "us", it is expressive .

If out of one crore people I find eighty lakh doing what falls under pattern variable B, I will say society is moving towards modernity; if eighty per cent fall in the traditional domain, I would say India is still not modern—highly traditional with very few elements of modernity . But before any research one must have such models in mind before drawing conclusions .

CRITICAL POINT

Whenever Parsons talks about social action he is considering only and only formal rationality, because his first assumption was that man is utilitarian and as a utilitarian man he is rational, has choices, and makes them accordingly . The other forms of rationality and the other forms of

social action he does not talk about . And even when people opt for what is expressive or falls under pattern variable A, he does not give importance to it—because to him being modern means pattern variable B, and A is traditional and non-modern . He looks down on A and gives all the importance to B .

Scholar			Basis of Classification	
Durkheim			Division of labour and collective consci	
<i>How Each Scholar Classified Society</i>			Marx	
			Modes of production and classes .	
			Weber	
			Rationality which includes authority and essentially the way we think .	
			Parsons	
			Pattern variables, that is, modes of orie	

EXAMPLE

On Weber’s “way we think”: today you opt for a college because you consider it a brand, not because you like the subject . You are not following your preference or your passion . Everything is over—we are in a disenchanted world, highly rational . That is the irrationality of rationality . The change in the way of thinking—from traditional social action to formal, highly rational social action—is what the rationalization process is all about . Today, before getting married, you would not be thinking about extravagant expenses; you would ask why not simply invest the money instead .

Traditional and Modern Society by Scholar

Scholar	Traditional Society	Modern S
Weber	Traditional social action, traditional authority, practical rationality .	Zweckrati legal-ratio rationality
Marx	Limited technological advancement, limited needs, community with no class structure .	Highest fo developm productio advancem formation asymmetr by anothe exploitatio
Parsons	Orientation falling under pattern variable A .	Orientatio variable B

QUICK REVISION

- Three significances: holistic understanding of individual social action; A and B as expressive and instrumental modes of orientation; and B as the key to classifying the larger social system .
- Parsons assumes a utilitarian, formally rational actor and treats A as merely traditional and non-modern .
- Classification bases: division of labour and collective consciousness (Durkheim), modes of production and classes (Marx), rationality (Weber), pattern variables (Parsons) .

8.5.6 Modes of Control and the Problem of Social Order

Take one actor whose goal is to make money . Three legitimate choices—a startup, a government job, a private job—and a fourth, gambling . Parsons asks: why did you not go with gambling? You may answer: because if I gamble I can be sent to jail, so I have a fear of punishment, or my status will be defamed . But how did you develop this consciousness? Why are you opting for the means seen as legitimate in society?

It was developed through three modes of control :

1. **Sanctions**—that is, punishment . Deviance is not encouraged; it is prohibited by the fear of law . Law is one institution that maintains solidarity and prohibits deviance; you follow the consensus because of sanctions . In UPSC or any examination you will see the instruction that anyone using unfair means will be debarred—the sanction is given right at the page of instructions .
2. **Values given by school and family**—the values that you have to be ambitious and aspirational . Right at school you start getting punished for something that is not seen as right for the

discipline of the classroom . The classroom is a mini society: all the students have different aspirations and come from different families, yet all of them are disciplined, sitting silently and listening to the teacher, because of the values families have given them and because of the sanction represented by the monitor standing in the middle .

3. **The larger social system**—societal values . These are values you do not really learn from school or family . For instance you only read about democracy in school; you do not practise or internalize it there . After school you go to college and then to a job, and in the job itself you learn how democracy actually operates—because your appointment, recruitment and selection are democratic, with everybody chosen on the basis of skill, opportunity and education, so you see equal opportunity irrespective of sex or gender .

KEY CONCEPT

These are the three modes of control, and these are the things which maintain social order . Without disciplinary authority and without values, social order would not be possible .

A Second Application: Entering Politics

Means to Enter Politics	What Constrains It
Wealth—you get a ticket from a political party because you are a millionaire or billionaire, or because you have been sponsoring political parties	Available only to those
Contacts—as an IAS or IPS officer you may have built up many contacts	Requires the prior posi
Marrying the son or daughter of a President, Chief Minister or Prime Minister	The choice finally take shaped by normative c bureaucrat you cannot minister .
Criminal behaviour—what we call the criminalization of politics, since politics is about majority, not about moral or immoral	Blocked by sanctions, v system: the Supreme C Commission act as wat of candidates and may contest .

CRITICAL POINT

The larger point: in the theory of the structure of social action, Talcott Parsons is always and only talking about formal rationality—you have multiple means before you, and you opt for certain means by eliminating others, considering these right and those wrong .

QUICK REVISION

- Three modes of control: sanctions (fear of law and punishment), values instilled by school and family, and the values of the larger social system .
- Together they explain why deviant means—gambling, criminality—are eliminated, and thus how social order is possible .
- The classroom is a mini society in which sanction and value operate simultaneously .
- Every such elimination of means is an exercise of formal rationality, which is the only rationality Parsons works with .

8.5.7 The Social System and the Four Needs

The human body has different needs—to eat, to drink, to meet and greet someone, to sleep, to rest . Just as the human body has different needs, society, if considered as an organism—which is what functionalists have always maintained—also has different needs .

KEY CONCEPT

The needs of society are four only:

- Adaptation
- Goal attainment
- Integration
- Latency

What makes Talcott Parsons difficult is only one thing—the words he uses . Otherwise he is a very simple scholar .

<i>The Shimla Illustration</i>	Need	In the Shimla Trip
	Adaptation	You land in Shimla and first take rest—you are at high altitude feeling breathless . You adapt to the external environment .
	Goal attainment	Then you decide to have a nice dinner, or to go out for a local sightseeing . After adapting, you go on to fulfil your goals .
	Integration	You go out and meet people; you eat the ordinary local food comfortably; you talk to friends and to the local people of Shimla . You get photographs with them; you sit with the taxi driver and talk to him; you integrate with the hotel staff . Unless you integrate with the people, people would not cooperate with you .
	Latency	In the whole process of discussion, integration and fulfilling goals, tension also builds up—you come home and find the balance account is nothing like what you assumed . Latency is tension management .

The Same Applied to Indian Society after 1990

- **Adaptation**—when liberalization, privatization and globalization happened in the 1990s, Indian society had to adapt to these external changes . There is an institution in society which adapts to the external environment .
- **Goal attainment**—after LPG the goals of our society also changed .
- **Integration**—changes came in the organs of our society: changes in laws, changes in the economy, changes in the way law, economy, state, school and family were integrated with each other as organs . After the 1990s, the school curriculum changed and NCERT textbooks changed: chapters on liberalization, privatization, capitalism and liberalism started appearing . The education structure changed . The family as an institution changed—where there were joint families, aspirations arose and people moved to Delhi and Mumbai, so families went from joint to nuclear . Laws changed, the state changed, everything changed—and yet they remained in integration with each other .
- **Latency**—with so many changes, tension builds up . Strains develop in the system, just as strains develop in the body or the mental system . Therefore we also have a tension management mechanism .

KEY CONCEPT

Unless we have four institutions catering to the four different needs of society, we will never be able to maintain social order . For social order to maintain itself, the four different needs have to be fulfilled by four different institutions of society . Which institutions serve which need is the next topic .

QUICK REVISION

- Society, treated as an organism, has four needs: adaptation, goal attainment, integration and latency .
- The Shimla trip illustrates all four: rest, dinner and walks, meeting people, and managing the tension that builds up .
- Post-1990 India illustrates them structurally: adapting to LPG, changing goals, reintegrating law, economy, state, school and family, and absorbing the resulting strains .
- Social order requires four institutions, each catering to one need .

8.5.8 Doubts Answered at the End of Class***What is the difference between situational and normative constraints and the modes of control?***

The modes of control include these constraints; they are sanctions .

- **Normative constraint**—you want to marry someone and are not able to, because he or she belongs to a different caste or religion . Or the normative constraint may be absent on caste and religion and appear elsewhere: she is from your caste and your religion but poor, and dowry cannot be paid . (Dowry is of course a bad institution and has been prohibited; the point is only what happens in practice.)
- **Situational constraint**—suppose you do not have the money to arrange the marriage, or you are not well enough situated economically to take care of the next generation . That way situational constraint is not about norms; it is about your income, geography and capability . Or: your wife is an IAS officer and so are you, but you are in Rajasthan and she is in UP, and ultimately it ends in divorce . That is not about norms; it is about geographical location, income and capability .

Parsons was influenced by the idealism school of thought—is it the same idealism? Idealism has multiple variants . Idealism simply means ideas are primary and matter is secondary . Remember this .

Parsons is influenced by three schools . From utilitarianism he takes that individuals have choice and are rational . From idealism he takes that norms will constrain the individual, that ideas are primary: the means you choose to fulfil your goals will be influenced by ideas, and the goal you set in your life is also influenced by ideas .

So the actor may be rational, in the sense that he can make all the choices by himself; but the means available before him would be governed by norms, and the goal he sets for himself would also be governed by norms . Both are there: the individual actor making his choice, and the norms constraining his action . And the third influence is positivism .

QUICK REVISION

- The modes of control include the constraints; sanctions are their core .
- Normative constraints concern caste, religion, dowry and other norms; situational constraints concern income, geography and capability—including two spouses posted in different states .
- Idealism = ideas are primary, matter secondary; through it norms shape both the means and

the goals .

- Parsons' three influences remain utilitarianism, idealism and positivism .

8.6 Answer-Writing Toolkit

The following collects only the answer-writing guidance actually given across these lectures .

8.6.1 *How to Approach the Question*

- Do not read the question as a sentence—look at the keywords . Everything in the answer is built from them .
- First get uncomfortable by looking at the question, then get comfortable by finding the part you can begin from .
- “Examine” is not an important direction word—both sides have to be written . Even for “elucidate” the other side must appear .
- Write what is asked . Do not write the history of the concepts, the evolution of the idea, or the origin of sociology, when the question does not demand it .
- The way to be different is to address the question . Most candidates never address it and then ask how to be different .
- Everyone studies from similar notes and hears similar lectures; what separates the marks is structure .

8.6.2 *Length, Time and the Use of Scholars*

- A 10-mark question is 150 words, and in class 7 minutes were given for it . Writing 10 marks is harder than writing 20 .
- In a 20-mark answer you should mention scholars for the critique; in a 10-mark answer you may ignore them .
- Criticism is not required in a 10-mark question on a definitional demand .

8.6.3 *Dimensions and Structure for the Two Questions Practised*

Which concept did Weber use to analyse the forms of legitimate domination? (2015, 10 marks)

1. Define domination—the probability of commands being obeyed; note that it is not power, and that authority is Parsons' translation of the term .
2. Explain legitimacy and the three bases: tradition or ancient texts, extraordinary/charismatic qualities, and formal rules and regulations .
3. Give the forms with quick examples—obeying the father, following a motivational speaker, stopping for a uniformed traffic policeman .
4. Name the concepts used: social action, ideal type, domination/authority, adequate causality .
5. Optional closing line: interpretative sociology was Weber's vision, and it helped sociology depart from the macro perspective to the micro .

Examine Max Weber's method of maintaining objectivity in social research (2016)

1. Define objectivity as a notion derived from the natural sciences claiming research to be value free .
2. State the positivist position: value-free analysis through the scientific method, to discover laws of society—with Durkheim's law relating industrialization to suicide rates as the example .
3. State Weber's position: the social world consists of meaningful social actions which are motivated and subjective, so objectivity is attained only if the researcher studies the web of meanings in a value-neutral fashion .
4. Show how the ideal type secures value neutrality—capitalism as accumulation of wealth, against the value judgments of Adam Smith and Marx; mention that ideal type has types: historical, universal, historical-particular .
5. Add adequate causality, and conclude that sociology is a science of social action with interpretative understanding of meanings, motives, causes and consequences .
6. Close with critics: Gunnar Myrdal and Alvin Gouldner (objectivity is an illusion; domain assumptions), and David Marsland .

8.6.4 Keywords to Carry Into the Answer

- **Weber on objectivity:** ideal type, value neutrality, verstehen, adequate causality .
- **Weber on authority:** domination, legitimacy, ideal type, social action, adequate causality .
- **Traditional authority:** gerontocracy, primary patriarchalism, patrimonialism (prebendalism), sultanism, patrimonial bureaucracy .
- **Charismatic authority:** routinization of charisma, historic and transitory phenomenon, hero or tyrant .
- **Bureaucracy:** machine-like efficiency, iron cage of rationality, irrationality of rationality, dictatorship of the officials .
- **Protestant Ethics:** predestination, salvation anxiety, calling, ascetic materialism, this-worldly orientation, Puritan work ethic, elective affinity, adequate causality, unintended consequence .
- **Parsons:** unit act, normative constraint, situational constraint, pattern variable, expressive and instrumental orientation, modes of control, adaptation-goal attainment-integration-latency .

8.6.5 Specific Instructions Given for Particular Topics

- **On the Protestant Ethic question:** explain the ideal type of Protestantism (the Protestant work ethic) and the ideal type of rational capitalism, and draw the relation between the two . Do not narrate the history of Martin Luther, John Calvin or Benjamin Franklin in the answer—that is only for your understanding, and it will help in other units .
- **On historical method:** when you see a question on historical method, write only Max Weber, not Karl Marx . Marx's theory is named historical materialism, but his method is dialectics .
- The history-versus-sociology distinction developed while teaching the Reformation can itself be used in a question on history versus sociology .

8.6.6 *How to Read for the Examination (Stated in the Second Lecture)*

- Read instrumentally: previous year questions first, then the weightage of areas, then the minimum book that gives maximum result in minimum time .
- **Ancient history:** Harappa/IVC, Buddhism, Jainism, Mauryan Empire, Guptas, scientific achievements, and the philosophies (Shad Darshanas) . Skip the Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushans and the Satavahanas . Three days maximum .
- **Medieval history:** only the Mughals, the Cholas, the Pallavas, and Bhakti and Sufi . No Sultanate .
- **Modern history:** skip the early modern period before 1857; read the major events along with the major acts, always alongside previous year questions . Do not try to become a scholar of modern history .
- **Art and culture:** NCERT only—Buddhist art, paintings, Indo-Islamic architecture, folk dances and classical dances .
- Whatever you find boring should be read first, because otherwise you will never read it .

8.6.7 *Applying the Syllabus to the Newspaper*

A newspaper article should be read twice: once as a common-sensical reader would, and once as a student of sociology . The class demonstration used two *Indian Express* pieces on examination culture and on instant spirituality, both read through formal rationality, the fetish of quantification, social Darwinism and the iron cage of rationality .